THE PRICE OF A NAME

A Novel of Rome

Rome, AD 112

This is a work of fiction. Its people, houses and quarrels are invented; the city that contains them is not.

Mature content: adult themes, including sexual exploitation, slavery and violence. 18+.

Set in EB Garamond.

"Power is inherited, fortunes are made, and some wounds never heal."

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PART ONE

The House

CHAPTER ONE

The Golden Vine

— ◆ —

The house had been built for a man who wanted to be remembered, and it had failed him twice. The first of its owners had died in exile with his name struck from the fasti; the second had lost it at dice to a man who lost it in turn to a creditor who lost it to Antonia Cassia in the fourth year of the emperor's Dacian war. The walls had kept their painted gods through all of it. On the south side of the peristyle, Diana still hunted with her dogs among a forest of faded green, and above the fountain a Neptune who had once been somebody's portrait held up a hand to a wave that would never fall.

Antonia had kept the Neptune. She had painted everything else.

At the tenth hour of a May afternoon the house smelled of hot stone, box hedge, and the resin the gardeners used on the fig trees. Somewhere behind the kitchen wall a boy was turning a spit too fast and being told so. In the corridor that ran from the service court to the new dining room, two of the under-stewards were arguing in whispers about a crate of Falernian that had arrived with three jars short, and they stopped arguing when they heard her sandals on the mosaic.

She had been in the house long enough that its noises sorted themselves for her without effort: the difference between a dropped cup and a thrown one, the particular flat sound of a slave's shoulder hitting a door frame in a narrow passage, the sudden hush that travelled ahead of a guest like a wind crossing barley. She could lie in her bed at the top of the house and know from the footsteps below whether the kitchen was behind, whether a girl had been crying, whether someone had brought a stranger in through the garden gate instead of the street door.

The new dining room was the largest thing she had ever paid for that could not be sold again. It had taken eleven months, two architects, and a

quantity of marble that had come up the Tiber on a barge she also owned, and it held seven couches beneath a ceiling painted with the twelve signs of the zodiac in gold leaf and lapis, on which the painter had laboured so long that his hands had begun to shake and he had asked, at the end, whether he might put his own small sign among the stars. Antonia had said no. She regretted it sometimes. She regretted it now, standing in the doorway with her keys at her belt, looking up at the Ram and the Bull and the Twins and thinking that a man who had spent nine months on his back in the dark ought to have been allowed to leave a mark.

'Well?' said Myrrhine. 'Will it do?'

Myrrhine was thirty-six and Greek and wore her hair in the old way, pinned close, and had a face that could be closed like a shutter. She had been in the house since it had been a bad investment with a good courtyard, and she was the only person in Rome who could ask Antonia a question in that tone and expect an answer.

'It will do,' said Antonia.

'It cost enough to do.'

'It cost enough to be talked about. That is not the same thing.' She walked the length of the room, past the seven couches with their bronze feet, and put her hand on the table where the wine would be mixed. The wood was citrus, from Africa, and the grain moved under her palm like water under ice. 'The lamps?'

'Lit at the ninth hour, all forty. Brennus is at the gate. Meno is at the inner door and unhappy about it.'

'Meno is unhappy about everything.'

'Meno is unhappy about standing at an inner door while an old man with a knife could come over the garden wall,' Myrrhine said. 'He says a doorkeeper who cannot see the street is a decoration.'

'Tell him the decoration is paid the same as the doorkeeper.' Antonia turned. 'Who has come?'

'Nobody yet. Naso's litter was seen on the Vicus Patricius. Sestius will be late because he believes it is a kind of rank. The young man Celer has been here an hour, in the garden, drinking water and trying to look as

though he does not care about anything.'

'Does he care about anything?'

'He cares very much,' Myrrhine said. 'He has the face of a boy who has been told his whole life that he is promising.'

Antonia laughed, once, and it was a real laugh, which happened perhaps four times a week. She was forty-one years old. She had a broad, still face that took paint well and needed little of it, a nose that had been broken when she was seventeen and set by a woman who set bones for the circus, and eyes that people described, depending on their feelings about her, as intelligent or as hard. She wore that afternoon a dress of pale Egyptian linen with a border of dull gold thread, and on her right hand a ring with a carnelian the size of a thumbnail, and at her belt the iron ring of keys that had once belonged to a woman in Arretium and now opened forty-one doors in Rome.

Eleven of those doors were locked against her own household. That was not because she was cruel. It was because she had been a slave, and had learned that the difference between a locked door and an open one is measured in what a person is willing to lose.

'They will begin arriving in a quarter of an hour,' she said. 'Eucharis?'

'Dressed. Harp tuned. She has a cough she says she does not have.'

'Then she has a cough.' Antonia went to the door and looked back at the room with the seven couches. 'The girl?'

'Lucilla is in the small room off the library. She has been sick twice. She is seventeen and she has been told she is going to meet men who could buy her whole family, which is true, and she has decided that the way to survive it is to be very quiet and very pretty and to agree with everything.'

'That is a reasonable decision.'

'It is a decision that will last about a year,' Myrrhine said, 'and then she will be twenty and she will not be able to find it in herself to agree with anything, and we will have a different problem.'

Antonia stood a moment. In the corridor beyond, someone was carrying a stack of folding stools and had dropped one, and the clatter went down the passage like a shout. She thought of the small room off the

library, of the seventeen years in it, of the way a girl's fear smells — like metal, like the inside of a cup left upside down.

'Bring her to me before the second course,' she said. 'Not to sit. To sing. One song, and then she goes back to her room, and no one goes to her room.'

'There will be men who—'

'There are always men who. That is why there are doors.'

———

The first guests came at the tenth hour and a half, and by the eleventh the house had changed its nature entirely, the way a face changes when it begins to perform. Torches were lit along the street front so that the painted portico seemed to breathe. Two slaves with fans stood at the entrance to move the warm air and to give the arriving litters something to look at. The noise of the Esquiline — carters forbidden by law to move by day and doing it anyway, a woman selling roasted chickpeas, the whole grinding commerce of the Subura coming faintly over the roofs — faded behind the closing of the gate.

Gaius Cluvius Naso came first, as bankers do when they wish to be seen arriving first. He was sixty-one, thin as a nail, with the careful hands of a man who had counted a great deal of money and the pale eyes of one who had counted other people's. He had lent Antonia the money to buy the house. He had lent her the money to buy the barge. He had, in the way of such men, become so entangled in her fortune that he could no longer tell the difference between affection and exposure, and he greeted her with the kiss of a kinsman and the grip of a creditor.

'You have gilded the ceiling,' he said, looking up.

'I have.'

'How much?'

'Less than the ceiling in your atrium.'

'I have no ceiling in my atrium,' Naso said. 'I have a roof. Ceilings are for men who intend to be spoken of.'

'Then you have come to the right house.'

He laughed and let her take his arm, which was itself a kind of payment. Behind him came the others in a slow wash: Marcus Sestius Verus, who was praetor this year and never let a room forget it; the rhetorician Hermagoras of Smyrna, who had been hired for the evening at a price that would feed a street for a month; a widow named Vibia Lucana, who was Antonia's friend in the way that two people who know each other's worst transactions can be friends; and half a dozen more whose names mattered less than their money, and whose money mattered less than their willingness to be seen spending it.

Aulus Rubrius Celer came last, from the garden, with his hair still damp and his new senatorial stripe sewn, Antonia suspected, by his mother. He was twenty-six. He had been in the Senate for four months. He had, in that time, made two speeches, both of which Antonia had paid a man to praise in the Forum and both of which had gone badly.

'Domina,' he said, and then flushed at the word, because it was what a slave called his mistress, and because he never knew what to call her.

'Celer.' She took his hand. 'You have been drinking my water for an hour. Have you eaten?'

'I wasn't hungry.'

'You are always hungry. You are twenty-six.' She steered him toward the dining room with a hand at his elbow. 'You will sit next to Vibia Lucana and you will laugh at her jokes and you will not mention the grain commission until the third course, and when you do mention it, you will mention it as though it were my idea and not yours.'

'I don't understand why—'

'Because Sestius will oppose anything that comes from you, and he cannot oppose a thing that comes from me without admitting that I have ideas.' She smiled at him. 'He would rather swallow a wasp.'

The dining room, when they were all in it, was the most beautiful room in Rome that nobody respectable would admit to having visited. The seven couches were arranged in the old fashion around three sides of the table,

and the table was set with silver that Antonia had bought from the estate of a man proscribed twelve years before, and the light from forty lamps moved across the ceiling so that the zodiac seemed to turn, slowly, as though the room were a small heaven and the guests were its only souls.

There was a whole roasted boar stuffed with figs and small birds. There were oysters from Baiae, which had come up the road that morning in barrels packed with seaweed. There were dormice rolled in honey and poppy seed, which Antonia disliked and served anyway, because men who had read Martial liked to be able to say they had eaten them. There was a sauce of fermented fish that had cost more than the boar and a wine that was older than the youngest woman in the room.

Antonia lay at the head of the left couch, which was the host's place, and watched them eat.

This was the part of her work that no one ever counted. She had a woman who kept the accounts, and a man who kept the cellar, and Myrrhine who kept everything else, but the watching was hers. She watched who drank first and who waited. She watched which man put his hand on a slave's hip without looking, as though touching furniture, and which man's eyes followed a girl around the room and then away, ashamed. She watched Hermagoras, who had made his name by despising wealth, eat three helpings of oysters. She watched Sestius refuse the dormice and then take one when he thought no one was attending, and she thought: there. That is the whole man, in one small hypocrite's mouthful.

'You are quiet,' said Vibia Lucana, from the middle couch. She was forty-five, twice widowed, comfortably rich in her own right, and had the sort of laugh that made men check their purses.

'I am counting.'

'The silver?'

'The evening.' Antonia turned her cup slowly by the stem. 'In four hours, half these men will have told me something they did not intend to tell me. In six, one of them will have offered me something he cannot afford. In the morning I will know which of them is in trouble and which is merely afraid, and I will be able to tell the difference, and that is worth

more than the silver.'

'And the women?'

'The women will have told me everything by the second hour,' Vibia said, 'because we are better at this and always have been.'

The first course came and went. Hermagoras, who had been hired to be brilliant, was brilliant about the decline of oratory, a subject on which he was much in demand and about which he had said the same eleven things for thirty years. Sestius, who had been praetor for five months, spoke about the games he would give, at length, in the manner of a man laying the foundation of a monument; and Antonia, who had heard that he had borrowed heavily against his own praetorship and would be ruined by the autumn if the emperor did not see fit to give him a province, said, 'How fortunate that the people love you,' and watched him try to decide whether he had been complimented.

It was during the second course, when the room had loosened, that Hermagoras put down his cup and said, in the tone of a man introducing a small entertainment:

'I am told, Antonia, that you have a doctrine.'

'A doctrine.'

'About the ownership of things.' He smiled around the room, inviting it in. 'They say that when a man of your acquaintance dies, his heirs find that certain objects have been disposed of in ways that the law did not anticipate. They say you hold that a thing belongs to the person who can keep it, rather than to the person whose name is in the will.'

The room went quiet in the particular way a room goes quiet when the quiet is a form of pleasure. Sestius stopped chewing. Naso's hand, on the table, went still.

Antonia ate a piece of fig. She did not hurry.

'That is not a doctrine,' she said. 'That is the law.'

'The law,' said Hermagoras, 'is rather precise about ownership.'

'The law is precise about who wins. It is a set of instructions for settling disputes in favour of the man with the better advocate.' She looked at him with the mild interest she reserved for insects. 'You have spent your life

teaching young men to speak well enough to take things from other young men in a court. Would you like to tell me that this is not a doctrine?'

Hermagoras laughed, but his eyes had gone flat. 'You are a philosopher.'

'I am a woman with a house and a great many enemies. The two things make one practical.'

'Practical,' he said. 'Yes. Rome is a practical city.'

'Rome,' said Antonia, 'is a city that has spent four hundred years telling itself that the only true inheritance is blood, and which has been governed, in that time, by men whose grandmothers were shopkeepers. It is not a mystery. It is arithmetic.'

'You are speaking of the Senate.'

'I am speaking of the emperors,' she said, 'and you may make of that what you like.'

There was a silence of a different quality, and Naso, who was a man of business, said comfortably, 'The emperor's grandmother was a shopkeeper?'

'She was a potter's daughter from Spain,' said Antonia. 'She is buried with a very fine inscription that does not mention it.'

'And you think that is a comfort.'

'I think that is a fact,' she said, 'and facts are the only comfort I have ever found reliable.'

Between the third and fourth courses she rose and went to the room behind the library, where the girl was sitting on a stool with her hands folded, being quiet and pretty.

Lucilla had been bought in March from a dealer in the Campus Martius for eleven thousand sesterces, which was a great deal for a girl with no training and a voice that had not yet been placed in a body that had finished growing. She had been born in a villa near Narnia, the daughter of a woman who had died of a fever, and had been sold at thirteen by a man who had a legal claim to her that was probably a fiction. Antonia had

looked at her for a long time before buying her, because there was a thing you could see in a girl that told you whether she would survive the house or be destroyed by it, and Antonia had seen it in Lucilla, though she could not have explained it, and had not been sure she wanted to see it.

The girl stood up when she came in, and her hands went to her sides and then to her stomach and then, with an effort, to her sides again.

'You are to sing after the fourth course,' Antonia said. 'One song. The one about the swallow. Do you know it?'

'Yes, domina.'

'You will sing it to the room, not to me, and you will not look at any man's face while you sing, and when you have finished you will say nothing at all, not even if they applaud, particularly if they applaud, and you will come back here, and you will stay here until Meno comes for you. In the morning you will be taken to the house of my physician, who will look at your throat and tell you what your voice is.'

The girl's eyes had filled, but she held them level. 'Domina, if one of the men—'

'No one comes to this room.'

'If one of them sends for me—'

'No one sends for you,' Antonia said. 'You are not in the house tonight to be sent for. You are in the house tonight to be heard. In six months, if you are worth it, men will send for you and I will decide, and you will have some small share in that decision, because I am not a monster and because it is better business. But not tonight.' She reached out and pushed a strand of the girl's hair behind her ear, which was an intimacy she rarely permitted herself and which startled them both. 'Tonight you are a voice. Voices are not for sale. Only the evenings are.'

Lucilla's chin trembled, and then did not. She said, 'Yes, domina,' in a different voice from the one she had used before.

Antonia went back to the dining room with something hot and tight behind her breastbone that she recognised, after years of practice, as the last useless remnant of the girl she had been.

When the applause had died down and Lucilla had gone back to her room, Hermagoras, who could not bear a silence that he had not made, said, 'You have a painter's eye, Antonia. The ceiling is very fine. Who did it?'

'A man named Febronius,' said Antonia. 'He is sixty. He has a shop in the fourth region and he has not painted a ceiling in nine years, because his hands shake.'

'Then why him?'

'Because eleven years ago he asked me for a small thing in return for a small thing, and I said no, and I have regretted it ever since.' She turned her cup. 'He painted the ceiling on his back in the dark for nine months, and at the end of it he asked whether he might put his own name among the stars — three letters, in a corner, where nobody would ever see them. I told him no. I told him that a ceiling was a thing I had paid for and that a signature on it was a thing he would be giving himself at my expense, which was the kind of remark I used to make when I was thirty and thought that cleverness was the same as being right.'

'And now you have hired him again.'

'And now I have hired him again, and he has his three letters in the fleece of the Ram, and when the room is finished I am going to have a bronze tablet put up in the portico, and it will say who painted the ceiling and who laid the mosaic and who made the lamps, and it will be in the name of the house and not in mine.' She looked at Hermagoras. 'You may make of that what you like. It is not modesty. It is arithmetic. In twenty years there will be men in this room who cannot remember my name and who will read that tablet and know the name of a painter with shaking hands, and that is the only kind of immortality that money can buy, and it is cheaper than a statue.'

'It is a very Roman kind of immortality,' said Naso.

'It is the only kind I have ever wanted,' said Antonia. 'I do not want a statue. A statue is a thing that is put up in a forum and pulled down by the

next government. I want a name at the bottom of somebody else's work, in a place where nobody looks, that will still be there in a hundred years when everything above it has come down.'

She said it lightly, and the table laughed, and moved on to the subject of the emperor's building programme, and Antonia sat with her cup and looked at the ceiling and thought about a name in a register that she had written once, at fifteen, on a scrap of wood, and kept in a box with a piece of blue glass.

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At the fifth hour of the night the party had separated into its elements, as parties do. Hermagoras had retired with two men who wanted to be told that their verses were good. Sestius had gone out to the garden with Vibia Lucana, either to seduce her or to be seduced, and Antonia thought it would do him good to find out which. Celer was asleep, sitting up, with a cup in his hand and the look of a boy doing arithmetic in a dream. And Naso had asked, with a lifted eyebrow, whether there might be somewhere they could speak without being overheard.

They went to the study at the top of the west wing, which was the one room in the house no guest had ever been invited into, and which contained a table, four stools, a strongbox, a lamp, and a wall of pigeonholes full of wax tablets that were not what they looked like.

Naso sat without being asked. Antonia did not.

'The Bithynian,' he said.

'The Bithynian is paid.'

'The Bithynian is the eighth part of paid. You have paid the interest on the interest. I have carried you through the spring on an assurance.'

'The assurance was good.'

'The assurance is still good, or I would not be sitting in your study at the fifth hour of the night.' Naso rubbed his eyes with the heel of his hand. 'There is a difficulty, and I would rather you heard it from me than from a man in the street.'

'Say it.'

'Lucius Tarquitius Priscus has been appointed curator of the public works. Not the grain. Not the aqueducts. The works.' He let that sit. 'He will have the oversight of the streets, the water, the building permits, the inspection of private structures that abut public land. He will have the power to require the demolition of anything that encroaches. He will have the power to decide what is an encroachment.'

Antonia stood very still. The lamp guttered and recovered.

'There are four hundred houses in Rome that encroach,' she said. 'Mine is not one of them.'

'Your portico is nine feet into the street on the north side.'

'My portico has a permit.'

'Which will be reviewed,' said Naso, 'by a commission of which he is the head, and which will be composed of men who owe him favours, and which will meet, I am told, in the autumn.' He spread his hands. 'It is a small thing. It is a nothing. But a nothing in the hands of a man who hates you is a lever.'

'He does not hate me,' Antonia said.

Naso looked at her for a moment with an expression that was almost pity, and it was the first time in eleven years of business that she had wanted to hit him.

'He speaks of you in the Senate,' Naso said. 'Not by name. He speaks of the corruption of the city's pleasures, of the houses where men of rank are separated from their money and their judgement, of women who have grown rich on the weaknesses of their betters. His father spoke the same way. It is a family with a long memory and a great deal of land.' He paused. 'Whatever is between the two of you, it is not a small thing, and I would be a fool to pretend that it is, and I have never been that.'

'There is nothing between us.'

'There is nothing between a man who mentions you every year for twenty years and a woman who flinches when his name is spoken in her own house,' said Naso. 'No. Of course. There is nothing at all.'

Antonia walked to the pigeonholes. She put one finger on the edge of a tablet and did not take it down.

'What do you want?' she said.

'I want my two million sesterces on the Kalends of October, or a share of the house, or a name on the deed. I am not a hard man. I am a man with a wife who has begun to ask questions about my patience.'

'You will have your money.'

'From where?'

'From the grain,' she said, 'and from the fact that in six weeks there will be a shortage in the city that no one has noticed yet, and from a woman in Ostia who owes me an introduction I have never spent.'

Naso was quiet. Then he said, 'You will ruin yourself to spite him.'

'I will ruin him to keep myself,' said Antonia. 'It is not the same, though everyone in this city confuses the two.'

He rose, and at the door he turned and said, in a different voice, almost gentle: 'Antonia. When a man like that comes for a woman like you, he does not come for her portico.'

'I know what he comes for.'

'Do you?'

'Good night, Gaius.'

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The guests left between the sixth and seventh hours. Antonia stood at the gate and received their goodnights and their promises, which were the same thing, and watched the last litter turn into the street with its lamps swinging, and listened to the door being barred behind her. The house exhaled. Somewhere a girl laughed, and someone else told her to be quiet, and a broom began to move across the peristyle, and the whole great machine of the night began the work of putting itself back in order.

She walked the house as she did every night, and the house gave her its accounts.

In the kitchen, the cook's boy had burned his forearm and was being tended by the second cook with a salve and a great deal of scolding. In the corridor by the bath, Prima was sitting on a bench with her sandals in her hand, thirty years old and beautiful in the way a well-made knife is

beautiful, and she said, without looking up, 'Sestius put his hand up my skirt in the garden and told me he would have me flogged if I moved.'

'Did you move?'

'I moved,' said Prima.

'Good.' Antonia paused. 'He will not have you flogged. He will not remember it by morning, and if he does, he will remember that he was drunk and you were kind.'

Prima looked up. 'I was not kind.'

'That is between you and the gods.'

In the small room off the library, Lucilla was asleep on the stool with her head against the wall and her mouth open, and Antonia stood in the doorway for a moment, and then took a blanket from the chest and put it over her, and the girl did not wake.

In the passage by the bath she met an old woman carrying a tray of cups, and the old woman stopped and stood aside, and as she did it she put out one hand and steadied herself against the wall.

Antonia knew that gesture. She had made it herself, at fifteen, in a corridor in a villa above the Arno, with a jug in her hands: the small, automatic, self-effacing reach of a slave who has been on her feet for sixteen hours and does not intend to be noticed being tired.

'What is your name?' she said.

'Silvia, domina.'

'How old are you?'

'Sixteen, domina. Perhaps. I was bought at four and I was not told.'

Antonia looked at her: the flat feet, the hands like her own hands had been at that age, the tray held level with the elbow, the eyes down.

'I was in the linen at Arretium when I was your age,' she said. 'Do you know what the linen is?'

'No, domina.'

'It is a room with a table in it and a window of thick green glass, and everything you do in it smells of lye and the sun.' She took a cup off the tray, a good one, rock crystal, and looked at it, and then put it back and put her hand flat on the tray so that the girl had to stop. 'Silvia. Look at me.'

The girl looked up.

'You will be at the door of the dining room at the tenth hour tomorrow,' said Antonia, 'and you will ask to see the atriensis, and you will tell him that I have said you are to be taught to read. He will not believe you. He will come to me and I will confirm it. It will cost me nothing and it will take you two years and it will make you worth four times what you are worth tonight.' She took her hand off the tray. 'And when you are twenty-five and you have a trade, you will remember that a woman took a cup off your tray in a passage and looked at your hands, and you will do it to somebody else, and that will be the whole of the transaction. Do you understand?'

'Yes, domina,' said Silvia, and went on down the passage with the tray, and did not look back, and did not smile, and Antonia stood in the passage for a moment with her hand against the wall.

In the peristyle the fountain had been turned down to a trickle. Neptune stood with his hand up against the dark. Antonia sat on the edge of the basin, which was cool through the linen, and looked at the sky above the roof, which in Rome is never black but a kind of brown glow, the whole city burning its oil, all those millions of people awake or asleep under the same smoke, each of them convinced of the importance of his own affairs.

She thought about the man who had been appointed curator of the public works.

She thought: twenty-four years.

Then Cinnamus came across the garden with a lamp in one hand and a small sealed tablet in the other, and his face was the face he wore when he had decided to be calm and was not.

'Domina. A boy brought this to the gate. He would not wait.'

She took it. The seal was a boar's head, stamped deep into the wax, and beneath it two letters, L. T. P., in the old-fashioned way, as though the man were a consular writing to the Senate and not a senator writing to her.

She broke the seal with her thumbnail. The tablet was thin, the writing small and upright, without ornament.

L. Tarquitius Priscus to A. Cassia. You will attend my house on the Ides at the ninth hour. Come alone. Bring nothing with you that you cannot afford to lose.

Antonia sat with it for a long moment. The fountain trickled. Somewhere beyond the wall a cart went by with a wheel that needed grease, and a dog answered it, and then the street was quiet again.

'Cinnamus,' she said.

'Domina.'

'In the morning, find out everything that is known about the household of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus. The slaves, the freedmen, the clients. Who sleeps in the house and who does not. Who is owed money and who is owed favours.' She turned the tablet over in her fingers. 'And find out whether his mother is still alive.'

'His mother, domina?'

'His mother,' said Antonia, 'is the only person in that house who has ever told me the truth.'

She went up to her bed at the seventh hour of the night, and lay in the dark with the tablet on the table beside her, and did not sleep for a long time.

CHAPTER TWO

What the House Requires

— ◆ —

Morning in the Golden Vine arrived in five waves, and Antonia met them in order.

The first was the house itself, waking. Water carriers in the service court. The smell of bread and of the previous night's wine being scrubbed off the mosaic with vinegar. Meno unbarring the street door and swearing at the hinge he had sworn at every morning for nine years. She lay in the dark and listened to it the way a farmer listens to rain, and when she came downstairs at the second hour, dressed plainly, with her hair still wet from the basin, the house was already at work.

The second wave was the accounts. Cinnamus waited for her in the tablinum with the tablets stacked in the order he knew she liked: money owed to the house, money owed by the house, and the third stack, which was the one that mattered, and which contained the things that were neither.

Cinnamus was fifty-four and had been her first purchase as a free woman, bought at a price he had never been told, and he had repaid the favour by knowing everything about everybody and never once, in eleven years, letting a rumour leave the house on his own breath. He had a broad Celtiberian face, a limp, and a wife in the Subura whom he visited on the seventh day of each month, and he was the only person in Rome who called Antonia by nothing at all.

'Well?' she said.

'We are solvent,' Cinnamus said. 'We are not comfortable.'

'That is a change from last month.'

'Last month we were comfortable and we were not solvent.' He set a tablet on the table. 'The dinner cost forty-one thousand sesterces. That is the boar, the oysters, the hire of the rhetorician, the wine that the young

Celer drank without noticing he was drinking it, and the three jars of Falernian that went out the garden gate with Hermagoras's slaves at the fourth hour of the night.'

'The wine went out with him?'

'Three jars under a cloak. I have it from the doorkeeper, who is sure, and from the boy who carried them, who is terrified.'

Antonia considered. Somewhere in the house a woman was singing, badly, and stopped.

'Send the boy to the country for a month,' she said. 'Not punished. Working. And when Hermagoras next writes to me — he will write, he will ask for the loan of the library for his students — I will tell him that my wine merchant has raised his prices and that I am no longer able to offer the kind of hospitality he has enjoyed. He will understand it as poverty, which will please him, and he will not come again, which will please me.'

'He is a famous man. His dislike has a price.'

'His dislike has a price and his friendship has a cost, and the cost is higher.' She took the next tablet. 'The doctor?'

'Pamphilus came at the fourth hour. The girl Lucilla has a stricture in the throat, which he says is not a disease but a shape, and which she must learn to sing around. He says she has a rare voice and that she will ruin it if she is used too early.'

'How early is too early?'

'He says three years.'

'She has three months.'

Cinnamus did not argue, because arguing with her about a slave's price was a waste of his time and he knew she knew the arithmetic as well as he did. He moved to the third stack.

'The portico.' He put the tablet down. 'I have been to the tabularium. The permit was granted in the consulship of Commodus and Lateranus. It is good for the life of the building. It grants three feet of encroachment on the public street, not nine.'

Antonia's hand stopped on the tablet.

'It grants three feet,' Cinnamus repeated, 'and there is a second page, which is missing. The clerk showed me the binding. It was cut out with a knife, and cut out a long time ago, not last week.'

'Who cut it?'

'The clerk does not know. The clerk is a freedman of the urban prefect's office and has been in that room for thirty years, and he says that in those thirty years the book has been consulted by eleven people, of whom he remembers seven, and of the seven, four are dead.' Cinnamus paused. 'He remembers your father-in-law consulting it in the year you bought the house.'

'Gaius did no such thing.'

'I did not say he did.' Cinnamus looked at her steadily. 'I said he consulted it. There is a difference, and the difference is the only thing standing between us and a demolition order.'

Antonia sat back. Outside the study window the fig tree moved in the morning wind, and a pigeon on the roof made the noise pigeons make, which is the sound of a city pretending to be a farm.

'Then we have a permit for three feet,' she said, 'and we have built nine, and we have a new curator of works who has spent twenty years waiting for an excuse to take this house apart stone by stone. And if the missing page were found, it would show that the six extra feet were granted by a clerk in the year —' She stopped herself. 'What year?'

'The year you bought it.'

'Then it is what I have always known it was.' She stood. 'Bring me the stone.'

'Domina?'

'From the portico. Not one of the good ones. The one at the corner that the carters knock against. Bring it in and put it by the fountain, and leave it there, and if anyone asks why, the house is having repairs.'

'And what will the stone do?'

'Nothing,' said Antonia. 'It will be a stone in a house. But a man who comes to inspect my portico will see that I am having repairs and that I am not afraid, and he will go away and tell his master that I am not afraid, and

that will cost him a night's sleep. It is the cheapest harm I can do him.'

The third wave of the morning was people, and the people who came to the Golden Vine's door in the morning were not the men who came at night.

There were petitioners. A woman whose husband had been taken for debt, who had come because someone in her insula had told her that the woman in the big house on the north slope could get a man out of the carcer if she chose. A ship's captain with a claim against a merchant who had already been paid twice for the same cargo. A freedman from the Gardens of Maecenas with a scheme for a water clock that would tell the hour in any weather, who wanted four hundred thousand sesterces and who had brought drawings, and whose drawings were, Antonia thought, genuinely beautiful and completely impractical.

She saw them all. That was a rule older than her fortune. She saw them in the small room by the entrance, where the mosaic was worn, sitting on a bench with her hands folded, and she listened to each of them for as long as she judged them to be telling the truth, which was sometimes a quarter of an hour and sometimes ninety heartbeats.

'Why do you see them at all?' Celer had asked her once, in the early days, when he still believed that her time was a thing that could be wasted. 'They have nothing to give you.'

'Everyone has something to give me,' she had said. 'The woman with the husband in the carcer has a story that six insulae believe, and when I get her husband out she will tell it better. The captain has a ship and a grudge and a route to Ostia that passes a warehouse I want to buy. And the man with the water clock has a mind like a jeweller's, and in ten years he will be the most useful engineer in Rome and he will remember that I gave him an hour and the others gave him a door.'

'And in the meantime you have lost an hour.'

'In the meantime I have bought a man's whole future for an hour,' said Antonia, 'which is the best price in this city, and if you cannot see that, you

will not last three years in the Senate.'

The woman with the husband in the carcer she got out, at a cost of eleven thousand sesterces and one favour owed to a praetor's clerk who would one day want something she would not want to give. The captain she sent to Naso with a note, because a man who has been cheated twice by the same merchant will be a very good client for a banker who likes to watch a cheat being squeezed. The man with the water clock she gave two hundred sesterces and her Greek engineer's opinion, and told him to come back in the winter, and he wept, which happened about once a month and which she had long ago stopped being moved by and never once stopped noticing.

The fourth wave was the women of the house, and this was the part that no ledger recorded.

There were nineteen of them at that time, of whom eleven were on the roster and eight were not: the two who cooked, the woman who did the linen, the girl who carried water, the woman who tended the sick, and three children born in the house who were not yet anything at all. The eleven had come to it by eleven different roads. Prima had been taken in a raid on a village in Pannonia when she was nine and had been in Rome ever since, and had been bought by Antonia at twenty-four out of a house in the Argiletum where she had been beaten so regularly that the scars on her back had healed into a pattern like a river delta. Eucharis had been sold by her own father, a harp teacher on Delos, for a sum that he had used to buy a boat. Two of the women had been married and widowed. One had been a free woman of good family who had run off with a gladiator and discovered that the gladiator's affection had a term, and who still had the manners of a senator's daughter and used them like a weapon.

Antonia paid them. This was the thing she was known for and it was the thing that respectable men found most offensive, more offensive even than the trade: she paid wages. Not a share of what a guest left, not a gift at the Saturnalia. A sum at the end of the month, written in a book, with a column for the food and the clothes and the doctor and a column for what was their own. Some of them had bought their freedom with it. Three had

left the house and married. One had come back.

She held them to the account, too. There was the rule about the guests and the rule about the doors, and the rule that a woman who was hurt by a guest could come to Myrrhine in the night and that the guest would never be admitted again, no matter what he was, no matter what he could do to them; and there was also the rule that a woman who stole from the house was gone before dark, and the rule about drink, and the rule that none of them, ever, was to speak to Antonia about the past unless Antonia spoke first.

That last rule had been broken exactly once, by Prima, in the fifth year, and Antonia had listened to her for an hour and had said thank you, and then had gone upstairs and been sick.

The fifth wave of the morning was the city, and the city came in with the news.

It came with Celer, who arrived at the fourth hour with his toga crooked and his hair still wet, and who had clearly been running.

'Have you heard?'

'I have heard a great deal,' said Antonia. 'Sit down. You look like a man who has been chased.'

'It is not a rumour. It is in the Acta. Tarquitius Priscus has the cura operum publicorum, and he has already issued an edict, and the edict says that all encroachments upon public ground in the fourth and fifth regions will be inspected before the Kalends of October, and demolished at the owner's cost.' Celer sat, and then stood up again. 'The fourth region is the Temple of Peace. The fifth is the Esquiline. He has named your hill, domina. He has named the hill and not the street, which is how a man names a thing without naming it.'

'And?'

'And he has been made a candidate for the proconsulship of Asia, and the lot will be drawn in the winter, and everyone says the emperor favours him, and if he is proconsul of Asia he will be away for a year and will come

back with an army of clients and a fortune, and then there will be no touching him for a decade.'

'Then he will be away for a year,' said Antonia.

Celer stared at her. He had the beautiful, furious sincerity of the young, and she liked him for it and was sometimes tired of it, the way one is tired of a lamp that burns too brightly in a small room.

'You are not afraid,' he said.

'I am extremely afraid,' she said. 'I am afraid in the way that a man on a ship is afraid of the sea. It does not go away. It becomes part of the work.' She poured him water. 'Sit. Drink. And then tell me what he said in the Senate, in his own words, and not the words the Acta gave him, because the Acta are written by a freedman who loves the sound of his own indirect speech.'

Celer sat. He drank. He said, 'He spoke about the corruption of the city's pleasures. He said that Rome had grown rich and that wealth without ancestry was a fire without a hearth. He said that there were houses in this city where men of the equestrian order were separated from their judgement and their money in the same evening, and that the wives and mothers of Rome had begun to ask why the state permitted such houses to flourish within sight of the temples.' He paused. 'He did not say your name.'

'He never says my name.'

'He said "a certain woman." Twice.'

Antonia looked out of the window. A lizard had come out on the warm stone of the sill and was holding itself perfectly still, as lizards do, as though stillness were a form of armour.

'He has done that for twenty years,' she said. 'When I was thirty he said it in a case about a will. When I was thirty-four he said it in a debate on the corn supply, which had nothing to do with me at all, and three men came to my door that week to see whether I was ruined. He is not a man who forgets. He is a man who keeps accounts, and he has kept an account of me, and he adds to it every year, and one day he will present the bill.'

'Why?' said Celer. 'What did you do to him?'

There was a small silence. In it, Antonia heard the water clock in the corridor, the one that did not work, ticking anyway.

'I made money,' she said. 'In a city where he believes money should belong to men like him. It is the only crime he recognises.'

Celer did not believe her. She could see that he did not believe her, and she could see him decide, out of loyalty and good manners, not to say so, and she was grateful, and she made a note to give him something valuable before the month was out, because a young man who suppresses a question for your sake has earned a payment.

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Before the afternoon, she went to the baths.

The thermae of Trajan had been open three years and were already the largest thing of their kind in the world: a mountain of brick and marble laid over the slope of the Oppian, with a caldarium that could have held a market and a frigidarium in which the water was so cold that men made offerings to it. Antonia went twice a month, not for the water but for the crowd, because there was no place in Rome where a woman could hear more truth in an hour.

She took with her Myrrhine and two of the women and a slave with the oils, and they went in at the hour when the city's respectable women came, which is to say before the men, and she sat in the tepidarium with her hair pinned up and her feet in the warm water and listened.

Two wives of equestrians were discussing a divorce, in the oblique way that respectable women discuss such things, which is to say that they discussed a house in the country and a daughter's dowry and the difficulty of finding good wool, and in the middle of it one of them said, 'Of course, if he takes her to Baiae in September, everyone will know,' and the other said, 'Everyone has known since March,' and they both looked at Antonia, and looked away.

A merchant from Narbo talked to a merchant from Alexandria about the price of wheat, and the Alexandrian said that the harvest in Egypt had been good and the ships were coming, and the man from Narbo said that

the ships were always coming and the price was always rising and there was a something in the city, a nervousness, a rumour that the granaries had been oversold by men who did not have the grain to sell. He said it quietly. He said it in the tone of a man who did not want to be overheard saying that the emperor's annona was being cheated, because that was a thing that could be said by a man with a name and not by a man with a warehouse.

Antonia, with her eyes closed and the warm water moving against her legs, made a small calculation and put it away.

And then a woman came and sat beside her, and said, 'You are Antonia Cassia.'

She was perhaps fifty, dressed in the plain heavy wool of a woman who had never in her life needed to be beautiful, and she had the face of a woman who had spent forty years being obeyed.

'I am.'

'I am Aufidia Severa. My husband is a friend of Lucius Tarquitius.' She arranged her towel. 'I am told you have a house on the Esquiline where men go to do what they cannot do at home.'

'You are well informed.'

'I am told also that you are rich, and that you were not always rich, and that you have a great many friends who would not know you if they met you in the street.' The woman smiled at the water. 'I have wondered, sometimes, what it is like to be in a room full of people who are all, in some way, in your power. It must be very tiring.'

'It is,' said Antonia. 'But it is less tiring than being in a room full of people who are all, in some way, in the power of one man.'

Aufidia Severa turned and looked at her fully for the first time, and there was something in the look that was almost respect, and something that was certainly dislike, and Antonia had been looked at in that way by a hundred women of her class and had long ago stopped needing to know which part was which.

'They say he will be proconsul of Asia,' the woman said.

'They say a great many things in the tepidarium.'

'They say he has asked to see you.'

Antonia did not move. 'Who says that?'

'My husband's secretary's brother is a slave in the house of the Tarquitii,' said Aufidia Severa, and stood, and gathered her towel. 'You should know that in that house, a thing that is said at the second hour is in the city by the sixth. It is not a discreet family. It has never needed to be.' She looked down. 'Whatever he wants from you, he will get it, and then he will punish you for having given it. That is what he does. It is what his father did.'

She went away toward the caldarium. Myrrhine, who had been sitting within earshot with her eyes on the water, said, 'Do you believe her?'

'I believe the first half,' said Antonia. 'The second half is what every woman in Rome believes about every man, and it is usually true, which does not make it information.'

In the carriage going back up the hill, Myrrhine said, 'You are going to the Palatine.'

'I am.'

'On the Ides. Alone.'

'Yes.'

Myrrhine looked out at the street, where a man was selling water from a cart and two children were fighting over the dipper. She had been nineteen when Antonia had bought her out of a house in Puteoli, and had been, for two years, the person Antonia loved, and then for twenty-two years the person Antonia trusted, and the two things had been separated so cleanly that neither of them ever spoke of the operation.

'There is a thing I have never asked you,' Myrrhine said.

'Ask it.'

'If he offered you the whole of it, this afternoon — the name, the house on the Palatine, the respectability, the masks in the atrium and the wife's place at the games — would you take it?'

Antonia watched the cart go by.

'No,' she said.

'Because of what he did?'

'Because of what I would have to become to be given it,' said Antonia. 'They would not give me the name. They would give me a place in a house where the name was, and I would spend the rest of my life being grateful for it, and I have been grateful for things before and I did not care for the taste.'

Myrrhine was quiet for a while. Then she said, 'That is not the same as no.'

'No,' said Antonia. 'It is not.'

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That afternoon, alone, she went up to the room at the top of the west wing that had no window and opened the strongbox.

There were four things in it that were not money. A ring of iron keys, too small for any door in the house. A lock of hair, dark, cut with a knife and tied with a thread that had once been red. A scrap of papyrus on which someone had written a name and a date in a hand that was not hers. And a small clay figure of a woman with her hands over her face, which had been given to her by a slave in Puteoli who had told her that it would keep her from dreaming.

She did not take any of them out. She put her hand flat on the lid of the box and stood there for a while.

Then she went down and told Cinnamus to buy a gift.

'What kind of gift?'

'A book,' she said. 'Something old and dull and expensive. Varro on agriculture. And have it wrapped and sent to the house of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus, for his mother, with my respects, and no letter.'

Cinnamus's stylus stopped.

'To his mother,' he said.

'To his mother.'

'Domina, if I may — a gift to that house will be read as a submission.'

'It will be read as a courtesy,' said Antonia, 'by everyone except the one man who knows it is not. And he will spend the whole of the Ides

wondering what it means, and a man who is wondering is a man who is not yet acting. We need six weeks. A dull book buys me six weeks.'

Cinnamus wrote it down. He had a beautiful hand, and he wrote slowly, and he did not look at her, and she was grateful for that too.

On the Ides she went to the Palatine at the ninth hour, alone, in a plain litter, with no escort but the two bearers, wearing a dark dress and no jewellery but the carnelian ring. It was the first time she had been on that street in twenty-four years.

The house of the Tarquitii had been in the family for six hundred years, and it showed. Not in splendour: in wear. The stone of the threshold was dished by the feet of thirty generations. The bronze of the door knocker, which was a boar's head, had been polished so often that the bristles had been rubbed nearly smooth. In the atrium, the ancestral masks were arranged in their cupboards, and the wax of the oldest had gone the colour of old honey, and the eyes of them all were holes.

A slave took her name and went away, and came back, and took her into a small room off the peristyle where a woman sat in a chair with a rug over her knees.

Tarquitia Priscilla was seventy-eight. She had been beautiful in a hard, narrow way — the bones were still there, the long jaw and the straight nose of the coins — and she was blind, and her hands were in her lap, and her hands were the only part of her that had not aged, because they had never done anything.

'Cassia,' she said.

'Domina.'

'Come where I can hear you. There is a stool. Do not sit on the couch; the couch is bad for my back and I do not like to hear it being sat on.' The blind eyes moved, not quite toward her. 'You are heavier than you were. Your voice is lower. You have been smoking your throat with that Egyptian stuff, and you have been angry for a long time, and you have not slept properly since the spring.'

Antonia sat on the stool.

'You have not changed,' she said.

'I have changed in every way that cannot be heard.' The old woman's mouth moved, and it was not a smile. 'I hear that you have a house full of beautiful women and that senators go there and forget their own names. I hear that you are richer than my son. I hear that you pay wages, which is said in the city as though you had taught the birds to plough.' She turned her head. 'Was the book your idea?'

'Yes.'

'It was a good book. I have had it read to me twice. Varro is a bore, but he is an honest bore, and there are not many.' A pause. 'He has been in a fury since it came. He believes you are mocking us.'

'I am mocking him.'

'I know. I told him it was mockery and he did not believe me, which is the only advantage of being blind: when I tell a man a thing he does not wish to hear, he can pretend I have not seen it.' Tarquitia Priscilla lifted one hand, and a slave came and put a cup into it, and she drank, and put it back into the slave's hand without looking. 'Why have you come?'

'He summoned me.'

'He summoned you to humiliate you. He will keep you waiting and then he will be cold and then he will offer you something you cannot accept, and when you refuse it he will be entitled to say that you refused him.' The old woman's voice was dry as a husk. 'You should not have come.'

'I had to come.'

'Why?'

Antonia looked at the hands in the old woman's lap. Twenty-four years ago those hands had held hers, once, on a night in November, and had let go.

'Because I want to know what he wants,' she said. 'And because I want to know whether you are still alive, and whether you have anything to say to me.'

The blind face did not move for a long moment. Somewhere beyond the room a young woman's voice was reciting something in Greek, badly, and being corrected, and the correction was patient.

'He does not know what he wants,' Tarquitia Priscilla said at last. 'He has never known. He wanted to be his father, and his father died, and then he wanted to be better than his father, and that is a thing a man can only do in the Senate, where no one can see him. He has spent his life being magnificent in public and unanswerable in private. And he is fifty-three and he has one daughter and no son, and the name will end with him, and that is the only thing he thinks about at night, whatever he tells himself.'

'And the daughter?'

'The daughter is nineteen and she is better than he is and he does not know it.' The old woman's mouth tightened. 'She has been betrothed to a boy with a great name and no money, and she will be married in the winter, and she will have his children, and she will be unhappy in a way that no one is permitted to notice. It is the fate of women in this family. It was my fate. It was my mother's.' Her blind face turned, and it was terrible, because it was not aimed at Antonia and yet struck her. 'You escaped it, Cassia. You escaped it by a door that no decent woman would use, and you are the only one of us who is free, and I have hated you for it for twenty-four years and I am too tired now.'

Antonia's hands were cold. She said, 'I did not escape.'

'No,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'I know.'

And then a slave came to the door and said that the master would see her now, and the old woman's face closed like a shutter, and the moment was gone, and Antonia followed the slave down a corridor lined with the masks of dead men into the room where the master of the house was waiting.

CHAPTER THREE

The Weight of a Name

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The room was small for a man of his standing, and that was deliberate. Lucius Tarquitius Priscus received visitors in a study off the peristyle with a single window, a table of old oak, two chairs, and a bronze bust of his father on a bracket at eye level, so that whoever sat opposite him sat also opposite the dead consul. The floor was black and white in a pattern that had been fashionable a hundred years before. There was no carpet. There was no cushion on the visitor's chair.

He was standing when she came in, and he did not sit until she had.

'Cassia,' he said.

'Tarquitius.'

Twenty-four years. He had been twenty-nine. She had been fifteen and had come into a room with a jug in her hands and her eyes down.

He was a tall man, narrow, with the thin-lipped, high-nosed face that appears on coins and in the histories of families that have produced more magistrates than children. His hair had gone the colour of iron and was cut short in the old style. His hands were beautiful and he used them when he spoke, sparingly, like a man who had been taught that gesture was a form of extravagance. He wore a plain tunic and no rings. Twenty-four years had put a fold in his neck and a shadow under his eyes and had not touched the essential thing about him, which was that he looked at the world from a height.

'Sit down,' he said.

'I am sitting.'

'You are sitting in the chair I offer my clients.' He went to the window. 'I have thought about this conversation for some time. I had intended to begin with the portico.'

'Begin with the portico.'

'Very well.' He turned. 'You have nine feet of public street under your portico on the north side. Your permit allows three. The six feet were granted by a clerk who has been dead eleven years, in a document that has been removed from the file. I have the file. I have had it since the spring. I could require demolition by the Kalends of October, and I could fine you the value of the land for twenty years, which would be one hundred and eighty thousand sesterces, and I could do it in a way that would appear in the Acta as a routine correction, and every man in Rome who owes you money would read it and understand that you were finished.'

Antonia waited.

'That is what I could do,' he said. 'I have not done it.'

'Why not?'

'Because I am not a fool, and because in the fourth region there are four hundred encroachments belonging to men whose fathers sat with my father in the Senate, and if I begin with the woman on the Esquiline I will be asked why I did not begin with the portico of the Aquilii, which is eleven feet, or the shopfronts of the Vitellii, which are in the street entirely. A curator who is seen to be settling a private account is a curator who will not be curator for long.' He came back to the table. 'So I will make you an offer instead. It is an honest one. I would like you to consider it as such.'

'I am listening.'

'Sell me the house. Not the business. The building, the land, the portico. I will pay you its assessed value, which is one million two hundred thousand, and I will pay it in cash, and the sale will be entered in the usual way, and the encroachment will become a thing that I have inherited and must regularize, which I can do quietly and at my own cost.' He sat down. 'You will keep your fortune, your women, your clients. You will move to another house, of which there are eleven for sale in the city at this moment, and in a year the whole thing will be a curious anecdote.'

Antonia looked at him for a long moment. The bust of his father looked at her from its bracket with its bronze eyes, which were not quite symmetrical; one had been repaired.

'Why do you want the house?' she said.

'Because it is on the north slope of the Esquiline, at the corner of the Vicus Patricius, and because in four years the new bath complex will have doubled the value of every foot of that street, and because I am not a man who pretends that he does not notice such things.' He said it flatly, as though the admission cost him nothing, and perhaps for him it cost nothing. 'And because I do not care to live in a city where a house of that kind stands at the gate of my hill.'

'There it is.'

'There it is,' he agreed. 'You asked. I have answered.'

'You have answered half.' Antonia put her hands on the arms of the chair. 'You do not want the house. If you wanted the house you would have bought one of the other eleven and let me keep mine, and you would have had the pleasure of watching me grow poor. What you want is for me to sell it to you. To come to your table and take your money and sign my name under your name and go away quietly. You want me to agree.'

The room was silent. Outside, in the peristyle, a fountain made the smallest possible sound.

'Yes,' he said.

'Why?'

'Because twenty-four years ago you were in my father's house,' said Tarquitius, 'and you took something from it, and you have been spending it ever since, and every year that you spend it in public I am required to watch.'

Antonia felt the blood go out of her face and come back. She had known he would say something. She had rehearsed eleven answers on the way up the hill in the litter, and not one of them had been for this.

'I took nothing,' she said.

'You were given nothing. There is a difference, and it is the difference the whole city lives on.' He leaned back. 'I am not going to argue with you about the past. I have no interest in it. I am interested in the autumn. In the autumn I will be examined by the Senate as a candidate for Asia, and men who dislike me will ask whether a man who cannot keep order on his own hill is fit to govern a province. I do not intend to be asked that

question with your portico in the room. So. One million two hundred thousand, in cash, on the Kalends of September. You will be richer than you are now and I will be at peace, and in twenty years, when we are both dead, no one will remember either of us.'

'And if I refuse?'

'Then I will do what I am required to do as curator,' Tarquitius said, 'and it will be correct, and it will be legal, and it will be merciless. And you will know, when it happens, that it happened because you would not take a fair price, and that the fault was yours.'

Antonia stood up. She had not meant to stand up; her body had decided before her mind. He rose too, because he was well bred, and for a moment they were both standing with the table between them, and the distance between them was the width of a table and twenty-four years.

'You have made me an offer of one million two hundred thousand sesterces for a property worth two,' she said. 'You have told me that if I refuse, you will destroy me legally, and you have described the destruction in detail, and you have called it correct. And you have asked me to believe that you are doing this because of what I took from your father's house.' She heard her own voice, level, cold, and it was the voice she used in the worst moments of her business, and she was proud of it and appalled by it. 'Let me tell you what you are doing. You are fifty-three years old. You have one daughter and no son. In the winter you will go to Asia for a year, and while you are away the city will go on without you, as it always does, and when you come back there will be a new curator and new consuls and men who were children when you were consul, and they will not remember what you said in the Senate. You know this. You have known it for years. And the one thing in this city that still makes you feel that you are the centre of it is the fact that there is a woman on the Esquiline who will not bend, and that as long as she does not bend, you have an enemy, and a man with an enemy is a man with a place in the world.'

His face did not change. That was the frightening thing about him. His face did not change at all.

'Get out of my house,' he said, pleasantly.

'I am going.'

'You will not be offered again.'

'I know.'

'And you will send my mother no more books.'

'No,' said Antonia. 'I will send her better ones.'

She was at the door when he said, in a different voice, quieter, almost careless: 'You have a girl in that house. Seventeen. Bought in March.'

Antonia stopped. She turned.

'I have nineteen,' she said.

'I mean the singer.' He was looking at the window again. 'Lucius Sestius's son was in the Forum yesterday telling four men that he had heard her and that she will be worth ten thousand by the summer. He said it in the tone of a man describing a horse he intends to buy.' He turned. 'I am telling you this because I am curator of the public works and because it is nothing to do with me, and because you will not believe that I am telling you for any other reason. Do with it what you like.'

'Why?'

'Because I have been in this city for fifty-three years,' said Tarquitius, 'and I know what happens to a girl who is spoken of that way in the Forum before she is spoken of in a house. Good afternoon.'

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He watched her cross the peristyle. She did not hurry, and she did not look back, and at the gate she stopped and spoke to the doorkeeper for a moment, and the doorkeeper laughed, and she went out into the street and the gate closed.

He stood at the window for a long time.

She had grown into a woman who could look at him. That was the thing he had not been prepared for. When he had thought about her — and he thought about her more often than he would have admitted to any man living, and always in the same three or four attitudes, like a set of bad statues — she had been fifteen, with her hair down, holding a jug, in a corridor that smelled of lavender and lamp oil. He had thought of her as a

girl he had once been kind to. A girl he had made, in a sense: the money he had given her had been the beginning of everything she was.

There was a version of the story in which he was generous. He had gone over it so many times that it had become smooth, like a coin handled for twenty-four years. In that version he had loved her, or something like love, and his father had found out, and there had been a scene, and he had done what a son must do, and afterwards — afterwards he had arranged the manumission, and the money, and the introduction to the household of the merchant at Puteoli, and had told himself that this was mercy.

There was another version. He did not go over that one.

His secretary came in with the morning's letters and he took them and did not read them. On the table was the book she had sent his mother: Varro, in a bad fourth-century copy, with the owner's mark of a Greek library on the flyleaf. He had wanted to throw it in the fire. His mother had had it read to her twice.

'Domine,' said the secretary. 'The men from the fourth region are waiting.'

'Let them wait.'

'There are eleven of them, and one is the builder Caius Sentius, who has come three times.'

'Let him come a fourth time.' He turned. 'Did you find out what I asked you?'

The secretary hesitated. He was a careful man of forty with a club foot, freed by Tarquitius's father, and he had been in the house since before the events in question, which meant that he knew enough to be careful.

'The woman Bassa is still alive, domine. She lives at Baiae, in a house on the Lucrine road that was bought for her in the year —' he consulted his tablet, though he did not need to '— in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo. She is old and she is not well. She has a granddaughter who keeps house for her.'

'And the child?'

'There is no record of a child, domine.'

'There is always a record. There is a record of every slave born in Italy, because somebody paid tax on it.' Tarquitius turned from the window. 'Find the record. Do not send a slave; go yourself. Do not use my name. If the record does not exist, find out who was paid not to make it.'

'Domine.' The secretary bowed and went out.

Tarquitius sat down at the table and put his hands flat on the oak, one on either side of the bust of his father, and looked at nothing.

At the sixth hour he went to the baths, because he went to the baths at the sixth hour every day of his life and because a man who does not appear at the baths for a month is a man the city has begun to talk about.

The thermae of Titus were full. He went through the usual sequence: the apodyterium, the tepidarium, the exercise ground where he did not exercise but stood and was seen to have come, and then the caldarium, where he sat on the highest bench with a strigil in his hand and the steam so thick that nobody could see anybody's face.

Two men came in and sat on the bench below him, and did not know who he was, and talked about the woman Cassia for a quarter of an hour.

He listened to all of it. It was a small masterpiece of ignorance. She was, according to the elder of the two, a freedwoman of a Greek family who had made her fortune out of a shipping fraud at Puteoli. She was, according to the younger, the mistress of a senator whose name he did not know but who was certainly in the Senate that year. She had, according to both, four hundred thousand sesterces in a strongbox, a house full of women who were all in love with her, and a book in which the private business of half the city was written down and which she had used eleven times to destroy men who crossed her.

'She was in the basilica in November,' said the younger. 'My cousin was there. He said that she stood up and told the whole court what she cost when she was sixteen, and there was not a man in that hall who was not crying.'

'That is what she wants you to think,' said the elder. 'A woman like that does not tell the truth in a court. She tells the thing that will be believed, and she has been doing it for twenty years, and she has got very good at it.'

Tarquitius sat on the bench with the steam around him and the strigil in his hand.

He wanted to say: she was not good at it at fifteen. She was fifteen and she could read Latin badly and she laughed at a joke about a boundary stone.

He said nothing at all, and after a while the two men got up and went into the cold room, and he sat on the bench until his hands had begun to shake, which was the heat.

Afterwards he heard the men from the fourth region.

They came in one at a time, with their plans and their pleas, and he sat at the oak table with the file open, and he was, for two hours, exactly what he had spent his life training to be. The builder Caius Sentius had built a shopfront four feet into the street and had a lease going back forty years and a wife who was ill and three sons in the trade, and Tarquitius listened to all of it and said, 'You will pull down the four feet before the Kalends of August, and you will rebuild the front of the shop at your own cost, and you will keep the lease, and I will not fine you, because you came when you were called and you did not lie to me about the four feet.'

The man wept. Tarquitius looked at the table while he did it.

The second was a widow who had inherited a portico from a husband who had inherited it from a man who had built it in the reign of Vespasian, and who had no papers at all, and who had four children and a brother-in-law who wanted the property. Tarquitius gave her the portico. He gave it to her because the brother-in-law had come to him three weeks earlier with a purse, and because he had a memory for such things, and because the law, on the point, was on the widow's side, and because he liked the shape of the thing: a woman with no papers, keeping what was hers.

The third was a corn merchant named Felix who had built an upper storey over the pavement, and who had lied about it, and who had tried to have the surveyor transferred, and who had offered the surveyor's clerk a hundred thousand sesterces. Tarquitius made him pull down the storey, fined him the value of the land for ten years, and reported him to the prefect of the corn supply.

'Domine,' said the secretary, when the man had gone, 'the fine is heavy.'

'It is the fine the law provides.'

'It is the fine the law provides for a man who does not have friends in the Senate.'

'He does have friends in the Senate,' said Tarquitius. 'That is why the fine must be the fine the law provides. If I am easy on a man with friends, then every man without friends will know that the law is a thing that is bought, and then I will be the curator who sold Rome's streets, and there will be a poem about me by the winter.' He closed the file. 'And he lied to me. Write that down. Not in the record. In your own book.'

'You keep a book of men who lie to you, domine?'

'I keep a book of everything,' said Tarquitius. 'It is the only inheritance my father left that was worth having.'

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That morning, before any of it, the salutation had been at the first hour and had lasted two. Forty-one men had come to the house to pay their respects, and he had received them in the atrium standing, because a man who receives clients sitting looks like a man who needs them. The first eleven had been senators and had been given eight minutes each. The next twenty had been equestrians with petitions and had been given three. The last ten had been freedmen, and had been given the pleasure of seeing him, which costs nothing and is worth a great deal.

His daughter had stood at the far end of the atrium through the whole of it, with her nurse, as she had stood every morning since she was fourteen, because a daughter of the house should be seen to be part of the

house.

Tarquitia Marcellina was nineteen. She had her grandmother's bones and her father's height. She was dressed that morning in a plain white gown with a border of blue, and she had braided her hair herself, and she was holding a small ivory box, and she came to him when the last client had gone and said, 'Father, I have a petition.'

'You have a petition.'

'Yes.' She held out the ivory box. 'It is the money for the shrine of the Lares of the crossroads. The tenants of the two insulae have not paid their collection this month, and the man who collects has taken his share out of it and says that he is owed it for the carrying. I have counted it. There is eleven sesterces missing. I would like to pay it from my own allowance, and I would like to be permitted to go to the shrine myself and give it to the priest, because if I send a slave they will say that the lady of the house thinks herself too grand for the crossroads.'

He looked at his daughter, who was nineteen and had just handed him a lesson in the management of tenants, and who did not know that she had done it.

'You may pay it,' he said. 'You may not go yourself.'

'Father—'

'You may not go yourself because the crossroads of the Vicus Cyprius is not a place where a girl of this family walks without an escort, and because if you go with an escort the whole street will believe that the family is making some statement, and the priests of the crossroads will begin to expect it.' He handed back the box. 'Send the nurse. Send her twice. Make her stay and be seen to be bored.'

Marcellina took the box. Her mouth had set in a way he recognised, because it was his own mouth, and because he had set it in that exact fashion at her age, in that exact room, at his own father.

'And the betrothal?' she said.

'What about it?'

'It is in the winter.'

'It is in the winter.'

'I have met him four times,' said Marcellina. 'He is courteous. He is not clever. He has a great name and no money and he plays at dice with men who cheat him. He will spend my dowry in three years and then he will be sorry, and I will be in a house in the Subura with his mother, and I will be sorry, and neither of us will be able to say anything about it because we will have been seen at the games together.'

Tarquitius was silent. He had not known that she knew about the dice, and he was irritated with his secretary.

'He will improve,' he said.

'Will he?'

'Men improve when they have something to lose. You are something to lose.' He stood. 'This is not a matter for the atrium, Marcellina. If you wish to discuss it, come to my study at the ninth hour and we will discuss it as we would discuss any contract, and I will show you the accounts of his father's estate and you will see why the match is a good one.'

'I have seen the accounts,' she said. 'The nurse's brother is a clerk in the prefect's office. They are terrible.'

'Then you will see why it is a good match,' said Tarquitius. 'A man whose accounts are terrible and whose name is great will be grateful to the woman whose dowry saved him. Gratitude is the most reliable form of affection available to a marriage. I have seen it succeed a hundred times.'

'And the other kind?'

'What other kind?'

Marcellina looked at him. She had her grandmother's eyes, which were pale and direct.

'I have heard that there is another kind,' she said, 'and that people will ruin themselves for it, and that it is in songs, and that when it happens in this city it is always a scandal and sometimes a death. And I have lived in this house for nineteen years, father, and I have never once seen it.'

'You have seen a great deal of Rome for a girl of nineteen,' said Tarquitius, 'and none of it has been seen by you. Go and do your accounts. The eleventh sesterces will be found in my study at the ninth hour, and you will enter it in the book as a gift, not as a payment, because a gift is

remembered and a payment is expected.'

She went. He watched her go, and thought, with a clarity that was almost pain: she will be married in the winter, and he could not protect her, and the boy would spend the dowry, and in ten years she would be a woman who had learned to say pleasant things in rooms where she was not listened to. It was the way of the world. It had been his mother's way. It would be his daughter's way.

And yet.

He went to the tablinum and worked until the sixth hour, and then he walked in the garden, and then he came back and stood at the window of the small study, and it was then that they told him Antonia Cassia had arrived.

Now, hours later, the light was going. He rang the little bell and told the slave to bring wine, and to bring it to the room where his mother sat.

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Dinner in the house of the Tarquitii was at the eighth hour in summer, in the small dining room, with the three of them: his mother, his daughter, himself. It had been the same room and the same hour for thirty years. The walls were painted with scenes from the Aeneid in a style that had been old when his grandfather was young, and the couches were of the same pattern, and the silver was the silver that had come to the family with his grandmother, and had been repaired in eleven places.

His mother ate with her fingers because she was blind and would not be fed. Marcellina read to her while they ate, in Greek, from the book she had chosen, which tonight was not Varro but a volume of letters, and she read badly, and her grandmother corrected her without malice and without stopping.

'There is a thing I have been meaning to say,' said Tarquitius, when the plates had been taken.

His mother went on chewing.

'The woman Cassia came today.'

'I know. I heard her in the peristyle.' Tarquitia Priscilla wiped her fingers on the napkin. 'She walks like her mother. Did you know that? Her mother walked with her weight forward, as though she expected the floor to give.'

'Her mother was a slave in a fuller's shop at Baiae,' said Tarquitius.

'Her mother was a Bithynian who had been sold twice before she was twenty, and she had a way of holding her head that her daughter has, and you never noticed it because you have never in your life looked at a slave's mother.' His mother turned her blind face toward him. 'What did you offer her?'

'A fair price for the house.'

'And she refused.'

'She refused.'

'Of course she refused.' Tarquitia Priscilla held out her cup and a slave filled it. 'Lucius, I am going to say something to you, and you will not like it, and I am eighty-seven years old and I have been saying things you do not like since you were four.'

'I am fifty-three, mater.'

'You are a boy who has been left in charge of a very old house,' she said. 'You have spent your life being correct. It has been your whole armour. You were correct when you were quaestor and correct when you were consul and correct in the law courts and correct with your wife, God rest her, who was a stupid woman and deserved better than correctness. And there is one thing in this world that has never been correct, and it happened in this house, and it was not her doing, and you know it.'

Marcellina had stopped eating. She was looking at her plate with great concentration.

'We are not discussing this at table,' said Tarquitius.

'We have never discussed it at table. We have never discussed it anywhere. That is the thing about this family: we do not discuss, and then we die, and the masks go up in the cupboard, and the next generation inherits a silence and does not know what it is for.' His mother's voice did not rise. 'When I am dead you will have no one in this house who

remembers, and you will find that a great relief for about a year, and after that you will find that you have become a man who talks to a bust.'

'Marcellina,' said Tarquitius. 'Leave us.'

'No,' said his mother. 'She is nineteen. She is to be married and taken out of this house in the winter, and she will sit at another table with another family's silences, and it would be a mercy if she knew, before she went, that the silences in this house were not her fault and were not her inheritance to keep.'

There was a long silence. The lamp on the sideboard had begun to smoke at the wick and a slave moved to trim it, and the shadow of the slave went up the painted wall and over the burning ships of Troy.

'Father,' said Marcellina, quietly. 'What happened in this house?'

Tarquitius looked at his daughter, and at his mother, and at the wine in his cup.

'Nothing that concerns you,' he said.

He said it pleasantly. He had been saying it pleasantly for twenty-four years, to himself, in the dark, in the middle of the night, when the whole of Rome was asleep and he was lying on his back in a house six hundred years old with the masks of dead men in the next room, and he had almost succeeded in believing it.

Almost.

CHAPTER FOUR

Debts Called In

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Naso came on the fourth day after the Ides, and he came in the morning, which was a bad sign. Men who bring good news come at night, when there is wine.

He would not sit in the study. He walked up and down it, three paces and turn, and the lamp on the table watched him go.

'He has written to the urban prefect,' he said. 'Not about you. About the fourth region generally, and about the inspection of private structures, and about the need for a schedule of demolitions by the Kalends of October. It is a routine letter. It has been copied to eleven men, of whom I am one, because I am a banker with property on the Esquiline and therefore a person who ought to be informed.' He turned. 'Do you know what it is like to receive a routine letter from a man who is going to be proconsul?'

'Tell me.'

'It is like being told, very politely, that your name is on a list.' Naso stopped walking. 'My partners have read it. My wife's brother has read it. Two of them came to me yesterday and asked whether the house of Cassia is a good risk, and I said yes, and they asked me to say it again with a number attached, and I could not.'

'How much?'

'Two million by the Kalends of September.' He held up his hand. 'I know what I said in the spring. I am not withdrawing the loan; I am moving the date. If I do not have the money by September I will have to sell my share of the Ostian warehouse to a man I do not like, and I would rather be thought a coward by you than be ruined by my own brothers-in-law.'

Antonia stood by the window with her back to him.

'You are not a coward,' she said. 'You are a man with partners. I have been a man with partners. It is an illness that makes you say things you would not otherwise say.'

'That is a generous reading.'

'It is an accurate one,' she said, 'and it costs me nothing, which is why I can afford it.'

She turned around. She had been awake since the fourth hour, which was when the letter from Ostia had come, and she had spent the two hours before dawn doing arithmetic on a wax tablet, and the arithmetic had been good.

'I can have it by September,' she said. 'Not from the house. From the grain.'

Naso's face did something complicated.

'You have been listening to the Alexandrian,' he said.

'I have been listening to everyone. That is what I am for.' She sat down at last and pushed the tablet across the table. 'Read it.'

He read it. He read it twice. Then he sat down, which was the first thing he had done that morning that resembled a man at his ease.

'The granaries are oversold,' he said. 'That is the whole of your argument. There is a rumour that they are oversold, and the rumour has been in the city for a month, and the price has gone up eleven per cent on the rumour alone, and if the Alexandrian fleet comes in on time the price will fall, and everyone who bought on the rumour will be ruined, and you will be one of them.'

'The fleet will not come in on time.'

'You cannot know that.'

'I can know that the corn merchant Felix has been buying contracts for grain he does not have,' said Antonia, 'because he has been doing it for two years, and because last month he was fined by the curator of works for a building offence and lost nine hundred thousand sesterces in a single afternoon, and because a man who has just lost nine hundred thousand sesterces and who is already selling grain he does not own will not stop. He will double. That is what men like Felix do. They do not reduce; they

double, because the alternative is to admit that they are finished, and there is no man in Rome who will admit that before dinner.'

Naso looked at the tablet.

'You want to buy his contracts,' he said.

'I want to buy his contracts at a discount, from a man who is desperate, in the last week of August, when he has realised that he cannot deliver and that the prefect of the corn supply is asking questions.' Antonia poured wine for both of them, which was itself a statement. 'Then I will hold them. I will not sell in the panic. When the price peaks — and it will peak, because there is less grain in Italy than the price says there is — I will deliver, and I will deliver to the city at a price that is high but not obscene, and the prefect will remember that when everyone else was hoarding I delivered, and that is worth more than the profit.'

'And the profit?'

'One million eight hundred thousand, if I am right. Two million two hundred if the harvest in Africa is as bad as the reports.' She drank. 'If I am wrong, I will lose the house and I will go to Puteoli and keep a shop, and you will have to explain to your brothers-in-law that you lent money to a woman who tried to corner the corn supply of Rome, which is a crime, and which will be in all the courts by the winter, and you will be ruined in a way that will be remembered for a generation.'

Naso sat very still.

'You are telling me this,' he said, 'so that when it happens I cannot say I was deceived.'

'I am telling you this so that you understand what you are being asked to do, which is not to lend me money. It is to hold your nerve while I do something that could destroy us both.' She set down her cup. 'I have never lied to you, Gaius. Not once in eleven years. There are men in this city who think that is a virtue. It is not. It is a business practice, and it has made me a great deal of money, and it is the reason you are sitting in this room instead of sending a slave.'

Naso looked at her for a long moment. Then he picked up his cup and drank the whole of it, which was not his habit.

'August,' he said. 'Not September. My brothers-in-law will not last until September.'

'August.'

'And if Felix will not sell?'

'Then I will find the man who holds his paper,' said Antonia, 'and I will buy it from him, and Felix will never know I was there until it is too late to stop it. There is always a man behind the man. That is the first thing I learned in this city, and it is the only thing I have never had to revise.'

She went to Ostia on the eleventh day after the Ides, at dawn, in a covered carriage, with Cinnamus and Brennus and two men she did not know well enough to like and trusted completely, which was a combination she had learned to look for in guards.

The road out of the city ran past the cattle market and the rubbish tips where the gulls came inland to feed, and then out into the flat country where the market gardens were, and then down through broken ground to the river. It was hot. The dust went into the throat and stayed there. Twice they passed carts turned over at the side of the road with men standing around them in the particular attitude of men who have decided that the day is finished.

Ostia in the morning smelled of tar and fish and the sweet rot of grain. The harbour was a forest of masts. The Alexandrian ships lay at the far mole, high out of the water, their crews asleep on the decks under awnings; and along the quays the stevedores were unloading the African fleet, which had come in three days before, and which was carrying about two thirds of what it had been contracted to carry, because two of the ships had been lost off Sicily and one had put in at Syracuse with a broken mast and a cargo that had heated in the hold.

Antonia stood at the end of the quay and watched the sacks come off. She counted, because she could not help counting, and the number did not please her any more than the report had. There was grain in Ostia. There was not enough grain in Ostia.

'It is worse than the letter said,' Cinnamus murmured.

'It is worse than the letter said and better than it will be in a month,' said Antonia. 'Where is the warehouse?'

'Beyond the temple of Vulcan, on the north side. It is the one with the new shutters.'

The warehouse of the corn merchant Felix was a long brick building with a tiled roof and a door of oak, and it was shut, and there was a man sitting on the step in front of it with his head in his hands.

He looked up when they came. He was perhaps forty-five, with the ruined complexion of a man who had once been florid and had lately stopped eating, and he was dressed in a tunic that had been expensive.

'The warehouse is closed,' he said.

'I am not here for the warehouse,' said Antonia. 'I am here for the paper.'

Felix got to his feet.

'Who are you?'

'My name is Cassia. I have a house on the Esquiline.' She stood in front of him, and she was shorter than he was and somehow it did not seem so. 'You were fined by the curator of the public works a month ago for building over the pavement, and you have been buying grain on the Alexandrian market for two years with money you did not have, and last week you sold three contracts for delivery in September to a man named Sura who is a client of my banker's, and there is not enough grain in Italy to fill them.'

Felix's face went through several things. The last of them was a kind of relief.

'You are here to ruin me,' he said.

'I am here to buy them.'

'At what price?'

'Sixty per cent of what you paid.'

'That is robbery.'

'That is sixty per cent more than you will get in September, when Sura discovers what you have done and takes you to court, and the prefect of

the corn supply discovers it at the same time and decides whether you are a fool or a criminal, and the difference between those two things in this city is about four days.' She let that settle. 'I will also require you to sign a statement that the contracts were sold to me without any guarantee of delivery, and that you told me, at the time of sale, that you were unable to fulfil them.'

'That is a confession.'

'It is an insurance policy. If you run, I will have it. If you lie about me afterwards, I will have it. If you do neither, it will stay in a box in my house for the rest of your life, and you will be free to grow old and be a fool in peace.' She took the tablet Cinnamus held out. 'Read it. Take it to your own advocate if you want. I will be at the inn by the theatre until the ninth hour.'

Felix read it there on the step, with the gulls screaming over the harbour and the stevedores chanting on the quay, and his hands shook.

'Why?' he said. 'You could have waited three weeks and taken everything.'

'Because in three weeks there will be a shortage in this city,' said Antonia, 'and if I wait three weeks I will make a great deal of money out of hungry people and I will be the woman who did it, and this city never forgets a woman who did it. If I buy now, I can deliver, and I can deliver at a price I choose, and I will be the woman who had grain when there was none. That is not virtue. It is arithmetic on a longer term.'

Felix looked at her.

'You are a strange woman,' he said.

'I am a woman who has been poor,' said Antonia. 'There is nothing strange about it. Poor people think about food all the time. It is one of the few advantages.'

Two days after Ostia she went to the office of the prefect of the corn supply, which was in a building behind the Porticus Minucia, and she went at the fourth hour in the morning and she waited in a queue for two

hours with forty other people.

The queue was made up of bakers and millers and the agents of shipping families and one man who had come about a boat, and it moved at the speed of a queue of people who are all waiting for a clerk, which is to say that it did not move.

Antonia had brought a stool, a slave with a fan, a tablet, and a book of contracts. She sat in the middle of the queue and read the contracts and marked them with a stylus, and she did it in full view of everyone, and by the end of the second hour three of the men in the queue had asked her what she was reading.

'The grain contracts for September,' she said. 'I am buying them.'

'From whom?'

'From whoever is frightened,' said Antonia, 'which will be eleven men by the end of August, and two of them are in this queue.'

The clerk who took her tablet was a thin, harassed man of forty with ink on his sleeve, and he looked at the contracts and then at her.

'These are contracts for delivery,' he said. 'You are not registered as a corn merchant.'

'I am registered as a creditor of four corn merchants,' said Antonia. 'The contracts are in their names and they have assigned the delivery to me, which is lawful, and I have the assignments here and they are witnessed. I am not asking you for a licence. I am telling you, in a room with a queue in it, that when the shortage comes there will be a woman on the Esquiline who has the paper for four hundred thousand modii, and I would like the prefect's office to have heard of it before it happens and not afterwards.'

The clerk put the tablet down.

'Why?' he said.

'Because in three weeks the price will rise and men will say that someone is hoarding, and the someone will be the woman with the foreign name,' said Antonia. 'I would like there to be a note in a file in this office, in your hand, dated today, that says she came in before it happened and told the office what she was doing. You will not remember me in a year. The file will.'

The clerk looked at her for a long moment. Then he wrote a note.

On the way out she passed a woman of about fifty in a good cloak who was sitting on the bench by the door with a basket on her lap, and the woman said, 'Is it true that you are buying grain?'

'It is true that I have bought paper for grain,' said Antonia. 'It is not the same thing, and in three weeks it will be the only thing about me that anybody remembers correctly.'

'My husband has a mill on the Tiber,' said the woman, 'and he has been buying in a panic since June, and he has borrowed money from his brother to do it, and his brother is a fool and has told the whole street.'

'Then tell your husband to stop buying,' said Antonia, 'and to sell a third of what he has in the last week of August, and to hold the rest.'

The woman stared at her.

'Why would you tell me that?'

'Because a mill on the Tiber will be useful to me in October,' said Antonia, 'and because I have just spent two hours in a queue and I have discovered that I cannot bear a room full of frightened men and no women in it.'

The favour from Vibia Lucana she called in three days later, over dinner in Vibia's house on the Caelian, which was small and full of very good Greek things and had a garden the size of a dining couch, in which Vibia grew nothing but roses and had them cut and sent to people she wished to impress or reproach.

They ate simply: bread, cheese, olives, a fish that had been alive that morning, and a wine that Vibia did not announce the vintage of, which was itself a form of boasting.

'You want me to speak to the prefect's wife,' Vibia said, when the plates had gone.

'Yes.'

'About the grain.'

'About the fact that there will be a shortage, and that when it comes there will be men in the city who say it is the fault of the emperor's officials, and that the prefect will need someone to be known to have been sensible in advance.' Antonia broke a piece of bread. 'His wife does not like me. She will not listen to me. She will listen to you, because your mother was her mother's friend, and because you are respectable and I am not, and because you have never in your life asked her for anything.'

'And you want me to spend that,' said Vibia. 'The one thing I have that is not for sale.'

'Yes.'

Vibia poured more wine. She was forty-five and had buried two husbands and had a laugh that could empty a room or fill it, and she had been, for eleven years, the only person of her class in Rome who came to Antonia's house without pretending that she was doing something else.

'There is a thing I have never understood about you,' she said. 'You could have been respectable. Not at twenty, no. But at thirty, with money, married to some equestrian with a decent name and a bad estate — you could have bought your way into a dinner table and been tolerated, and your daughter would have married a senator's son. Instead you built that house and you filled it with women and you made yourself the one thing this city cannot forgive.'

'What is that?'

'A woman who does not need a man's name to be safe,' said Vibia. 'They can forgive a rich freedwoman. They can forgive a courtesan. They cannot forgive a woman who has a house that men come to, with her own name over the gate. It is not the trade that offends them. It is the sign.'

Antonia turned her cup slowly.

'You are asking me why I did not become respectable,' she said. 'The answer is that I tried. For four years, when I first had money, I tried. I wore the right wool and refused the right invitations and went to the temple of Pudicitia with women who spoke to me and looked at my hands to see whether they were a slave's hands.' She held them up. They were not; they were a rich woman's hands, and the marks of the loom had faded thirty

years before. ‘And in the fourth year a man at a dinner said something to me, and I answered him, and there was a silence, and then a woman said, very kindly, "She is clever, isn’t she," and everyone laughed, and I understood that I could spend the rest of my life being laughed at kindly, or I could build a house where I made the jokes.’

‘And now?’

‘Now I am laughed at unkindly,’ said Antonia, ‘by men who need me, in a house I own, and I find that I prefer it.’

Vibia laughed — the real laugh, the one she kept for her own table.

‘I will speak to her,’ she said. ‘And you will owe me.’

‘I will owe you.’

‘And one day I will ask you for something that is not respectable, and you will not refuse me, because you will remember this fish.’

‘What could you possibly want that is not respectable?’

Vibia turned her cup. ‘I am forty-five,’ she said, ‘and I have been a widow for six years, and in this city a widow of forty-five is a piece of furniture that is permitted to talk. I would like, before I am too old, to do one thing that is entirely my own and entirely unwise.’ She looked up. ‘I do not know what it is yet. When I know, I will come to you, and there will be no discussion of virtue or arithmetic, and you will help me, and neither of us will ever mention it again.’

‘Agreed,’ said Antonia.

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The secret she had kept for more than a decade concerned a fire.

In the third year of the emperor’s reign there had been a fire in the ninth region, in a block of tenements off the Via Lata, and nineteen people had died, and the block had belonged to the family of Marcus Sestius Verus, who had been aedile that year and responsible, in a general way, for the city’s fire precautions, and whose brother had owned the warehouse next to it.

The tenements had burned. The warehouse had not. It had not burned because the watch had been directed to it first — not by Sestius, but by a

man who worked for him, a contractor of the vigiles named Gaius Albinus, who had been paid eleven thousand sesterces to be confused about which building was on fire, and who had come to Antonia nine months later, drunk and terrified, because his son had died and he had begun to think about judgement.

She had written down what he said. She had kept the tablet. She had also kept the name of the woman who had sold Sestius the ground the tenements stood on, which he had bought at a tenth of its value eleven days after the fire.

She had never used it, because a thing like that could only be used once, and because the man who used it would have to be willing to be the sort of man who had it. She had told herself, on the nights when she took the tablet out and looked at it, that she was keeping it for a day when she would need it, and she had known, even then, that the day would come,and that when it came she would find that she had been keeping it not for the day but for the pleasure of knowing it was there.

The day came three weeks after the Ides of May, at the eleventh hour of a warm night, when a young man with his father's jaw and none of his father's sense came to the door of the Golden Vine and asked for the singer.

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'He is in the atrium,' said Meno, from the doorway of the study, in the voice of a man who had been arguing. 'He has two friends with him and a litter in the street. He says he is the son of the praetor.'

'He is the son of the praetor,' said Antonia. 'Show him into the small room. Fetch Myrrhine and do not fetch anyone else. And Meno — the girl is not in the house. Do you understand me? If he asks for her, the girl is not in the house.'

Meno looked at her for a moment. He had been a doorkeeper for thirty years in four houses and he understood her perfectly.

'A girl is never in the house,' he said, and went.

Lucius Sestius Cirrus was twenty-two. He had his father's breadth and his mother's money and the particular confidence of a young man who has never been refused by anyone except his father. He was drunk in the way of a man who has been drinking since the afternoon and has reached the stage of absolute clarity.

He bowed, badly.

'Cassia.'

'Cirrus.'

'I have come about the singer.'

'There are eleven women in this house and several of them sing. You will have to be specific.'

'The little one. The Greek. Lucilla.' He smiled. 'You know the one. My father heard her at your dinner in May. He said she had a voice like a knife in a drawer. He has talked about it for a month, which for my father is a kind of passion.'

'Your father has excellent taste,' said Antonia.

'He has. He also has a wife, and a career, and a reputation for severity that he is very careful of, and so he will not do anything about it.' Cirrus sat down without being asked. 'I have none of those things. So I am here.'

'To do what?'

'To buy her evening.'

'She is not for sale.'

'Everyone is for sale. My father says so. My father says the only question is the price and whether the seller is honest about it.' He leaned forward. 'I will give you twenty thousand sesterces for one night. Not for the house. For me. She can keep nothing; I'll give the money to you, and you can give her whatever you think is proper, and the whole of Rome will say that Antonia Cassia got twenty thousand for one girl's night, and there are men who will come to you next week with better offers, and you will be richer, and she will have a story to dine out on for the rest of her life.'

Antonia sat down opposite him and folded her hands.

'You have thought about this,' she said.

'I have thought about it all week.'

'And what will you do when she says no?'

'She will not say no. She is a slave.'

'She will say no,' said Antonia, 'because I will tell her to, and because I will be in the room, and because — this is the part that you have not thought about, Cirrus — because she is seventeen and you are a man who has never had to ask twice for anything, and the thing you want is not a night with a singer. The thing you want is to be refused and then to win, and I am not going to give you that, because the last man I gave it to is now a magistrate who cannot walk through the Forum without being laughed at behind his back.'

Cirrus's face changed. He was not stupid, and it was the worst thing about him.

'You are threatening me,' he said.

'I am telling you that you are in my house at the eleventh hour, drunk, with two friends in my atrium, asking for a girl who is not here, and that if you go home now, in the morning this will be a thing you did when you were young.' Antonia stood. 'If you do not go home, it will be a thing that happened to you, and you will not enjoy it, and neither will your father, and your father will know that it was your fault, which he will not forgive.'

For a moment she thought he would hit her. His hand moved on the arm of the chair. Then he stood up, and straightened his tunic, and smiled the smile of his father, which was worse than the anger.

'My father has been looking for a reason to close this house for eleven years,' he said. 'He has the ear of the urban prefect and the prefect of the corn supply and half the Senate. He only lacks a complainant.' He went to the door. 'You have made one tonight. Remember that when the seal goes on your door, Cassia. I want you to remember that it was not the great man on the Palatine who did it. It was the boy you would not sell a girl to.'

He went out. The street door closed. In the atrium his friends laughed at something, and then the litter was lifted, and the sound of it went away down the hill.

Myrrhine came in with her arms folded.

'Well,' she said. 'That was foolish.'

'It was correct.'

'It was correct and foolish and they are not exclusive.' Myrrhine sat on the edge of the table, which she was the only person in the world permitted to do. 'He will go to his father. His father will go to the prefect. In September there will be an inquiry into the morals of this house, and you will be required to answer, and you will need an advocate who is not frightened of the Sestii, and there is no such advocate in Rome except the men who are already Sestius's friends.'

Antonia went to the window. The street was empty and the lamps at the corner had been lit by the watch. Somewhere beyond the wall a woman was singing, very badly, the same song Lucilla had sung at the dinner.

'There is one,' she said.

Myrrhine looked at her.

'No,' she said.

'He is the best jurist in the city. He was consul. He has never lost a case he undertook, and he has undertaken cases against men with better names than Sestius. He hates me, and he would rather see me ruined than saved, and he is the only man in Rome who could stand up in the basilica and say that Antonia Cassia is innocent of a charge and be believed, because everyone knows what he thinks of me and everyone would know that he was saying it against his own inclination.'

'No,' said Myrrhine again.

'Not yet,' said Antonia. 'But by the winter, if it comes to it, I will go to him and I will ask him, and he will refuse, and I will make him do it anyway.'

'How?'

Antonia turned from the window.

'Because twenty-four years ago his father's house did something that his mother has never forgiven him for,' she said, 'and I know exactly what it was, and I have never once in twenty-four years used it. That is what I have instead of a name. It is not much. But it is mine.'

PART TWO

The Price Of A Name

CHAPTER FIVE

The Linen Room

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Arretium, twenty-six years earlier.

The villa of the Tarquitii stood on a ridge above the Arno valley, in country that was green in spring and yellow in July and full of the sound of doves. It had been built by a man who made money in the clay beds and married into a family that made money in the Senate, and it had been enlarged four times since, so that it was not one house but a series of houses leaning against one another, with a courtyard in the middle and a tower at the northern end that was used for storing quinces and, in the summer, for sleeping, because it was the only place on the estate where the air moved.

Cassia was fifteen that spring and had been in the household for two years, and she knew the villa the way a sailor knows a ship: not room by room but by the things that needed doing in each of them.

She knew that the old consul's chamber faced north and got no sun after the fourth hour and was therefore cold even in June, and that he hated being cold, and that there were three braziers in it and only one was ever lit. She knew that the steward, who was called Faustus and was a freedman of the family, counted the wine on the calends and the oil on the ides and the linen once a week, and that his count depended on the weather, because he counted what was dry. She knew that the cook's daughter had a cough that would kill her before the winter, and that the cook knew it, and that no one spoke of it. She knew that the second-best dining room had a mosaic of a hunting dog in the doorway that had been damaged in the year of the earthquake, and that if you walked over it in the dark you could feel the dog's ear with your foot, and that everyone in the household walked over the dog's ear in the dark and no one had ever been told why.

And she knew the linen room, which was hers.

It was in the west wing, off the corridor that ran from the bath to the kitchen court, and it had a window of thick green glass and a table, two chests, and a shelf on which the household's linen was laid in the Roman way: sheets, towels, napkins, tablecloths, the good set with the purple stripe for the master's birthday. Her work was to sort, to mend, to count, to see that nothing went out with a stain or a tear, and to see that nothing went out at all that was meant for someone else. It was not heavy work. It was work that could be done with the hands while the mind went elsewhere, and Cassia's mind went elsewhere a great deal, which was the beginning of everything that happened to her.

She had been born in Baiae, in a house behind the fuller's shop, to a woman who had been born in Nicomedia and sold twice before she was twenty. Her mother had died when she was six, of a thing that began in the throat. She had been sold at eleven to a dealer in Puteoli and sold again at thirteen to Faustus, who had come to the market with a list and had bought her because she was small and quick and because the price was good. She had a name, which the dealer had given her, and no other. She had never seen Rome. She had never seen the sea except from a distance, as a brightness beyond the roofs of Puteoli.

Her whole world, at fifteen, was a villa above the Arno, eleven rooms that were hers to keep clean, and forty-one people whose linen she washed.

She was not unhappy. This is a thing that people who have never been property find difficult to understand, and Cassia understood it better than anyone: she was not unhappy because she had no image of a life in which she would be happy, and a person without such an image can be contented in the way that a dog is contented. She had food, and a bed, and work that she did well, and a corner of the linen room where the sun came in the afternoon, and two friends, and a small store of things she had not stolen but had been given: a bronze hairpin, a piece of blue glass, a Greek word she had learned from the tutor's discarded tablets and kept like a coin.

The word was *eleutheria*. She did not know at first what it meant. She had found it on a wax tablet in the rubbish behind the schoolroom, in a line of a poet, and she had copied it out with a stylus on a scrap of wood

and kept it in the box with the hairpin, and it was three months before the tutor's slave told her what it meant, and when he told her she had laughed, because it seemed to her a very large word to give to such a small thing as the freedom to go where one liked.

The old consul had been dying for a year and a half. He had dropsy, and a temper that had once been famous in the Senate and had shrunk with him into something small and bitter and domestic. He was carried out to the garden in the morning and carried in at the fourth hour and he shouted at everyone, and his wife sat with him for two hours every day and read to him, and there was no affection in it that Cassia could see, only a kind of punctual duty, like the changing of a dressing.

The mistress of the house was Tarquitia Priscilla, who was then fifty-two and who ran the villa and the estates and the family's affairs as though they were a small army in a country that might at any moment be invaded. She was not cruel. That was the thing that people found hardest to explain about her. She did not beat her slaves, or sell them for trifles, or take their children; she paid the physician when they were ill, and she knew all their names, and when the cook's daughter died in November she sat with the cook for a whole night, and the household saw it, and was grateful, and did not understand that they had been shown the exact size of the box in which they lived.

The son of the house had been away for nine years.

He was a legate with the army on the Danube, and his name came into the villa four or five times a year in letters that were read aloud in the atrium, and the household knew the shape of his career as it might have known the weather in a province: he had been quaestor, he had been tribune of the soldiers, he had commanded a cohort, he had been in Pannonia and then in Moesia, he had written a book about the laws of boundaries that his father had had copied and given to three men. There was a bust of him in the tablinum, made when he was twenty-four. He had a narrow, careful face and hair that went back from the temples. Cassia had

dusted it a hundred times.

In the spring of the year, the news came that the army had been beaten in Dacia, that a governor had been killed, that a legion's eagle had been taken, and that the whole of the frontier was in an uproar; and three weeks later the news came that the consul's son was coming home.

The villa prepared for him for eleven days.

The whole household was turned out: the mosaics polished, the good couches brought from the storeroom and beaten, the wall paintings in the south range touched up by a man from Arretium who was paid a great deal and did a poor job, the wine brought up, the cook given money and a list and two men from the market. Three rooms were made ready, and then a fourth, because the mistress decided that his study must be his own. The linen was changed twice. On the last day Faustus walked the whole villa with a tablet, and Cassia walked behind him with a basket, and whenever he found a thing that was wrong he said a number, and she wrote it down.

At the ninth hour of the day he arrived, the household was drawn up in the courtyard in order of rank, and Cassia was at the end of the line with the laundry women, and she looked at the gate for a long time before anyone came through it.

He came in on foot, which surprised everyone, with two soldiers behind him and a slave with the horses, and he was thinner than the bust, and older, and he stopped in the gateway and looked at the courtyard as though he were reading a list of things that had been there when he left and were still there.

Then he crossed the courtyard to his mother, and knelt, and put his head against her hands, and the whole household watched, and the cook wept, and the mistress stood with her hands on her son's head and her face perfectly still.

Cassia, at the end of the line, thought: he is the most important person I have ever seen.

She did not speak to him for a month.

He was busy with his father, and with the estate's accounts, and with letters that went out every day and men who came up the road from Rome and stayed the night. He walked in the fields in the early morning. He sat with the old man in the north chamber for an hour every afternoon and read to him, and the old man shouted at him too, and he did not shout back.

Cassia saw him at a distance, and she learned him as she learned rooms. He rose before the fourth hour. He drank water, not wine, until the sixth. He read in the garden in the afternoon with his feet on a stone. He was courteous to slaves in a way that made them uneasy, because courtesy from a master is a kind of weather that can change. He had a habit of standing still in doorways, as if he had forgotten what he had come for.

The first time they spoke, she was carrying a jug.

It was the fifth hour of a hot afternoon in June, and she was taking water and a clean towel up to the bath in the north range, because one of the boys had been sent and had not come back, and she came around the corner into the corridor that ran past the linen room and found him standing with his back to the wall and his hands shaking.

There was blood on his hands. Not much. It was on the knuckles and the palm and it had dried in the lines of the skin, and he was looking at it as though it belonged to somebody else.

She stopped. A slave who comes upon a master in a condition should go back the way she came. She knew that. She had known it since she was eleven. But the jug was in her hands and the corridor was narrow and she was fifteen years old and he looked, for a moment, exactly like a man in the road who has fallen off a cart.

'Domine,' she said.

He looked up.

'There is water,' she said, and held up the jug, and then, because it seemed to require saying, 'It is clean.'

He looked at the jug. Then he put his hands out, and she poured the water over them, and he rubbed them together, and the water went down

onto the mosaic in a thin pink line and into the drain at the side.

'Thank you,' he said.

'Domine.'

'What is your name?'

'Cassia.'

'Cassia.' He said it as though he were putting it somewhere. 'Whose are you?'

'I am in the linen, domine. Under Faustus.'

'Faustus.' He dried his hands on the towel. 'Faustus is a good man. He is a thief, but he is a good man. It is a combination one learns to value in a household.' He handed her back the towel. His hands were steady now. 'My father,' he said. 'He has been bled. The physician bled him this morning and there was a great deal of blood and my father said —' He stopped. 'It does not matter what he said. Thank you, Cassia. You may go.'

She went. At the corner she looked back, and he was still standing there, looking at the drain.

That night she lay in her bed in the women's room and thought about the word *eleutheria*, and about the fact that a man who could have anything he wanted had stood in a corridor with blood on his hands and had said thank you to a girl with a jug.

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He sent for her four days later, which was how it began, and the sending was so ordinary that no one in the villa thought anything of it.

The schoolroom had a library attached, or the beginning of one: three presses of books, most of them law, some of them history, one of them poetry that had belonged to his grandfather. He had found the room disordered — the mice had got at a roll of Livy, and the slave who was supposed to keep it had been sleeping in the garden — and he wanted it put right, and he had said to Faustus, 'Send me the girl from the linen. She reads.'

Faustus, who did not know that she could read, said so.

'She writes the numbers in my book better than I do,' Faustus said, 'but that is numbers.'

'Numbers are the hard part,' said the consul's son. 'Letters are for children.'

So she was sent, and she spent four afternoons in the library with a feather duster and a pot of paste and a young man who sat at the table with his sleeves rolled up, and who asked her, on the second afternoon, whether she knew what she was dusting.

'Livy,' she said.

'Which Livy?'

She looked at the roll in her hand. 'The one that begins with the founding.'

'And what does the founding say?'

She had never been asked a question like that by anyone. She stood with the roll in her hands and her heart going, and said, 'It says that Romulus killed his brother.'

He laughed. It was a real laugh and it surprised them both, and it changed the shape of the room.

'It says a great deal more than that,' he said, 'and rather less. Sit down. Not on the floor; there is a stool. Read me the first column.'

'I cannot read Greek, domine.'

'It is not Greek. It is Latin and it is not even good Latin; Livy writes like a man who has swallowed a trumpet.' He pushed the roll toward her. 'Read.'

She read badly, and he corrected her, and she read again, and after an hour she was reading better than she had ever read in her life, and her ears were hot, and she had forgotten to be afraid of him.

That was the first afternoon. There were eleven more over the next two months, and at the end of them she could read Latin, and had begun, secretly, on the easier Greek, and had been given a wax tablet of her own and told to keep it, and had written on it, in her best hand, the word *eleutheria*, and had hidden it in her box with the blue glass.

She was in love with him by the fourth afternoon. She was fifteen and he was twenty-nine and he had a broken provincial accent in Greek and a careful way of listening, and he was the first person who had ever asked her what she thought. That was all. It would have been enough to ruin her if he had been a good man; and he was not a good man, and he was not a bad one either, which was worse, because it meant she had to find out for herself, and by the time she found out it was too late.

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The autumn of that year was wet. The grapes came in early and the wine was thin. The old consul got worse and then, in October, better, and then worse again, and the household lived from week to week by the physician's face.

The son of the house had been due to go back to the frontier in September. He did not go. There were letters about it; there was one letter, in particular, that came in a courier's bag from Rome and that he read in the garden and then folded and put in his sleeve without a word. After that he stopped speaking about the Danube altogether, and when the men who came up from Rome asked him about the war he answered them civilly and briefly and turned the conversation to drainage.

Cassia did not know then what it meant. She learned it later, in Puteoli, from a man who had served in Moesia: that after the disaster the emperor had looked for men to blame, and that the son of a family that had once opposed him was a very good man to blame, and that a legate who was recalled to Rome in the autumn and not sent back in the spring had been, in the language of the court, set aside.

So he stayed. He wrote his book on boundaries. He walked in the fields. He read in the garden with his feet on a stone. And in November, when the nights had begun to be cold and the household had moved into the winter rooms, he came to the linen room at the second hour of the night with a lamp in his hand and stood in the doorway, and Cassia, who had been mending a sheet at the table and had known his step in the corridor from the first sound of it, put down the needle.

'Domine,' she said.

He stood there for a long moment. She could see him deciding. Afterwards, for years, she would think about that moment and about the fact that he had stood in the doorway for long enough to have gone away.

'You should send me out,' he said.

'I know,' she said.

That was all. He put the lamp on the shelf and closed the door, and the door of the linen room had a latch that could not be locked from the inside, and it did not matter, because nobody came.

Later, when it was over and they were lying in the dark with the lamp turned down and the smell of clean linen all around them, he said, into her hair, 'I am sorry.'

'For what?'

He did not answer that. He said, after a while, 'I will look after you.'

She believed him. That was the thing she could never afterwards explain to anyone, not to Myrrhine, not to the physician at Puteoli, not to the priestess of Isis to whom she went once, in her thirties, in a city where no one knew her: she had believed him, and it had not been stupid, because in the world she had been born into a promise of protection from a man like him was the largest thing a girl could hope for, and because he had meant it, at the time, in the way that such men mean things.

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The winter was the happiest of her life. She knew that afterwards, and it made her ashamed for years, and then one day it stopped making her ashamed and became simply true: the winter of that year, in the villa above the Arno, was the happiest she had been as a girl, and it was built on a lie, and both of those things were the case at once.

They were careful. They were not careful enough; nobody is, in a house that has forty pairs of eyes and a routine. But they were careful in the way that people in a dangerous situation become expert in small things: she learned to know which of the slaves could be trusted and which could be paid and which would tell, and he learned to arrange papers so that a girl

could be sent to the library for an hour without anyone finding it strange, and they invented a whole private language of the ordinary, which is the way such things are always done.

She was taught things in that winter that no free woman of her class would have been taught. He read to her: laws, histories, the letters of Cicero, which he loved and which she found, honestly, insufferable. He taught her to argue — properly, in the way of the courts, to state a case and put the objections and answer them, and he was delighted when she found a hole in his reasoning, and he said once, 'If you had been born a man I would have made you a jurist,' and then looked as though he had said something he should not have.

She kept the linen. She was better at the linen than she had ever been, because she was happy, and because she had begun to think of the household as a thing she might one day have a place in.

In February, Faustus stopped her in the corridor.

He had a basket of tablets on his hip and he was going toward the tablinum, and he stood aside for her, and then he did not move, and she stood with her own basket against her stomach and waited.

'You are in the library a great deal,' he said.

'Domine sends for me to mend the books.'

'There are three slaves in this villa who can read, and two of them are men, and one of them is sixty,' said Faustus, 'and he sends for the girl from the linen.'

She said nothing. She had learned, in that winter, that saying nothing was a skill, and that it could be practised like any other.

Faustus looked at her. He was fifty and had been in the family since he was nine, and he had a wife in Arretium and a son in the vigiles in Rome, and his whole life had been built on knowing which of the family's small disorders to see and which to be blind to.

'I have been in this house for forty-one years,' he said. 'I have seen three girls sent to the mill at Puteoli and one sent to the mines for a thing that was not her fault, and I have never once seen the family lift a finger to stop it, and I have never once seen the family blame the man. Do you

understand what I am saying to you?'

'Yes.'

'You do not,' said Faustus. 'You think I am telling you to be careful. I am telling you that when this ends, and it will end, it will end in a morning, with a steward's list, and you will be a line on the list, and there will be a cart. I have written such lists. My hand has written them.' He shifted the basket. 'The old man is dying. When he dies the household will be divided among the heirs and the daughter will come from Rome with her husband, and she is not her mother, and she counts everything twice. If she finds a girl in the house who has been in the library, she will not send you to the mill. She will sell you somewhere that a message cannot reach you, and she will do it in a week, and she will tell herself she is protecting her brother.'

Cassia's mouth was dry.

'What should I do?' she said.

Faustus looked at her for a long moment. Something in his face shifted, and for a moment he was not the steward at all but a tired man in a corridor.

'You should ask him for a paper,' he said. 'Not a promise. A paper. Manumission in his own hand with a date, and a sum, and the date before the old man dies, because after the old man dies he will be a man with a sister and a share of a debt and a name to protect, and he will be a different man, and he will not remember that he was ever the man who taught you to read.' He stepped aside. 'That is all. I have never said this to you and I will never say it again.'

He went. And she stood in the corridor for a while, and then she went and mended a sheet, and she did not ask for a paper, because she was fifteen and she was in love and it seemed to her the most insulting thing in the world to ask the man who had taught her to read for a document.

The old consul died in the last week of February, in the night, without a word.

The household knew before dawn. There was a particular sound that a villa makes when its master dies: a door opened and not closed, a woman crying in the kitchen court and then being told to be quiet, the steward's voice going from room to room with the same four words. Cassia heard it all from the women's room and lay still, and understood, with a clarity that was almost physical, that the roof over her had changed.

For nine days the villa was in mourning and in confusion. The body was washed and laid out and the masks were brought from the cupboards. The tenants came up from the farms. The neighbours came. The old man's freedmen came, and his old clients, and two men from Rome who had been his colleagues and who stood in the atrium and looked at the masks and said the things that are said.

The daughter of the house arrived on the third day, from Rome, with her husband and four slaves and a great deal of luggage. She was thirty-six, and her name was Tarquitia Aurelia, and she was not beautiful and had never been, and she had made herself formidable instead, which is a longer road and arrives somewhere more permanent.

She walked into the villa and she did what her mother had done for thirty years and what her mother was now too tired to do: she counted.

She counted the silver and found it correct. She counted the wine and found it short, and Faustus explained, and she accepted the explanation and wrote it down. She counted the linen and found it correct, and she looked at Cassia for a moment longer than the counting required, and Cassia kept her eyes down and her hands still and felt the look go over her like a hand.

That evening, at dinner, she heard the mistress say to her daughter, in the flat voice of a woman who has decided to say a thing once: 'The girl in the linen is not to be sold.'

'Why not?'

'Because I say so.'

'Mother, if there is a reason—'

'There is a reason,' said Tarquitia Priscilla, 'and it is mine, and I am not going to give it to you at table. When I am dead you may do as you like.'

And Aurelia said, after a moment, in a voice like her mother's: 'Very well.'

Cassia, standing at the sideboard with the jug, heard all of it. She did not know what it meant. She would spend the next twenty-four years finding out.

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In the spring, in March, when the almond was out and the doves had begun again, she went three weeks without bleeding, and then four, and then she was sick in the morning behind the kitchen court, and the cook's wife looked at her for a long moment and said nothing, and Cassia went and sat in the linen room with the door open and the sun coming through the green glass and understood, all at once, the exact size of the box in which she lived.

She did not tell him at once. She waited nine days, and in those eleven days she did the arithmetic that she would do, in one form or another, for the rest of her life.

She was a slave. The child was a slave, and belonged to the household, and would be entered in the census as property. She was fifteen; she would be sixteen in June. If she told him, he would do something — she believed that, she had to believe it — and the something would be a kindness, and the kindness would be arranged within the limits of what a man in his position could arrange without damaging himself, and she had already begun to understand, because she was quick and because the winter had made her quicker, that the limits of what such a man could arrange were not where she had once thought they were.

On the eleventh day she told him.

He was in the library. It was the afternoon and the light was behind him and there was a roll of the law of boundaries open on the table, and he listened to her without moving, and then he got up and closed the door and stood with his hand on the table.

'You are certain?'

'Yes.'

He nodded slowly, as though she had given him a figure in an account. Then he said, 'Say nothing to anyone. Not to Faustus. Not to the women. If you are sick, say it is the water. I will think of something.'

And he did think of something, and it took him eight weeks, and he thought of it with great care and in perfect good faith, and it destroyed her.

She did not know that yet. That night she lay in the women's room with her hand flat on her stomach and a happiness in her that she was later ashamed of, and she thought: he will look after me.

And in the corridor outside, the lamp that the steward carried at the second hour of the night went past the door and stopped, and then went on.

CHAPTER SIX

The Price of a Girl

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Puteoli, that summer.

They told her it was for the sea air.

The villa had been sold, or would be sold; the estate was in the hands of the heirs and the heirs were in Rome, and Faustus had gone up with the accounts in April and had come back with a list. On the list, fourth from the top, between two farm slaves and a pair of mules, in the same hand, was: *Cassia, ex linificio, to the house of Bassa at Puteoli, for her health.*

She saw the list. Faustus left it on the table in the tablinum when he went to speak to the mistress, and she stood over it and read it, and her hands were steady, and she thought: he has written something. It was the only thing she could think. *He has written something, and this is the arrangement, and I am to be got out of the way quietly until it is done, and then there will be a paper.*

The son of the house had gone to Rome in the last week of March, and had not come back. He had been sent for by his sister; there had been a letter, and then a second letter; and he had stood in the library with the second letter in his hand and said, 'I must go. It is about my father's will and there is a difficulty with the land at Volsinii and my sister will not sign without me. I will be back before the summer. I will be back before —' and he had stopped, and looked at her, and said, 'Before.'

'Yes,' she said.

'I will write.'

He did write. Two letters came in April and one in May, and they were careful letters, and the carefulness was itself a kind of tenderness: he asked about the books. He asked whether she had finished the fourth decade of Livy, and he sent a line of Greek that she was to translate and send back, and the line was from Euripides and meant, roughly, that the sea washes

away the evils of men, which she thought was a strange thing for a man to send to a woman who was six months pregnant and had never seen the sea.

She read the letters until the wax was smooth. She slept with them under the mattress. She answered the Greek and gave the answer to Faustus to send, and she never knew whether her answers arrived.

The house of Bassa at Puteoli stood on the road to the Lucrine lake, in a garden of lemon trees, with a courtyard and a well and a room at the back that had a window looking east. It smelled of the sea, which Cassia smelled for the first time in her life at the age of sixteen, and which she did not like: it smelled of something enormous that had been left out and had gone off, and she could not understand why anyone would build a town next to it.

Bassa was sixty-one that summer and had been a midwife for forty years. She had been a slave of the family, freed by the old consul in the year of the earthquake for services that were never specified, and she had a house, a garden, a freedman's cap that she kept in a chest and never wore, and a way of looking at a woman's belly that was entirely without sentiment and entirely without contempt.

She looked at Cassia's belly on the day she arrived, and said, 'August. Perhaps the end of August. You are small, which is good, and you are frightened, which is normal, and you have been badly fed for the last two months, which I can see in your wrists, so you will eat what I give you and you will not argue with me about it.'

'I am not frightened,' Cassia said.

'You are frightened of me,' said Bassa, 'which is sensible. You will be less frightened in a week. Come and see the room.'

The weeks at Puteoli were the strangest of her life, and afterwards she thought of them as a kind of island. She was not working. She had never not worked. She sat in the garden in the mornings and read, and Bassa's two slaves — a woman called Sabbia, who was thirty and sour and kind, and a boy of twelve — treated her with the careful respect that is given to

valuable property, and she learned to hate that respect more than she had ever hated being kicked.

She was, for the first time in her life, alone with her own thoughts for whole days together, and she found that she had a great many, and that they were not pleasant company.

There was a girl in the house next door who was pregnant also, the wife of a rope-maker, and she was nineteen and this was her third child and she was not frightened at all. She came over the wall in the afternoons and sat with Cassia, and talked without stopping, about her mother-in-law, and the price of fish, and the scandal of a woman in the town who had left her husband and gone to Rome with a ship's captain, and Cassia listened to all of it and understood that she was being given a lesson in how to be a woman, and that the lesson was being given by someone who had a name.

'Your husband is a sailor?' the rope-maker's wife said, the second week.

'Yes,' said Cassia.

'Where is he?'

'At sea.'

'They are always at sea,' said the woman, comfortably. 'Mine is at sea in his own way. He goes to the docks at the sixth hour and he comes back at the ninth and he has been at sea all day.'

Cassia laughed, and was surprised by it.

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Bassa asked her, once, in the sixth week, when they were shelling peas in the courtyard.

'What has he promised you?'

Cassia's hands stopped.

'You may tell me or not,' said Bassa. 'I have heard worse. I have heard everything. There is nothing you can say that will make me think less of you, because I have already thought the worst, and it is not you.'

'He is going to free me,' Cassia said. 'There will be a paper. And then —' She stopped. 'And then I do not know.'

'No,' said Bassa. 'That is honest. Most girls would have said something pretty.' She dropped a pod in the bowl. 'I will tell you what I know, and then we will not speak of it again. In forty years I have delivered two hundred children in this town and a hundred and forty of them were born to women who had been promised something. Of the hundred and forty, eleven got the paper. Of the eleven, four got the money with it. Of the four, one is still alive and she keeps a bakery on the harbour and she is the hardest woman in Puteoli and she does not speak to me.' She wiped her hands. 'A paper is not a kindness, girl. A paper is a decision a man makes about his own honour. It costs him nothing and it makes him feel like a god, and it can be taken back by his heirs, and it is worth exactly as much as the man's family allows it to be worth.'

'He is not like that,' said Cassia.

Bassa looked at her for a long moment. There was no cruelty in it. That was the terrible thing.

'No,' she said. 'He is not like that. He is worse. The ones who are like that, the brutes, they sell you in the first month and you know where you are. It is the ones who are not like that who take a year to do it, and who do it kindly, and who send a letter afterwards explaining why it was necessary.' She picked up another pod. 'Eat your peas.'

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The end of August came. The heat was enormous. The town filled with people from Rome and the bay filled with boats and the nights were so warm that nobody slept before the second hour, and Cassia sat in the courtyard in the dark with her hands on her belly and felt the child turn like something swimming in a sack.

She had begun to talk to it. She had not meant to. But it was there, and it was hers, and it was the only thing in the world that was entirely hers, and she talked to it in a whisper in the dark: about the sea, which she still did not like; about Livy, who had begun with the founding and had got no better; about the plan, which she had made in the garden over many afternoons and which involved a room above a shop and a lamp and a

basin and the two of them, and which she had worked out in great detail because there was nothing else to do with her mind.

It was a girl, she had decided. She did not know. She had decided it was a girl because a girl could be kept.

The pains began on the twenty-ninth day of August, at the fourth hour of the night, and lasted thirty-one hours.

Afterwards, she remembered it in pieces, and the pieces did not fit.

She remembered Sabbia's hands, which were hard and quick, and Bassa's voice saying, over and over, in the flat tone of a woman doing a job, 'That is right. That is good. Again.'

She remembered the window going from black to grey, and a bird starting outside it, and thinking, with enormous clarity: the bird does not know.

She remembered being given something to drink that tasted of iron and honey and made the room go soft at the edges. She remembered the ceiling, which had a stain in the shape of a boot. She remembered a great pressure and a great tearing and the sound she made, which she had never heard herself make before, and which was not a scream but a kind of lowing, like an animal in a field.

And then she remembered a cry.

She was certain of it afterwards. She was certain for twenty-four years, and the certainty was the thing that kept her alive, and everybody who loved her told her, kindly, that a woman in that condition will hear anything, and that the mind makes what it wants to make.

It was a small sound, thin, and it stopped almost at once. And then there was a great deal of activity in the room that did not include her, and hands, and the murmur of voices at the door, and then nothing.

She woke in the afternoon. The room was hot and the light was yellow and Sabbia was sitting on a stool by the window with her hands in her lap, and she was crying without making any noise at all.

'Where is she?' Cassia said.

Sabbia stood up and went out of the room.

Bassa came in. She had washed and put on a clean dress and she stood at the foot of the bed with her hands folded.

'You had a girl,' she said. 'She was born at the ninth hour of the morning.'

'Where is she?'

'She did not breathe,' said Bassa. 'She was blue when she came out and she did not breathe. I worked on her for half an hour. It was very quick and it was not your doing and there was nothing in the world that could have been done.'

Cassia looked at her.

'I heard her,' she said.

'You heard the door,' said Bassa. 'You heard Sabbia. Women hear all sorts of things; it is the medicine and the blood and the pain, and it means nothing.'

'I heard her cry.'

'You heard what every woman in this town hears when it goes wrong,' said Bassa, and her voice was steady and she did not look away, and that was the thing Cassia remembered afterwards, for twenty-four years: that she did not look away. 'She is buried. It was done this morning, before the heat, in the ground beyond the wall of the garden. There is no stone. There will be no stone; she was not a person in law and there is no stone to be had for nothing, and I am sorry, and I have done this two hundred times, and the ones who get a stone are the ones whose fathers claim them.' She unfolded her hands. 'I will bring you something to eat.'

For three days Cassia did not speak. She lay in the room with the window and watched the light move along the wall and the stain on the ceiling in the shape of a boot, and she was not grieving in any way that she could have described. She felt as though a large object had been removed from a room and the room had not adjusted: the world was the wrong size and everything in it was too far away.

On the fourth day she got out of bed and went into the garden, and stood at the wall at the bottom, where the ground was turned over in a place about the length of a man, and stood there for an hour.

On the fifth day a man came to the house.

He was a freedman of the family, or said he was; he had the family's name, which meant nothing, because half of Italy had it. He was about forty, with a shaved head and a good cloak, and he came in the afternoon, and Bassa brought him into the courtyard, and Cassia was sitting there, and he did not sit down.

'You are Cassia, formerly of the household at Arretium.'

'I am.'

'I have the papers.' He unrolled a document. 'You are sold. The price is two thousand four hundred sesterces and it has been paid, and the sale is registered in the town records as of yesterday, and here is the copy.'

She heard the sea.

'Sold to whom?' she said.

'To the house of Caesonius Verus in this town,' said the man, 'which is a respectable establishment, and which has a good name among the merchants who come to the port, and which will treat you better than most, and where you will have work that is suited to you.' He rolled the document. 'There is a clause: you will not leave the house except with the permission of the proprietor, and you will not attempt to communicate with the household at Arretium or with any member of it, and if you do, the proprietor will be within his rights to have you corrected. The house does not sell. It does not sell, and it does not free, and you will not ask it to, because the asking is itself a disorder and the disorder will be corrected.'

'Who ordered it?'

'It is a lawful sale. It does not require an order. It requires a signature, and the signature is a valid signature, and I have seen it, and I have been paid to see it.'

'Whose signature?'

The man looked at her. He had the flat, patient eyes of a man who had done this a great many times.

'The signature of the master of the household at Arretium,' he said. 'And before you ask, because they all ask: he is the only master that household has. There is no other. There is no appeal. There is no letter. There is no man in Rome who will read a letter from a girl in a house in Puteoli.' He looked at Bassa. 'She is to come tomorrow, at the ninth hour, with her things. The price includes the clothes she stands in. Nothing else.'

He went out. Bassa stood in the doorway with her arms folded and her face like a wall.

'Bassa,' said Cassia. 'The burial. Show me the burial.'

'There is nothing to show you.'

'Show me the place.'

'I have shown you the place.' Bassa's voice was hard. 'There is a turned piece of earth at the bottom of my garden and you have stood on it and you will stand on it again if you like, and it is a piece of earth, and that is all it is.'

'Who came, that morning?'

'Nobody came.'

'Somebody came. There were voices at the door. I heard—'

'You heard me and Sabbia and the boy,' said Bassa. 'That is all that was in this house. Now go and pack your things, because I have a house full of women and I cannot keep a girl who is not mine, and if I could I would not, because the man who signed that paper paid for my house and my freedom and I am sixty-one years old and I am not going to be a hero for a girl I have known eight weeks.' She turned away. 'I am sorry. I am sorry. Go and pack.'

She went to the house of Caesonius Verus on the last day of August, in the afternoon, and it was not what she had feared, because she had no picture of what she feared, and the house was a house: a courtyard with a fountain, a garden with a vine on a trellis, eleven women, a cook, a doorkeeper, and a proprietor who was fifty and had a bad leg and who told her, with something that was almost kindness, that she would not be

expected to work for a month, and that the first rule of the house was that no man touched a woman who was still bleeding, and that he was a businessman and not a barbarian.

Her name in that house was Cassia, and then, within a year, it was Cassia still, because she would not take another, and because Caesonius, who was a businessman, discovered that a woman who would not change her name could be sold as a novelty.

She learned the trade in the way that one learns a thing that must be learned. She learned to read a man in the first three sentences. She learned which ones wanted to be listened to and which wanted to be feared and which wanted, more than anything, to be told that they were not like the others, and she learned that the last was the largest group and the easiest to manage. She learned to keep her own body at a distance from herself, and she learned that the distance could be made and then taken away, and that the taking away was the part that cost.

The first man who came to her was a ship's captain from Massilia, forty years old, with a wife and three children at home and a great terror of the sea, and he sat on the edge of the bed and talked about his youngest daughter for an hour and then could not do anything at all, and wept, and she held him, because it was the only thing left to do.

The second was a magistrate of the town, who did what he did without speaking and left without speaking, and who came back the following week and the week after that.

The third was a young man from Rome who had been at the games and was drunk, and who hurt her, and who was thrown out by the doorkeeper before he had finished, and who came back the next day with a purse and an apology, and Cassia took the purse, because Caesonius took the purse, and the apology she kept.

It was in the fourth month that she spoke her first line as property.

There was a man in the house that night, a wool merchant from Mutina who had been drinking since the afternoon and who had begun, in the manner of such men, to explain the world. He had explained the corn supply, which he understood entirely. He had explained the war in Dacia,

which he had not been to. And then he had said, spreading his hands, 'And of course, the whole of this — all of it, the city, the empire, the law — rests on one thing, and the one thing is that some men are born to command and some to serve, and a man who says otherwise is a liar or a fool. There is no third thing. Look at you. You are clever. Anybody can see you are clever. And yet here you are.'

Cassia had learned, by then, to smile at that. She had a smile she used for it, which she had practised in the polished bronze in her room, and which cost her nothing at all except the part of her that had been fifteen in a linen room with the sun coming through green glass.

She did not smile.

'There is a third thing,' she said.

The merchant blinked at her. 'What?'

'A man can be a fool,' said Cassia, 'and still be born to command. I have met six of them this month.'

He stared at her. Then he laughed, uncertainly, and looked around the room to see whether anyone had heard, and there was no one to hear, and that was the whole of it: there was no one to hear, and so nothing happened, and he drank his wine and later he paid and later he went back to Mutina and told a story about a clever whore in Puteoli, and the story went around Mutina for a year and then stopped.

But Cassia lay awake that night in a small hot room above a courtyard with a fountain, and she found that she was shaking, and that it was not fear, and that she had not felt anything like it since the morning she had woken to be told that her daughter was buried at the bottom of a garden.

Two things had happened to her in that house, and she knew it even then.

The first was that she had learned what she was worth.

The second was that she had begun, in a place where nobody could hear her, to say what she thought.

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She was in the house of Caesonius Verus for six years, and she left it at twenty-two with a hundred and ten thousand sesterces, a freedman's cap, and the name she had refused to change.

The hundred and ten thousand was not a gift. She had made it in the way that a woman in her position can make money, which is to say by being useful to men in ways that they do not recognise as work. In the second year she had begun keeping a book. It had started because Caesonius's accounts were a disgrace — he was a decent man with a bad memory and a worse hand, and he was being robbed by his own cook — and because she had learned the numbers in a linen room at Arretium and had never lost the habit. She balanced his book for him. Then she balanced the book of the wine merchant who supplied the house, who was being robbed by his own son. Then she balanced the book of the widow who owned the insula next door, who had a great deal of property and no idea what it was worth.

She took a fee. It was four per cent, which was less than the bankers charged and more than nothing, and she took it in the name of the house and gave Caesonius a third of it, which he was delighted by, and which made him, for the rest of his life, her ally.

By the fourth year she had eleven clients, and a strongbox, and an arrangement with a scribe who came on the seventh day of each month. By the fifth year she had begun lending: small sums, at the legal rate, to men who could not go to a banker because a banker would ask them why they needed it.

Two things happened in the sixth year.

The first was that Caesonius Verus died, of a dropsy, at the age of fifty-six, and his heir was a nephew from Capua who arrived three days after the funeral with an inventory and an intention to sell everything in the house including the doorkeeper. Cassia sat down with him in the courtyard, and showed him the book she had kept for six years, and explained to him, in the tone of a woman doing him a favour, that eleven of the house's regular clients were hers and not the house's, and that if he intended to sell her he would find that he had bought a building with a fountain in it and a great

deal of wine in the cellar, and nothing else.

The nephew, who was twenty-eight and had never run anything, asked her what she wanted.

She wanted her freedom, and she wanted it registered properly, in the town records, with a copy that she kept herself, and she wanted the hundred and ten thousand sesterces that were in the strongbox and that were, by any accounting, hers.

He gave her all of it. He gave it to her because he was frightened of her, which she noticed, and which she remembered, and which she thought about for the rest of her life.

'A woman like you,' he said, at the end, when the papers were done and the money counted, 'will do well in Rome.'

'I am not going to Rome,' she said.

'Everyone goes to Rome,' said the nephew, 'in the end. It is where the money is.'

The second thing happened four months later, in the winter, when she went back to the house on the Lucrine road to see Bassa.

She had not seen her in six years. She had not wanted to. But Bassa was old and the sea air had begun to be bad for her, and Cassia had, in the strongbox, a paper that she had paid a lawyer eleven sesterces for, and she went with it on the feast of the Saturnalia, in a good cloak, with her hair up and a slave girl behind her.

The house was the same. The lemon trees were the same. The window that looked east was shuttered against the cold, and Sabbia opened the door, and Sabbia was thin and grey and looked at her for a long moment and then began to cry, and that was the first thing that was wrong, because Sabbia had never in six years cried in front of her except the day the child was born.

Bassa was in the back room, in a chair, with a rug over her knees, and she was seventy and she had shrunk, and she looked at Cassia for a long time with her flat, patient eyes.

'You have done well,' she said.

'I have done well.'

'Caesonius is dead. I heard. He was a decent man, in his way. He never beat a girl who did not steal from him, which in that trade is almost a virtue.' Bassa moved her hand on the rug. 'Why have you come?'

Cassia took the paper out of her sleeve and put it on the table.

'I have bought the ground,' she said. 'At the bottom of your garden. The turned piece of earth. I have bought it from the town, and I have registered it, and I am going to put a stone there, and I am going to put a wall around it, and I want you to tell me what to write on the stone.'

Bassa looked at the paper on the table. Then she looked at Cassia, and her face did something that Cassia had never seen it do.

'There is nothing buried there,' Bassa said.

The room was very quiet. Outside, a gull was making its noise over the garden, and someone in the next street was shouting about a cart.

'Say that again,' said Cassia.

'There is nothing buried there,' said Bassa. 'There was nothing to bury. That is what I have been sitting in this chair for six years wishing I had the courage to write to you about, and I did not, because I am a coward and because I have a house and because the man who signed your paper paid for both.' She put her hands together in her lap. 'The child was born alive. She was born at the ninth hour and she cried, and I put her in the arms of a woman who was waiting in the corridor, and that woman took her out of this house before the sun went down, and I was told that if I ever spoke of it, the paper that freed me would be found to be a forgery, and my house would be taken, and I would die a slave in the house I was born in.'

Cassia found that she was standing. She did not remember standing.

'Who was the woman?'

'I do not know her name. She was a slave of the household at Arretium; she had come up with the man who brought the orders, and she was called Sabbia, and she was not my Sabbia, and I have thought about that for six years as though it meant something, and it does not.' Bassa's voice was steady. It had always been steady. 'The child was to be given to a family.

That was what I was told. That was the whole of what I was told: that the child was to be given to a family, and that the mother was to be told it had died, because a mother who knows her child is alive will tear a town apart looking for it, and the family required quiet.'

'What family?'

'I do not know.'

'What did the child look like?'

'She had your hands,' said Bassa. 'That is all. She had your hands and she cried like a cat and she was very small.' She closed her eyes. 'I am sorry. I have been sorry for six years and it has done nothing at all, and now you are here in a good cloak and you have bought a piece of my garden, and I find that being sorry is even less use than I thought.'

Cassia walked out of the house. She walked down the Lucrine road in the winter light with her slave girl behind her, and she walked past the lemon trees and the wall and the town gate and onto the beach, and she stood at the edge of the sea, which she had never liked, and she looked at it for a long time.

She had been told, for six years, that her daughter was dead, and she had grieved a thing that was not there, and the grief had been real, and the ground had been empty. And on the other side of the world, somewhere, there was a girl of six with her hands.

She went to Rome in the spring.

She went with a hundred and ten thousand sesterces, a freedman's cap, a copy of her manumission that she had registered twice, and one name that she had refused to change. She was twenty-two years old. She had no family, no patron, no letters of introduction, and no intention of ever again asking a man to give her anything that she could not take.

The first house she rented was two rooms above a laundry on the Aventine, and the first thing she bought for it was a lock.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Informer

— ◆ —

The man's name was Hilarus, and he did not look like anything.

He was perhaps forty-five, thin, with the stooped shoulders of a clerk and the hands of one, and he dressed in the decent brown wool of a freedman who worked for a family of moderate means. He had a wife and two daughters, a house in the sixth region, and a small property at Tibur that he visited four times a year. He was, by profession, a *delator*: a man who made his living by bringing accusations, and who had brought eleven in fourteen years, of which nine had succeeded.

Antonia had used him once before, in the matter of a will, and had paid him eleven thousand sesterces and had disliked him thoroughly, and had recommended him to two people since.

They met in the back room of a shoemaker's shop on the Via Sacra, which was not a place where anyone of consequence went, and which Hilarus used because the shoemaker owed him money and because the smell of the glue was, he said, conducive to clear thinking.

'You want a child found,' he said.

'I want a woman found. The child was twenty-six years ago. The woman is the way to her.'

'Twenty-six years.' Hilarus turned his cup around on the table. 'That is a long time, domina. Records rot. Records are burned, and clerks die, and the ones who don't die develop a convenient forgetfulness. And the tax records for the sale of slaves are kept for eleven years and then sold for waste paper, which means that the paper in which your child was entered has been, at some point, sold to a man who used it to wrap fish.'

'I know what a record is,' said Antonia. 'I have been in this city eleven years.'

'Then you know that what I am selling you is not a certainty. It is a probability, priced accordingly.' He set the cup down. 'Tell me everything. Not the parts that make you look well. Everything.'

She told him. She had decided before she came that she would, and she told it flatly, in the voice she used for the accounts, and she did not stop when her voice did something strange in the middle, and Hilarus did not look away or look sympathetic or, at any point, write anything down.

When she had finished he was silent for a while.

'The household at Arretium,' he said. 'The old consul died in February of that year. The heirs were the son and the daughter. The daughter was married to a man named —?'

'Servius Aelius Gracilis. Not the young one; his father. He died eight years ago. The widow is still alive and lives at Tibur and is seventy-nine and has nothing to do with anything.'

Hilarus nodded slowly. 'And the son — the present Tarquitius — was in Rome at the time of the birth.'

'He was in Rome from March until the autumn. I never had a letter after June.'

'Why not?'

'I have thought about that for twenty-six years,' said Antonia, 'and I have three answers, and two of them are unbearable, and the third is that his letters were intercepted, and I have no evidence for any of them, and the lack of evidence is the whole of my life.'

Hilarus looked at her.

'You want me to find a girl,' he said, 'who may be dead, or may be a slave in a house in Naples, or may be the wife of a farmer in Campania with four children and no idea that anything ever happened to her. And if I find her, you may not want what I find.'

'I am aware.'

'You are not aware. Nobody is aware until it is in front of them.' He turned his cup again. 'Fifty thousand sesterces. Twenty now, thirty on the day I put a name in your hand. If I find nothing in a year, you have lost twenty and I have lost a year, which for a man in my trade is worse.'

'Agreed.'

'And one other thing.' He looked up. 'You will appear as a witness in a case I am bringing in the autumn. A false will, in the matter of the estate of a man named Vipsanius, who died in the fifth region and whose brother has manufactured a codicil. You know the family. You will swear to a conversation you had with the dead man, in your own house, in front of five witnesses, in which he said that he intended to leave his property to his daughter. You will not be asked whether you liked him. You will be asked what he said.'

'And what did he say?'

'What I have just told you,' said Hilarus, 'which happens to be true, and which is why I am asking you and not one of the eleven people who would say it for money.'

Antonia looked at the shoemaker's back room: the glue pots, the lasts, the smell, and the narrow window with the light coming through it onto the table between them.

'Why do you do this?' she said. 'The accusations. You are not poor. You do not need it.'

'No,' said Hilarus. 'I do not need it.'

'Then why?'

He considered. It was the first time in the conversation that he had looked like a man rather than a profession.

'Because when I was nineteen my father was sold,' he said. 'Not by a bad master. By a good one, who needed the money for a dowry, and who wept when he did it, and who wrote him a letter of recommendation, which my father kept until he died. My father was sold to a man in Sicily who worked him in a stone quarry for nine years, and he came back at forty with a cough and died of it in my house, and the master who sold him was never once asked to explain himself, because the law had been obeyed.' He drank. 'I cannot do anything about the law. But I have found that when a man manufactures a codicil, or cheats an inheritance, or sells a girl he should not have sold, the law will sometimes, if it is pushed in exactly the right place, make him explain himself. That is all the justice there is. It

is not much. I have made a living out of it and I am not ashamed of the living, and I would rather be doing it than be a shoemaker.'

Antonia put a purse on the table.

'Twenty thousand,' she said. 'And Hilarus — when you find her, you will tell me first. Not the household. Not a friend. You will tell me, and you will tell me in a room, and there will be no letter.'

'That is the first sensible thing you have said,' said Hilarus, and took the purse.

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She did not tell anyone. That was the strange part of the summer: she carried it alone for eleven weeks, in the middle of everything else, and there were mornings when she woke and remembered it before she remembered her own name.

She told Myrrhine, in the end, in July, on the roof of the house at the second hour of the night, when the whole city was lying out on its balconies because the rooms were unbearable.

'I have hired the delator,' she said.

Myrrhine did not ask what for. She lay on her back on the tiles with her hands behind her head and looked at the sky.

'Since the spring,' she said.

'Since the Ides of June.'

'And you have been walking around with it for a month.' Myrrhine's voice was flat. 'You could have told me.'

'I could have.'

'Why didn't you?'

Antonia looked up. Above the roof the sky was the brown-orange of a Roman night, and there were three stars visible, which in July was two more than usual.

'Because if I said it out loud in April,' she said, 'it would have been a hope, and hopes are things I have learned to keep in a box. And now it is a search with a fee and a man and a paper, and a search is a business, and I can do business.'

Myrrhine was quiet for a while. Then she said, 'If it is a girl, and she is alive, and she is a slave —'

'I will buy her.'

'If she does not want to be bought?'

'Then I will buy her and free her and give her the money and go away,' said Antonia. 'I have thought about it. I have thought about very little else. I have written eleven letters in my head, and burned all of them.'

'And if she is dead?'

'Then I will know where she is buried, and I will buy the ground, and put a stone on it with her name, and that will be the end of it.'

Myrrhine turned her head.

'You bought the ground at Puteoli,' she said. 'Twenty years ago. You bought an empty piece of a midwife's garden and put a wall around it and never told me why.'

Antonia did not answer.

'I went there,' Myrrhine said. 'In the ninth year. I was in Puteoli on the business of the house and I went and looked at it. There was no stone. There was a wall and a lemon tree and a piece of turned ground, and a woman in the next house said that a rich woman from Rome had bought it and came once a year, in August, and stood in it.'

'You never said.'

'You never said,' said Myrrhine. 'That is the arrangement, isn't it. That is what we agreed when you were thirty and I was twenty-five and we decided to be sensible. I do not ask, and you do not have to say, and we have kept it for sixteen years and it has been a good arrangement and I have hated it for about eleven of them.'

Antonia lay still. On the next roof a man was singing, badly, and a woman told him to stop, and he stopped.

'I am sorry,' Antonia said.

'Do not be sorry. Be careful.' Myrrhine sat up. 'You have hired a man to find a girl, in a summer when the praetor's son is telling every dinner table in Rome that you refused him, and when the curator of the public works has the file on your portico open on his table, and when your

banker's brothers-in-law are asking questions. Any one of those things can be survived. All three at once is a house with three fires in it.'

'Then I will put out two,' said Antonia.

'How?'

'By making one of them into an ally,' she said, 'which is what I am going to do to the curator of the public works, and which he is going to hate more than anything I have ever done to him.'

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The case that made it possible was not hers. It came out of Lusitania, and it had been three years in the making, and by July it had begun to be spoken of in the Forum as a thing that would be heard in the autumn.

A governor named Titus Atilius Rufus had left his province in the fifth year of the emperor's reign, and the provincials had come to Rome with a bill of particulars: extortion, requisitions, a forced loan from the towns, three men flogged, one man's estate seized and given to a favourite, and a system of receipts, kept in duplicate, in which the sums paid by the province and the sums entered in the governor's own book differed by a factor of three. The case had come before the Senate, as such cases do, and had stalled, as such cases do, because half the men who would have to judge it had done something similar in their own provinces and did not care to establish a precedent.

Tarquitius Priscus had taken it up in June.

He had taken it up because he was a jurist and because the law on extortion was clear and because, Antonia thought, he had reached the age at which a man begins to want a monument. He had taken it up in the full knowledge that it would make him enemies, and he had done it, she suspected, precisely because it would: a man who has failed to be sent back to the Danube will find another field.

The difficulty was the receipts.

The province's receipts were in the hands of the publicani, the tax farmers, who had collected them and kept copies, and the copies were in the hands of the Roman agent of the company that had bought the

contract for Lusitania — and that company's Roman agent was a man named Pollio, who was Cluvius Naso's partner, and who would not produce a single tablet without Naso's word.

Tarquitius had asked Naso. Naso, who was a banker and not a fool, had said that the tablets were the property of the company and that he would consider the matter with his colleagues, which is what a man says when he intends to do nothing until he is certain which way the wind will blow.

In the third week of July, Naso came to Antonia's house at the ninth hour and told her all of this, and then said, 'He will come to you.'

'He will not.'

'He will. He has no other road. Pollio will not move without me, I will not move without a reason, and the reason is that the praetor's son has spent the last two months telling the city that you keep a disorderly house. If the tablets come out, the case goes forward, and if the case goes forward the Sestii are damaged, because Sestius's brother was legate in Lusitania under Atilius and signed three of the receipts.' Naso spread his hands. 'You are the only person in Rome who has a reason to want both of those things at once and the means to arrange them, and he knows it, and he will hate it, and he will come.'

'What does he want from me?'

'He wants me to produce the tablets, and he will ask you to produce me, and he will call it a public duty, and you and I will both know what it is.' Naso looked at her for a moment. 'Do you want him to come?'

Antonia thought about a room on the Palatine with a bust on a bracket and a chair without a cushion.

'Yes,' she said. 'I want him to come, and I want him to have to ask, and I want him to know, while he is asking, that I am the person he is asking. Not because I am vengeful. Because everything I will ever need from that man will be cheaper if he has once been through that door.'

'And the portico?'

'Is a portico,' said Antonia. 'There are four hundred of them in the fourth region. It was never about the portico.'

Before that, she made peace with the praetor's son.

It was not a peace she wanted. It was a peace she judged necessary, in the way that a general judges a bridge necessary, and she went about it the way she went about all such things: in public, with a great deal of courtesy, and with a knife concealed in the courtesy.

The occasion was the games of the Augustan festival, at which the praetor's family had a place of honour, and at which Marcus Sestius Verus would be seen by the whole city. Antonia did not go to the games. She never went to the games; the crowds were a nuisance and the seats were for people who needed to be seen sitting in them. Instead she sent, on the morning of the first day, a gift to his house: a pair of silver cups, old, good, worth perhaps twenty thousand sesterces, with a note in her own hand that said that she had heard that the praetor's son had admired the cups at her table in May, and that she could think of no better home for them than a house that understood hospitality.

The cups had been on her table in May. Cirrus had not admired them. He had spilled wine on the cloth and had not noticed.

The gift did three things at once, and she counted them off to Myrrhine that evening like a woman laying out cards.

'First, it is public. Everyone in the city will know by the fourth hour that Antonia Cassia sent a gift to the house of Sestius, and they will conclude that the quarrel, whatever it was, has been settled. Second, it is expensive and useless, which is the only kind of gift that a proud man can accept from a person he has threatened: he cannot call it a bribe, because a bribe is money, and he cannot call it a submission, because he does not know what it is for. Third, and this is the one that matters —' she turned the ring on her finger '— it puts him in the position of a man who has received a favour from me. He cannot now bring a charge against my house without every man in Rome asking why, four weeks after he accepted twenty thousand sesterces of silver from me, he suddenly discovered that my house was disorderly. He will have to wait a year. A year

is a long time, and in a year he will have spent the silver and found something else to be angry about.'

'Unless he simply denies that the gift was from you,' said Myrrhine.

'Then he calls me a liar in public, and I produce the note in my own hand, and he is a man who called a woman a liar about a pair of cups, and no one will believe a word he says about anything else.' Antonia smiled. 'The note is the point. It is four lines and it will cost me a great deal of trouble and it is the most useful thing I have written this year.'

Sestius accepted the cups. He sent back a note of thanks that was three lines long and had been dictated, and a few days later he made a speech in the Senate about the moral condition of the city in which he did not mention Antonia Cassia at all, and Myrrhine, hearing of it, said that Antonia had bought herself a month.

'A year,' said Antonia. 'Six months, at any rate. He is not a patient man.'

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The other thing that happened in July happened on the Palatine, and she did not hear of it until much later, and she heard it from a woman who had it from a slave who had it from the steward, so it came to her third-hand, and she never knew how much of it was true.

Tarquitius Priscus had gone to the prefect's office on the business of the Lusitania case and had been told, by a clerk with a long face, that the company's tablets would not be forthcoming. He had then gone to Naso, and Naso had told him the truth, which was that the tablets existed, that they were in a strongbox in the Ostian warehouse, and that they would be produced for the Senate if the curator of the public works could arrange for a certain objection to be withdrawn from the file of a certain property in the fifth region.

That is to say: if he would drop the matter of the portico.

Tarquitius had said, in the flat voice of a man who has been insulted by a tradesman, that he did not make bargains of that kind.

Naso had said, with great politeness, that he had not proposed one, and had shown him out.

Three days later the case had begun to be spoken of in the Senate as a case that would fail, and two of the men who had promised to support the prosecution had found reasons to be in Baiae in October. Tarquitius had spent a night with the file, and in the morning he had sent his secretary to the house of Cluvius Naso with a letter that said that the curator's inspection of the fifth region had been delayed by the condition of the streets and would not now begin before the spring.

Naso had replied, with equal politeness, that the tablets would be in Rome by the ninth day of August.

That, Antonia thought, when she heard it, was the end of the affair, and the portico was safe, and Naso was a better friend to her than she deserved, and she had never in her life been so thoroughly insulted by a piece of good news.

She sent Naso a jar of wine and a note that said: *You have made me a woman who was saved by her banker. I will not forget it, and neither, I imagine, will he.*

Naso wrote back: *He will not know it was me. He believes he acted on a point of law. He is a jurist; that is how they think.*

She read that twice, and then she wrote, on the back of a shopping list, because she had nothing else to hand: *No. He knows. A man like that always knows. And now he has been made to give way to me in a matter of law, and he will not rest until he has taken something of equal value, and I have nothing of equal value except the one thing he cannot buy.*

She did not send that. She put it in the strongbox with the four other things, and she was glad, later, that she had kept it, because it turned out to be the truest thing she wrote that year.

On the second day of August, Eucharis asked to see her.

The Greek woman was twenty-five and had been in the house six years and was, by common consent, the reason half the men who came through

the gate had come. She played the harp better than she sang and sang better than she played, and she had a way of listening to a man that made him feel that he had said something interesting, which is a rarer gift than beauty and lasts longer.

She came into the study and stood with her hands folded, and Antonia, who knew the difference between a woman who wants a favour and a woman who has come to make a statement, put down her stylus.

'Domina, I want to buy myself.'

Antonia leaned back.

'How much have you got?'

'Sixteen thousand sesterces. It is in the chest in my room and it is not stolen and Cinnamus counts it every month and he will tell you the same.' Eucharis's chin came up. 'I want to buy myself, and I want to stay. I have thought about it for a year and I know how it sounds. I want to be a free woman in this house, on wages, with a contract, and I want the contract in writing, and I want it registered, and I want to be able to leave in three years if I choose and to be paid the same whether I choose or not.'

Antonia was silent for a moment. In the corridor outside, a broom went past and stopped and then went on, and someone, somewhere, dropped a pan.

'You have thought about this,' she said.

'I have had nothing else to do with my evenings,' said Eucharis.

'You know what a contract would mean. If you are free and you stay, every man who comes through that gate will know that you are free and can be approached. They will offer you money to leave and set up in your own rooms, and two of them will offer you a house, and one of them will offer to marry you and will mean it and will be a fool, and you will have to decide, every month, whether to stay.' Antonia put her hands flat on the table. 'In this house you are protected by the fact that you are mine. It is not a noble kind of protection. It is the same protection as a good lock. But it is a lock, and the day you are free you will be a woman with sixteen thousand sesterces and no lock at all.'

'I know,' said Eucharis.

'You have been thinking about the wrong thing,' Antonia said. 'You have been thinking that freedom is a thing a person buys once. It is not. It is a thing a person buys every morning, and some mornings it costs more than others, and some mornings you will not be able to afford it, and you will go back to bed and be somebody's property for another week and you will hate yourself for it. I know. I have done it.'

'Then you will refuse.'

'I will not refuse.' Antonia took a tablet and a stylus. 'You will pay me twelve thousand, not sixteen, because the other four will be your first month's rent, and the room over the garden is yours, and the contract will say that you pay a rent, and that you are free to leave with a month's notice, and that the house will not sell your contract to anyone because there will be no contract to sell.' She began to write. 'And it will say one thing more. If you leave, you leave with your money and your clothes and nothing else, and you will not take any of the other women with you, and you will not tell a guest anything that you learned in this house. Not because I will punish you. Because a woman who tells is a woman no house will have, and I am not doing this to give you a way to ruin yourself.'

Eucharis stood very still. Then she said, in a different voice, 'You are crying, domina.'

'I am writing,' said Antonia.

'You are crying and writing.'

'It is the same thing when the writing is a contract,' said Antonia, 'and if you tell anyone I will deny it.' She sanded the tablet and held it out. 'Take it to Cinnamus. He will make the fair copy and he will register it, and he will charge you for the registration because he charges everyone for everything and it is why we are not poor.'

Eucharis took the tablet and held it against her chest with both hands, the way a person holds something that might break.

'Domina,' she said. 'Why twelve and not sixteen?'

Antonia looked up.

'Because a woman who buys her freedom should have something left over for the first bad month,' she said, 'and because when I bought mine I

had a hundred and ten thousand and I still woke in the night for a year thinking I had spent it.'

The first report came on the last day of July, and it came in a way she had not expected: Hilarus sent a boy with a message asking her to come to his house, which was in the sixth region, above a fuller's, and which she entered by the back stairs with a veil and a hood, feeling absurd.

He had a room at the top with a table and a lamp and eleven boxes of tablets, and he had been, she could see, sleeping in it.

'For the sale of slaves,' he said, 'the tax is four per cent, and the record is kept at the station of the quattuorviri in the town where the sale is made, and a copy goes to the prefect's office in Rome. The town records at Puteoli are in the cellar of the basilica, and the cellar floods in February, and the boxes are stacked by year and nobody has looked at them since the reign of Domitian.' He sat down. 'I found nothing in the town records for that year, because the year is missing. The whole year. It is not rot; it is not water; the box is there and the year before it and the year after it are there, and the year itself is not, and there is a note in the index in a later hand that says "mislaid."'

Antonia sat down opposite him.

'So it is gone.'

'So somebody took it,' said Hilarus, 'which is the best news I have had in a month, because a man does not steal a record unless the record says something. So I went to the man who was clerk of that station in that year, and he is seventy-four and lives in a room in Naples and he remembers the year very well, because in that year the station was visited by a woman from the household at Arretium who paid him eleven sesterces to lose the box.' Hilarus looked up. 'A slave woman. He did not know her name. He described her: fifty years old, a mark on the left hand, a scar through the eyebrow, and a way of speaking that put him in mind of a household he had served in as a boy, which was the household of the Tarquitii at Arretium, because he was born on that estate.'

Antonia's hands were very cold.

'He took nine sesterces,' she said.

'He took eleven sesterces and he lost the box, and then he worried about it for twenty-six years, and when I found him he wept and asked me whether he was going to be prosecuted, and I told him that he was not, and he told me everything he remembered, which was more than I expected, because it turns out that a man who has been worrying for twenty-six years has been rehearsing.' Hilarus turned over a tablet. 'The box was taken by a woman he knew as Sabbia, who was in the household of the Tarquitii, and who was in Puteoli with a child. A girl child, two days old. And Sabbia took the child to a dealer in the town — a man named Caius Oppius Felix, who is dead, but whose business was bought by his partner, whose name is Lucius Annaeus Phoebus, and who is alive and is sixty-two and lives in Rome, on the Aventine, and who has been for thirty years a dealer in children.'

The lamp guttered.

'Where is the girl?' said Antonia.

'That is the next thing,' said Hilarus, 'and it will take another month. Phoebus sold her, and Phoebus will have a record, because dealers keep records, because a dealer who cannot prove where a child came from cannot sell it twice. He will have a record, and the record will have a price and a buyer, and the buyer will be a household or a family or a brothel.' He paused. 'Domina. Before I go to him, I need to know what you want me to do if the answer is a household in Rome, and the household is one that knows you.'

'Why would it know me?'

'Because there are perhaps forty families in this city who would buy a healthy girl child in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo at a price worth recording,' said Hilarus, 'and a third of them are families whose names are in your account books.'

Antonia stood up. She went to the little window and looked down into the street, where a man was leading a goat and two children were following it.

‘You will tell me,’ she said. ‘And then I will decide. And Hilarus —’

‘Domina.’

‘When you go to Phoebus,’ she said, ‘you will not mention my name. You will go as an advocate’s clerk, or a man from the prefect’s office, or a brother of the child, or anything at all. You will not mention me, and you will not mention the Tarquitii, and you will not mention a price.’

‘And if he asks why I want to know?’

‘Tell him the truth,’ she said. ‘Tell him a woman is looking for her daughter. It is the one thing in this city that nobody will think is a lie, because nobody would invent it.’

CHAPTER EIGHT

A Daughter of the House

— ◆ —

Marcellina had never in her life been alone in a street.

That was the thing she noticed first, and she noticed it with a kind of astonishment: that a person could walk down the Vicus Patricius at dusk with a hood over her hair and a basket on her arm and no one would look at her twice. She had expected to be stopped. She had prepared four answers, and one of them was a lie so elaborate that she had rehearsed it aloud in her room. Nobody stopped her. A man with a barrow shouted at her to move, and she moved, and he went past without seeing her at all.

She had come out of the house at the eighth hour, through the garden gate, while her father was at a dinner at the house of a man named Sura and her grandmother was asleep and the steward was counting the silver. She had told the girl who attended her that she was unwell and was not to be disturbed. She had taken off her rings and put them in a box and put on the plain grey dress of a woman of the merchant class and a pair of her nurse's sandals, which were a size too large.

The dress was the hardest part. A senator's daughter does not own a plain grey dress. She had bought it, three weeks earlier, from a woman who sold cloth in the market by the Temple of Tellus, and she had paid for it out of the money she had been given for the shrine of the crossroads, and she had hidden it under the floor of the linen press, and she had thought, each time she looked at it, that she was committing a crime.

The Golden Vine was not what she expected either. She had expected lamps and music and women in paint and a doorkeeper who would refuse her. There were lamps, and there was a doorkeeper — a large old Thracian with a scar through one eyebrow, who looked at her for a long moment — and there was a fountain in a peristyle, and a smell of box hedge and hot stone and something cooking that made her suddenly, absurdly hungry.

'You will wait here,' said the doorkeeper.

'Will you tell her—'

'I will tell her a young woman with a basket is at the door and will not give her name,' said the doorkeeper. 'What she does with that is her business.'

She waited in a small room by the entrance with a bench and a worn mosaic and a lamp. There was a smell in that room that she could not place and afterwards identified as beeswax and cheap wine and the dust of a hundred sandals.

Then the doorkeeper came back and took her through.

Antonia Cassia was standing in the peristyle with her hands in the folds of her dress, and she was not what Marcellina expected either. She was not painted. She was not young. She was a woman of forty-one in a plain dark dress with her hair pinned up and no jewellery except one ring, and she looked at Marcellina for a long moment, and her face did something that Marcellina did not understand, and would understand much later.

'You had better come into the garden,' said Antonia Cassia. 'There are eleven people in this house who can hear a whisper through a wall, and four of them are honest.'

The garden was small and walled and full of the smell of a fig tree. There was a bench under the wall, and Antonia sat on it and gestured, and Marcellina sat.

'Take off your hood,' said Antonia.

Marcellina took off her hood.

'You are Tarquitia Marcellina,' said Antonia. 'You have your father's mouth and your grandmother's bones, and you have come here in a grey dress you bought in the market and a pair of sandals that do not fit you, and you have left your rings at home, which was sensible, and you have come at dusk, which was also sensible, and you have made four mistakes since you came through the gate, the first of which was giving your name to the doorkeeper in a voice that has been taught to speak to inferiors.'

Marcellina found that her heart was going very fast and that she was not frightened.

'What were the other three?' she said.

'You looked at the mosaic,' said Antonia. 'A woman who has lived in a house with a mosaic all her life does not look at a mosaic. You said "will you tell her" instead of "will you tell your mistress," which means you have been in a house where the doorkeeper is a man with a name. And you are wearing your nurse's sandals, which are a size too large, and a girl who has run away from a house does not borrow her nurse's sandals; she steals her own back from the laundry. You are not running away. You have come out for an evening and you intend to go back.' She folded her hands. 'What do you want?'

'I want to know what my father will not tell me,' said Marcellina.

'About what?'

'About you.'

Antonia was silent for a moment. In the dark of the garden the fig leaves moved, and somewhere beyond the wall a woman laughed and was hushed.

'Why?'

'Because he has thought about you every day of his life and I have watched him do it,' said Marcellina, and heard her own voice shake, and went on. 'When I was nine I asked him who had painted the ceiling in the north room and he told me the name of the painter and the year and the price of the gold, and then he stopped in the middle of a sentence and went out of the room. When I was twelve, a woman at the baths said your name in front of him and he finished his cup and left. When I was fifteen, I found a cupboard in his study that was locked, and I picked the lock with a nail, which took me three days, and there were no papers in it at all. It was empty. He had a cupboard built, and a lock put on it, and there was nothing in it, and I understood that the nothing was the point.' She stopped, and then said, 'Every year, in August, he writes a letter and burns it. He does it in the garden, at the ninth hour, and he does not know that I have seen it. He writes it, and he does not send it, and he burns it in the

brazier by the wall, and then he goes in and washes his hands.'

Antonia did not move.

'Every year?' she said.

'Every year since I was old enough to watch,' said Marcellina, 'and my grandmother says he has done it since before I was born.'

The fig leaves moved. Antonia sat with her hands in her lap and looked at the wall for what seemed to Marcellina a very long time.

'And what have you been told?' Antonia said at last.

'That you are a woman of no family who keeps a house where men go, and that my father has had dealings with you, and that I am not to speak of it.' Marcellina lifted her chin. 'And that whatever happened was twenty-five years ago and is not my concern.'

'That is more than most girls are told.'

'It is nothing at all,' said Marcellina, 'and I am nineteen, and in the winter I am to be married to a man who has a great name and no money and who plays at dice with cheats, and I will go into his house and be the daughter of my father, and the wife of my husband, and one day I will be the mother of a boy who will be told that his father's name is the most important thing about him. And I will have a cupboard in my house with nothing in it, and I will sit in front of it, and I will not be able to say a single true thing to anyone I love, because the truth will have been decided for me by people who are dead.' Her voice did not rise. 'I am not here to be scandalised. I have been scandalised for a week and it was boring. I am here because there is a true thing in my father's life, and he will not tell it to me, and he never will, and if I marry in the winter and go to that house I will never have another chance to hear it.'

Antonia looked at her for a long moment.

'You are very like him,' she said. 'You have his manners at the end of a speech.'

'I have been told I have his mouth.'

'You have his manners,' said Antonia. 'The mouth is your grandmother's.' She stood up and walked to the end of the garden and back, and Marcellina watched her, and it was like watching a woman do

arithmetic. 'I am going to tell you three things,' she said, 'and then you are going to go home, and you are not going to come back, and if you are asked where you were this evening you will say that you were at the house of your nurse's sister, and you will say it as though you were bored.'

'Three things.'

'The first is true and will do you no good: your father and I have known each other since I was fifteen, and whatever else there is, there is that, and it cannot be undone by either of us. The second is also true and is the only thing in the world that will help you: he is not a cruel man, and that is worse for you than if he were, because a cruel man can be hated and a man who is not cruel can only be disappointed, and you will spend your life being disappointed by him in small ways and he will never understand why. The third—' She stopped. 'The third is that whatever you have heard about me is probably true, and that the reason I am not going to tell you the rest is not that I am protecting him. It is that I have spent twenty-five years not telling it, and I have not yet decided what it is.'

Marcellina sat very still.

'That is not an answer,' she said.

'No,' said Antonia. 'It is a door. You may knock on it again when you are older and I will decide then whether to open it.' She turned. 'Now. Before you go. You will do something for me.'

Marcellina's eyes narrowed. 'What?'

'You said there is a cupboard in his study with nothing in it. Is there anything else in that room with a lock? A box, a chest, a drawer in the table?'

'There is a strongbox in the wall behind the second press. It has an iron door and two locks.' Marcellina paused. 'I have never opened it.'

'Do not open it,' said Antonia. 'But tell me — is it opened often?'

'Every month. He opens it himself, and the steward is not present, and he counts something and locks it again. I have heard him do it. It takes about a quarter of an hour.'

Antonia nodded slowly.

'That is all,' she said. 'You have paid for your evening. Now go home before the ninth hour.'

Marcellina stood. She felt, suddenly, that she had been handled, and she was not sure she minded, and that frightened her more than anything else that had happened.

'Why do you want to know about his strongbox?' she said.

'Because in the winter your father is going to try to ruin me,' said Antonia, 'and I would like to know what he keeps in it before he does.'

'And you think I will tell you.'

'I think you will think about it for a month,' said Antonia, 'and then you will come back, and you will tell yourself that you are coming back to ask a question, and you will bring me something in your basket, and you will not know why you are doing it, and neither, by then, will I.' She walked her to the gate herself. 'Marcellina. One more thing, and then we will not speak of it. There is a man in this city named Marcus Sestius and a boy named Cirrus, and if either of them ever speaks to you at the games, you will be very polite and you will tell your father that same evening, whether you wish to or not.'

'I do not know them.'

'You will,' said Antonia. 'Go home.'

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Marcellina's betrothed came to dinner two days before.

His name was Servius Aelius Gracilis and he was twenty-seven, and he had the misfortune to be exactly what he appeared to be: a pleasant, weak, well-mannered young man from a family that had been consular in the time of the divine Augustus and had not produced a magistrate of any consequence in four generations. He was not a villain. He was not even a fool, quite. He was a man who had been told all his life that he was the last of something, and who had responded to that information by developing a taste for expensive horses and a talent for losing money in company, so that the losing could always be described as generosity.

He arrived at the eighth hour with two friends and a jar of wine that had cost him more than he had, and he was charming to the grandmother, and respectful to Tarquitius, and he treated Marcellina with a courtesy that was so careful that it was almost a form of distance, as though she were a valuable object he had been permitted to look at.

At dinner he talked about the games. He talked about a charioteer named Scorpus, and the factions, and a race in which a man had been killed at the turn, and he told the story well, and the two friends laughed, and Tarquitius asked a question about the size of the purse, and Marcellina sat with her hands in her lap and watched him.

He would be kind to her, she thought. He would be kind to her the way a man is kind to a thing that has been given to him and that he does not quite know how to hold. And in seven years he would have spent her dowry, and he would be sorry, and he would be sorry in the way of a man who has never had to be anything else.

After dinner, when the men had gone to look at the horses, her grandmother said, 'He has good manners.'

'He has nothing else,' said Marcellina.

'Good manners are not nothing. I have been married to a man with bad manners and a great deal of money and I would not recommend either.' The old woman turned her blind face. 'You are thinking of refusing him.'

'I am thinking that no one has asked me.'

'That is not the same as refusing,' said Tarquitia Priscilla, 'and it is the most dangerous thing a woman can think, because it feels like virtue and it is only delay.' She put out her hand for her cup. 'If you are going to refuse, refuse in the summer, while your father still has something to lose. If you wait until the contracts are signed you will be refusing a man who has already been humiliated and you will find that the world has very little sympathy for a girl who changes her mind after the wine has been bought.'

'I do not know how to refuse,' said Marcellina.

'No,' said her grandmother. 'Nobody teaches us that. It is the great omission in the education of daughters.' She drank. 'You will learn. Every woman learns, or she is broken, and you are not the broken kind. Your

father's sister learned it and used it too well, and I learned it and never used it at all, and you will have to find your own way, and I will not be here to see it.'

She got home at the ninth hour and went in through the garden gate and up the back stairs, and she was in her room with the grey dress in her hands when the door opened and her grandmother came in, feeling her way along the wall with one hand.

'You have been out,' said Tarquitia Priscilla.

Marcellina stood with the dress against her chest.

'The nurse's sister,' she said. 'She is ill.'

'You have been out,' said her grandmother again, 'and you have come back with the smell of a fig tree on you, and there are no fig trees between this house and the house of your nurse's sister, which is in the fourth region and has a courtyard with a bay tree in it. You have been on the Esquiline.'

Marcellina said nothing.

The blind face came toward her. Her grandmother's hand found the edge of the bed and then the dress, and her fingers went over the cheap wool.

'Grey,' she said. 'You bought a grey dress, and you paid for it out of the shrine money, and you have been to that house.' She sat down on the bed. 'Sit down. Do not stand there breathing like a horse.'

Marcellina sat.

'Did she see you?' said her grandmother.

'Yes.'

'Did she tell you?'

'Nothing,' said Marcellina. 'She told me three things and one of them was that she had not yet decided what the truth is.'

Her grandmother was silent for a long time. In the corridor the watchman went past with his lamp, and the light came under the door and went away.

'She is a better woman than your father,' said Tarquitia Priscilla at last, 'and she is a worse one, and both of those things are true in the same way that a coin has two faces and you cannot buy bread with the edge of it.' Her hand found Marcellina's hand and held it. 'I am going to tell you something, and then we are not going to speak of it again, and you are not going to repeat it to your father, because he would not survive it and I am too old to watch him not survive it.'

'Grandmother—'

'When I was young,' said the old woman, 'I was told that there was a way for a woman in this family to live. You kept the accounts, you kept the peace, you kept your mouth shut, and in exchange the family kept you. It is a bargain, and it is not a bad bargain, and I made it, and I made it for sixty years, and I have been comfortable, and I have been respected, and I have not once been happy, and there is not a day that goes by that I do not think about a girl in a linen room and what I did not do.'

Marcellina's hand was being held very tightly.

'What girl?' she said.

'Go to sleep,' said her grandmother, and stood up, and found the wall with her hand. 'The grey dress goes in the fire tonight. I will hear it, so do not lie to me about it in the morning. And Marcellina—' At the door she stopped. 'When you marry in the winter, and you are in that house, and they tell you that the way to live is to keep the accounts and keep the peace and keep your mouth shut — you will remember that your grandmother did it for sixty years and was never once happy, and you will decide for yourself, and whatever you decide, you will not tell me, because I will be dead.'

Antonia did not sleep that night.

She sat in the small room off the library, where a girl with a remarkable voice had once slept on a stool, and she had a lamp and a cup and a tablet, and she did not write on the tablet.

Every August, at the ninth hour, he wrote a letter and burned it.

She had written eleven letters herself, over the years, and had burned all of them, and she had done it in the brazier in the corner of the courtyard at the ninth hour of the evening on the twenty-ninth day of August, and it had never once occurred to her — not once, in twenty-five years — that he might be doing the same thing at the same hour on the other side of the city.

It was not proof of anything. That was what she told herself, and it was true, and it did not help. A man might burn a letter out of hatred as easily as out of grief, and a woman might sit in a small room at midnight and invent a symmetry because she needed one.

But she sat there until the lamp went out, and she thought about a girl of nineteen in a grey dress with her grandmother's bones, who had picked a lock with a nail when she was fifteen and found nothing in the cupboard, and who had come across the city at dusk to ask a woman she had been taught to despise for the truth.

In the morning she sent for Cinnamus.

'The cupboard in the study of the house on the Palatine,' she said. 'It is empty. He had it built and there is nothing in it. And there is a strongbox in the wall behind the second press with two locks, and he opens it once a month, alone, and counts something, and it takes a quarter of an hour.'

Cinnamus wrote it down.

'Domina,' he said, 'may I ask how you know this?'

'You may not,' said Antonia, 'and you will not write that down either.'

Three days later, Hilarus came to the shoemaker's shop with the second report.

He had found Phoebus, the dealer on the Aventine, and Phoebus had been cooperative, and the reason Phoebus had been cooperative was that he was sixty-two and frightened of dying and had begun, in the manner of such men, to keep a book of his own in which the prices were written honestly.

The girl child sold out of Puteoli in the September of that year had been sold for two hundred and forty sesterces, which was the price of a healthy infant with no defects, to a household in Rome.

'A household,' said Antonia.

'A household,' said Hilarus, 'and Phoebus remembers it, and he remembers it because it was not the kind of buyer he usually had. It was a woman of about forty, well dressed, with a slave with her, and she paid in silver and she asked for the bill of sale to be made out in the name of a man who was not present, and Phoebus, who has been in the trade for thirty years, asked no questions, because the questions are what cost you your licence.' He turned the tablet. 'The name on the bill of sale was Lucius Tarquitius Priscus.'

The room was very quiet. Somewhere below, the fuller's vats were being stirred.

'That is not possible,' said Antonia.

'It is written,' said Hilarus. 'It is written in a dealer's book in a hand that is not Phoebus's, and it is twenty-five years old, and it is the only thing in the world I have found that was not meant to be found, and I would not believe it either, except that I have spent fourteen years learning that the thing a careful man arranges is never the thing that happens.' He put the tablet down. 'The child was sold into the household of the Tarquitii. She was sold in her own father's name, by a woman, for two hundred and forty sesterces, and Phoebus does not know where she went after that, because the household did not sell her. Households do not sell a child they have bought; they keep it, and it grows up, and it becomes a maid, or a secretary, or a cook, and it is never entered in any record again unless it is sold or freed or dies.' He looked at her. 'Domina. Are you all right?'

Antonia was looking at the wall.

'It could be a fiction,' she said at last, and her voice was steady, and she was proud of it. 'A dealer with a book. A name written in the margin. He may have written the name because a woman gave it and he wanted a respectable name on the bill; dealers do that. It may mean nothing at all.'

'It may,' said Hilarus.

'Have you been to Arretium?'

'Not yet. I wanted to bring you this first.'

'Go,' said Antonia. 'The household will have a slave list. Every villa with forty slaves has a list, because the steward must account for them, and the list will be in the estate records, and if a foundling was bought in the autumn of that year she will be entered, and she will have been given a name.' She stood up, and found that her hands were shaking, and put them behind her back. 'And Hilarus — the name. If she was bought into a household as an infant with no name, the steward will have given her a number, because when you buy four slaves in a month you enter them as primus, secundus, tertius. And a girl entered as a number is called the number for the rest of her life, and it becomes her name, and it becomes the name she is freed under, and it becomes the name she signs on the certificate. So look for a woman's name in that household that is also a number.'

Hilarus looked at her for a moment with something that was not quite admiration and not quite pity.

'You have done this before,' he said.

'No,' said Antonia. 'I have been on the other end of it. It is how I know what the paper looks like.'

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She walked home from the shoemaker's, which she never did, and Myrrhine met her at the gate with her face already set.

'You have been to the sixth region,' she said. 'Alone, veiled, at the seventh hour of the evening. If you were seen, half the city will know by the morning that Antonia Cassia goes to that neighbourhood, and by the afternoon they will have invented a lover, and by the winter it will be in a speech in the Senate.'

'Then I will not be seen,' said Antonia, and went past her.

'Antonia.' Myrrhine caught her arm in the corridor, which she had not done in eleven years. 'Antonia. Stop.'

Antonia stopped.

'You have found something,' said Myrrhine. 'Look at me. You have found something, and you are not going to tell me, and you are going to go up to that room with the strongbox and sit in it until the morning with the four things in the box and the one name you will not say, and then you will come down tomorrow and you will be a woman who has decided something, and I will be told the decision and not the reason, and it will be the same as it has been for twenty-five years, and I am tired of it.'

Antonia stood in the corridor with the lamps lit and the smell of the evening's cooking coming up from the court.

'She is in a house in Rome,' she said. 'She has been in a house in Rome for twenty-five years. The paper says she was sold into a great household, and the name on the paper is the name of a man I know, and I do not know whether he bought her or whether he signed the bill and never saw her.' She heard her own voice, flat, careful, and it was the voice of the accounts. 'I do not know if she is alive. I do not know if she is a slave. I do not know whether the household I am thinking of is the household, and if it is, I do not know whether she has been in a room above my head at a dinner table at which I was not present, and I do not know what I will do when I find out, and I have been thinking about it for two hours and I have got exactly as far as I got in the first minute.'

Myrrhine let go of her arm.

'Oh,' she said.

'Yes.'

'Oh, Antonia.'

'Do not,' said Antonia. 'Not tonight. If you are kind to me tonight I will not be able to do what I have to do tomorrow, and what I have to do tomorrow is write letters to four men as though the world were ordinary.'

'What do you have to do tomorrow?'

'Wait,' said Antonia. 'That is the thing nobody tells you about money. Everyone thinks it buys you the power to act. It buys you the power to wait, and the waiting is the part that costs.'

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That night she did not go up to the room with the strongbox.

She went up to the roof instead, and lay on the tiles in the dark with the whole of Rome making its noise beneath her, all those millions of people awake or asleep under the same smoke, each of them in a room with a door, and behind some of those doors, she thought, there was a girl of twenty-five who had been entered in a list as a number and had been called the number ever since, and who did not know that she had a mother on the Esquiline who had been looking for her for eleven weeks, and who had, at some point in her life, learned to read, or not.

The last of the four things in the strongbox was the clay figure of a woman with her hands over her face, which a slave in Puteoli had given her to keep her from dreaming.

She had never once in twenty-five years slept with it under her pillow. She took it downstairs that night and put it on the table by her bed, and in the morning she put it in her sleeve, where it stayed for the rest of the summer, and where anyone who had known what to look for would have seen a small clay woman with her hands over her face, worn smooth by somebody's thumb.

CHAPTER NINE

The Dedication

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It rained on the morning of the dedication, which the whole city took as an insult and then, by the ninth hour, as a blessing, because the rain stopped and the stone came up cool and the smell of the streets was washed away for the first time since June.

Antonia went. She had not intended to go. She had intended to spend the day in the house with the shutters closed, doing the accounts of the grain contracts, which had come back from Ostia with three signatures and a clause that she did not like. But on the morning itself she stood at the window of her bedroom and looked down at the street, where the whole hill was already moving, and she thought: if I do not go, they will say I was afraid.

There were eleven thousand people in the streets between the Esquiline and the Forum that morning. There were litters and chairs and donkeys and a man with a trained bear and three separate processions of priests going in different directions, and the vigiles standing at the corners with their buckets and their poles and their expressions of men who expected trouble and intended to be early to it.

Antonia went in a plain litter with Myrrhine and two of the women and Brennus walking beside it, and they came down the Vicus Cyprius into the flood of the city, and it took them an hour and a half to travel a distance that could be walked in a quarter.

The new forum was not finished. It had been eleven years in the making, and it had swallowed a hill and a market and a temple and part of the old Greek quarter, and the emperor had paid for it out of the Dacian spoils, which was the only reason the city had tolerated the noise. But the great basilica was done, and the two libraries, and the column with its spiral of carved soldiers, and the open square where the equestrian statue stood

in the middle of everything like a man who has arrived at a party and knows that the room is looking at him.

The ceremony was in the square, in front of the basilica, and the space was so large that most of the people in it could not see the ceremony at all, and did not mind, because the point of a crowd is to be a crowd.

Antonia stood with Myrrhine at the edge of the equestrian order's section, where she had a right to be, because her fortune was above the census, and where she was tolerated, because a woman of her kind is tolerable at a public ceremony if she stands at the edge and does not attempt to be seen. She wore a dark blue dress and the carnelian ring and nothing else, and she stood with her hands folded and her face composed, and for the first hour she watched the crowd instead of the ceremony.

The crowd was the city in its own shape. There were senators in their broad stripes and their careful dignity, and equestrians with their narrow stripes, and the people in their tunics, and the women in their rows with their veils and their children, and in the upper part of the square, where the slope came down from the old quarters, the whole mass of the poor, wedged in and cheerful.

There were slave women carrying wine and cakes in baskets, calling their prices. There were pickpockets, and there were men who watched the pickpockets and would take a share later. There was a girl of about seven sitting on her father's shoulders, with a garland of laurel that was too big for her, holding on to his hair. There was a man in a toga that had been mended at the hem, who stood very straight and mouthed the words of the ceremony as they were spoken, and who Antonia realised, after a while, was a freedman who had learned the words from a book because he had never been allowed to hear them.

When the emperor came out onto the steps of the basilica the noise went up like a physical thing, and Antonia found that her eyes had gone wet, and she was furious with herself, and she was not the only one.

He was a heavy man, forty-nine, with a broad face and grey hair and the particular look of a soldier who has been promoted beyond his expectations and has decided to be worthy of them. He did not look like a

god. That was the thing that people said about him afterwards, in the crowd, going home: *he does not look like a god, he looks like a man who is good at his job*. He stood with the consuls and the prefects and the priests of the city, and he spoke for eleven minutes, and the speech was about stone and water and the duty of the state to the city, and it was not a great speech, and the crowd loved it.

'He is not much of an orator,' said a man behind Antonia, to his neighbour.

'No,' said the neighbour. 'But he pays on time.'

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When it was over, and the incense had been carried away in its silver dishes and the priests had gone off in their procession to the Capitol, Antonia did not go home.

There was a distribution of money at the gates of the basilica — three hundred sesterces to every citizen on the roll, which was the emperor's way of saying that the Dacian gold had been well spent — and the crowd had to be managed in lines, and the lines had to be managed by the vigiles, and the whole of the great square was a slow-moving river of people who had been given money and were determined to enjoy it.

Antonia stood with Myrrhine at the foot of the column and watched the queue.

'We should go,' said Myrrhine.

'In a moment.'

'You have been saying that for an hour.'

'I am watching something,' said Antonia, and it was true. She was watching the queue, which was the truest thing in Rome, because a queue is a society with the decoration removed. There were men in the queue who had been born free and men in the queue who had been freed the year before and men in the queue who were technically the property of the man in front of them and who had been sent to collect his money. There were women with babies and old men with sticks, and there was a blind beggar being guided by a dog, and there was a group of Jews from the Trans

Tiberim who had come across the river for the distribution and who stood together, separate from the line, waiting until the crowd thinned, as people do who have learned that being first is not always a good idea.

And at the head of the queue, at the table where the money was given out, there was a clerk with a list, and a freedman of the prefect's office beside him, and a soldier, and beside the soldier there was a man whose whole function, Antonia realised after a while, was to look at the faces of the people who came to the table and decide which of them were citizens and which of them had borrowed a toga.

'It is the most honest thing in the city,' she said. 'A list of names, and a man with a stick, and a queue. Everything else in Rome is a performance. That is an account.'

'You are in a sentimental mood,' said Myrrhine. 'It is the rain.'

'It is the emperor,' said Antonia. 'He was not a god, and he did not pretend to be, and for a whole morning the city was governed by a man who was good at his job, and everyone in the square felt the same thing at the same time, and it was not love. It was relief.' She turned. 'And it will not last, and in twenty years the Senate will be back to arguing about blood, and the man after him will be worse, and my daughter's children will be told that this was the golden age and will not believe it.'

She stopped. She had said it out loud, in the middle of the Forum, with eleven thousand people around her.

Myrrhine looked at her.

'You said my daughter,' she said.

'I said nothing.'

'You said my daughter, and the man in front of us in a brown cloak heard you, and he has already decided that you meant something else, because no woman in a dark blue dress in the equestrian section says my daughter in the Forum of Trajan in the year of the consulship of—'

'Myrrhine.'

'—and we are going home,' said Myrrhine, 'now, and you will talk about the weather, and I will not ask you anything, and when we are behind the door of your own study you will tell me what you have done,

and if you do not tell me I will put laudanum in your wine and find out from Cinnamus.'

'Cinnamus does not know.'

'Cinnamus knows everything,' said Myrrhine. 'Cinnamus knew before you did. Cinnamus has probably known since June and has been keeping it in the third stack, which is where he keeps the things that are neither.'

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They were ten paces from the edge of the square when a woman in a green dress stepped out of the crowd in front of them and said, 'Antonia.'

It was Vibia Lucana, and she was flushed and her hair was coming down and she was holding the hand of a small boy of about six, who was eating a honey cake and had it all over his face.

'This is my sister's son,' said Vibia. 'I have lost my sister. She was in the crowd by the fountain and now she is not, and I have been walking in circles for a quarter of an hour and he has eaten three cakes and I have begun to be afraid that I will be arrested for kidnapping a child I am related to.'

'He is not troubled by it,' said Antonia.

'He is six. Nothing troubles him except the absence of cake.' Vibia looked at her, and her face changed. 'You have been crying.'

'I have not.'

'You have the face. I have seen that face at eleven funerals and one wedding.' Vibia glanced at Myrrhine, and something passed between them, and then Vibia said, in a different voice, 'I have heard a story about you and the curator of the works in the portico.'

'There was a rainstorm. There were four hundred people in the portico.'

'There are always four hundred people in every story,' said Vibia. 'That is what makes them believable.' She shifted the boy's hand in hers. 'I am going to tell you something as a friend, and then I am going to go and find my sister and pretend I never said it. You cannot be seen with him. Not once, not ever, not in the rain. Not because of what it means; because of

what it will be made to mean. There is a kind of man in this city who cannot bear the thought of a woman with a house and a fortune and no husband, and those men have been looking for a way to explain you for eleven years, and now you have given them one. The explanation is not that you are clever. The explanation is that you have a protector on the Palatine, and everything you have built is his, and every woman who works for you is his, and the whole of your life is a front for a man's appetite.' Vibia's voice was quiet and hard. 'I have seen it happen to a woman in Ostia. She kept a shipping office for nineteen years. A rumour like this got into her business and she was dead in three years — not ruined. Dead. She took a fever because she could not afford a physician and her friends had all been told that she was somebody's mistress and had stopped calling.'

The boy pulled at her hand and said something about a dog.

'Thank you,' said Antonia.

'Do not thank me. Go home.' Vibia turned, and then turned back. 'And Antonia — the thing I said I would ask you for, one day. I have not decided what it is yet. But I want you to remember that I stood in a crowd and told you the truth when it would have been easier to tell you a joke.'

'I will remember.'

'Good,' said Vibia, and went off into the crowd with the boy, calling her sister's name.

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It was after the ceremony, when the crowd had begun to break up into its smaller currents, that the rain came back — not the morning's steady rain but a sudden violence out of the north, the sort that Rome gets three or four times in a summer and never expects. The whole square turned at once and moved for the colonnades. Antonia, with Myrrhine and Brennus, was carried by the crowd into the portico of the basilica as though by a river, and there she stopped, because the portico was full and there was a wall, and there was nowhere to go.

She was standing with her back to a marble column and water running off the edge of the roof in a sheet, and Myrrhine was pressed against her

shoulder and saying something that could not be heard, and a senator's wife was complaining about her hair, and a small boy had lost his mother and was being passed overhead from hand to hand toward the outer edge, where a woman was screaming his name.

And Lucius Tarquitius Priscus was standing four feet away, with his toga over his arm and his hair wet, and he was looking at her.

They looked at each other for a moment. The noise of the rain on the roof was enormous.

Then he came across the four feet — it took him some time, because the crowd was a wall — and stopped in front of her, and said, in a voice pitched to be heard by her and not by anyone else, 'This is unfortunate.'

'It is rain,' said Antonia.

'It is a portico full of the entire Senate,' said Tarquitius, 'and I am standing in it, and you are standing in it, and there are forty men here who are already composing the sentence they will use at dinner.'

'Then you should go and stand somewhere else.'

'There is nowhere else. The alternative is the street, and I am not going to be seen running in the street in a wet toga at my age.' He looked at the rain. 'We will talk about something that no one can misrepresent. Tell me about your grain.'

Antonia's mouth twitched, once, despite her.

'You have heard about my grain,' she said.

'I have heard about your grain from eleven men, all of whom told me a different thing, and one of whom told me that you were ruining the city and another of whom told me that you had saved it.' He watched the water coming off the roof. 'I have also read the contract. The prefect of the corn supply sent me a copy because I am a jurist and he wanted an opinion on clause nine.'

'And what is your opinion of clause nine?'

'It is unenforceable. You have written a clause that requires you to deliver at a price fixed by the prefect in the event of a declared shortage, and there is no definition of a declared shortage anywhere in the document, and if the prefect declares one and you refuse to accept his

price, the case will go to the courts and you will win, because the clause is void for uncertainty.' He turned his head. 'You knew that when you wrote it.'

'I knew it when I dictated it.'

'Then clause nine is not a promise. It is a performance of a promise, designed to be shown to the prefect and to be litigated if it is ever tested, and the whole of the city will believe you for a year, and in a year the shortage will be over and no one will ever test it.' He said it without heat, as a man states the price of a fish. 'It is very cleverly done. I have seen worse men do worse things with better paper.'

'It is not a performance,' said Antonia.

'No?'

'If the prefect declares a shortage, I will deliver at his price, and I will not litigate, and I will lose two hundred thousand sesterces on the transaction, and I will do it because I have written the clause and because a woman in my position cannot afford to be shown to have written a clause she did not mean.' She looked at him. 'You cannot understand that, because you have never in your life had to be believed by people who did not wish to believe you.'

The rain was easing. The crowd had begun to move.

'You are wrong about that,' said Tarquitius, and there was something in his voice that she had not heard in twenty-five years, and it was gone almost before she heard it. 'I am going to ask you something, and you will answer it, and then we will not speak again until it is necessary.'

'Ask.'

'The publicani's tablets. Naso will produce them if you tell him to. The case is in October. If the tablets come out, the prosecution succeeds, and Atilius is exiled, and the Senate is reminded, for one season, that the law applies to governors.' He looked at her. 'If they do not come out, the case fails, and the provincials of Lusitania are told again what they have been told all their lives, which is that the law is a thing that happens in Rome and not in the provinces.'

'And what do you want from me?'

'I want you to tell Naso to produce them,' said Tarquitius, 'and I want you to want it, because the only thing in this city that I cannot buy, bully or argue into existence is a reason for a woman like you to help a man like me, and I am asking you to have one.'

'There is one.'

'Tell me.'

'Because the governor's brother-in-law is Marcus Sestius,' said Antonia, 'and because Sestius has spent the summer telling the city that my house should be closed, and because I would like him to spend the autumn explaining three receipts with his brother's name on them to a bench of consulars.' She smiled, and it was not a warm smile. 'You asked for a reason. I have given you a reason. It is not a noble one, and it is the only kind I have ever been able to afford.'

Tarquitius looked at her for a long moment. The rain had almost stopped. The light had come back, and the wet marble of the square beyond the portico was shining like something polished.

'That is a better reason than mine,' he said.

'What is yours?'

'I want to win,' said Tarquitius. 'I have wanted to win since I was a boy of nine in a house where my father had already won everything, and I have spent forty years finding out that winning is a thing that happens to you once and then becomes a habit that no longer feeds you.' He straightened his toga. 'I will tell the prefect that the tablets will be produced. You will tell Naso. And Antonia —'

She had not heard him say her name in twenty-five years. She had thought, in the way one thinks such things, that he had probably forgotten it, that she was to him a category, "the woman Cassia," a name on a bill.

'— the boy Cirrus is telling a story about your house,' he said. 'He is telling it in the baths and at dinners, and the story is that he was thrown out by a doorkeeper while you laughed, and that the singer is available at a price, and that you are the kind of woman who keeps a girl for a man and then sells her to his betters. Two of those things are lies and one of them is a slander and none of them will matter until the winter, when he will begin

to say them under oath.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'Do you know that his father has begun to collect evidence of the disorder of your house? He has a slave who was in your kitchen for a month in the spring.'

Antonia turned her head. 'Which slave?'

'A woman called Doris. She is not in your house now; she was sold in June to a baker in the fourth region, and Sestius bought her back in July and has her in his household, and she has been talking for a fortnight.' He said it evenly. 'She says that there are men in your house every night, that the women are paid wages, that wine is served to slaves, and that on the night of the Ides of May a young man was thrown into the street by a doorkeeper and that you stood in the doorway and laughed.'

'That is not what happened.'

'It is close enough to what happened to be sworn to,' said Tarquitius. 'A lie that is nearly true is the only kind that survives a cross-examination. You know that; you have been in court.'

The crowd had begun to move out into the square, and the sunlight was coming through the portico in long bright bars, and there were people pressing past them now from both sides, and a man with a tray of cakes shouting, and a woman calling for her son.

'Why are you telling me this?' said Antonia.

Tarquitius looked at her.

'Because in October I will be prosecuting a governor,' he said, 'and I will need to be a man whose judgement is respected, and it will not be respected if it is known that I warned the keeper of a disorderly house about a charge before it was laid.' He turned to go. 'So this conversation did not happen. You heard it from a clerk. You have never spoken to me in your life. Good day, domina.'

He went out into the light, and the crowd swallowed him, and Myrrhine said, at Antonia's shoulder, in a voice like a knife:

'Everyone saw.'

'I know.'

'Everyone saw, and half of them heard, and by the ninth hour of the night there will be a story, and the story will not be that the curator of the public works warned you about a charge. The story will be that you have been his mistress for twenty years and that the house on the Esquiline is where he goes on the seventh day.' Myrrhine took her arm. 'We are going home. Now. And you will not speak to anyone on the way, and if you smile at a single man I will personally put you in a litter and sit on you.'

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They went home through streets that were steaming. The whole city was out on the doorsteps, and the whole city had an opinion, and Antonia sat in the litter with her hands in her lap and listened to it through the curtains.

'A woman in blue, in the portico of the basilica, talking to the curator—'

'—the one from the Esquiline, the one with the house—'

'—they say the emperor looked at her—'

'—they say she has a senator's ring—'

It was extraordinary, she thought, how quickly a city could build a thing out of nothing, and how much pleasure there was in it, and how little of the pleasure was malice. They were not being cruel. They were making the day into a story, because a day is long and a story is short, and because the alternative — that nothing had happened in the portico but two people out of the rain — was unbearable to a crowd that had stood in the wet for four hours.

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On the Palatine, the story arrived at the seventh hour, in the form of a steward who came to the door of the small room where his mistress sat with a rug over her knees and said that there was a thing being said in the city that she might wish to hear.

Tarquitia Priscilla heard it out without moving.

'And what,' she said, when he had finished, 'is my son doing about it?'

'Nothing, domina. He came home at the fifth hour and he has been in his study since, and he has sent for the file on the Lusitania case, and he has not spoken to anyone.'

'Good,' said the old woman. 'That is what a man does when he has done something foolish and intends to behave as though he has not.' She was quiet for a moment. 'Caius. How long have you been in this house?'

'Thirty-one years, domina.'

'Thirty-one years. You came the year of the fire in the fifth region.' Her blind face turned. 'Do you remember, in the year after my husband died, a woman called Sabbia who was in the household at Arretium?'

The steward was silent.

'I remember her, domina.'

'Was there a child with her, when she came back from Campania?'

The silence went on for a long time. In the courtyard below, someone was watering the plants, and the water made a sound on the hot stone.

'There was a child, domina,' said the steward. 'She was entered in the household accounts as purchased at Puteoli, in the name of the master, and she was nursed by Sabbia's sister, and she was given the name Tertia, because she was the third child bought into the household that year.' He paused. 'She is not in the household now. She was freed seven years ago on your instruction, by the council's leave, and given a sum, and sent to Rome with a trade.'

'I know,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'I remember what I instructed. I am asking whether you remember what I did not instruct.'

'Domina.'

'Bring me the household list for the year she was bought,' said the old woman. 'The original. Not the copy. And Caius — you will bring it to me yourself, tonight, after the household is asleep, and you will not enter it in any book that you have brought anything to me at all.'

The steward bowed and went out.

Tarquitia Priscilla sat with her hands in her lap.

She had known, in the way that a blind woman knows things, that the story of the portico would come to her before the week was out, and she

had known what she would do when it came, and she had known it for twenty-five years, and she had not done it, and now she was seventy-eight years old and her son was fifty-three and there was a girl of nineteen in the house who had begun to ask questions.

'Well,' she said, to nobody at all. 'It has taken a long time.'

At the gate Meno took her cloak and said, quietly, 'There is a young woman in the garden, domina. She came at the ninth hour. She says she is the daughter of the house of Tarquitius.'

Antonia stopped.

'She said that?'

'She said, "Tell her it is the girl from the fig tree."' Meno's face was entirely without expression. 'I put her in the garden and told her to sit on the bench, and I told Prima to sit where she could see her, and Prima is there now, and the girl has been crying for an hour.'

Marcellina had been at the dedication. She had stood in the women's section with her grandmother's nurse and two of her father's clients' wives, and she had seen the ceremony, and she had seen the emperor, and she had seen, at the edge of the equestrian section, a woman in a dark blue dress who stood with her hands folded and watched the crowd instead of the ceremony.

Then the rain had come, and the crowd had moved, and Marcellina had been carried with it into the portico of the basilica, and she had been twenty feet away when her father came through the crowd and stopped in front of Antonia Cassia and spoke to her for the length of time it takes to say eleven sentences.

She had heard three of them. She had heard *this is unfortunate*, and she had heard something about grain, and she had heard, at the end, in a voice pitched low, the word *domina*.

She had stood in the portico with the rain coming off the roof and the crowd pressing and her heart going like a bird in a sack, and she had

understood in that moment, with a clarity that was like a door opening in a dark house, that her father was not a man with a secret. He was a man with a whole second life, going on in the same city, on the same days, in the same rain, and she had been nineteen years in his house and had never been told.

So she had gone home, and then she had gone out again, and she had come to the Esquiline in the rain, and she had sat in the garden under the fig tree for an hour, and she had cried, and she was ashamed of the crying and could not stop it.

'You said you would not come back,' said Antonia.

'I know what I said.' Marcellina's face was blotched and her hair was coming down. 'I have been in that portico. I heard him say domina to you, in the voice he uses for the gods and the dead. He has never in his life said my name in that voice.'

'What do you want me to tell you?'

'The truth,' said Marcellina. 'All of it. Not three things. I am not a child and I have been in a house with a cupboard in it for nineteen years, and in the winter I am to be married to a man who will spend my dowry, and I have decided, this afternoon, in the rain, in that portico, that I am not going to spend my life being told three things.'

Antonia looked at her for a long moment. Then she sat down on the bench, and put her hands in her lap, and looked at the wall.

'If I tell you the truth,' she said, 'you will have to carry it, and it will be heavy, and you will not be able to put it down, and the person it will hurt most is a man you love, who is not a monster and is not a good man, and who has spent twenty-five years building a wall around a room with nothing in it.' She looked up. 'And if I tell you, you will be in my debt, because that is how it works with secrets: the person who gives you one owns a part of you forever. I am telling you this now, before you ask, so that afterwards you cannot say I did not warn you.'

'I understand,' said Marcellina.

'You do not,' said Antonia. 'Nobody understands that until it happens to them.' She was silent for a moment. 'But you are nineteen and you are

alone in this city and you have asked, so I will tell you one thing tonight, and it is the only one you are ready for.'

She told her about the linen room.

PART THREE

What The Streets Know

CHAPTER TEN

The Dog Days

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By the thirteenth day of August the city had given up.

It gave up in a particular way, which anyone who has lived through a Roman summer knows: not with collapse but with a kind of slow, good-humoured surrender. The rich went to the coast or to the hills, and the ones who stayed sent their wives and children ahead and stayed themselves because of business, and were irritable about it. The poor moved their beds into the street. The markets opened before dawn and shut at the fourth hour. The shops that sold cold drinks did the trade of the year and the shops that sold wool did nothing at all. Dogs lay in the shade of the aqueduct arches and did not move for the flies. The Tiber went down and smelled of mud and old iron, and the sewers smelled of something worse, and the whole city acquired a smell that was, if you had been born in it, simply the smell of August.

The Golden Vine changed too.

In the winter the house was a machine with a roof and a fire and eleven women who were always warm. In the summer it was a house with the shutters closed at the third hour and the floors wet down twice a day and the water jars refilled four times, and the women lay on the roof at night on mattresses dragged up the back stairs, and the whole household became nocturnal, and the work happened between the ninth hour and the second hour of the night, when the air moved.

Antonia slept on the roof with the rest of them. It was the only time of year she did. She would come up at the ninth hour with a pillow and a cup and lie on her back and listen to the women talking in the dark, and they talked in a way they never did in the day: about their mothers, about the towns they came from, about the men who had been kind and the men who had not, about money, about whether it was better to be a free

woman in a bad marriage or a slave in a good house. There was no conclusion to any of it. It went on until the second hour and then it stopped, and the whole roof slept, and above it the sky was the colour of a coal that has been left in a brazier overnight.

That was how the house sounded when it was at peace. She was to remember it, afterwards, more clearly than anything else that happened that year: nine women on a roof in the dark, talking about their mothers.

Rubrius Celer came on the nineteenth, in the afternoon, when no sane man was out, and he came on foot with his toga over his arm and his face as red as a brick.

He had been at his mother's house at Tusculum for a month, and he had come back to Rome because he had been told, at a dinner, that the curator of the public works had been seen talking to Antonia Cassia in the portico of the basilica; and because he was twenty-six and had no other way of finding out whether it was true.

'It is true,' said Antonia. 'There was a rainstorm and there were four hundred people in the portico and he spoke to me about the grain supply.'

'They are saying—'

'I know what they are saying. I have known since the day it happened, and I have had eleven days of it, and I am tired of it, and you are tired and hot and you have walked up this hill in the sun for nothing.' She poured him water. 'Sit down.'

He sat down. He drank the water. He put the cup down and said, 'I am going to ask you something and I want you to answer it as though I were a man and not a boy.'

'Ask.'

'Do you want me to speak for you in the Senate? About the house. About Sestius.' He looked up. 'I have been a senator for seven months. I have no weight. I know that. But I have a name, and I am not afraid of him, and if I stand up in the autumn and say that the house of Antonia Cassia is a lawful business and that the praetor's son is a liar, it will be said, and it

will be said by a Rubrius, and it will be in the Acta, and it will make a difference.'

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

'It would make a difference,' she said. 'It would also end you. You are twenty-six and you have no money and one speech in the Senate, and if you spend it on me you will be the young man who defended a brothel, and the men who decide who gets the tribunate will read the Acta and they will remember it, and in ten years you will be a man of forty with a name and a grudge and no career. I have seen that man. He is the most bitter thing in Rome.'

'I do not care.'

'You do not care now. You will care at forty.' She sat down opposite him. 'Celer. I am going to tell you a thing that will sound cruel, and I want you to hear it as a kindness. You are the only person in this city who has ever offered me something that cost him something, without being asked and without a price, and I am not going to spend you. Not because I am noble. Because you are worth more to me in ten years as a man of standing who owes me nothing than you are this autumn as a boy who ruined himself for me and blamed me for it.'

He stared at the floor.

'And if you are convicted?' he said.

'Then I will be convicted. I have been poor before and I was not very good at it, and I have got better.' She stood. 'Go back to Tusculum. Do not come to this house again before October, and do not be seen with me. And if you are asked, in the autumn, in the Senate, whether you know me, you will say that you have met me, that I lent you money when your mother's estate was in difficulty, and that you do not know anything about my house because you have never been in it after the ninth hour.' She smiled at him, and it was a real smile. 'That last part is a lie, and you will tell it badly, and everyone will know it is a lie, and they will respect you for it.'

He got up. At the door he said, 'You are always deciding things for people.'

'Yes.'

'Why?'

'Because somebody has to,' said Antonia, 'and because in this city, if you are a woman and you wait to be asked, you will wait until you are dead.'

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The Nemoralia came on the thirteenth, which was the festival of Diana of the grove, and which was, in the city, the slaves' day.

It had been a slaves' day for as long as anyone could remember, and nobody in authority had ever quite decided why: the goddess of the grove at Nemi had been the goddess of the runaways, and the runaways had become the household slaves, and the household slaves had kept the day, and the city had let them, in the way that the city let a great many things happen that it did not approve of. The custom was to walk out to the grove with torches, and to hang a piece of cloth or a lock of hair on a tree, and to ask for something, and to spend the day in the open air with whoever one liked, and to come back at night.

Antonia gave the household the day. It cost her nothing — the house would have been empty of clients anyway, because the men who came to it were at Baiae — and it bought her a great deal. She had a pig killed and roasted in the courtyard and set out with bread and wine before the household went out at the fourth hour, and she stood at the gate and watched them go: the cooks, the water girl, the boy from the kitchen, the two under-stewards, the laundry women, Prima and Eucharis and Lucilla and four of the others with their hair down and their good clothes on, and Cinnamus with his wife's hand in his, and Meno, who was a Thracian and had been a slave for fifty years and had never once, in all that time, told anyone what he asked for at the grove.

'You are not going?' said Myrrhine.

'I am too old to walk to Nemi in the heat.'

'You are forty-one.'

'And I have been to Nemi,' said Antonia. 'I went when I was twenty-six, and I asked for something, and I got it, and it has been nothing but

trouble ever since, and I have decided not to ask for anything else.'

Lucilla sang that night on the roof.

She had been in the house three months and had changed in the way that girls of seventeen change when they are fed properly and not frightened: she had put on weight, and her face had settled, and she had stopped apologising for the space she took up. Pamphilus had given her exercises and Eucharis had taught her four songs, and she had a habit, when she thought nobody was listening, of humming under her breath in the corridor.

She sang the song about the swallow, which she had sung at the dinner in May, and she sang it better. The roof was quiet. When she finished, Prima said, from the far end, 'Well. There it is,' which was the highest compliment she had paid anybody in six years.

'She will be worth thirty thousand by the winter,' said Eucharis, later, when Lucilla had gone down to fetch water. 'I have heard women worth thirty thousand. She is better than any of them and she does not know it, which is the thing that makes it work.'

'She will not be sold,' said Antonia.

'She will not be sold,' Eucharis agreed, 'but she will be asked for, and you will have to decide what she is. A singer who is not for sale is a curiosity, and a curiosity can be exhibited for years. A singer who is for sale is a commodity and lasts two seasons. You will have to choose, and whichever you choose, there will be men who hate you for it.'

'You have been thinking about this.'

'I have been free for nine days,' said Eucharis, 'and it has made me impertinent.'

Antonia laughed. Down in the courtyard someone dropped a jug and there was a shout, and the whole roof laughed, and the night went on.

At the second hour, when most of them were asleep, Antonia said, into the dark, 'Myrrhine.'

'Mm.'

'On the twenty-ninth, I want the carriage.'

A pause.

'To Puteoli?'

'To Puteoli. I go every year. You know I go every year.'

'I know you go every year and I know you tell me it is business.' Myrrhine's voice was flat with sleep. 'Do you want company?'

'No.'

'All right.' A longer pause. 'Antonia.'

'Mm.'

'Whatever you find there this year, remember that you have a house full of women who would be on the street in a week if you were not in it, and that they did not choose to be your children, and that they are yours anyway.'

Antonia lay on her back and looked at the sky.

'I know,' she said.

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The Sestii came on the twenty-first, at the eleventh hour of the night, and they came without warning, which was the point.

Antonia was in the study with Cinnamus, going over the Ostian contracts, when Meno came up the stairs two at a time, which he had not done in nine years, and said, 'Domina. There are three of them at the gate and one of them is the young Sestius and he is drunk and he has brought a litter and he says he will not go away.'

'Is he alone?'

'Two friends and four bearers and a slave. The friends are drunker than he is. One of them has been sick in the street.'

Antonia put down the stylus.

'Where are the women?'

'Prima is in the garden with the physician. Eucharis is in her room. The girl is asleep.'

'Get Brennus and two of the men and put them in the peristyle, not at the gate. Bring the young man into the atrium and nobody else. And Meno

— the gate stays open. If he makes trouble, I want the street to see him being put out of it, not the other way round.'

She went down.

Lucius Sestius Cirrus was in worse condition than she had expected. His eyes were loose in his face and his tunic was wet down the front, and he was standing in the middle of her atrium with his hands hanging at his sides, looking at the masks on the wall as though he had never seen a mask before.

'Cirrus.'

He turned. It took him a moment to find her.

'You,' he said.

'I am the only person here who owns the floor you are standing on. Sit down.'

'I am not going to sit down.' He swayed. 'I have come to say something.'

'Say it and then go home.'

'I have come to say that you are a' — he stopped, and breathed, and the breath went on too long — 'that you are a woman who has made a business out of the worst thing in men, and that the whole of this city knows it, and that you have a girl in this house who is worth thirty thousand sesterces and that you are keeping her for a better price, and that everybody knows that too, and that I will not be made a fool of by a freedwoman in a house with a fountain.'

Behind him, in the doorway, Brennus had appeared with two men and was standing very still.

'You have said it,' said Antonia. 'Now go home.'

'I am not finished.'

'You are finished. You have come to my house at the eleventh hour with two drunk men and a slave and you have shouted at me in my own atrium, and if you do it for another minute I will have you carried out into the street and laid on the pavement, and the watch will find you there in the morning and every man in Rome will know by the ninth hour that the son of the praetor was thrown out of a brothel by a woman and two slaves.'

She said it quietly. 'You do not want that, Cirrus. Go home.'

He looked at her. And then something happened in his face that she had seen before, in other men, in other rooms, and that she had learned to recognise as the point at which a drunk man stops hearing words.

'I want the girl,' he said.

'No.'

'I will give you forty thousand.'

'No.'

'Sixty.'

'Go home,' said Antonia, 'before you say something that your father cannot undo.'

He came toward her. He was twenty-two and heavy and she was forty-one and not tall, and the distance between them was four feet of mosaic.

'You think you are safe,' he said, 'because you are rich and you have a house and men come to you. You are not safe. You are a freedwoman with a brothel and no name, and my father is a praetor of Rome, and in the winter he will put a seal on your door and take your girls out of this house one at a time and sell them, and you will be in the street with them, and you will come to my house and ask me for work.'

And then his legs went.

It was not a collapse. It was worse than that: he sank, slowly, and sat down on the mosaic in the middle of the atrium with his legs out in front of him, and he began to laugh, and then the laughing stopped and he put his head in his hands and said, 'I am going to be sick.'

Antonia looked down at him for a moment.

'Brennus,' she said. 'Take him into the small room by the garden and put him on the couch and have a basin brought. And find his friends and put them in the garden with a jug of water and tell them that if they make a noise I will have them thrown into the street in their own vomit and I do not care whose fathers they have.'

She went to the door of the small room and stood looking at him as they laid him down. Then she said, to Meno: 'Send for his slave. Not the friends. The slave. Tell him his master is unwell and that he may either take

him home in the litter now or stay the night in this house and take him home in the morning when he can walk, and if he stays there will be a man outside the door all night.'

The slave, who was perhaps thirty and looked as though he had done this before, chose the morning.

She went up at the first hour of the night and lay on the roof and could not sleep.

At the third hour she went down to check the shutters in the garden, which she did anyway, and stopped in the passage because there was a light in the small room and the door was ajar.

Prima was sitting on the floor beside the couch with her back against the wall.

'What are you doing?' said Antonia.

'Watching him breathe.' Prima did not get up. 'The slave is asleep in the corridor. Meno is at the gate. Brennus has gone to his bed and left the boy from the kitchen, who is fifteen and would run away from a mouse. So I am sitting here.'

'You do not have to.'

'Yes,' said Prima, 'I do. Because if he dies in this house in the night we will need to be able to say exactly who was with him and when, and if he wakes up and puts his hand on a girl in this house I want to be the one he puts it on.' She looked up. 'You should go to bed.'

Antonia sat down on the floor on the other side of the couch.

They sat there in the lamplight with the praetor's son asleep and breathing between them, and the shutters open to the garden, and the smell of the fig tree coming in.

'He will not die,' said Antonia.

'No,' said Prima. 'He will wake up at the fourth hour and be ashamed and go home and be cruel to his slave in the litter. That is what they do.' She was quiet. 'When I was fifteen there was a man in the house in the Argiletum who used to come in the afternoons and sleep in the room at the

top of the stairs. He never touched me. He used to give me a copper and ask me to sit on the floor and talk to him about the market. And then one afternoon he did touch me, and it was not the touching, it was that he had been kind first, and I have never been able to explain to anyone in eleven years why that was the worst thing that ever happened to me.'

Antonia looked at the lamp.

'I know,' she said.

'Yes,' said Prima. 'You do.'

He was dead at the sixth hour of the morning.

It was Pamphilus who said it, having been sent for at the fifth, and it was Pamphilus who stood in the small room with his bag in his hand and his face grey and said, 'Domina, this is not the wine and it is not the heat. He has taken something. There is a smell to him that I know from the army, and I have seen two men die of it in my life, and the second one was a tribune who took it because he had heard that it made a man a bull, and it made him a bull for one night and then it made him dead.' He wiped his mouth. 'It is Spanish fly. It is bought in the market at the ninth hour by boys who do not know what it does. There will be a box in his clothes.'

There was a box in his clothes. It was a small bronze box with a lotus on the lid, and it was empty, and it was not his, because his friends said afterwards that he had bought it himself in the Forum that afternoon from a man with a monkey.

The praetor's son lay on the couch in the small room in Antonia's house with his mouth open and his face the colour of old wax, and the whole of the house stood in the passage outside the door, and nobody said anything at all.

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

Then she said, 'Myrrhine. Where is the woman who was with him?'

'There was no woman with him,' said Myrrhine.

'There was a woman with him. He did not come alone into that room and he did not die alone, and the man who was outside the door went to

sleep, and I am not going to have it said in this city that a boy died in my house in a locked room and that I cannot produce the person who was in it.' She turned. 'Who was with him?'

The girl's name was Berenice. She was nineteen, she had been in the house a year, and she was in the room over the kitchen with her hands over her ears and had been there since the fourth hour of the night, and when Antonia came in she began to shake so violently that her teeth knocked together.

'Tell me,' said Antonia.

'He woke at the third hour and he was —' The girl could not find the word. 'He was not himself. He was like a man in a fever, and he wanted — and he had the box, and he took more of it, and then he could not breathe properly, and I went and got water and I put it on his face and he did not —' She stopped. 'I did not kill him, domina. I did not even — he did not do anything to me. He could not. He was like that for an hour and then he stopped and I thought he was asleep and I sat on the floor and I fell asleep and when I woke up he was cold.'

Antonia stood in the doorway of the little room over the kitchen, where it was already hot at the sixth hour of the morning, and she made a decision that she would spend the rest of her life paying for.

'Berenice,' she said. 'You are going to go and stay with my physician's sister at Tibur. You will go today, in the carriage with the shutters closed, and you will stay there until I send for you, and you will not speak to anyone about anything.'

'Domina—'

'You did nothing wrong,' said Antonia. 'That is exactly why you cannot stay. If the praetor's household finds you in this house they will have you in a cell by the ninth hour and they will ask you for three days what you did to their master's son, and you will tell them the truth, and it will not matter, because a slave's truth in a cell with a praetor's men is not evidence. You are going to Tibur, and you are going to be alive, and when it is over you will come back, and I will make it up to you.'

She went out. Myrrhine was waiting in the corridor with her arms folded.

'That was a mistake,' said Myrrhine.

'It was mercy.'

'It was both,' said Myrrhine, 'and you have just made the only witness in the house into a woman who has fled in a closed carriage before dawn, and when the praetor's people come here this afternoon — and they will come this afternoon — I will have to stand in the atrium and say that I do not know where she is, and I will be telling the truth, and it will sound exactly like a lie.' She stepped closer. 'You should have kept her. You should have kept her in that room with the door open and the whole household able to see her, and sent for the praetor's steward before you sent for the physician, and had every one of us stand in the passage and say what we saw.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'Then why?'

Antonia looked at the passage, where the household was standing: the cooks, the water girl, the boy from the kitchen, Brennus, Meno, Eucharis with her hair down, Lucilla with her hands over her mouth. All of them looking at her.

'Because she is nineteen,' said Antonia, 'and because I have been that girl, and because when I was that girl there was nobody in the world who would have put me in a carriage.'

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Marcus Sestius Verus came at the ninth hour with six men, a steward, and a physician of his own, and he came in the way that a praetor comes: not as a father, but as an officer of the state arriving at a place where the state's business has gone wrong.

Antonia met him in the atrium. She had washed and changed her dress and put on the carnelian ring, and she had had the body laid out in the small room by the garden with the door open and a lamp at the head and two of her own people standing beside it, and she had had the whole

household assembled in the peristyle, in order, in clean clothes.

He stopped in front of her and looked at her for a long moment.

'Where is my son?'

'In the room behind you,' said Antonia. 'He has been laid out and nothing has been moved. My physician is here and will show you what he found. There is a box in his clothes that is not mine and that I have not touched, and there is a slave of his own household who was in the corridor outside the door from the third hour of the night, and there is a doorkeeper who will tell you what hour your son came to this house and in what condition.'

Sestius looked past her at the open door.

He was fifty-eight, and he had been handsome, and he had the face of a man who has spent his life being obeyed in a city where obedience is a currency, and he was not prepared for this. That was the thing Antonia saw, and that she was not supposed to see, and that she never forgot: under the praetor's manner there was a man in the middle of a sentence he could not finish.

He went into the room. He was in there for a long time.

When he came out his face had closed like a hand.

'My son,' he said, 'was in good health yesterday. He dined at the house of a friend and he came to this house at the eleventh hour, and by the sixth hour of the morning he was dead, in your house, in a room with your woman in it, and the woman is gone.' His voice was perfectly level. 'The doorkeeper says she left at dawn in a closed carriage.'

'She left at dawn in a closed carriage,' said Antonia.

'Where is she?'

'That is a question I am not going to answer.'

There was a silence in the atrium. The six men behind him did not move, and Brennus, at the door, did not move, and somewhere in the house a fly was hitting itself against a shutter.

'You understand,' said Sestius, 'that I am the praetor of this city.'

'I understand that you are the praetor,' said Antonia. 'And I understand that if I give you the woman, you will have her in a cell in the

vigiles' barracks by nightfall, and in three days she will have confessed to whatever your household requires, and then your son will have been murdered by a slut in a brothel instead of having been killed by a box of Spanish fly that he bought himself in the Forum at the ninth hour with money from his own purse, and the second of those things is true and the first is convenient.' She took a step toward him. 'I have nineteen women in this house and a doorkeeper and an atriensis and a physician, and every one of them will stand up in front of a magistrate and say what happened, and my books will be produced, and the box will be produced with the seal of the man who sold it, if I can find him. I do not intend to be tried for your son's death in the court of public opinion in the month of August. If you want to charge me, charge me. The courts open in October.'

Sestius looked at her.

'You have made an enemy of me,' he said. 'Do you understand that? Not a man who dislikes you. Not a man who will speak against you in the Senate. An enemy. In this city an enemy is a man who wakes up in the morning and thinks about you before he thinks about his own affairs, and I will think about you every day until one of us is dead.'

'I have had enemies before,' said Antonia.

'Not like me.'

'No,' she said. 'Not like you. You are the first one who has ever been in my house as a guest, and eaten my food, and put his hand up the skirt of a woman who worked for me, and gone home and told his wife that the wine was poor.' She turned away. 'Take your son home, Sestius. You may take him out of my house and you may have the physician's report and the box, and I will send you the names of the men who came with him, and the name of the shop where he bought it if I can find it. That is all I have. There is nothing else in the world that I can give you, and if you stay in this house one minute longer I will begin to think that you came here for something else.'

He stood very still. Then he said, to his steward, 'Bring my son.'

They carried Cirrus out of the house through the garden gate with a cloth over him, and the whole street came out to watch, and Antonia stood

in the peristyle with her household behind her and watched it go.

When it was gone, and the gate was closed, and the sound of the litter had gone down the hill, Myrrhine said, quietly, 'You have just told the praetor of Rome that his son died in a brothel because he was a fool, and you said it in front of six witnesses.'

'Yes.'

'Why?'

Antonia stood in the middle of her peristyle in the heat of an August afternoon.

'Because it is true,' she said, 'and because in this city a true thing said out loud in front of witnesses is the only kind of armour there is, and because if I had been soft with him he would have thought I was afraid, and he would have been right.'

The house did not open that night.

It did not open for eleven nights, which was the longest it had been closed in eleven years, and Antonia sat in the study on the first of them with a cup of wine she did not drink and the box of tablets open in front of her, and wrote, in her own hand, on a tablet that she would later burn:

The girl is safe at Tibur. The body is with his father. The box is with his father. Berenice is safe and will not be found and I have made an enemy who will think about me every day for the rest of his life.

And on the twenty-ninth I am going to Puteoli, and I will stand in a garden at the bottom of the Lucrine road, and I will be forty-one years old, and there is a woman somewhere in this city who is twenty-five, and I do not know her name.

She looked at it for a long time. Then she burned it in the brazier, at the ninth hour of the evening, and went up onto the roof, where eleven women were lying in the dark, and lay down among them, and did not sleep.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Two Kinds of Silence

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The room was above a bookseller's in the Argiletum, and it smelled of glue and dust and the particular sourness of papyrus that has been stored in a damp place.

There was a table, two chairs, a lamp, and a window that looked out on the roof of the shop next door. On the table was a jug of water and a cup, and nothing else, and Antonia noticed that there was only one cup, and understood from it that the person who had arranged the room had been told to arrange it for one person receiving another, and had not been told what the other was.

She was early. She was always early. She sat with her back to the wall and her hands in her lap and waited, and outside in the Argiletum the shops were shutting: the booksellers, the cobblers, the men who sold second-hand furniture, the women who sold flowers and would sell anything else if you asked them in the right way.

He came at the second hour of the night, alone, with a hood over his head like a man going to a brothel, and she had the satisfaction of seeing that he was embarrassed.

'You came,' he said.

'You asked.'

'I did not think you would.'

'Then you do not know me as well as you think you do,' said Antonia, 'which would be a relief to us both.'

He sat down. He looked at the jug and the single cup, and then he got up and went to the door and opened it and said something to someone on the stairs, and came back, and sat down again.

'There is a boy on the landing who will whistle if anyone comes up,' he said. 'The bookseller has been paid. The bookseller thinks I am a senator

who is buying a library from a widow, and he thinks you are the widow, and he will not be surprised by anything, because booksellers never are.'

'You have done this before.'

'I have done a great many things before,' said Tarquitius. 'I am fifty-three.'

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Before that, there had been eleven days.

The house was closed, which meant that the gate was barred at the ninth hour and that Meno sat in the doorway with his stick across his knees, and that no one came in or out except by the garden door, and that the women did not go to the market or the baths or the temple. It meant that the street outside, which had always been a street, became a thing that was watched: the neighbours on the corner, the woman who sold chickpeas, two men who stood at the fountain at the fourth hour and again at the seventh and did not buy anything.

On the second day the first of the women left.

Her name was Chloe, she was twenty-eight, she had been in the house four years, and she came to Antonia in the study with her hands folded and said that her sister lived at Ostia and that she would like to go and stay with her until the winter. Antonia gave her the money that was owed to her and a month over and a letter to a shipping agent at Ostia, and Chloe kissed her hands, and cried, and was in a cart on the Ostian road by the fourth hour.

'She will not come back,' said Myrrhine.

'No.'

'And two more will go by the end of the week, and one of them will go to a man who has been asking her for a year, and she will tell herself that she is doing it for the house.'

'Yes,' said Antonia. 'And I will give her a dowry, and she will send me a note at the Saturnalia, and in three years she will have two children and a husband who is not unkind, and she will tell them that she once worked in a house on the Esquiline and they will not believe her.' She looked at the accounts. 'Open the door for them, Myrrhine. All of them. Anyone who

wants to go. Tonight, before they have to ask.'

'And if all of them go?'

'Then I will be a woman of forty-one with an empty house and a trial in November,' said Antonia, 'and I will still have the price of a good advocate.'

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Cinnamus came on the third day with the books and the news that the praetor's household had been to the tabularium.

'They have asked for the record of the sale of the woman Berenice, and for the record of the purchase of the girl Lucilla in March, and for the record of the manumission of the woman Eucharis, which is nine days old and which they found, and which has made them very interested indeed.' He put the tablet down. 'They have also asked for a copy of the will of Gaius Cassius Verus, which is your father-in-law's, and which is a matter of public record and which contains nothing that could help them, and which they have asked for because a man who is building a case asks for everything and sees what the clerks bring him.'

'What do they want with the manumission?'

'I do not know, domina. I have thought about it for three days.' Cinnamus sat down without being asked, which he did when he was worried. 'The charge will be that the house is a place of vice. If the women are slaves, the vice is yours, because you own them and you profit. If the women are free and paid, then the vice is theirs, and you are a woman who keeps a house where free women choose to work, which is not a crime in law, and which they know is not a crime in law.' He rubbed his jaw. 'So they will use the manumission the other way. They will say that you freed her eleven days ago because you knew a charge was coming, and that the freeing of a woman who was in the house on the night the boy died is evidence that you are hiding something. It does not matter what the something is. In a court, a woman who does an unusual thing at an unusual time has done it for a reason, and the reason is always the one the prosecutor supplies.'

'Then we will supply a reason first,' said Antonia. 'We will produce the contract she signed and the sum she paid and the date on the tablet, and we will produce three other women who have bought their freedom in the last four years, and we will produce the book, Cinnamus. The whole book. Every woman in this house for eleven years, and what she was paid, and what she paid, and where she went. All of it, in front of the court.'

Cinnamus was silent.

'Domina,' he said, 'the book has things in it that you will not want said aloud in a basilica. There are men's names in that book. There is the man who came in the ninth year and paid for the girl Myrtale to be sent away and the money came through a third party and the third party was a senator's freedman. There is the loan to the wife of a magistrate. There is —'

'There is everything,' said Antonia. 'And if I produce the book, half the Senate will be in that basilica by the second day, not to hear the case but to find out what is in it, and every one of them will be a man who has something to lose, and they will not be able to stop the reading and they will not be able to leave.' She put her hands flat on the table. 'A woman with a book like that does not need an advocate. She needs a court that is afraid of her. And the only way to be feared is to show, once, in public, that you are willing to burn the whole of it.'

'And if they convict you anyway?'

'Then I will be convicted in a city where half the men on the bench know that their own names are in my book,' said Antonia, 'and I will be sent into exile, and I will go, and I will write letters. But they will not convict me. They will acquit me and they will hate me for having made them need to.'

Cinnamus looked at her for a long moment.

'You have changed this summer,' he said.

'Have I?'

'When I came to this house eleven years ago you were a woman who won by knowing things. Now you are a woman who wins by being willing to lose.' He picked up the tablet. 'I do not know whether that is better. It is

certainly more frightening.'

Lucilla came on the fifth day.

She had been in the small room off the library since the morning of the death, and she had not eaten properly, and she came in with her hands twisting in her skirt and said, 'Domina, I want to go.'

Antonia put down her stylus.

'Where?'

'To my aunt. In Narnia. She is a free woman, she married a smith, she has a house with a yard. I have not seen her since I was thirteen and she will not know me, but she is the only family I have, and I have written to her —' she faltered '— I have written to her twice, and Cinnamus sent the letters, and there is no answer, and I would like to go anyway.'

'You think it is your fault.'

'It is my fault,' said Lucilla. 'He came to the house because of me. He came in May because of me, and he came in August because of me, and a man is dead and the house is closed and Chloe has gone and Berenice has been sent away and there are men in the street watching the door, and all of it is because a man heard me sing.'

Antonia stood up and came around the table.

'Lucilla,' she said. 'Look at me. In May, in this room, I told you that you were not in the house to be sent for, and that you were a voice, and that voices were not for sale. Do you remember?'

'Yes.'

'I told you that because it was true, and because I have been in this business for more than a decade and I know what a girl is worth and what she is not, and I have never once been wrong about it.' She put her hand under the girl's chin and lifted it, which she had done once before, in May. 'What happened in this house happened because a man of twenty-two who had never been refused anything in his life was refused, and because his father had spent twenty years telling him that the world was arranged for his convenience. It did not happen because you sang. It happened

because he listened, and because what he heard when he listened was not a voice but a price. That is not your doing. That is a thing that was done to you, twice, and if you go to Narnia and spend the rest of your life thinking that you killed a man by singing, then he will have done it to you a third time, and I will not have it.'

Lucilla was crying, and she was angry, and both at once.

'I am not a —' she said, and stopped.

'You are not a what?'

'I am not one of the women,' said Lucilla. 'I am not Eucharis. I cannot do what she does. I cannot sit at a table and have a man put his hand on my knee and smile. I have tried, in my room, to practise the smile, and I cannot do it, and I am seventeen and I have a voice and no other thing in the world, and if you close this house in January I will have a voice and a room above a laundry.' She wiped her face with the back of her hand. 'So I want to go to Narnia, and I want to go before I am old enough to be told that I am being ungrateful, and I want you to give me a letter to my aunt saying that I am honest, because she will not believe me otherwise, and I want —' She stopped. 'I want to be somebody's niece.'

Antonia stood in front of her for a long moment.

'Go and pack,' she said. 'You will go on the twenty-sixth with Cinnamus, and you will have the letter, and you will have a purse with enough in it to be respectable and not enough to be robbed, and you will not sing in the inns on the road, and if your aunt will not have you, you will go to the magistrate of the town and show him the letter and the purse, and he will find you a place, because a letter from me is worth something even in Narnia.' She went back to the table and sat down. 'And Lucilla. When you are twenty-five, and you have a house with a yard, and a husband who is a smith and does not know what a basilica is, you will remember this summer. Not the boy. The summer. And you will decide what to tell your daughter, and whatever you decide will be right, and I will not be there to see it.'

Lucilla went out with her hand over her mouth, and Myrrhine, who had been standing in the doorway for the last part of it, came in and said,

'You are sending her away without a fee.'

'She is not a fee. She is a girl with a voice and no mother.' Antonia picked up her stylus. 'And if I kept her, she would be worth thirty thousand by the winter, and in four years she would be a woman who had learned the smile, and I would have made her into something that could be sold, and I have done that to enough people.'

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He began with the case, because a lawyer begins with the case.

'The tablets came from Naso on the ninth day of August and they are in the prefect's strongbox and they will be produced in October. I have read them. There are three receipts with Sestius's brother's name on them and a fourth that is in a different hand but has his seal.' He turned the cup around. 'The prosecution will succeed. Atilius will be exiled and his property will be assessed at four times the amount extorted and the province will be told that Rome has noticed. That is what will happen, and it will happen because you told a banker to open a box.'

'And?'

'And in the same week that I stand up in the Senate and open that case, a charge will be laid against you. It has already been drafted. Sestius has three men working on it and one of them is a jurist of the second rank who owes me money, and it will allege that Marcus Sestius Cirrus died in your house of poison administered by your household, that the woman who was with him has been secreted away by you to avoid examination, and that your house is a place of habitual vice in which men of rank are drugged and robbed. It will ask for the closure of the house, the sale of the women, and your exile from Italy.'

Antonia did not move.

'On what evidence?' she said.

'On the evidence of a physician who will swear that the symptoms of Spanish fly and the symptoms of a vegetable poison are indistinguishable to a man who wishes them to be. On the evidence of the box, which will be produced by Sestius as a thing found in your house, and which is in his

possession and not yours. On the evidence of the slave Doris, who will say that she was sold out of your household for knowing too much. And on the evidence of a girl who will be found at Tibur, because Sestius's men will find her, because a physician's sister at Tibur is not a secret; she is a woman with a house and a neighbour and a cook.'

'Then I will produce her myself,' said Antonia. 'I will produce her in the court and she will tell them what she told me, and they will see a girl of nineteen who has been in the house a year and who did not run away, and they can make of it what they like.'

'You will produce her and she will be cross-examined for two hours about what she did in that room and what she did not do, and by the end of it, whatever the verdict, she will be a woman that no house will take and no man will marry, and she will know that it happened because she was in the wrong room on the wrong night.' He looked up. 'You should have kept her in the house. That is what a lawyer would have done.'

'Yes,' said Antonia. 'A lawyer would.'

There was a small silence.

'I am not reproaching you,' said Tarquitius. 'I am telling you what will happen.'

'I know what will happen. I have known since the sixth hour of that morning.' She leaned back. 'You have not brought me here at the second hour of the night to tell me what will happen. You have brought me here to tell me what you will do about it, and you are going to do it as though it were a favour, and I am going to have to be grateful, and we are both going to pretend that this is the first time.'

He looked at her for a long moment.

'I will appear for you,' he said.

'You will not.'

'I will appear for you,' said Tarquitius, 'and it will be the most damaging thing I have ever done to myself, and I will do it, and you will not be grateful, and I will not want you to be. There is no other advocate in Rome who can take that case and win it, and you know it, and I know it, and if I do not do it you will be convicted in November and your house

will be sold in December and the women will be sold in January, and in February I will be a man who could have prevented it and did not, and I have been that man before.' He stopped. 'I have been that man before.'

The lamp guttered. In the street below someone was arguing about a price.

'On what terms?' said Antonia.

'Two.'

'Say them.'

'The first is that you close the house.' He held up his hand. 'Not now. In January, when it is over. You will keep the building, you will keep your fortune, you will keep every one of the women as a freedwoman with a contract or a marriage portion or a trade, and you will close the doors, and you will become a woman of business and no more, and in five years no one will remember that there was ever a fountain in the peristyle.'

'And the second?'

'The second is that you tell me what happened in my father's house,' said Tarquitius.

Antonia sat very still.

'You know what happened in your father's house,' she said.

'I know what I did. I was there for that.' His voice was flat and did not change. 'I know what I was told afterwards, and I have spent twenty-five years deciding whether to believe it, and I have not decided, and I am fifty-three and I have a daughter who has begun to ask questions and a mother who has stopped answering them, and I would like to be told by the only other person who was there.' He looked at her. 'That is my price. The house, and the truth. You will not like either of them, and I am not asking because I think you owe me. I am asking because the alternative is to spend the rest of my life in a room with a cupboard in it.'

Antonia looked at the table.

'There are two kinds of silence,' she said.

'What?'

'In a house. There are two kinds of silence, and I have lived in both of them, and I can tell them apart at fifty paces.' She turned the cup around,

once. 'The first is the silence of a thing that everyone knows and nobody says. It is thick. It has a shape. You can walk around it. It makes people careful in doorways. That was the silence in your father's house after the funeral, and it is the silence in that house now, and it is the silence of your mother at dinner when your daughter asks what happened.'

'And the second?'

'The second is the silence of a thing that only one person knows,' said Antonia. 'It is thin. It has no shape. It is the silence of a woman who is in a room with eleven people who believe something about her that is not true, and who has decided that the truth would cost more than the lie. There is no walking around it. You carry it. It is not heavy; that is the strange thing. It is light and it never goes away.' She looked up. 'I have lived in the second kind for twenty-five years. You have lived in the first. You do not know what I know, and I do not know what you were told, and if we begin to tell each other now, at this table, in this room, we will get about four sentences in before one of us says something that cannot be taken back, and then we will spend the rest of our lives being right.'

'Then say the four sentences.'

'No.'

'Why not?'

'Because you have not asked me as a man,' said Antonia. 'You have asked me as a jurist. You have offered me a defence and a closing of the doors and a future in which no one remembers the fountain, and in exchange you want the truth, and the truth is not a thing that is bought with a favour. If I tell you, I will have sold it, and I have sold a great many things in my life, and I have never yet sold that.'

Tarquitius sat back.

'You think I am buying it,' he said.

'I think you are a man who has bought everything he has ever had, including his reputation, which he bought with thirty years of being correct, and I think you do not know how to ask for a thing without offering something in return, and I think that when you were twenty-nine you did the same thing to a girl in a linen room and you called it looking

after her.' She stood up. 'I will take the first term. I will close the house in January, and I will do it whether you win the case or lose it, because you are right that it is finished, and because I have been running it for eleven years and I am tired, and because I have found something this summer that is worth more to me than the fountain. I will not take the second. Not tonight. Not like this.'

He rose too.

'Then tell me one thing,' he said, 'and I will not ask for more.'

'Ask.'

'Did you take money from my father's house?'

Antonia's hands were cold. She had not expected that; she had expected the child.

'What?'

'When you left,' said Tarquitius. 'There was a sum missing from the household accounts that year. Not a great deal; four thousand sesterces, perhaps, in the account of the steward, in the month you were sent to Campania. My sister found it when she went through the books after my father died and she wrote to me in Rome about it, and I have had that letter in my strongbox for twenty-five years, and I have never once been able to decide what it means.' His face was quite still. 'Did you take it?'

The room was very quiet. Below, in the street, the flower sellers had gone home and the last of the shutters had been closed.

'No,' said Antonia.

'Then who did?'

'I do not know.' She heard her own voice as though it were somebody else's. 'I have never seen four thousand sesterces in one place in my life until I was twenty-six years old. When I left that house I had the clothes I was standing in and a lock of hair and a clay figure, and I was put into a cart at the fourth hour of the morning by a steward who would not look at me, and I was given a piece of bread by a kitchen woman who wept, and I have never in twenty-five years been able to account for the fact that I was sold at Puteoli for two thousand four hundred when I was worth four.' She stopped. 'Four thousand missing. Two thousand four hundred paid.

Somebody in that house made a profit on me, and it was not me, and I have had twenty-five years to think about who it was and I have a name, and I am not going to say it in this room, tonight, to you.'

Tarquitius was looking at her with an expression she had never seen on his face before.

'What name?' he said.

'Not tonight.'

'Antonia—'

'Not tonight,' she said, 'and not from me, and not in a room above a bookseller's with a boy on the landing. You have a mother who is seventy-eight and who has been sitting in that house for twenty-five years with the first kind of silence, and if you want to know what happened in your father's house you should go home and ask her, and she will tell you, and then you will know why I will not.' She went to the door. 'Do not follow me down the stairs. The bookseller thinks I am a widow and I would like him to go on thinking it.'

She was on the landing, with the boy standing against the wall, when he said, from the doorway: 'I was told the child died.'

Antonia stopped.

The boy on the landing looked at her, and then at the floor, and then at his own hands, and he was fifteen and he had been paid to whistle and he had heard something he was not supposed to hear and he was trying not to breathe too loudly.

'Who told you?' said Antonia.

The silence went on too long.

'My sister wrote to me,' said Tarquitius. 'In September. She wrote that you had been delivered of a dead child at Puteoli and that you had gone, and that the household had done what was necessary, and that I was not to write to you or to speak of it again, and that our father had died in the spring and that the family could not survive another scandal in the same year.' His voice was very quiet. 'I believed her.'

'You believed her,' said Antonia.

'I was thirty years old and I was in Rome and my father was dead and my sister was the only person in the world who was managing that estate, and I was a man who had been correct all his life, and she wrote me a letter that was correct.' He came out onto the landing. 'I have believed it for twenty-five years.'

Antonia stood with her hand on the rail.

'She was alive,' she said. 'She cried. I heard her cry, and I was told that it was the door, and for twenty-five years I have been told that it was the door, and this summer I found out that it was not.'

Tarquitius did not move.

'What?' he said.

'I have found her,' said Antonia. 'Not her. A paper. A dealer's book. She was sold, at four days old, in your name, to a woman who paid two hundred and forty sesterces, and she was entered in the household lists at Arretium as a foundling, and she has been in your family's house ever since. She may be there still. She may be in this city. I do not know where she is, and I have a man looking, and I am telling you this tonight because you have just told me that you did not know, and because if you go home and ask your mother, she will begin to cry, and she has not cried in forty years, and you should be prepared.'

Tarquitius put his hand out and found the door frame.

'In my house,' he said.

'In your house.'

'For twenty-five years.'

'I do not know that. I know she was sold into it. I know she was entered in the lists. I do not know what became of her after that, and I am not going to invent it for you.' Antonia went down two steps and then stopped and looked up at him. 'You asked me for the truth and this is what it costs. Now you have it, and it is not four sentences and it is not a bargain and it will not close a cupboard; it will open one. And there is one thing I want from you in return, and it is not for me.'

'What?'

'When you find her,' said Antonia, 'if she is alive and if she is in that house, you will not tell her who I am. Not without asking me. You will not go to her with your father's name and your name and your family's guilt and put it on her in an afternoon. She has had twenty-five years of being a number in a list. If she is to be told, she will be told by a woman, in a room, with the door shut, and it will be me.'

He looked down at her from the top of the stairs, and there was something in his face that she had wanted to see for twenty-five years, and now that she saw it she found that it gave her no pleasure at all.

'I will not tell her,' he said.

'Swear it.'

'I swear it,' said Tarquitius, 'by the gods of my house and my father's name.' He was silent a moment. 'Antonia. If she is in that house —'

'Go home,' said Antonia, 'and ask your mother.'

———

She walked home. She would not take a litter; she had come in a litter and she sent it away and walked up the hill in the dark with Brennus ten paces behind her, and the streets were quiet and the lamps were low and the whole city smelled of the end of August.

At the top of the Vicus Cyprius she stopped.

'Brennus.'

'Domina.'

'You heard all of it.'

'I heard nothing, domina.'

'You heard all of it,' said Antonia, 'and you will hear nothing, and one day, if you are ever asked, you will say that you were walking ten paces behind me and that the street was noisy.' She looked down the hill at the lights. 'Brennus, do you have children?'

'Two, domina. In Lugdunum. I was sold away from them when the eldest was six.'

'I am sorry.'

'It was a long time ago,' said Brennus, 'and I have been free for nine years, and I have written twice, and there is no answer, and I have decided that no answer is an answer.' He shifted his stick from one hand to the other. 'If you will permit me, domina. The man on the stairs tonight — he is not a bad man. I have known bad men. I was sold by a bad man and I have worked for two, and I know the smell. He is a weak man who has been told he is strong, and that is worse in a magistrate and better in a father.'

'Is it?'

'Yes, domina,' said Brennus. 'A bad man would have gone home and burned the letter. He went home to ask his mother.'

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At the house, Myrrhine was waiting up with a lamp and a face like a wall.

'Well?'

Antonia sat down on the bench in the peristyle and put her hands over her face, which she had not done in eleven years, and which she did not do for long.

'He will appear for me,' she said. 'In the winter. He will take the case.'

Myrrhine sat down beside her.

'And what did he want?'

'The house closed, and the truth, and he offered me a bargain and I refused it, and then he gave me the truth for nothing and I gave him mine, and now we are two people who know what the other one knows and neither of us can undo it.' She took her hands down. 'Myrrhine. He did not know. He was told the child died. His sister wrote to him in September and told him the child died and that I had gone, and he believed it, and he has believed it for twenty-five years.'

Myrrhine was silent for a long moment.

'And what did you believe?' she said.

'That he had ordered me sold.'

'And now?'

‘Now I believe that his sister ordered me sold, and that she wrote him a letter, and that the letter is in a strongbox in a house on the Palatine, and that I have spent half my life hating a man for a thing his sister did.’ Antonia looked at the fountain. ‘And I find that I do not feel better. I feel as though somebody has moved the furniture in a dark room and I have been walking into it for twenty-five years and now I know where everything is and I still cannot see.’

Myrrhine took her hand.

‘Then we will light a lamp,’ she said.

‘It is not that simple.’

‘Nothing is that simple,’ said Myrrhine, ‘and I have been in this house for twenty-two years and I have never once seen you ask for help, and you have just done it, and I am going to take it as a good sign and not as an omen.’ She stood. ‘Come to bed. Tomorrow you have to write to Tibur and find out whether the girl is still there, and then you have to decide whether to produce her or hide her, and then you have to be seen in the Forum looking as though nothing has happened, and you cannot do any of it on two hours’ sleep.’

Antonia stood up.

‘Myrrhine.’

‘Mm.’

‘On the twenty-ninth I am going to Puteoli.’

‘I know.’

‘I want you to come with me.’

Myrrhine stopped with the lamp in her hand. Then she said, ‘All right,’ and went up the stairs, and did not look back, and Antonia followed her, and the house settled behind them, and outside in the street a dog barked twice and was quiet.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Ledger of Favours

— ◆ —

Vibia Lucana's house on the Caelian had eleven rooms and a garden in which nothing grew but roses, and in the first week of September she asked Antonia to come and eat with her alone.

That was unusual. Vibia never ate alone with anyone; she said it made her feel like a woman in a play. But she asked, and Antonia went, and they ate in the garden under a vine with a lamp on the table and a jug between them, and Vibia talked for an hour about a wedding she had been to, and a senator's wife who had worn a dress that was eleven years old and had pretended it was new, and a rumour about the prefect's daughter, and Antonia listened and laughed in the right places and waited.

When the plates had gone and the slaves had withdrawn, Vibia said, 'I want to buy a house.'

'You have a house.'

'I want to buy a house in my own name, with my own money, that my husband's family cannot touch, and I want to put it in writing so that no one in Rome can take it from me, and I want you to tell me how.' Vibia poured the last of the wine. 'Also I want to sell the factory at Puteoli, and I want to keep the proceeds in a place where my late husband's brother cannot see them, and I want to stop paying his allowances. He has had eleven thousand a year from me for six years and he has spent it on horses and a boy from Capua, and I am tired of it.'

Antonia put down her cup.

'You cannot do any of that,' she said.

'I know. That is why I am asking you.'

'No, listen to me. You cannot do any of it, and it is not because the law forbids it. It is because your husband's will left you a usufruct and not a title, and because your dower went into the estate and the estate is

administered by your husband's brother as trustee for your son, and because your son is nineteen and has been told since he was twelve that his mother is an eccentric who must be humoured.' Antonia counted on her fingers. 'The house you want to buy will be bought in the name of a man, because a woman cannot hold property in her own name under the law as it stands, and the man will be a friend, a freedman, or a trustee, and in ten years or in ten days he will discover that he holds the title and you do not. The factory at Puteoli is in the estate's name. The allowances are in your husband's will. And your brother-in-law is not going to give up eleven thousand a year because you have discovered that you dislike him.'

Vibia was silent for a moment.

'Then what am I to do?' she said.

'You are to do what every woman in this city does who has money and no power over it. You are to make yourself so useful to the man who holds the title that he cannot afford to cheat you, and so dangerous to the man who administers the estate that he does not dare.' Antonia leaned back. 'Your brother-in-law has a daughter who is to be married in the spring. He has no money for the dowry because he has spent it on horses. You will offer to pay the dowry — out of the factory's profits, which are in the estate, which he administers, which he has been using for six years to pay himself an allowance that the will does not authorize. You will offer it in front of witnesses, generously, in the temple of the family gods, with a notary present. He will accept, because he cannot refuse in front of witnesses and because he needs the money. And in the act of accepting he will have admitted that the profits of the factory are yours to give, and from that day forward a competent jurist can argue that his administration of the estate is a fiction.'

Vibia stared at her.

'That would take a year,' she said.

'It will take two.'

'And in the meantime?'

'In the meantime you will buy your house in the name of my atriensis,' said Antonia, 'who is a freedman of mine, and who has a wife and no debts

and a horror of lawyers, and who will sign a deed of trust that I will draw up myself and that my own advocate will witness, and if I ever cheat you, Vibia, you will be able to take the deed to the urban prefect and ruin me and every woman in my house.' She picked up her cup. 'I am not offering to do it because I am noble. I am offering because you stood in a crowd in the Forum of Trajan and told me the truth when it would have been easier to tell me a joke, and because in this city a woman who tells the truth in a crowd is worth more than a house.'

Vibia looked at her across the table for a long moment.

'You are a strange woman,' she said. 'I have known you eleven years and I have never once been able to decide whether you are the most honest person in Rome or the most dangerous.'

'Both,' said Antonia. 'It is the same thing in this city. The honest ones are dangerous because everyone knows what they will do.'

'And the dangerous ones?'

'The dangerous ones are honest about one thing,' said Antonia, 'and it is usually not the thing you think.'

The counterstrike came three days later, and it came in the form of a tablet with a copy of a copy in the hand of a clerk.

Hilarus brought it himself, in the morning, to the house, which he had never done. He came in through the garden door and stood in the study with the tablet in his hands.

'The woman Doris,' he said. 'The one who was sold in June to the baker and bought back by Sestius in July. She is not going to testify.'

'Why not?'

'Because she is dead,' said Hilarus. 'She died on the fourth day of September, in the household of the praetor, of a fever, according to the physician who signed the certificate, and the physician is the same man who has been engaged to swear that your house poisoned the boy. I have it from a slave in the praetor's household who is frightened and who wants money, and I have paid him, and he says that the woman was not ill on the

second of September and that she was buried on the fifth, in the ground outside the Colline gate, without a stone.' He put the tablet down. 'I cannot prove it. There is no body to look at and no one will ever be charged. But it changes the case, and it changes what I am going to say to you now, which is that you should settle.'

'I will not settle.'

'Domina—'

'Three charges,' said Antonia. 'The poisoning of Cirrus, which is a lie and which I can disprove with a box and a physician and a slave. The keeping of a disorderly house, which is true and which is not a crime that anyone has been convicted of in eleven years except in the provinces. And the corruption of the young, which is not a crime at all and which is the only one that will be read aloud in the Senate.' She turned the tablet around. 'They will not convict me of the first. They will convict me of the third in the court of public opinion, and that is the whole of the case, and I am not going to settle, because a woman who settles has admitted that there was something to settle.'

Hilarus looked at her.

'Then you will need a weapon that is not evidence,' he said.

'Yes,' said Antonia. 'That is why you are here.'

———

The fire had been in the third year of the emperor's reign, in the ninth region, in a block of tenements off the Via Lata, and nineteen people had died in it, and the tablet in Antonia's strongbox was the sworn statement of a contractor of the vigiles named Gaius Albinus.

He had been drunk when he made it, and terrified, and he had made it in her presence at a table in a back room of a cookshop with the door locked, and he had wept twice, and at the end he had asked her what she was going to do with it, and she had said that she did not know, and he had said, 'If you use it, I am a dead man,' and she had said, 'Then I will not use it unless I must.'

He had died the following year, of an abscess in the jaw.

What the tablet said was this: that on the night of the fire the watch had been directed to the warehouse next to the tenements before the tenements themselves, and that the direction had come from a man in a good cloak who had spoken to the curator of the watch and had shown him a token, and that the man had been paid by the brother of the aedile, and that the aedile that year had been Marcus Sestius Verus, whose brother owned the warehouse, and who had bought the ground the tenements had stood on eleven days after the fire at a tenth of its value.

Antonia had never used it. She had thought about it every year, in the way that one thinks about a knife in a drawer.

She did not use it now, either — not directly, and not in writing. Instead she sent for Cinnamus and gave him four instructions, and she gave them in the flat voice she used for the accounts, and he wrote them all down and did not comment on any of them.

The first was to find out, quietly, whether Marcus Sestius had a brother-in-law named Publius Calpurnius who had lent him money four years ago and had never been repaid.

The second was to find out whether that same Publius Calpurnius had a daughter of marriageable age.

The third was to have a copy made of the tablet of Gaius Albinus — not the whole of it, and not in a hand that could be traced, but the first eleven lines, which named the hour, the street, the direction of the watch, and the sum paid — and to leave that copy, in an envelope of thin leather, with the doorkeeper of the house of Publius Calpurnius, with no letter, on the morning of the twelfth day of September.

The fourth was to have a message carried to the praetor's household on the same morning, by a boy from the street who could not be traced back to the Esquiline, saying only this: *The woman on the hill has a copy of the tablet. She has had it for nine years. Ask your brother-in-law what he intends to do about it.*

'Domina,' said Cinnamus, when he had written it all down, 'may I ask what this is intended to achieve?'

'It is intended to start a family quarrel in a house that has been united against me for eleven years,' said Antonia. 'Calpurnius has been owed money by Sestius for four years and cannot press for it because his daughter is to be married and he needs Sestius's name at the wedding. When he learns that Sestius's name is going to be in a basilica in November attached to a fire that killed nineteen people, he will do one of two things. He will either come to me to buy the tablet, or he will go to Sestius and demand his money before the case opens.' She set down her stylus. 'If he comes to me, I will give him the tablet for nothing and tell him to take it to the urban prefect, and Sestius will spend the winter defending himself instead of prosecuting me. If he goes to Sestius, then Sestius will have to choose between paying four hundred thousand sesterces he does not have and explaining to his brother-in-law why the woman on the hill has a document about a fire.'

'And if he does neither, and simply waits?'

'Then nothing happens,' said Antonia, 'and I have spent nothing, and lost nothing, and I will go into that court with the truth and an advocate and be acquitted or not, and I will have learned something about the man, which is always worth the price of a leather envelope.' She looked up. 'You disapprove.'

'I do not disapprove, domina. I am counting.'

'Counting what?'

'The number of men in this city who will have heard, by the Saturnalia, that you keep documents about fires in a strongbox,' said Cinnamus. 'Eleven, by my reckoning. And of those eleven, four will be men who have something to hide and who have never done you any harm, and they will now have a reason to want you ruined, and they will be quiet about it, and they will be in the basilica in November, in the second row, listening.'

Antonia was silent for a moment.

'Yes,' she said. 'That is the price.'

'It is a high price.'

'It is a cheaper price than being convicted,' said Antonia, 'and I have been in this city long enough to know that the only real question about a

price is whether you can pay it in the month it falls due.'

Publius Calpurnius came to the house on the fifteenth day of September, at the ninth hour, in a litter with the curtains drawn.

He was a thin, careful man of fifty with the look of a man who has spent his life in the second rank of a family that has always been in the first, and he came into the atrium and stood with his hands behind his back and said, 'I have received a document.'

'I know,' said Antonia. 'I sent it.'

He blinked. Whatever he had prepared, it had not been that.

'You sent it,' he said.

'I did. Sit down. There is wine, and it is good, and you have had a difficult week.'

He did not sit down. He took the envelope out of his sleeve and held it.

'This names my brother-in-law,' he said. 'It says that the watch was directed away from a building in which nineteen people died, on the instruction of a man paid by my brother-in-law, and it is signed by a contractor of the vigiles who is dead.' He looked up. 'Is it genuine?'

'Yes.'

'And you have had it for nine years.'

'Nine years.'

'And you have produced it now,' said Calpurnius, 'three weeks before the trial of a charge that my brother-in-law has spent the summer preparing, in an envelope with no letter, delivered by a boy who cannot be found.' He put the envelope on the table. 'What do you want?'

'Nothing.'

'Everybody wants something.'

'I want your brother-in-law to spend the winter explaining a fire,' said Antonia, 'and I want my house open in the spring, and I want the woman Doris, who died in his household on the fourth day of September, to be remembered by somebody besides me. That is all. I am not asking you for money and I am not asking you to testify. I am giving you a document

because you are the only man in Rome who has both a reason to use it and the standing to be believed.'

Calpurnius stood very still. Then he sat down.

'I have lent him four hundred thousand sesterces over six years,' he said. 'He has never repaid a sesterce. My daughter is to be married in the spring and I have been selling land to pay for it, and last month I asked him for the money, and he told me that a man who presses his friends is a man who has no friends.' He picked up the cup and drank from it. 'I am not a brave man. I have been in the Senate for twenty-two years and I have never made a speech that anyone remembers. I have four children and a modest estate and a wife who is cleverer than I am, and my whole life has been arranged around not being noticed.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'And now you have put this in my hands,' said Calpurnius, 'and if I use it, I will destroy my wife's brother and my wife will never forgive me, and my daughter's wedding will be a small quiet affair in the country, and I will be a man who did a thing.' He turned the cup around. 'And if I do not use it, I will have it in my strongbox for the rest of my life, and I will take it out every year and look at it, and I will be a man who did not.'

'Yes,' said Antonia.

'Why did you send it to me and not to the prefect?'

'Because the prefect would have buried it,' said Antonia, 'and because a man who has been cheated for six years by a man he is obliged to admire is the most dangerous creature in Rome. He is not angry. He is certain.'

Calpurnius looked at her for a long moment. Then he put the envelope back in his sleeve and stood.

'My wife's brother,' he said, 'is going to be told tomorrow morning that I have the document, and that I intend to take it to the urban prefect on the first of October unless he repays me in full and withdraws his name from the charge against your house.' He straightened his tunic. 'He will refuse. He will refuse because he cannot pay and because a man like him would rather be ruined than be seen to give way. And then I will take it to the prefect, and I will be a man who did a thing.' He went to the door.

'Domina. If I do this, and it goes badly, I will lose everything I have, and I will remember that it was a woman on the Esquiline who put the envelope in my hand.'

'You will remember it either way,' said Antonia. 'That is what documents do.'

———

The other thing that happened in September happened at Tibur, and Antonia did not learn of it for nine days.

Two men came to the house of the physician's sister on the eighth day of the month, in the afternoon, and asked for the woman Berenice, and were told that there was no such woman in the house, and went away. They came back on the tenth with a magistrate's man and a written authority, and searched the house, and found nothing, because Berenice had been moved on the seventh to a farm belonging to Naso's cousin, six miles further up the valley.

On the eleventh, the physician's sister sent a message to Rome by a boy on a fast horse, and the message reached the house at the fourth hour of the morning, and Antonia read it in the study by lamplight, and then sat for a long time with her hands in her lap.

'They found her,' said Myrrhine.

'They found the house. They did not find her.' Antonia folded the note. 'They will find her. There are six farms in that valley and they will visit all of them, and a farm is not a city; there is nowhere to hide a woman in a farm.'

'Then bring her back.'

'And put her in this house, where every man in Rome knows she is, three weeks before the trial?' Antonia shook her head. 'No. She stays where she is, and we send word to the farm that if men come asking, she is the wife of the cousin's steward, and she has a name and a marriage and a child, and there is a document to prove it, and the document will be in her hand before the men get there.' She stood up. 'And Myrrhine — send to Hilarus. Tell him I want to know what happened to the woman Doris, and

I want to know it in a form that a court will hear, and I want it before the first of October.'

'That will cost.'

'Everything costs,' said Antonia. 'I have spent the summer learning the price of things. It turns out that I had it wrong for more than a decade: I thought I was buying safety. I was buying time, and time runs out, and then you pay again.'

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The crack in her own household came four days later, and it came from Prima.

Antonia had known for years that Prima kept money of her own. It was not a secret; half the women kept money, in a box, under a tile, in a hole behind a loose brick in the bath, and Antonia had never asked about any of it, because a woman with nothing of her own is a woman with no reason to stay.

What she had not known was that Prima had been taking it from one man for nine years.

His name was Quintus Valerius Asiaticus, he was a merchant of the wine trade with an office on the Tiber and a wife in the country, and he had been coming to the house since the fourth year. He was fifty, fat, good-tempered, and generous, and he had given Prima, over nine years, a sum that came to something over two hundred thousand sesterces, which he had entered in his own books as the purchase of a share in a ship.

'He did not buy me,' said Prima. 'He gave me money because he wanted to. There is a difference, and I have had nine years to think about what it is, and it comes down to this: he could stop at any time and I would still be in this house.'

Antonia stood in the doorway of Prima's room.

'Why are you telling me this now?' she said.

'Because his wife's brother came to see me,' said Prima. 'On the sixth day. He sat in the garden with me for an hour and he said that his sister had found the entry in the book, and that there would be a divorce, and that in

a divorce the wife's family will look for everyone who has taken money out of the estate, and that I am a woman with two hundred thousand sesterces and no name to protect me.' She was folding a dress, and she did not stop folding it. 'He offered me a choice. I could give evidence in November that this house is a place where men are drugged and robbed, and he would see that I was left alone. Or I could refuse, and he would bring an action against me for the money in the spring, and I would lose it, and I would be in the street at thirty-one with nothing.'

Antonia came into the room and sat down on the chest.

'And what did you say?'

'I said I would think about it.' Prima put the dress down. 'And then I came home and I have been thinking about it for four days, and I have decided, and I am telling you before you hear it from someone else, because whatever else I am, I am not a woman who takes a bribe behind a locked door.'

'What have you decided?'

Prima looked at her.

'I have decided to keep the money,' she said. 'I am going to give the money to Cinnamus to hold, in the house's name, in a trust, with a deed, and I am going to tell the wife's brother that if he brings an action I will produce the letters his brother-in-law wrote to me and read them aloud in the basilica, and that his sister will hear them, and that he will be a man who ruined his own sister's marriage to save two hundred thousand sesterces.' She folded her arms. 'I am not going to testify for him, and I am not going to testify for you. I am going to be a woman who was in the house and who says that she saw the boy take the box himself, because I did, and that is all I am going to say, and if that is not enough for you, then I am sorry, and I will go.'

Antonia sat on the chest in the small room and looked at her.

'You were with me that night,' she said. 'On the floor. You sat with him for four hours because you did not want him to be alone in a strange house, and you told me about the man in the Argiletum, and I have never told anyone that and I never will. And now you are telling me that you will

not stand up and say what happened.'

'I am telling you that I will stand up and say exactly what happened,' said Prima. 'What I will not do is stand up and say everything else. I will not be the woman who says that the house pays wages and the wine is free and the girls are free to leave, and I will not be the woman who says that Antonia Cassia is a good woman. Because you are not a good woman. You are a woman who has done good things and terrible things in the same afternoon for eleven years, and I have watched you do both, and I am thirty-one years old and I have two hundred thousand sesterces and I want to be alive at forty.'

There was a long silence.

'That is honest,' said Antonia at last.

'I have been in this house seven years,' said Prima. 'You have never once lied to me. I am not going to begin.'

Antonia stood up.

'Give the money to Cinnamus in the morning,' she said. 'Have the deed drawn in your own name and a copy kept in the temple of Castor. And Prima — when the case is over, whether I am acquitted or exiled, I want you to take that money and buy something that cannot be taken from you. A house, a shop, a field. Not a ship, not a share, not a loan to a man with a good name. Something with a door and a lock, and a deed in your own name, and a woman in it who is not obliged to be pleasant to anyone.'

Prima looked at her.

'Why?' she said.

'Because I have spent eleven years telling the women in this house that they are free,' said Antonia, 'and I have just discovered that I have been paying them enough to be free and not enough to be safe, and that is the difference between me and the men I have spent my life despising.'

Myrrhine heard all of it, of course. Myrrhine heard everything, and she came to the study that night with the accounts and a face like a wall.

'Prima is right,' she said. 'Cinnamus is right. Vibia is right. Half the house will leave before the winter and the other half will stay because they have nowhere to go, and every one of them will be asked, in a basilica, in front of the whole city, what she does for a living and how much she is paid for it.' She put the tablets down. 'And you have spent the whole of September arranging other people's lives and you have not once sat down and asked yourself what you will do if you lose.'

'I will go into exile,' said Antonia.

'Where?'

'Massilia. There is a woman there who runs a shipping office; I lent her money in the sixth year and she has never defaulted. She will give me a room and a desk.' Antonia turned her cup. 'I have thought about it. I think about it every night at the second hour. I have a plan, and a route, and a sum of money that is not in the house and not in Naso's bank, and I have had it for nine years, and I have never told anyone, and now I have told you.'

Myrrhine sat down.

'Why now?'

'Because you are the only person in the world who has never asked me for anything,' said Antonia, 'and because I am going to ask you to come with me, and I want you to know what you are agreeing to before you say yes.'

Myrrhine looked at her for a long moment.

'I have been waiting sixteen years for you to ask me something,' she said. 'Sixteen years. I have watched you give money to women who left and letters to girls who went to Narnia and a contract to Eucharis and a trust to Prima, and I have sat in this house and kept your accounts and slept in a room down the corridor from yours and never once asked for anything, because I decided when I was twenty-five that if I had to ask, I did not want it.' She stood up. 'And now you have asked me to go into exile with you, and I am going to say yes, and then I am going to go to bed, and tomorrow I will be the woman who keeps the accounts again, because that is what this house requires.'

'Myrrhine—'

'No,' said Myrrhine. 'You have had a very difficult summer and you are about to be tried for murder in a basilica, and I am not going to have the conversation that we should have had sixteen years ago in the same month. When it is over. When you are acquitted, or when we are in Massilia, and there is nothing left to be afraid of. Then you will ask me properly, and I will not say yes immediately, because I want to be asked twice.' She picked up the tablets. 'And Antonia. Whatever happens in November — do not make the bargain with him.'

'What bargain?'

'The one you are going to make,' said Myrrhine. 'The one where he saves you and you close the house and you are grateful to him for the rest of your life. I have watched you refuse that bargain twice this summer and I have been proud of you, and I know that in November, when the court is full and the witnesses are finished and the verdict is being counted, you will be offered it a third time in a voice you cannot refuse, and you will take it, because you will be tired, and because it will look like peace.' She stopped in the doorway. 'It will not be peace. It will be the same silence he has been living in for twenty-five years, and you will be living in it with him, and the house will be closed and the women will be gone and you will be a woman of forty-two with a great fortune and a name that is spoken carefully in rooms you are not in.'

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Baiae

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The letter came on the second day of October, and it was written by Sabbia, and it was four lines long.

Domina. She will not last the winter. She has asked for you every day since the twenty-ninth of August, when you did not come, and she has said to me that she does not blame you, which is how I know that she does. If you want to see her alive you should come now. She cannot write and I cannot write better than this.

Antonia read it standing in the atrium with her cloak still on.

'Saddle the carriage,' she said.

'It is the fourth hour,' said Cinnamus. 'You will be on the road in the dark and you will be at Puteoli by the second hour of the morning, and there will be no inn open and no gate open and the road through the Pomptine is bad in October.'

'Saddle the carriage.'

'Domina—'

'Cinnamus.' She turned. 'I did not go on the twenty-ninth. I have gone every year for twenty years, and this year the house was closed and there was a dead boy and a trial coming and I told myself that a woman with a dead boy in her house does not go to Puteoli in August to stand in an empty garden. And she sat in that room on the twenty-ninth and waited for me, and I was not there, and she is eighty and she is dying and she has sent me four lines because she cannot write more.' She took off her cloak and put it down on the bench. 'I am going to Puteoli. You may saddle the carriage or I will hire one in the street and go without a guard, and if you think I will not, you have not been paying attention for eleven years.'

Cinnamus went to saddle the carriage.

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They took the Via Appia as far as Terracina and then the coast road, and they went in the rain, which began at Aricia and did not stop until the sea. Myrrhine sat opposite her with a rug over her knees and a basket of food she had made the kitchen put up in a quarter of an hour, and she did not say anything for the first two hours, and then she said:

'You will not be able to save her.'

'I know.'

'And you will try.'

'Yes.'

'And you will spend the winter paying for the physicians and the wax and the funeral and the ground, and you will do it because it is the only thing you can do, and it will not be about her at all.' Myrrhine looked out at the rain. 'It will be about the twenty-ninth of August and a garden and a woman who did not come.'

Antonia watched the rain on the window.

'Yes,' she said.

'Good,' said Myrrhine. 'As long as you know.'

Puteoli in October was a town that had put its shutters up. The great harbour was still working — the Alexandrian fleet had sailed and the African fleet was loading, and there were ships at the mole and stevedores on the quay and the whole machine of the grain trade grinding on — but the villas along the Lucrine road were closed, and the bathing beaches were empty, and the shopkeepers who had made their year in July and August were sitting in their doorways with their hands in their sleeves, watching the rain.

The house on the Lucrine road had a lemon tree in the courtyard and a leaking gutter and a smell of sickness in the back room.

Sabbia opened the door. She was sixty now, and thin, and she had been with Bassa for forty years, and she looked at Antonia for a long moment and then stepped aside without a word.

'How long?' said Antonia.

'The physician says a week. He said that three weeks ago.' Sabbia took her cloak. 'She has a growth in the belly and she will not have it looked at, and she has not eaten more than a mouthful a day since the ides of September, and she has been giving away her things. She gave her good cloak to the woman next door and her bronze mirror to the girl who brings the water, and she has been asking for you since the twenty-ninth of August, and she has been asking in a way that is not like her.' Sabbia's mouth worked. 'She has been asking like a woman who has something to say.'

Bassa was in the bed in the back room with the window that looked east, and she was very small in it.

Her face had gone the colour of old ivory, and her hands on the coverlet were like a bird's feet, and her eyes were open blue and entirely aware.

'You did not come,' she said.

'I did not come.'

'Why?'

'Because a boy died in my house in August,' said Antonia, 'and because the house was closed, and because there was a trial coming, and because I told myself that a woman with a dead boy in her house does not go to Puteoli to stand in an empty garden.'

Bassa lay still for a moment.

'That is a good reason,' she said. 'I have heard worse. I have heard a great many worse, from a great many people, over the years, and I have believed most of them, because it is easier to believe a reason than to be angry.' Her hand moved on the coverlet. 'Sit down. Not there; there is a stool by the bed that Sabbia sits on. Sit on the stool.'

Antonia sat.

'I am dying,' said Bassa.

'I know.'

'It is not quick and it is not interesting and it is not dignified, and I have delivered two hundred children into the world and I am going out of it through my own belly like a fish on a slab, and there is no justice in it and I do not want any.' She turned her head. 'I have been thinking about you since August. Not about the girl; about you. About a girl of sixteen in a hot room with her hair stuck to her face and her hands on the bed frame, and the way you looked at me when I told you the child was dead.' She closed her eyes. 'I have told that lie to eleven women in forty years. It is the only part of the trade that I have never been able to do properly. Some of them believed me and some of them did not, and you looked at me as though I were a door that had been shut, and I have seen that look every year when you come and stand in the garden, and this year you did not come, and I thought: she has found out, and she is not coming because she cannot look at me.'

'I found out in the summer,' said Antonia.

'I know. I heard. The whole town heard; you hired a man and he came and asked questions in the basilica, and the clerk in the records office is my cousin's husband, and he came and told me that a man from Rome had been asking about the year.' Bassa opened her eyes. 'You should have come to me first.'

'You lied to me for twenty-five years.'

'Yes,' said Bassa. 'And then I told you the truth six years ago and you walked out of this house and down to the sea and you did not write to me for three years, and when you came back you stood in the garden and did not come in.' She shifted, and her face tightened with pain. 'I am not going to argue with you. I have about a week and I am going to spend it saying what I have been keeping, and you are going to listen, and then you are going to leave and I am going to die, and neither of us is going to be forgiven, because that is not what this is.'

'Then say it.'

'Not tonight,' said Bassa. 'Tonight I am going to sleep, because I have been keeping myself awake for eleven days waiting for you, and I have not got the strength to say it twice.' Her hand found Antonia's wrist on the

coverlet and closed on it with surprising force. ‘Tomorrow. In the morning, when the light is good. And bring the Greek woman, the one you sleep in the same room with, because you will need somebody to hear it who is not you.’

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She said it in the morning, with the shutters open and the light coming in grey off the sea, and it took an hour and a half, and Antonia did not interrupt her once.

She said that on the twenty-ninth of August, when the child was born, there had been a woman waiting in the corridor. She had come from Rome two days before and had been in the house since, and had given her orders in a voice that made Bassa’s hands shake, and she had been perhaps forty, tall, thin, with a jewelled clasp at her shoulder and a slave with her who did not speak.

‘She was not a slave,’ said Bassa. ‘I have been forty years in this trade and I know a slave when I see one, and I know a free woman who has been given orders all her life, and she was the second. She stood in my corridor with her hands folded and she said, "The child is not to remain in this house," and I said, "The mother is sixteen and she is bleeding and she has been told nothing," and she said, "The mother is not your concern. The child is."’

‘What did you do?’

‘I delivered the child,’ said Bassa. ‘She was born at the ninth hour and she was small and she cried, and I put her in a cloth and I held her for a moment. And then the woman held out her arms, and I gave her the child, and she did not look at her. She gave her to the slave who did not speak and she said, "The dealer is expecting us before dark," and they went out of that door and down the road and I never saw the child again.’

Antonia sat very still.

‘You told me it was buried in the garden.’

‘I told you it was buried in the garden, and then I went out and turned over a piece of earth at the bottom of my own garden with a spade, so that

there would be a place, in case you asked to see it. And you asked to see it.' Bassa's eyes were wet and her voice was perfectly steady. 'I have stood in that garden with you, year after year, while you looked at a piece of turned earth that I dug myself, and I have said nothing, and I have taken your money for the wall, and I have let you buy the ground, and I have let you believe that you had a grave.'

'Why?'

'Because I was told what would happen to me,' said Bassa, 'and because I was sixty-one and I had a house and a freedom that could be taken back by a signature, and because I had been a slave for fifty years and I knew exactly what a signature could do.' She turned her head on the pillow. 'That is the whole of the reason, and it is not enough, and I know it is not enough, and I have been saying it to myself for twenty-five years in the hope that it would become enough, and it has not.'

'What was her name?' said Antonia.

'I do not know her name.'

'Bassa.'

'I do not know her name,' said Bassa again, 'and that is the truth, and it is the one thing in this whole business I cannot give you. She was called domina by her slave and she was never called anything else in my hearing, and I did not ask, because a midwife who asks is a midwife who is paid less.' She closed her eyes. 'But I know the dealer, because I had dealt with him before, and I know what he was told to write on the bill, because I heard her say it at the door. She said: "Enter it in my brother's name. He is the master of the household and it is his household that is buying."'

The room was silent except for the sea.

'Her brother's name,' said Antonia.

'She said it,' said Bassa. 'She said, "Enter it in the name of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus," and the dealer wrote it down, and that is how I have known all these years that the child went into that family and not into a brothel or a field.' She opened her eyes. 'And there is one thing more, and then I am going to sleep. Under the loose tile by the window, in the corner, there is a hole. I put a paper in it the day after they took her, and I have

never taken it out, and I have never told anyone, not Sabbia, not the priest, not the woman who comes to wash me.' Her hand moved. 'It is the copy of the bill that the dealer left with me. I asked him for a copy because I said I must have something for my own book, and he gave it to me, and it has the name on it, and the price, and the date, and the mark of his office. I have been afraid of it for twenty-five years. Take it out of my house and take it to Rome and do whatever it is you are going to do with it, and do not tell me what it says.'

Antonia got up and went to the corner by the window and knelt and lifted the tile, and the hole beneath it was lined with a piece of leather that had gone hard, and inside the leather there was a folded paper.

She did not unfold it there. She put it in her sleeve and came back and sat down on the stool.

'Bassa,' she said.

'Do not,' said Bassa. 'Whatever it is. Not now.'

'I was going to say thank you.'

'That is worse,' said Bassa, and turned her face to the wall.

On the second afternoon, while Bassa slept, Antonia walked down to the harbour.

She had not meant to. She had meant to sit in the courtyard and write letters, and she got as far as the end of the Lucrine road and then kept walking, and Myrrhine walked beside her and did not ask where they were going, because she had understood from the first turn.

The house of Caesonius Verus had changed its name and its trade.

It was a boarding house now, for merchants and ships' officers, with a new portico and a new doorkeeper and a sign with a ship on it. The fountain in the courtyard was the same fountain; she could see it through the gate. The vine on the trellis had thickened and covered half the wall. The room over the kitchen, where she had slept for six years, had a new shutter.

'Do you want to go in?' said Myrrhine.

'No.'

They stood in the street for a while, and the doorkeeper looked at them, and Antonia looked at the fountain.

'It was a good house, as those houses go,' she said. 'He did not beat us. He did not sell us to the sailors. He had a rule that no man came into the courtyard after the second hour, and he kept it, and when a magistrate's son broke it he was thrown into the street by a doorkeeper who was paid extra for the throwing.' She turned away. 'There is a thing that respectable people cannot hear, and it is this: that house saved me. Not in the way they mean when they say a woman is saved. It taught me to read a man in three sentences, and to keep a book, and to know what a favour costs, and it gave me six years in which nobody owned my body except a man with a bad leg who wanted the accounts balanced. If I had stayed in the villa at Arretium I would have been a laundry woman at thirty, and dead at forty, and I would never have learned that I could do arithmetic.'

'You do not have to defend it,' said Myrrhine.

'I am not defending it. I am telling you what it was.' Antonia started back up the road. 'The bishop of the Christians says that a woman in such a house is a sinner and that the man who goes to her is a sinner, and that both may be forgiven. The philosophers say that the woman is a victim and the man is a beast. The law says that the woman is a thing and the man is a citizen. None of them has ever asked me what it was, and I have been in this town for two days and I have walked past that gate and I have found that I still do not know how to answer.'

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The woman who had lived next door to Bassa for thirty years was called Vera, and she came in on the third day with a bowl of soup and stayed for two hours, and it was she who sat with Antonia in the courtyard while Bassa slept.

Vera was sixty-five and had been the wife of a rope-maker and was now a widow with four sons and a small income and no patience at all.

'You are the one who bought the ground,' she said.

'I am.'

'Bassa told me you come every year and stand in it.' Vera stirred her soup. 'I asked her once why you did it, and she said, "Because she thinks her child is there," and I said, "Is it?" and she said, "No," and then she did not say anything else for a year.'

Antonia looked at her.

'You knew.'

'I knew there was no child in that ground because I was in the house the morning she dug it,' said Vera, 'and she dug it alone with a spade at the fifth hour, and she was crying, and she was sixty-one years old and she had a bad hip and she would not let me help her, and she would not tell me why.' She put the bowl down. 'I am not going to be sorry for her in front of you. She was my neighbour and I liked her and she did a wicked thing and kept it for twenty-five years, and both of those are true, and I have been to the priest about it and he told me that the gods see everything and that I should mind my own business.' She looked at Antonia sideways. 'The girl. Did she live?'

'She lived.'

'Where is she?'

'I do not know yet. In Rome.'

Vera nodded slowly.

'Then find her,' she said, 'and when you find her, do not tell her that her mother is a rich woman with a house full of beautiful women and a trial for murder in November. Tell her that her mother is a woman who has been looking for her for twenty-five years and has made a great many mistakes and is not going to make this one.' She picked up her bowl. 'And when you have told her, bring her here, and I will tell her what her grandmother Bassa was like, because there is nobody else left who can, and a girl should have one old woman in her life who remembers the beginning.'

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She died on the fourth day, in the afternoon, with Sabbia on one side of the bed and Antonia on the other, and at the end she said something that Antonia did not catch and Sabbia did, and Sabbia wept and would not repeat it.

The funeral was the next morning. She had been a freedwoman for forty years, and she had been a midwife for fifty, and the town came: the women she had delivered and the children she had delivered and some of the children's children, the physician, two of the town magistrates, the priestess of Isis in her white linen, the woman from the house next door who had been given the good cloak, the girl who brought the water and had been given the bronze mirror. There were eleven wreaths and a flute player and a man who was paid to make the lament and did it very well, and there was a procession down the Lucrine road to the burial ground outside the town wall.

Antonia walked in it. She was the richest woman in the procession, and she walked behind the bier with Sabbia and did not speak to anyone, and the town looked at her and made its own arrangements about who she was.

Afterwards she stood at the edge of the ground with the sea behind her.

'What will you do with the house?' said Myrrhine.

'Give it to Sabbia. And the ground at the bottom of the garden.' She looked at the turned earth, which had grown a lemon sapling in the twenty years since it had been dug, and which was, as it had always been, empty. 'Have a stone put there. Not a grave. A stone with no name, and a line from the poet, the one about the sea washing away the evils of men, and the date. She can decide what it means, or the woman next door can, or nobody can, and it will be there in a hundred years and no one will know why.'

'That is a strange thing to build,' said Myrrhine.

'It is what I have,' said Antonia. 'I have spent twenty years paying a wall around a lie. A wall and a stone with no name is at least honest.'

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She read the paper in the carriage on the way back to Rome, at dusk, on the road between Formiae and Fundi, with the sea on her right and the hills going dark.

It was a bill of sale, four inches by six, in a dealer's hand, with the office mark at the foot. It said that in the ninth month of the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo, one Caius Oppius Felix had sold to the household of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus a female child, age four days, of good health and no defect, for the sum of two hundred and forty sesterces; that the child was of slave condition, born of a slave woman of the household of the Tarquitii at Arretium; and that she had been given the name Tertia in the household accounts, being the third such purchase of that year.

At the bottom, in a different hand, in ink that had gone brown, there was one line more.

Received, and the child delivered to the household at Arretium in the care of the slave Sabbia, on the sixth day before the Kalends of October.

Antonia read it four times.

'Well?' said Myrrhine.

'Her name is Tertia,' said Antonia. 'She is twenty-five years old. She was bought for two hundred and forty sesterces and given to a woman named Sabbia and taken to a house in the country where I spent the worst year of my life, and she was entered in a book as the third purchase of the year.' She folded the paper. 'And she was freed seven years ago, by the council's leave, on the instruction of Tarquitia Priscilla, and sent to Rome with a trade.'

Myrrhine sat forward.

'Then she is in Rome.'

'She is in Rome,' said Antonia. 'There are perhaps four hundred thousand people in this city. I have a name that is also a number, a date, a household, and a woman who freed her and knows where she went.' She looked out of the window at the dark hills. 'In the morning I am going to send for Hilarus, and I am going to have him find her, and then I am going to have to decide what to do with the rest of my life.'

'And the trial?'

'The trial is in nine days,' said Antonia. 'And when I stand up in that basilica I will be a woman who has been told by a dying midwife that her daughter is alive in this city, and I will not be able to say so, because the court will hear it as a fiction invented for sympathy, and because the one man who could confirm it is the man who is going to defend me.' She leaned her head against the side of the carriage. 'So I will say nothing, and I will be tried for a boy who died of his own foolishness, and I will keep my face still, and when it is over I will go and find my daughter.'

'And if she does not want to be found?'

Antonia closed her eyes.

'Then I will have a name,' she said, 'and I will know that she is alive, and I will be a woman in a house on the Esquiline with an open door for the rest of my life, in case she ever wants to come through it. It is not much. It is more than I had in August.'

Before they left Puteoli, on the last morning, Sabbia came to her in the courtyard with a bundle in her hands.

It was the child's cloth. The one she had been wrapped in.

'I took it,' said Sabbia. 'That morning, when the woman took her. I took the cloth and I put it in my chest and I have had it for twenty-five years, and I have washed it twice and I have not used it for anything, and I have been afraid that somebody would find it and afraid that nobody would.' She held it out. 'It is nothing. It is a piece of linen that a slave woman in this house wove and a midwife cut up for baby clothes, and there is a stain on it that will not come out, and it is not worth a sesterce.' Her hands were shaking. 'But I held her in it, domina. For an hour, before the woman came. She had the cord around her neck when she came out and Bassa cut it and she started to cry, and I held her while Bassa was seeing to you, and she stopped crying when I talked to her, and she held my finger with her whole hand, which they do; the books say they cannot, but they do.'

Antonia took the cloth.

It was thin and worn and the colour of old paper, and there was a brown stain in one corner, and along the hem someone had sewn a line of small cross-stitches in dark red thread, which had been a good thread once, before forty years of washing.

'What was she like?' said Antonia.

'Small,' said Sabbia. 'Loud. She had a great deal of hair for a baby, and it was dark, and it was not the hair of a four-day child, and Bassa said that meant nothing, and it meant nothing.' She wiped her face with the back of her hand. 'And she had a mark. Here.' She touched her own left shoulder blade. 'On the back of the shoulder. Not a birthmark like a wine stain. It was like a small crescent, the size of a fingernail, and it was a little darker than the rest of her, and it will have faded, or it will not. You should know. Somebody should know.'

Antonia folded the cloth and put it in her sleeve with the bill of sale.

'Thank you,' she said.

'Do not thank me,' said Sabbia, and began to cry in earnest, and said, through it, the thing that Antonia had been waiting four days to hear and had not asked for: 'I should have run out of that door with her. I was thirty-nine years old and I could have run out of that door and down the Lucrine road and they would never have caught me, and I did not, because I was afraid, and I have thought about that every day for twenty-five years and there is nothing in the world I can do about it now except tell you that I have thought about it.'

Antonia stood in the courtyard of a house on the Lucrine road with a piece of linen in her sleeve.

'You held her,' she said. 'For an hour, you held her, and she stopped crying, and that is not nothing. It is the only thing anyone in that house did for her that had no price on it, and I am going to tell her so, if I ever get the chance.'

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They left at the fourth hour and were in Rome by the evening of the next day, and the city was in its October mood, which is the best month it has: the heat gone, the light gold, the markets full, the rich coming back from the coast with their servants and their seasickness and their stories.

At the gate, Meno said, 'There are three things, domina. The praetor's brother-in-law has been to the urban prefect. There is a letter from the house of Vibia Lucana. And a man has been here twice asking for the atriensis and would not give his name, and Cinnamus has put him off, and he says the man is a clerk from the Palatine.'

Antonia stood in her own atrium for a moment with the smell of the house around her: wax and wine and the dust of a hundred sandals and, underneath it, the fig tree.

'Bring me wine,' she said, 'and then bring me Cinnamus, and then send to Hilarus, and tell him I want a woman found in this city, and I want her found in ten days.'

'In ten days, domina? The trial is in eleven.'

'I know,' said Antonia. 'I would like to know who my daughter is before I am tried for my life, and I would like it very much if those two things could happen in that order.'

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Secretary

— ◆ —

Hilarus found her in six days, which was fast even for him, and he found her by the simplest method available: he asked the woman who had freed her.

It was done in the way that such things are done. A clerk was sent to the house on the Palatine with a letter from the office of the urban prefect, which was true in the sense that the letter was written on paper from that office and signed by a man who worked in it and had been paid; and the letter asked, for the purposes of a matter of inheritance, whether the household could confirm the manumission of a freedwoman named Tertia, formerly of the household at Arretium, freed by the council's leave in the seventh year before the present consulship.

The steward confirmed it. The letter asked, further, for the woman's present address, and the steward, who was seventy-one and careful, replied that the household did not keep the addresses of its freedwomen, which was a lie, and that the woman had been given a sum and a trade and had gone to Rome, which was true.

Hilarus then did the thing that Antonia would not have thought of, which was to go to the council's register.

Every manumission by the council's leave in the city of Rome was entered in a book, and the book had, by law, to record the freedwoman's name, her former master, the sum paid for the leave, and the guarantor. The guarantor in this case was the household of the Tarquitii, and the entry gave an address for the service of any claim: a shop in the Subura, in the fourth region, in the street of the sandalmakers.

The shop belonged to a builder named Gaius Vipsanius Polla, who had a contract with the household at Arretium and had taken the freedwoman on as his bookkeeper seven years before, and who was, Hilarus reported, a

decent man with a bad temper and a great deal of work.

'Her name is Tertia Vipsania,' said Hilarus. 'She took his name when she was freed, which freedwomen do. She is twenty-five. She is not married. She lives in two rooms above a bakery on the Vicus Sabuci with another woman, who is a midwife. She keeps the books for Polla's building business and for two shops in the same street, and she has a reputation for being quick and hard and for finding money that other people have lost.' He put the tablet down. 'She has never been in any trouble. She has never been in any court. She has no children and no husband and no debts, and she has saved, in seven years, something over eleven thousand sesterces, which is a great deal for a woman who was freed with nothing.'

Antonia sat with her hands in her lap.

'What does she look like?' she said.

'I have not seen her, domina. I have seen the shop and the bakery and the woman she lives with. I do not go and look at people; that is not my trade.' Hilarus paused. 'I can tell you that she is short. The woman at the bakery says she is short and that she walks fast and that she counts under her breath when she is thinking, which the bakery woman finds funny and I do not, because I have known two men who counted under their breath and both of them were accountants.'

Antonia stood up.

'I want to hire her,' she said.

'That will be difficult.'

'Why?'

'Because she is not a fool,' said Hilarus. 'Because she has a place and a reputation and eleven thousand sesterces, and because a woman like that does not leave a builder who has been fair to her to go and work in a house on the Esquiline three weeks before that house is tried for murder. She will have heard of you. Everyone in the fourth region has heard of you. She will think that you want her for something, and she will be right.'

'Then I will not hire her,' said Antonia. 'My atriensis will hire her. A trial needs a scribe and a copyist; there are eleven boxes of accounts and four hundred tablets and a book of contracts, and the advocate will want

them all copied and arranged by the first of November. Cinnamus will go to the builder and offer to buy her time for a month at double her wage, and the builder will agree because he is a man with a bad temper and a great deal of work and no money to refuse.'

Hilarus looked at her.

'And then?'

'And then she will come to this house,' said Antonia, 'and sit in the tablinum, and count under her breath, and I will not be able to say a word to her, because if I say a word to her before I know what I am going to do with the rest of my life, I will ruin her.'

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Tertia Vipsania came on the eighteenth day of October, at the second hour, with a box of tablets under her arm and a stylus behind her ear.

Antonia watched her come up the hill from the window of the upper room. She had set herself at the window deliberately, because the alternative was to be in the tablinum when the girl came in, and she did not trust her own face.

She was short. She walked fast. She had dark hair pinned up in a way that was not fashionable and was entirely practical, and she wore a plain grey dress and good sandals, and she stopped at the gate and spoke to Meno for a moment, and Meno laughed — Meno, who laughed perhaps twice a year — and then she came in.

Antonia stood at the window with her hand flat against the shutter and watched her daughter cross the atrium.

She had prepared herself. She had prepared herself for twenty-five years, in a way; she had imagined the meeting in a hundred forms, and in every one of them she had been a woman who knew what to say. In none of them had she been a woman of forty-one standing at a shutter on the upper floor, unable to breathe, watching a stranger with a box of tablets being shown into a room by a doorkeeper.

She was not beautiful. That was the first thing. She had a broad, pleasant, entirely ordinary face with a strong jaw and her grandmother's

nose and a small mole by the corner of her mouth, and she had a way of looking at a room as she came into it, once, quickly, from side to side, taking the exits, which Antonia had seen in exactly one other person in her life and which was her own.

She was in the tablinum for four hours. At the third hour Antonia went down and stood in the passage outside the door and listened to her voice, which was low and quick and had a Campanian vowel in it, and to Cinnamus's voice, and to the sound of a stylus on wax.

At the fourth hour she went in.

'Domina,' said Cinnamus, and stood. 'This is the copyist, Tertia Vipsania.'

Tertia stood up. She did not look frightened and she did not look impressed. She looked at Antonia the way a person looks at a door they are deciding whether to open.

'Domina,' she said.

'You have been four hours,' said Antonia.

'Nine boxes,' said Tertia. 'Four of them are in the same hand and the other five are in three different hands, and the fourth box has been wet at some point and the tablets have warped, and two of the entries in the seventh box do not balance, and I have written down eleven questions.'

'Ask them.'

'Not in front of the atriensis,' said Tertia. 'He has told me twice that the seventh box does not balance and he is right, but he is wrong about why, and I would rather tell you why when he is not in the room, because he will be embarrassed.'

Cinnamus made a sound that was almost a laugh and gathered his tablets.

'I will be in the kitchen,' he said, 'being embarrassed.'

When the door closed, Antonia sat down.

'Ask them,' she said.

The questions were good. They were better than good; they were the questions of a woman who had spent seven years finding money that other people had lost. She asked why the house had paid a wine merchant twice

in the same month, and whether the second payment had been a loan, and if so where the note was. She asked why there were eleven entries for one woman's wages in a year with twelve months in it, and whether the woman had been ill or had been away. She asked about a loan to a name that appeared three times in five years, always in the spring, always the same sum, and never repaid.

'That is a loan to a man who is not going to repay it,' she said, 'and you know he is not going to repay it, and it is in the book as a loan, which means the book is honest but the man is not. Who is he?'

'He is a magistrate's freedman,' said Antonia, 'and the money is not a loan, it is a payment, and it is in the book as a loan because if it were in the book as a payment it would be evidence of something that would put me in a cell.'

Tertia looked at her for a moment.

'Then you should not have written it down at all,' she said.

'Then I would not have known what I had paid.'

'You would have known,' said Tertia. 'You would have remembered. You are the kind of woman who remembers.' She made a small mark on her tablet. 'It is not my business. I will copy it as it stands and I will put a note in the margin that the entry is unexplained, and when the advocate asks me, I will say that I copied it faithfully and that I do not know what it is, and I will be telling the truth.'

Antonia looked at her.

'You are very careful,' she said.

'I am a freedwoman with eleven thousand sesterces and no family,' said Tertia, 'and I have been in this city for seven years, and in seven years I have learned that the only thing that protects a woman like me is being exactly what she says she is.' She put her stylus down. 'May I ask you something, domina? Not about the book.'

'Ask.'

'Why did your atriensis offer my builder double my wage for a month's work?'

'Because a trial needs a copyist.'

'There are forty copyists in this city who would do it for half the money and would not need to be bought out of a contract,' said Tertia. 'I asked him and he said the work was confidential. I have done confidential work before and I have never been bought out of a contract for it; I have been made to swear an oath and I have been paid at the end.' She looked at Antonia steadily. 'So I am asking you, domina, because I would rather ask now than find out in three weeks. Why me?'

The room was quiet. In the atrium a slave went past carrying a basket, and the light from the door moved across the floor.

'Because you were recommended,' said Antonia.

'By whom?'

'By a man who knows the fourth region and who was told that the best bookkeeper in the Subura was a freedwoman called Tertia,' said Antonia, 'and who did not tell me the rest of it, and I did not ask.'

Tertia's face did not change.

'That is an answer,' she said, 'and it is not the whole answer, and I am going to take the work anyway, because the money is good and because I have never in my life been paid double for anything.' She picked up her stylus. 'But I will tell you what I tell everyone I work for. I will keep your books honestly and I will not steal, and I will not lie for you, and if I am asked a question in a court I will answer it, and if you want a woman who will do otherwise you should hire a man.'

'That is what I want,' said Antonia.

'Good,' said Tertia, and went back to the ninth box.

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She came every day for eleven days.

She came at the second hour and left at the ninth, and she sat in the tablinum with the shutters open and copied four hundred tablets and made a fair copy of the book of contracts in a hand that was small and upright and beautiful, and she ate with the household at the sixth hour because it was easier, and she talked to Eucharis about the price of wool and to Meno about the races and to Cinnamus about the seventh box, and

she called Antonia domina.

Antonia watched her.

She watched her eat — she ate quickly, and she left the best part of anything on the plate, which is a habit that people who have been hungry in childhood never lose. She watched her count under her breath. She watched her sit, and the way she sat, with her feet tucked under her and her shoulders a little forward, as though she were protecting her chest. She watched her hands, which were small and square and had a callus on the second finger of the right hand from a stylus, and which were, unmistakably, the hands of the woman watching her.

On the fourth day she heard her say to Eucharis, in the corridor: 'I was raised by a woman called Sabbia, and she was not my mother, and she never pretended to be, and she used to say that a lie told kindly is still a lie and a truth told kindly is worth two.'

Antonia was in the passage at the time. She went into the small room off the library and stood there for a while with her hand over her mouth until she could come out again.

On the fifth day, Prima asked her about it.

They were in the garden at the sixth hour, and Prima was eating bread and olives and watching the tablinum door, and she said, without preamble, 'Who is she?'

'The copyist.'

'The copyist is a freedwoman from the fourth region who has been in this house nine days and has eaten at our table and has made Meno laugh twice, and she has your hands and your way of standing in a doorway, and she counts under her breath the way you do when you are adding a column, and I have watched you watch her for a week and you have the face of a woman looking at something she has lost.' Prima spat an olive stone into her hand. 'So. Who is she?'

Antonia looked at the tablinum door.

'She is my daughter,' she said.

Prima stopped chewing.

'Your daughter.'

'Yes.'

'You have a daughter.'

'I have a daughter,' said Antonia, 'who was born in Puteoli twenty-five years ago and taken from me the same day and sold into the household of the Tarquitii, and I was told she was dead, and I found out in the summer that she was not, and I have known for certain for four days, and she does not know, and she is copying four hundred and eleven tablets for a trial in which I am accused of murder.' She took an olive. 'You asked. That is the answer.'

Prima was silent for a long moment.

'Does she know she is a freedwoman of that household?'

'She knows that. She has the name and the register entry. She does not know the rest of it, and I do not know what she has been told, and I have not asked her, because every question I ask her is a question I have no right to ask until I have decided what I am going to do.'

'Then decide,' said Prima.

'It is not that simple.'

'It is exactly that simple,' said Prima, 'and you are making it complicated because you are afraid, and you have been afraid since August, and in August your fear made you send Berenice away in a closed carriage and hide her, and now it is making you sit in a room for a week watching your daughter copy tablets.' She wiped her hands on her skirt. 'You told me in September to buy a house with a door and a lock and a deed in my own name. I have been looking at houses. There is one on the Aventine, two rooms and a yard, and it costs eleven thousand sesterces, and I am going to buy it, and I am going to do it because you told me to. So I am telling you: that girl is not a house. You cannot buy her, and you cannot put a deed on her, and you cannot keep her safe by watching her from a doorway.'

'I know that.'

'Then do something,' said Prima, and got up, and went in to help with the bread.

On the seventh day, Myrrhine said, 'You have not told her.'

'No.'

'You are not going to tell her before the trial.'

'No.'

'And after?'

'After, if I am acquitted, I will tell her in a room with the door shut, and she will have a choice: she may have a mother, or she may have a client, or she may have nothing, and I will give her the money to be nothing if that is what she wants.' Antonia looked at the tablets. 'And if I am convicted, I will not tell her at all. I will go to Massilia and she will never know, and she will be a woman of twenty-five with eleven thousand sesterces and a good name in the fourth region, and she will not have to carry it.'

'That is cowardice,' said Myrrhine.

'Yes.'

'And you are going to do it anyway.'

'Yes.'

Myrrhine stood in the doorway with her arms folded.

'Then I will tell you what I have been doing for eleven days,' she said, 'while you have been watching her hands. I have been watching her too. She has a mark on the back of her left shoulder, and I have seen it, because she washes her hands at the basin in the corridor and her dress slips, and it is a small crescent, the size of a fingernail, and it is a little darker than the rest of her.' She came into the room. 'So there it is. She is your daughter. There is no doubt in the world now, and you have been sitting in this house for a week with her in the next room, and you have not said a word to her except about the seventh box.'

Antonia sat down slowly.

'You are certain?'

'I am certain,' said Myrrhine. 'And Antonia — I am going to say this once and then I am going to keep the accounts. That girl is not a tragedy. Look at her. She is twenty-five and she has a trade and a reputation and a

friend who is a midwife and eleven thousand sesterces in a bank, and she did all of it herself, in a city where a freedwoman with no family is a piece of furniture. She is not waiting to be found. She is not a girl in a tower. She is a woman who has been managing without you for twenty-five years, and if you go into that room and tell her that you are her mother, the first thing she will feel is not joy. It will be that her whole life has been a thing that happened to her without her consent.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'Do you?'

'I have been that woman,' said Antonia. 'I was told my daughter was dead, and it was a lie, and I have spent the whole of this summer being angry about a thing that was done to me without my consent, and now I am about to do the same thing to her.' She looked up. 'That is why I have not said a word. Not cowardice. I am trying to find a way to tell her that does not take anything from her, and I have not found it, and I have a fortnight.'

On the ninth day she went into the tablinum at the eighth hour of the evening, when the household was at dinner and the room was empty except for one lamp and one woman copying.

Tertia looked up.

'Domina. The light is bad; I am doing the summary now and I will finish the copying in the morning.'

'Do not stop,' said Antonia, and sat down on the bench by the wall.

Tertia went back to work. The stylus moved. After a while she said, without looking up, 'You have not asked me anything about myself in nine days.'

'Should I have?'

'Everyone asks. The women here have asked me four times where I was born, and the atriensis asked me on the first day whether I had a family, and Meno asked me on the third day whether I had ever been to Thrace, which I have not, and which he asked because he is Thracian and because

he has decided that I am a person worth asking.' The stylus moved. 'You have asked me nothing. You have asked me about the seventh box and the wine merchant and the loan in the spring, and you have not asked me a single question about myself, and I have noticed, and I have been trying to decide what it means.'

'What have you decided?'

Tertia put the stylus down.

'I have decided that you already know,' she said.

The lamp guttered. In the dining room someone laughed, and a chair scraped.

'What do I know?' said Antonia.

'That I was bought,' said Tertia. 'That is what people know about me; it is on the register and it is in the household book at Arretium and it is in the mouth of every woman who has ever been unkind to me. I was bought at four days old for two hundred and forty sesterces and entered as the third purchase of the year, and I was given the name Tertia because I was a number in a book, and I was raised by a woman called Sabbia who was kind to me and who died when I was nineteen, and I was freed at nineteen by the council's leave on the instruction of the old mistress, with a sum of four thousand sesterces and a trade.' She said it flatly, the way one recites a thing one has said many times. 'I was told that my mother was a slave of the household who died, and I was told it once, by the steward, when I was fourteen and asked, and he told me not to ask again, and I did not ask again, because I was fourteen and I was property and I had learned what questions cost.'

Antonia sat very still.

'And now?' she said.

'Now I am twenty-five and free and I have eleven thousand sesterces,' said Tertia, 'and I have thought about it for seven years, and I have come to this: whoever she was, she did not sell me. Sabbia told me once, when she was dying and had had a little wine, that I was taken out of a house in Campania in a cloth, and that the cloth had a cross-stitched hem, and that the woman who gave me to her cried.' She picked up her stylus again.

'That is all I have. A cloth with a hem, and a woman who cried, and a name that is a number. It is not much to build a mother out of, and I have stopped trying, because a woman of twenty-five who spends her life imagining her mother is a woman who will be unhappy for the rest of it.' She looked up. 'And you have the face of a woman who knows something. So I will ask you once, domina, and then I will not ask again. Do you know who my mother was?'

Antonia sat in the lamplight with the piece of linen in her sleeve, folded small, with the cross-stitched hem and the brown stain.

'Yes,' she said.

Tertia's hand was quite steady on the stylus.

'Who?'

The door opened. Cinnamus put his head in and said, 'Domina, there is a man from the prefect's office at the gate and he has a summons for the morning, and he says it is to be served tonight because the court sits at the second hour and not the third.'

Antonia stood up.

'Tell him I will come to the gate,' she said. 'Tertia. Not tonight. After the court, on the day it is over, in a room with the door shut, I will tell you everything I know, and I will not ask you for anything in return, and whatever you decide to do with it, I will do as you ask.' She went to the door and stopped. 'One thing only, and then I will not say another word. The woman who cried: she did not sell you. She was sixteen years old and she was told that you were dead, and she has believed it for twenty-five years.'

Tertia sat with the stylus in her hand.

'Sixteen,' she said.

'Sixteen,' said Antonia, and went out to the gate.

On the tenth night, Tarquitius came to the house to prepare the case.

He came at the tenth hour, through the garden door, with a rolled copy of the charge and two tablets of notes, and he sat in the study for three

hours with Antonia and Cinnamus and went through the whole of it: the box, the physician's report, the dead woman Doris, the witnesses, the order in which they would be called, the four questions he would ask the praetor's physician, and the one question he would not ask, because a question you cannot control the answer to is a gift to the other side.

At the end of the third hour Cinnamus took the tablets away to be copied fair, and Tarquitius stood in the passage with his cloak over his arm, and Tertia came out of the tablinum with the fair copy in her hands and went past them both with her head down and her stylus behind her ear.

Tarquitius watched her go. Then he said, quietly, 'Who is that?'

'My copyist,' said Antonia.

'She has your hands,' he said. 'She has your hands and your way of walking, and she put her head down when she passed me in a way that a copyist does not do; a copyist looks at a senator, because a senator is a man who might pay her.' He turned. 'Antonia. Is that her?'

'Yes.'

He stood very still in the passage with his cloak over his arm.

'She does not know,' said Antonia. 'Not yet. I have told her that I know who her mother was and that I will tell her when the case is over, and she has agreed to wait, and until then she is a copyist in this house and nothing else, and you will not look at her again, and you will not speak to her, and if you come to this house tomorrow night you will come after the ninth hour when she has gone home.'

He looked at the closed door of the tablinum.

'I have a daughter,' he said, 'who is nineteen and has been in my house all her life and who is going to be married in the winter to a fool, and I have a daughter who has been copying tablets in this house for ten days and who has a stylus behind her ear.' He put his hand over his eyes, briefly, and took it away. 'What is her name?'

'Tertia.'

'Tertia,' he said. 'That is a slave's name.'

'It is the name she was given in your household book,' said Antonia, 'because she was the third child bought that year. She has another name

now; she took the name of the builder who employed her, which is what freedwomen do. I am not going to tell you which one.'

He nodded slowly.

'In the morning,' he said, 'I am going to stand up in that basilica and I am going to defend you, and there will be a great many men in that court who will be watching me, and some of them will be able to see what I am feeling if I am not careful. So I am going to be very careful, and I am going to win, and then I am going to go home and I am going to sit in my study and I am going to think about the fact that a woman I have despised for twenty-five years has been raising my daughter's wages in a house on the Esquiline.' He went to the garden door. 'Do not tell her anything about me. Not yet. Not until I have spoken to my mother.'

On the eleventh day, the day before the trial, Tertia came to her in the study and said, 'The book is finished. Four hundred and eleven tablets copied and arranged by date, and the contract book, and a summary of the seventh box with the eleven questions and my answers where I have them.' She put a bundle on the table. 'I will be here at the second hour tomorrow and I will bring the summary in the fair copy, and I will stand in the court if the advocate wants me to, and I will say what I have done and nothing more.'

'Thank you,' said Antonia.

Tertia did not go.

'Domina,' she said, 'there is a thing I have been going to say for eleven days.'

'Say it.'

'I know who you are,' said Tertia. 'Not who you are to me; I know who you are in this city, everyone does. I mean that I know what this house is and what it has been, and I have been in it for twelve days and I have watched it, and I want to tell you a thing that nobody in this city will tell you, because they are all either afraid of you or obliged to you.' She stood with her box under her arm. 'You are not going to be convicted. Not

because you are innocent; I have read your books and you are innocent of nothing in particular. You are not going to be convicted because the men who will judge you have all, at some point, needed something from a woman they did not respect, and they know it, and when they look at you they will see the woman they needed and did not respect, and they will not be able to bear it. That is not justice. It is the closest thing to justice that this city has, and it will be enough.'

Antonia looked at her for a long moment.

'You are a remarkable woman,' she said.

'No,' said Tertia. 'I am a woman who has had to be right about people, because being wrong was expensive.' She went to the door. 'Tomorrow, domina. The second hour.'

She went out. Antonia sat at the table with the four hundred and eleven tablets in their bundles and the light going down, and did not move for a long time.

Then she opened the drawer and took out the piece of linen with the cross-stitched hem and the brown stain, and she folded it small and put it in the sleeve of the dress she would wear in the morning, and went up to bed.

PART FOUR

The Judgement Of The City

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Old Woman's Confession

— ◆ —

The message came at the tenth hour of the night, two days before the ides of November, and it came in the hand of the steward of the house on the Palatine, and it said:

My mother is not well. She has asked for you. She has asked in a manner that suggests she will not be refused and I have learned, at my age, not to argue with her. The gate will be open. Come at once.

There was no signature. The seal was the boar's head.

Antonia read it in the study with the tablets of the defence spread out on the table and the lamp burning low, and she stood for a moment with the paper in her hand.

'It is the night before the trial,' said Myrrhine.

'It is the night before the trial.'

'You should sleep. You should be asleep now; you have seven hours before the second hour and you will be standing in a basilica in front of half the Senate.'

'She is seventy-eight,' said Antonia, 'and she has been sitting in that house for twenty-five years, and in the spring she told me that she would not be here to see what her granddaughter decided.' She reached for her cloak. 'If she dies tonight I will spend the rest of my life not knowing whether she would have said it, and I have spent twenty-five years not knowing things, and I am finished with it.'

'Then I am coming with you.'

'No.'

'Antonia.'

'No,' said Antonia. 'She will not speak in front of a stranger. She would not speak in front of her own son. She has asked for me, and she has asked for me tonight, which means that she has decided, and a woman of

seventy-eight who has decided does not need an audience.' She went to the door. 'Have Brennus walk behind me and wait at the gate. If I am not out by the fourth hour, come and get me.'

The house of the Tarquitii at night was the same house and not the same house.

The torches were lit along the street front, and the gate was open, and the steward was waiting with a lamp in the hall, and the masks in the atrium looked out of their cupboards with their holes for eyes. There was no one else in the whole of the front of the house; it was the second hour, and the household was asleep or pretending to be, and the steward walked ahead of her with the lamp and did not speak, and their footsteps went ahead of them through the corridors.

At the door of the small room off the peristyle the steward stopped.

'She is awake,' he said. 'She has been awake since the ninth hour. The physician has been and gone and says there is nothing wrong with her that a younger body would not cure, and she told him that if he came again she would have him thrown out of the window.' He hesitated. 'Domina. There is something you should know before you go in. The young mistress is with her.'

'Marcellina?'

'The young mistress has been with her since the seventh hour. She has not been sent out. I was told to bring you to the room and to leave the door open.' The steward's face, in the lamplight, was old and careful. 'I have been in this house thirty-one years, domina. I have never known the old mistress to leave a door open for a conversation in her life.'

In the corridor that ran from the atrium to the peristyle, Tarquitius was standing in a doorway.

He had a lamp in his hand and a cloak over his arm, and he had clearly been there for some time, and he did not come forward. The steward went past him with his own lamp and his eyes down, and Antonia stopped.

'She has asked for me,' she said.

'I know. The steward told me.' His voice was low. 'I have been standing in this doorway for an hour.'

'Why?'

'Because I do not know what she is going to say to you,' said Tarquitius, 'and because I have known for four months that there is something in this house that everyone has agreed not to tell me, and because I am fifty-three years old and I find that I am afraid of a room.' He looked down the corridor at the closed door. 'I could come in. She is my mother. I could come in and sit down and say, "Say it in front of me."'

'You could.'

'I am not going to,' he said. 'I have thought about it for an hour and I am not going to, and I would like you to understand why, because you will otherwise decide that I am a coward, and you would be right, but not for the reason you think.' He shifted the lamp. 'If I go into that room she will tell me what she thinks I can bear. She has been doing it since I was a boy. She told me my father was dying for a year before he died, and she told me in a way that was designed to be borne, and I have never once heard the whole of anything from her while I was in the room.' He stepped back. 'She will tell you the whole of it because you are not her son. Go in. I will be in the study. When it is over, come and tell me whatever she says I may hear.'

'And if she says it may all be heard?'

'Then I will hear it,' said Tarquitius, 'in the morning, after the trial, when I have won, and when I am a man who can afford to be told the truth.'

The room smelled of camphor and old wool and the particular dry smell of a body that has been in the same bed too long. There were three lamps and a brazier and a chair by the bed, and the shutters were closed, and Tarquitia Priscilla was propped up on cushions with her hands on the coverlet.

Marcellina sat on a stool at the foot of the bed. She was in her nightgown with a shawl over it and her hair was down her back, and she looked at Antonia as she came in and did not say anything.

'Sit down,' said the old woman. 'Not the chair; the chair is too far. Sit on the bed. I want to hear you breathing.'

Antonia sat on the edge of the bed.

'You look like a woman who has not slept,' said Tarquitia Priscilla.

'I have not slept.'

'Good. Sleep is for people who have nothing to say.' Her blind face turned. 'Marcellina is here because I asked her to be here. I have thought about this for four months, since the day my son came home from a room above a bookseller's and asked me a question in the doorway of this room and I told him to go to bed.' She paused. 'I told him to go to bed. That is what I said. He stood in that doorway with his cloak on and his face the colour of a fish and he said, "Mother, is it true that there was a child?" and I said, "Go to bed, Lucius, it is the middle of the night."'

The brazier ticked.

'He has not asked me again,' she said. 'That is what this family does. We ask once, at the wrong hour, and when we are told to go to bed we go to bed, and we do not ask again for twenty-five years.' She moved her hands on the coverlet. 'There is wine on the table. Pour yourself some and pour nothing for me; I have had my wine and I am allowed one cup a day and I have had it.'

Antonia did not move.

'I am going to tell you three things,' said Tarquitia Priscilla, 'and then I am going to ask you for something, and then you will go home and be tried in the morning. The first thing is what I did. The second is what my daughter did. The third is what my son was told. I have arranged them in that order because it is the order of the guilt and because if I begin with my son I will not get to the end.'

The first thing was this.

In the spring of the year, when the household at Arretium was in mourning and the estate was in the hands of the heirs, a steward came to her and told her that the girl Cassia from the linen room was pregnant, and that the child was her son's.

'I had known for a month,' she said. 'I am blind, not stupid. I knew from the way the household spoke in the kitchen and the way the girl walked and the way my son did not go back to the Danube. I had known for a month and I had done nothing, because I was fifty-two years old and I had just buried a husband and there was a daughter in the house who counted everything and a son in Rome who was being destroyed at court, and I told myself that if I did nothing the problem would resolve itself.'

'It did not resolve itself,' said Antonia.

'It resolved itself in the way that problems resolve themselves when a woman does nothing,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'My daughter resolved it.'

She had come up from Rome in the last week of March, and she had gone through the household books, and she had found the entry, and she had come to her mother and said, 'The girl must go.'

'I said yes,' said the old woman. 'I want you to hear that. I did not say, "She is a child, and your brother loves her, and she is carrying your father's grandchild." I said yes, because my daughter had a plan and the plan was tidy and I was tired.' Her hands moved on the coverlet. 'The plan was this. The girl would be sent to Puteoli, to Bassa, who was a freedwoman of the family and a midwife and who could be relied upon. She would be delivered there, quietly, in the summer. The child would be disposed of, and the girl would be manumitted and given a sum and sent away from Italy, and my son would be told that she had gone and that the child had died, and in a year he would marry and it would be over.'

'That was the plan,' said Antonia.

'That was the plan,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'And the first part of it was carried out, and the middle of it was not what I was told, and the last part of it was a lie that I helped to write.'

Marcellina had not moved.

'The middle of it,' said Antonia.

'My daughter went to Puteoli in August,' said the old woman. 'She did not tell me she was going. She told me afterwards, in September, when it was done, and she told it to me as a thing well managed: the child had been born alive, and had been sold the same day to a dealer for two hundred and forty sesterces, and had been entered in the household book at Arretium in her brother's name, and the girl had been sold to a house in Puteoli for two thousand four hundred, and a box of records at Puteoli had been paid for and lost, and everything was tidy.' Her voice was perfectly flat. 'I said to her, "Aurelia, the child is your brother's." And she said, "The child is a slave, and my brother is a man who will be consul, and there will be other children in this house who are born in wedlock and are not entered in a book as a purchase."'

Antonia sat with her hands in her lap and her heart going slowly and heavily.

'And the money,' she said. 'Four thousand sesterces was missing from the household accounts that year.'

'My daughter took the difference,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'Two thousand four hundred for the child, two thousand four hundred for the girl, and four thousand in the account of the steward, and the four thousand went into my daughter's own purse, and she called it the cost of managing the affair.' She turned her blind face. 'I found that out later. When I found it out, I said nothing, because by then she had been managing that estate for two years and my son was in Rome and there was no one else.'

'Six years later,' said Antonia, 'there was a child in your household called Tertia.'

'Yes.'

'You knew.'

'I knew from the day she came into the house,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'The steward brought me the bill of sale, as he brought me every bill of sale, and I had it read to me, and I heard the words "female child, four days, purchased at Puteoli" and I heard the name of the house of the Tarquitii on the bill and I understood everything that had happened in the space of

about four heartbeats.' She closed her eyes. 'And then I said, "Enter it in the accounts and put her with Sabbia's sister and see that she is brought up to work." Those were my words. I remember them. I have had twenty-five years to remember them.'

Marcellina made a small sound and put her hand over her mouth.

'You want to know why,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'Everybody wants to know why. My son will want to know why, and the girl will want to know why, and there is no answer that is equal to the question, so I will give you the small one.' She moved her hands on the coverlet. 'I was married at sixteen to a man of thirty-four whom I had met twice, and I came into this house with a dowry and a nurse and a set of rules, and the first rule was that nothing in this house was ever to be discussed at table. My husband was a correct man. He was correct in the Senate and correct with his tenants and correct with me, and in thirty-six years he never raised his voice to me and never once asked me what I thought about anything. I bore him three children and buried one, and I kept his accounts and his peace and his mother's memory, and in all that time the only thing I was ever permitted to decide was what was served at dinner.' She turned her blind face. 'I am not telling you this so that you will be sorry for me. I am telling you because it explains the thirteen years. When a woman has been trained for thirty years to keep the accounts and the peace, and a thing comes into the house that would destroy the accounts and the peace, she does not ask whether it is right. She asks how it may be managed. My daughter asked the same question. She asked it at twenty-nine and she asked it with a knife, and I asked it at fifty-two and I asked it with a pen, and the difference between us is only that she enjoyed it.'

'Did she?'

'She enjoyed it,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'She came back from Puteoli in September and she ate a very good dinner and she told me what she had done, and she was pleased with herself in the way that a woman is pleased when she has done a difficult thing competently. And I sat at the table and said, "You should not have taken the four thousand," and she said, "It was owed to me for the managing," and I said nothing more.' She closed her

eyes. ‘That was the whole of my resistance. One sentence about money. I did not say one word about the child.’

‘I did nothing for thirteen years,’ said the old woman. ‘I want that in the account. Thirteen years. She was in the linen and then in the kitchens and then in the villa’s office, because she could read, and she read the way her mother read, and it never once occurred to me that she was doing it in the same room in which her mother had done it. I did nothing and I said nothing and I watched her grow up in my house and I told myself that she was well fed and well treated and not beaten, and that was the whole of the mercy available in the world, and that I had done what any woman in my position would do.’

‘And then you freed her,’ said Antonia.

‘And then I freed her,’ said Tarquitia Priscilla, ‘when she was nineteen, by the council’s leave, at a cost of eleven hundred sesterces and a favour to the prefect’s wife, and I gave her four thousand sesterces and a trade and sent her to Rome, and I told her nothing.’ Her voice did not change. ‘I told her that she had been bought as an infant and that her mother was dead. I told her that in this room, with the door open, sitting where you are sitting now, and she listened to me and she was nineteen and she said, "Was she kind?" and I said, "Yes." That was the only true thing I said to her in the whole conversation, and I do not know whether it was true.’

Antonia looked at her hands.

‘And your son,’ she said. ‘What was he told?’

The second thing was a letter, and the third thing was the writing of it.

In September of that year, when the child was a month old and the girl was in the house at Puteoli and the household at Arretium was in mourning and in debt, Tarquitia Aurelia wrote to her brother in Rome.

She wrote it at the table in the tablinum in the afternoon, and she brought it to her mother and read it aloud, and asked whether it was right.

'I was in this room,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'I was in this room with a rug over my knees, exactly as I am now, and my daughter read me a letter that said that the girl had been delivered of a dead child at Puteoli and had gone, and that the household had done what was necessary, and that he was not to write to her or to speak of it again, because their father had died in the spring and the family could not survive another scandal in the same year.' She stopped. 'And I said, "It is well written. Say that the girl was paid and went willingly; it will be easier for him."'

The brazier ticked.

'That is the whole of it,' said the old woman. 'I sat in this room and I made the lie easier for him to believe. I did it because I could not think of any other way to keep the house standing, and because I had spent thirty years keeping the house standing, and because the house was the only thing I had ever been given to do.' Her blind eyes were wet. 'And he believed it, and he has believed it for twenty-five years, and he has been a man with a cupboard in his study and a letter in a strongbox and a woman in this city whom he mentions every year in the Senate without naming her, and I have watched him do it and I have said nothing, and I have told myself that the alternative was to tell him that his sister had sold his daughter, and that he would have destroyed her, and that the family would have been torn in two.' She turned her face toward Antonia. 'It is not a good reason. I have had twenty-five years and it is not a good reason. But it is the true one.'

Antonia sat on the edge of the bed with the three lamps burning and the brazier ticking and the whole of the last twenty-five years arranging itself, quietly and terribly, into a shape she could see.

'Aurelia,' she said. 'Is she alive?'

'She is at Tibur,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'She is seventy-nine, like me. She has a disease of the joints and she cannot walk and she is in a great deal of pain, and she has been in a great deal of pain for eleven years, and I have visited her once a year and I have not once in that time told her what I think of her.' She closed her eyes. 'I have not told her that I know about the four thousand sesterces. I have been waiting, I think, for a moment when it would do some good. There is no such moment. There never is. You wait

for it and it does not come and then you are seventy-eight and your son is fifty-three and there is a girl in the fourth region who counts under her breath.'

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'What do you want?' said Antonia.

The old woman was quiet for a moment.

'Two things,' she said. 'The first is small and the second is not, and I have no right to either.'

'Ask.'

'I have written a letter,' said Tarquitia Priscilla, 'to the girl. To Tertia. I wrote it in the summer, after my son came home from the bookseller's, and I have not sent it, because I am a coward and because I did not know whether she would want it, and because a letter from a blind old woman is not a thing a girl of twenty-five can refuse.' She put her hand under the pillow and brought out a folded paper. 'I am not asking you to give it to her. I am asking you to read it, and then to decide, and if you decide not to give it to her I will not ask again. It says what I have just said to you. It does not ask her for anything. It does not ask her to come to this house, and it does not ask her to forgive me, and it does not call myself her grandmother, because I have not earned the word.'

Antonia took the paper.

'And the second thing?'

'Marcellina,' said the old woman.

Marcellina looked up.

'The girl is to be married in the winter,' said Tarquitia Priscilla, 'to a boy with a great name and no money and no sense, and she is going to refuse him, and she is going to refuse him in public, and it is going to be the talk of the city for a month. I know this because I have known her since she was born and because she has been sitting on that stool for four hours without saying a word, which is what she does before she does something.' She turned her blind face toward her granddaughter. 'I want you to let her do it in your house. Not here. There will be a scene here, and her father will

say things he will regret for the rest of his life, and she will be alone in a house with a man who cannot bear to be argued with.' She turned back. 'She has nowhere to go. If she goes to my daughter at Tibur she will be eaten alive. If she goes to her nurse she will be hidden in a back room and married off in a year to a man who is worse. She will come to you, because you are the only woman she knows who has ever refused anything, and I am asking you to take her in for the winter, and to teach her the things you know, and to let her find out what she is before she is somebody's wife.'

Antonia looked at Marcellina.

'And what do you want?' she said.

Marcellina's voice was steady and her hands were not.

'I want to be in a house where nobody has a cupboard,' she said.

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At the door the old woman said, 'Cassia.'

Antonia turned.

'Tomorrow,' said Tarquitia Priscilla, 'when you stand in that basilica, they will ask you questions that have nothing to do with the boy. They will ask you what you charge, and how many men have been in your house, and whether you have ever taken money from a married man, and whether you have ever been in love. They will ask it politely, because they are senators, and it will be the same question each time, and the question is: what is she?'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'Do not answer it,' said the old woman. 'Every woman who has ever stood in that place has tried to answer it, and every one of them has lost something in the answering. Say only what is true and no more; be as dull as a ledger; make them ask the same question three times and let them hear themselves doing it.' Her blind face was turned toward the door. 'And when the advocate for the other side has finished, and the court is quiet, and they are all waiting for you to be clever — say nothing. Let the silence be theirs. You are the only person in that room who has nothing to explain, and if you can sit there for the length of a hundred heartbeats without

explaining yourself, you will have won more than the case.'

'That is good advice,' said Antonia.

'I have had twenty-five years to think of it,' said Tarquitia Priscilla, 'and no one to give it to.'

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Marcellina came with her to the door.

'I will come,' she said. 'Not tomorrow. Tomorrow you will be in a basilica and I would be one more pair of eyes on you. In three days, when the court has adjourned for the games, I will come, and I will bring nothing but a box of my own clothes, and I will be a woman of nineteen with a dowry and a name and no idea what to do with either.' She stopped in the corridor. 'Domina. May I ask you something, before you go?'

'Ask.'

'My grandmother says that you refused everything. She says you have been offered the house and the name and the quiet and you have refused all of it, and that you are going to be tried tomorrow by men who will never in their lives offer you anything.' Marcellina's hands were clenched at her sides. 'Why? Not why you refused. I understand why you refused. Why do you stay? You could have taken a ship nine years ago, or eleven, and gone somewhere with no Senate and no praetor and no man on the Palatine, and nobody would have known your name, and you would have been free in the way that nobody in Rome is free.'

Antonia looked at her.

'Because I built it,' she said. 'Every stone of it. Not the stones; the other thing. The book of contracts, and the wages, and the eleven women who can read their own contracts because I had them taught, and the fact that when a girl in this city is sold out of a house she has somewhere to go that is not a brothel and not a gutter.' She pulled her cloak around her shoulders. 'If I take a ship, all of that is a story that a man tells in a tavern about a rich woman who ran away. If I stay and I am tried and I win, then it is a thing that happened in Rome, in a basilica, in front of the Senate, and for twenty years every woman in this city who is told that she cannot will be able to

say, "Antonia Cassia did."' She opened the door. 'That is worth more than Massilia. It is worth more than the house. And it is the only thing I have ever owned that nobody gave me.'

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Antonia walked home at the fourth hour with the letter in her sleeve and the sky beginning to grey over the roofs, and Brennus behind her, and the streets full of the first carts and the first slaves and the first of the city's morning.

The house was awake when she came in. Myrrhine had the lamps lit and the water hot and the good dress laid out, and Cinnamus had the tablets in their bundles and Tertia's summary in the fair copy with a ribbon on it, and Meno had swept the step and the doorkeeper's bench was clean.

Antonia stood in the tablinum and looked at the four bundles on the table.

'Well?' said Myrrhine.

'There was a letter,' said Antonia. 'Written in September by a woman of seventy-nine and read aloud to her mother, and the mother said, "Say that the girl was paid and went willingly; it will be easier for him to believe."' She sat down. 'It was not the man on the Palatine who sold me. It was his sister, who is dying by inches at Tibur, and I am almost sorry that she is, because I have spent twenty-five years hating a man and it turns out that the man was only a fool and a coward and his sister was the one with the knife.'

'And does that help?' said Myrrhine.

'No,' said Antonia. 'It does not help at all.' She looked at the window. 'But I know now. And in an hour I am going to stand up in a basilica and be tried by men whose fathers bought and sold people like me, and I am going to be defended by a man who was told that his daughter died and believed it for twenty-five years, and I am going to know, while they are speaking, exactly what all of it was, and nobody in that room will know that I know.' She stood. 'Bring me water. And Myrrhine — after today,

whatever happens, I want the household in the garden at the ninth hour, all of them, and I want to tell them myself.'

'Tell them what?'

'That the house is closing,' said Antonia, 'and that every one of them will have a deed, a sum, and a trade, and that it will be done properly and in writing and in front of witnesses, and that it will be the last thing I do as the woman who owns this house.' She picked up the bundles. 'And then I am going to go and be tried for my life, and I would like to have it done first, so that if they convict me they will know that I had already started giving it away.'

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Prosecution

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The court sat in the Basilica Julia, in the great hall on the south side, and by the second hour of the morning there were three thousand people in it and around it.

The hall was a hundred and one paces long and half as wide, with a floor of marble in a pattern of squares and two rows of pillars down the sides and a roof so high that the noise of the crowd went up into it and came back down as a low roar. The judges sat on a raised platform at the eastern end: twenty-two men, all of consular or praetorian rank, in their broad stripes, and behind them the presiding magistrate's chair and the standards of the court. The advocates had a space in front of the platform with two tables and a rail. The witnesses would stand in the space between the rail and the platform, in full view of everybody, which was the point.

The rest of the hall was the city.

Antonia came in at the second hour through the crowd at the western door, and the sound changed as she came: not a roar, but a kind of hiss and shift, thousands of people turning to look at one woman in a dark blue dress with her hair pinned up and a bundle of tablets under her arm.

'Do not look at them,' said Cinnamus, at her shoulder. 'Do not look at anyone. Look at the platform, walk to the table, stand still, and put the bundle down.'

'I have been in courts before.'

'Not like this.'

He was right. She had been in courts four times in eleven years, in the matter of a debt, and once as a witness in a will case, and each time she had been one of eleven people in a small room with a magistrate's clerk and a bad smell. This was a different animal entirely. This was the city, in a hall, arranged in rows, in which every man who had ever come to her house and

paid her money was now sitting and looking at her with an expression that said: *whatever happens to her, it was not me.*

She walked to the table and put the bundle down and stood still.

Tarquitius was already there, with two juniors and a freedman clerk, and he was in the plain white toga of a man who does not need to be noticed, and he did not look at her. On the other side of the rail, at the prosecution's table, Marcus Sestius Verus was arranging his tablets with great care, and beside him were two men: a young orator named Scaevola, who had made his name that year by prosecuting a provincial governor, and a thin, grey, careful man of sixty who was the family's jurist, and who had drafted the charge.

In the front row of the spectators, on the left, there was a woman in a green dress: Vibia Lucana, with her hands folded and her face quite still.

In the second row, behind the prosecution's table, in a plain grey dress, there was a woman of nineteen who had no business being there at all, and who had come anyway, and who was sitting with her hands in her lap and her chin up: Marcellina.

In the gallery above, where the clerks and the copyists and the advocates' slaves were, Tertia Vipsania was sitting with a stylus behind her ear and her box of tablets on her knee.

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The charge was read at the third hour.

It took a quarter of an hour. It alleged that Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, of the fifth region, had on the nineteenth day of August caused to be administered to Marcus Sestius Cirrus, a Roman citizen of the senatorial order, a noxious substance; that the same Marcus Sestius Cirrus had died thereof in her house on the following morning; that she had, with malice, secreted the woman who had been present at the death, in order to prevent examination; that her house was a place of habitual vice and the resort of men of rank who were there plied with wine and separated from their fortunes; and that by these acts she had offended against the peace of the city and the dignity of the Roman people.

There were eleven clauses, and by the seventh the crowd had begun to mutter, and by the eleventh it had gone quiet.

Then Sestius rose.

He was fifty-eight and he had been a pleader for thirty years, and he had something that Antonia had not expected and that she should have expected: he was good. He did not shout. He began with his son.

He began with a boy of six learning to ride in the fields at his mother's house at Tusculum; with a boy of twelve who had been beaten for lying and had come to his father afterwards to say that the beating had been just; with a boy of seventeen who had gone to the Danube with the army and had written home eleven letters, and he read out two of them, and they were ordinary and young and full of weather and horses and the price of wine, and by the end of them there were men in the second row who were crying, and the whole vast hall had gone still.

You will hear, said Sestius, *that my son died of his own foolishness. You will hear that he bought a box in the Forum from a man with a monkey. I do not deny that a box was bought. I say to you: where does a boy of twenty-two buy a box of Spanish fly? In the Forum, from a man with a monkey, in the afternoon, in the sight of the whole city, because for twenty years the whole city has been selling such things, in shops, in taverns, in houses with painted doors and fountains in the courtyard, and we have said nothing, because the men who go into those houses are men of rank, and we have not wished to know.*

And when the boy is dead, and his father goes to that house at the ninth hour, what does he find? He finds a woman who has had the body laid out for him, with a lamp at the head, and who has already sent the woman who was in the room away in a closed carriage before dawn. He finds a physician who has been in her pay for eleven years. He finds a household of nineteen people, every one of whom is hers, body and soul, who have been rehearsed. And he finds that he is a praetor of Rome, and that he cannot do anything at all, because the law requires him to bring a charge and to prove it, and the woman has been in this city for more than a decade and knows precisely what can be proved.

So he brings the charge. And I say to you, judges, that when you have heard it, you will not be asked to decide whether my son was a fool. He was twenty-two years old and he was drunk and he was a fool, and I will not have him defended by lies. He is dead, and he will be dead whatever you decide, and I have buried him in the ground outside the Colline gate in a stone that I paid for, and I do not want revenge.

What I want is for this court to say, once, in public, in the sight of the city, that a house in which a Roman citizen can die in the night and have his death arranged by a woman before breakfast is not a lawful business, whatever its accounts may say.

He sat down.

The hall was silent for the length of about ten heartbeats, and then the noise came up, and the presiding magistrate had to call for order twice.

'He is better than I thought,' said Tarquitius, without turning his head. 'He will not win on the law. He is not trying to win on the law.'

'What is he trying to win on?'

'The gallery,' said Tarquitius. 'Look at the fourth row. There are eleven men there who have been in your house and who are now afraid that they will be named. They will not vote to convict you. But they will vote to close the house, and they will call it a compromise, and they will go home and tell their wives that they have done justice.' He turned a tablet over. 'The woman. Berenice. Where is she?'

'At a farm above Tibur.'

'She will be produced,' said Tarquitius, 'this afternoon. Sestius has had men in the valley for a month and he has not produced her because he wanted to produce her here, in front of the city, after that speech, when the hall is full and everyone has been crying. When she comes in, she will be frightened, and she will contradict herself, and it will be the best thing that happens to us all day, and it will feel like the worst thing in the world.'

At the fourth hour the court broke for a quarter of an hour, and Antonia was taken by her own people into the portico at the back of the

hall, where the advocates' clients waited, and given water, and told by Cinnamus that she had not eaten since the previous evening and that she would eat now or he would have her carried out.

She ate bread. She could not taste it.

The portico was full of people who wanted to be seen to be near her without being seen to speak to her. Two men of equestrian rank who had been to her house eleven times between them walked past within three feet and looked at the wall. A woman in a great deal of jewellery came up and took her hand and said, 'My dear, you are magnificent, and the whole city is with you,' and was gone before Antonia could reply, and Vibia Lucana, standing at her elbow, said:

'That was Aufidia Severa's cousin. She has never spoken to you in her life and she will not speak to you in a year's time if you are convicted.' She took the bread out of Antonia's hand and ate a piece of it herself. 'How are you?'

'I am watching the judges.'

'They are watching you.'

'The fourth man on the left and the seventh on the right are with me,' said Antonia. 'The fourth because I lent his brother money in the sixth year and never asked for it back. The seventh because he came to my house nine times and he is terrified that I will remember. The presiding magistrate is against me; he is a friend of Sestius's father and he has decided that the case is a scandal that must be closed quickly, whichever way. And the old man at the end of the second row, the one who has not looked at anything but his own hands since the third hour —'

'Yes?'

'He is the one who will decide,' said Antonia. 'He is not afraid of me and he owes me nothing and he has not enjoyed one minute of this morning. He is the only man on that platform who is thinking about the law.'

'And that is good?'

'That is very good,' said Antonia. 'The law is on my side. It is the men who are not.'

Vibia was quiet for a moment.

'Antonia,' she said. 'The thing I told you I would ask for one day. The unwise thing.'

'Not now.'

'No,' said Vibia. 'Not now. But I have decided what it is, and I am telling you so that you have something to think about in there besides the boy.' She folded her arms. 'When it is over — whichever way it goes — I am going to leave Rome. I am going to Ostia, and I am going to buy a house with a courtyard, and I am going to keep the shipping office open, and I am going to be a widow of forty-five who is not in anybody's family and does not go to anybody's dinners. And I want you to come and eat with me once a month, and I want you to bring the women who have nowhere to go, and I want us to be two old women in a courtyard who are not respectable and do not care.' She looked at Antonia. 'That is my unwise thing. I have been thinking about it since August.'

'Why is that unwise?'

'Because in this city a woman alone is a scandal and a woman alone with a house full of women is a brothel,' said Vibia, 'and I have been respectable all my life, and I am going to give it up at forty-five for a courtyard in Ostia and the company of a woman who has been tried for murder.' She smiled. 'Tell me in three days. Go back in there and be dull and truthful and make them ask the same question three times.'

The witnesses began at the fifth hour.

The praetor's physician was first. He was a thin, prosperous man named Hermes, with a Greek manner and a bad memory, and he testified that he had been called to the house at the seventh hour of the morning and had found the deceased already cold, that the countenance was congested, the tongue swollen, the pupils wide, and that in his opinion — his considered opinion, formed over thirty years — the deceased had died of a vegetable poison administered in wine.

'Which vegetable?' said Tarquitius.

'I beg your pardon?'

'You have said a vegetable poison. I am asking which vegetable.'

'I am not a cook,' said Hermes. 'There are a great many substances.'

'Name one.'

'Henbane,' said Hermes. 'Hemlock. The juice of the poppy in quantity. There are a great many.'

'Have you ever seen a man die of henbane?'

'I have seen men die of a great many things.'

'Have you ever seen a man die of Spanish fly?'

The physician was silent.

'Take your time,' said Tarquitius. 'You have thirty years.'

'I have not,' said Hermes.

'You have not seen a man die of Spanish fly. Have you read Galen on the subject?'

'I have read Galen.'

'Then you will recall that Galen describes the symptoms of cantharides poisoning as congestion of the face, swelling of the tongue, dilatation of the pupils, and death by convulsion within twelve hours of ingestion, which is precisely the description you have just given this court of a vegetable poison.' Tarquitius did not raise his voice. 'You will also recall that Galen notes that the same symptoms follow a blow to the head, a seizure, and a great many fevers, and that a physician who has not examined the stomach cannot tell one from another. Did you examine the stomach?'

'It was not permitted. The body had been taken by the family.'

'The body had been taken by the family,' said Tarquitius, 'at the request of the praetor, who is the prosecutor, three hours after the death, and before any magistrate had been informed. So we have a physician who did not examine the stomach, giving an opinion of poison, on a body removed by the prosecutor's household, in a case brought by the prosecutor, and I am asked to believe that this is an inquiry into the facts.' He turned to the judges. 'I have no more questions for this witness.'

The second witness was Meno.

He came up the hall in his good tunic with his stick, sixty-eight years old, a Thracian, with a scar through one eyebrow, and he stood in front of twenty-two consulars without any appearance of being impressed by them.

He testified to the hour of Cirrus's arrival, the condition he was in, the two friends, the litter, the four bearers, the fact that one of the friends had been sick in the street. He testified that the young man had been brought into the atrium and had sat down on the floor. He testified that he had been carried to the small room and laid on the couch, that a man had been placed at the door, that the slave of the deceased had chosen to stay the night, and that the door had been open.

'Was the door open all night?' said Scaevola, for the prosecution.

'It was open when I looked at the second hour and it was open when I looked at the fourth.'

'And who was in the room?'

'Prima, of this house, was in the room at the second hour. The woman Berenice came in at some point after that; I did not see her come, because I was at the gate. The physician came at the fifth hour and the master's son was dead at the sixth.'

'Did you see the woman Berenice leave the house?'

'I did not.'

'Did you see a carriage?'

'I saw a carriage at the garden door at the first hour, and I was told it was for the physician's sister, and I did not ask, because I am a doorkeeper and not a magistrate.'

There was laughter in the gallery, and the magistrate called for order, and Scaevola said, 'The doorkeeper of this house is a witty man,' and Meno said, 'I am an old man who has been at a gate for nine years and has learned that the less he asks the longer he lives,' and there was more laughter, and Antonia sat at the table with her hands folded and thought: he is doing it for me, he is making them like him, and he has no idea what he is doing and it is working.

The third witness was Prima.

She came up the hall in a plain dress with her hair pinned and her hands at her sides and she did not look at Antonia at all. She gave her name, her age, her condition — a freedwoman of this house, freed in the eighth year of the reign — and her occupation, which she gave as *of this household*, and when Scaevola pressed her she said, 'I am a woman of this house. You know what that means. I will not use a prettier word for your convenience.'

'Very well. On the night in question, were you in the room with the deceased?'

'I was. From the second hour until the fourth.'

'What did you see?'

'I saw a young man who had drunk too much and taken something he had bought in the Forum, and who was sick twice, and who could not breathe properly at the fourth hour, and who told me to go away and let him sleep.'

'Did he take anything while you were in the room?'

'He took a second dose from a bronze box. I told him not to. He told me to mind my own business and he took it.'

'Did anyone in this house give him anything?'

'No.'

'Did the accused give him anything?'

'No. She was not in the room. She came to the door at the first hour and looked in and went away.'

'And the woman Berenice?'

'She came in at the fourth hour, when I went to get water, and I did not go back, because I was tired, and because he had told me to go away, and because I had been in that room for two hours with a man who was not himself.' Prima's voice did not change. 'I sat on the bench in the passage until the fifth hour. I heard him breathing. And then I heard him stop.'

Scaevola looked at her for a moment.

'You are a freedwoman of the accused,' he said. 'You are paid wages by her. You are, in effect, her creature. Why should this court believe you?'

'You should not,' said Prima. 'You should believe the box, and the physician who says it was Spanish fly, and the shop in the Forum that sold it, and the two friends who will tell you that he bought it that afternoon and showed it to them in the street.' She turned her head and looked at Sestius for the first time. 'What you should not believe is that a boy of twenty-two can die of his own foolishness in a city that has spent twenty years selling him the foolishness and taking his money for it, and that the fault must belong to a woman with a house because it cannot belong to the men who built the market.'

There was a silence.

'You may step down,' said the magistrate.

'I have not finished,' said Prima.

'You have finished,' said Tarquitius, quietly, and she looked at him, and something passed between them, and she stepped down.

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They produced Berenice at the seventh hour, when the light was going and the lamps had been lit along the platform, and the hall was so full that men were standing on the bases of the pillars.

She came in through the western door between two of the praetor's men, and she was in a plain dress with her hair down and her hands bound in front of her, which was not necessary and which was done to be seen, and she was so frightened that she could not walk without being held.

Antonia stood up.

'Sit down,' said Tarquitius.

'They have bound her—'

'Sit down,' said Tarquitius, 'and look at the judges, and do not look at the girl, and let me do this.'

The presiding magistrate looked at the bound hands and said, 'The witness will be unbound. This is a court of the Roman people and not a market.'

They unbound her. She stood in the space between the rail and the platform with her hands at her sides and her whole body shaking, and

Scaevola rose and said, 'Your name?'

'Berenice.'

'Your condition?'

'I am a slave of the household of Antonia Cassia.'

'Were you in the room with Marcus Sestius Cirrus on the night he died?'

'Yes.'

'Did you give him anything to drink?'

'Water.'

'Did you give him anything else?'

'No.'

'Did anyone in that house give him anything?'

'I do not know. I was not there.'

'Where were you?'

'I was in the room over the kitchen until the fourth hour,' said Berenice. 'And then I came down because the girl Chloe told me that he had asked for me.'

'He asked for you?'

'He asked for the singer,' said Berenice, 'and the singer was not there, and I went because I was the one who was there.'

There was a stir in the gallery.

'And what happened when you went in?'

'He was —' Berenice stopped. Her hands were shaking. 'He was like a man in a fever. He had the box in his hand and he took more of it and he tried to — he wanted — and then he could not breathe, and I got water, and I put it on his face, and he was like that for an hour, and then he stopped.' She was crying now, and she said it as though she had said it a hundred times in her head. 'I did not kill him. I did not even — he could not. He was like that and then he stopped and I thought he was asleep.'

'And then?'

'And then it was morning,' said Berenice, 'and the physician came, and the domina told me to go to Tibur in the carriage, and I went.'

'Why did she send you away?'

'Because she said that if the praetor's household found me in the house they would put me in a cell and ask me for three days what I had done to their master's son, and that a slave's truth in a cell is not evidence.' Berenice wiped her face with her wrist. 'She said I had done nothing wrong and that was why I had to go.'

The hall was silent.

Scaevola looked at her for a long moment, and then he said, 'Thank you. I have no further questions.'

And Tarquitius rose.

'Berenice,' he said. 'You have been at a farm above Tibur for eleven weeks. Who found you there?'

'The praetor's men,' said Berenice.

'How many times did they question you?'

'Four times.'

'Where?'

'In the barn,' said Berenice. 'They took me out to the barn and they asked me.'

'Did they touch you?'

She hesitated.

'Did they touch you?'

'One of them put his hand on my throat,' said Berenice, 'and said that if I did not say what they wanted he would have me sold to the mines, and that no one would ask where a slave of Antonia Cassia had gone.'

The hall came apart.

It took the magistrate a quarter of an hour to restore order, and by the time he had done it the light had gone entirely and the lamps were the only light in the hall, and the whole of the city's opinion had turned around like a weathercock, and Sestius was on his feet, and his jurist was pulling at his sleeve, and Scaevola was standing with his hands spread, saying something that nobody could hear.

'That is enough for today,' said the presiding magistrate. 'The court will adjourn until the third day from tomorrow, and the witness Berenice will be lodged in the custody of the court and not of the prosecutor, and

any man who speaks to her before the court sits again will answer to me.' He looked at the hall. 'The court will sit again on the day after the games. Until then, the city will keep the peace, and I will hear no more of this case in the streets, and any man who brings it up at dinner will find that I have a long memory and a great deal of leisure.'

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They walked out into the dark with the crowd pressing and the torches smoking, and Cinnamus had his hand under Antonia's elbow, and Brennus was in front of them with his stick, and behind them the hall was emptying slowly into the Forum.

'We have won the day,' said Tarquitius, at her shoulder. 'We have not won the case. But we have won the day.'

'They hurt her,' said Antonia.

'Yes.'

'They put their hands on her throat in a barn above Tibur, and she is nineteen, and she told them what they wanted because she is a slave and she has been told all her life that a slave's truth is not evidence, and she has been sitting in a farm kitchen for eleven weeks waiting to be found.' Antonia stopped in the middle of the crowd, and people went around her. 'And I sent her there. I put her in a carriage and I sent her to Tibur because I thought it was mercy, and it was mercy for a week, and then it was a trap, and the trap was mine.'

Tarquitius looked at her in the torchlight.

'Yes,' he said. 'It was yours. And if you had kept her in the house, they would have taken her from the house, which is worse, and if you had sent her further they would have found her anyway, because a slave has no papers and no name and no place to hide in Italy.' He took her arm, which he had never done before, and turned her toward the street. 'You did the best thing available to a woman with no power in a city with no law for her, and it failed in one particular, and she is alive, and tomorrow she will be alive, and in three days the court will sit again and I will make Scaevola explain to twenty-two consulars why his witnesses are in the habit of

putting their hands on the throats of girls in barns.' He let go of her arm. 'Go home. Sleep. And Antonia — do not go to the girl tonight. She is in the court's custody and if you are seen with her you will have undone the only good thing that happened today.'

She went home.

At the gate, Meno took her cloak and said, 'There is a woman in the garden, domina. She came at the eighth hour with a box and she says she is the daughter of the house of Tarquitius and that you told her she might come in three days and that she has decided not to wait.'

Antonia stood in her own atrium.

'And there is something else,' said Meno. 'The house on the corner of the Vicus Cyprius — the baker's, the one with the bad roof. It is on fire, domina. It started at the ninth hour and the watch are there, and the wind is from the north.'

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The fire took the baker's shop and the two tenements behind it and the roof of the wineshop on the corner, and it did not take the Golden Vine, because the wind turned at the second hour of the night and because Brennus and Meno and every man in the house had been on the roof for three hours with wet cloths and buckets, beating out the sparks as they came over.

Antonia stood in the street with her household around her.

It was the first time she had ever seen the whole of the house from the outside at night, and it looked smaller than she had imagined, and more beautiful: the lamps in the peristyle, the fig tree over the wall, the dark cypress at the corner of the garden, and over all of it the orange light from the burning block and the sparks going up and across like a swarm of insects.

The whole street was out. The neighbours were out with their own buckets and their own families; the woman who sold chickpeas was sitting on a chest in the middle of the road with her cat in her lap, weeping; the vigiles had formed a chain from the fountain and were passing buckets

hand to hand, and one of them was shouting at a man in a senator's tunic to get out of the way, and the man in the senator's tunic was shouting back.

'Three houses,' said Cinnamus, at her elbow. 'Four. It will not cross the road; there is a gap.'

'Are they all out?'

'All out. There is an old man on a mattress in the road and a woman with a baby, and the wineshop keeper has lost everything and is standing in the street with a jug in his hand, which is the only thing he saved.'

Antonia looked at the fire.

'Go and tell the vigiles that there is water in my cistern and that they may have all of it, and that there is wine for the men, and bread, and that they are to come into the courtyard and take what they need and not ask.' She turned. 'And Cinnamus. When it is out, find the wineshop keeper and the baker and the woman with the baby and bring them to me. Not tomorrow. Tonight. They will need a room and a floor and something hot, and there are eleven empty rooms in this house because women have been going home to their mothers and their sisters all month, and it will be a great deal easier for me to be tried for keeping a disorderly house if the house has a baker's family in it.'

Cinnamus wrote it down.

'Domina,' he said, 'there is a woman in the garden.'

'I know.'

'She has been there for two hours. She came out into the street when the fire started and she has been helping with the buckets; she was on the roof with Brennus at the first hour in her good dress.' He paused. 'She is nineteen years old and she has nowhere to go, and her father will be at the court tomorrow and will see her, and the whole city will know by the afternoon that the daughter of Tarquitius Priscus is living in a brothel.'

'Then I will have to be acquitted,' said Antonia, 'so that she is living in a house.'

She went in through the garden door and across the wet courtyard, where the household was coming back in ones and twos with their clothes

black with smoke, and through the peristyle, and into the small room off the library where a girl with a box of clothes was sitting on a stool with her hands in her lap.

Marcellina's face and hands were black with soot. She had lost one of her sandals. She stood up when Antonia came in.

'I could not wait three days,' she said.

'I know.'

'I have left a letter for my father on the table in his study, and it says that I have refused the betrothal and that I am not coming back, and that he may keep the dowry because I will not need it.' Her chin was up and her hands were shaking. 'And I have been on your roof with a bucket for two hours, and I have never done anything with my hands in my life, and I found that I was good at it.'

Antonia looked at her for a long moment.

'You will sleep in the room at the top of the west wing,' she said. 'It has no window and a good lock. In the morning you will wash, and I will find you a dress that is not a senator's daughter's dress, and you will come to the court with me and sit in the gallery with the copyists, and you will watch, and you will say nothing, and when it is over you and I are going to have a conversation about what a woman of nineteen with no dowry and a great name can do in this city.' She turned to go. 'And Marcellina. The letter to your father. Did you sign it?'

'Yes.'

'Then he knows,' said Antonia. 'And a man who knows is a man who will act, and by the morning he will have decided what to do about it, and whatever he decides, it will be done in public, because he is that kind of man.' She stopped in the doorway. 'We have three days until the court sits again and the whole of the city is watching. Try to sleep. I will not be able to.'

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Defence

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The games lasted three days, and the whole city went to them, and the case was the thing that everyone discussed in the intervals.

Antonia did not go to the games. She spent the three days in the house with the shutters open and the doors unlocked and the baker's family in the west wing, and she did four things.

The first was to find the man with the monkey.

Hilarus found him in a day and a half: a small, quick, frightened man named Scylax who sold cures and amulets and boxes of things in the Forum from a tray, and who had sold a bronze box with a lotus on the lid to a young man in a good tunic on the afternoon of the nineteenth of August for eleven sesterces and had told him exactly how much to take and had told him, twice, that more than that would kill him.

He had also, being a careful man in a careless trade, kept the nine sesterces separate, because they were the largest single sale he had made that month, and he remembered the young man, and he remembered the two friends, and he remembered that one of them had laughed and said, *he will not need it, he has no trouble in that direction.*

'Will he say that in court?' said Antonia.

'He will say it for four hundred sesterces and a guarantee that he is not prosecuted for selling a noxious substance,' said Hilarus, 'and I have given him both, and he has signed a statement, and he is frightened enough to be honest, which is the best combination available in a witness.'

In the intervals of all this, the city went to the games.

Myrrhine brought back the reports, because Myrrhine went, on the second day, with two of the women and a basket of food, and came home at the ninth hour with her ears ringing and her opinions sharpened.

'They are selling dolls of you,' she said. 'In the portico of Pompey. Little clay figures with a house on the base, and you can take the roof off. Eleven sesterces, and the man has sold four hundred.'

'What do I look like?'

'You look like a woman with a large nose and a key in her hand, and there is a scroll under your arm that says VIRTUS on it, which I think is meant kindly.' Myrrhine sat down and took off her sandals. 'The talk in the crowd is that you poisoned the boy and that you will be acquitted because you have half the Senate in your book, which is not true, and because you are the emperor's mistress, which is not true either, and one man near me said that you had been a gladiator. I did not correct him.'

'Why not?'

'Because he was enjoying himself,' said Myrrhine, 'and because the truth is going to be in the Acta tomorrow and he can read it then, and because I have discovered in the last four days that I do not care what the city thinks of you, and that this is a great relief, and that I should have discovered it years ago.' She rubbed her feet. 'The chariot racing was very good. There was a crash at the second turn and a man was killed and the whole crowd stood up at once. I have never seen anything like it and I do not want to see it again.'

The baker's family stayed in the west wing for four days.

The baker was called Gaius and he was fifty and he had lost his shop and his oven and his stock and he cried on the first night and then stopped and spent the next three days doing things: he mended the hinge on the garden door, which had been broken for nine years and which Meno had sworn was beyond repair, and he built a new frame for the kitchen fire, and he made bread in the house's oven for the whole household every morning at the fourth hour, and by the third day the entire house had rearranged itself around the fact that there was fresh bread at the fourth hour.

On the last morning Antonia found him in the courtyard with a bag of tools.

'I have no money to pay you,' he said. 'I had eleven sesterces and they went in the fire. So I am paying in work, and I will go on paying in work

until the shop is rebuilt, and the whole street knows I am in your house, so the whole street knows that you took us in, and that is worth more than money to you at the moment, and I am not a fool and I know it.'

'You are not a fool,' said Antonia.

'I am a baker,' said Gaius, 'and I have been in this street for twenty-two years and I have watched your house for all of it, and I have said things about it in the wineshop that I am not proud of.' He put the bag down. 'And when my shop burned, your doorkeeper was the first man in the street with a bucket, and your women carried water for three hours in their good clothes, and I have been trying to work out ever since what I am going to say to the wineshop keeper, and I have decided that I will say that I was wrong, and that I do not know what goes on in that house, and that they took my family in when nobody else did.'

The second thing was that she wrote out, in her own hand, on eleven tablets in a fair copy, the whole account of her life from the day she was sold at Puteoli to the day she opened the house on the Esquiline, including the parts that no one in Rome had ever heard, and gave it to Tarquitius.

He read it in the study on the second night of the games, with the lamp between them and the shutters open and the noise of the city coming in.

At the end he put it down and sat for a while without speaking.

'You are going to put me in the box,' he said.

'I am going to put myself in the box,' said Antonia. 'You are going to ask me questions.'

'They will destroy you.'

'They will try.'

He turned the tablets over.

'You have written here that you were sold for two thousand four hundred sesterces. You have written that you were in the house of Caesonius Verus for six years and that you bought your freedom with a hundred and ten thousand. You have written the name of the man who bought you and the name of the woman who delivered you and the name

of the house.' He looked up. 'You have not written the name of the father of your child.'

'No.'

'Why not?'

'Because it is not my secret to give away,' said Antonia, 'and because in three days you are going to stand in that court and be asked whether you have ever been in my house, and you will say no, and it will be true, and it will be the last true thing you say in this case that costs you anything.' She met his eyes. 'If I put your name in that box, the whole of it comes out — the villa at Arretium, your father, your sister, the child, the bill of sale. You will be destroyed and so will your mother and so, most of all, will Tertia, who has not agreed to any of it and who will be sitting in the gallery with a stylus behind her ear while the whole city learns what she is.'

Tarquitius sat back.

'I have thought about that for four months,' he said. 'I have thought about nothing else. Do you know what I have concluded?'

'Tell me.'

'That the truth is not a thing that can be kept in a cupboard,' said Tarquitius, 'and that if I stand up in that court and defend you as a woman of business whose house is a lawful business, and if I am clever and fortunate and we are acquitted, then I will have spent the whole of it — my name, my mother's silence, my daughter's marriage, your twenty-five years — to obtain a verdict that says that Antonia Cassia is a woman of business.' He put his hand flat on the tablets. 'And it will be a lie. Not the verdict. The frame. I will have defended the wrong woman. I will have defended the woman they can tolerate, and the woman they cannot tolerate is the one who is actually standing there, and if I do that, then all of it — the villa, the linen room, the child, all of it — will have been for nothing at all.'

'What are you saying?'

'I am saying that I am going to ask you the question,' said Tarquitius, 'and you are going to answer it, and whatever happens after that, happens.'

The court sat again on the fourth day after the games, and the hall was fuller than before, and there were men standing in the porticoes and in the street outside, and the presiding magistrate had the doors shut at the third hour and put two cohorts of the watch at them.

Tarquitius spoke for two hours and eleven minutes.

He began with the box. He produced Scylax, who stood with his tray in his hand and his eyes on the floor and told the court what he had sold and what he had said and what the friends had said, and Scaevola cross-examined him for a quarter of an hour and got nothing but a clearer account, and at the end of it the hall was in no doubt at all that Marcus Sestius Cirrus had bought a box of Spanish fly, in the Forum, in the afternoon, from a man with a monkey, in front of witnesses.

He produced the physician Pamphilus, who had been in the house for eleven years and was sixty-one and had been in the army and had no fear of consulars, and who testified that the symptoms of cantharides poisoning were as he had described them in writing on the morning of the twentieth of August, and that the praetor's physician had given an opinion of vegetable poison without examining the stomach, on a body which had been removed by the prosecutor's own household before any magistrate had been informed.

He produced the books.

Cinnamus brought them in in four boxes and set them on the table, and Tertia's fair copy of the contract book was laid before the court, and Tarquitius read out, one after another, the terms on which eleven women had bought their freedom in eleven years, and the wages paid, and the sums advanced, and the two marriages and the one return, and the manumission of Eucharis eleven days before the charge was laid.

He read out the entry for Doris, sold in June to a baker, and then bought back in July by the household of the praetor, and then he stopped.

'Judges,' he said, 'the woman Doris is not in this court. She is dead. She died on the fourth day of September in the household of the prosecutor, of

a fever, according to a physician; and she was buried on the fifth day outside the Colline gate without a stone. I cannot prove that she was killed. I have no body and no witness and no physician who will say otherwise, and I am not going to stand in this court and allege murder without evidence, because I am a jurist and because it would be a lie.' He turned a page. 'But I will say this. She was bought back by the man who is prosecuting this case, and she was in his house for six weeks, and she died there, and no one has explained why a household that had bought a woman for her evidence buried her in an unmarked grave in five days. The court may make of it what it wishes.'

There was a silence in the hall of a different quality from the noise of the first day.

'And the woman Berenice,' said Tarquitius, 'who was produced in this court on the first day with her hands bound, and who told you that she was taken to a barn and questioned four times and put a hand on her throat and told she would be sold to the mines — the woman Berenice is not a witness for the prosecution. She is a witness for the truth, and she was found by the prosecutor's men and frightened by the prosecutor's men, and she told the truth anyway, and I ask the court to notice that.'

He sat down.

The hall was quiet, and the presiding magistrate said, 'The court will hear the accused.'

Antonia stood up.

She had thought about what to wear for a long time, which was absurd, and she had decided in the end on the plain dark blue dress she had worn to the dedication, with no jewellery but the carnelian ring, and her hair pinned up in the way she had worn it since she was thirty.

She walked to the space between the rail and the platform, and she stood in front of twenty-two men who had all, at some point in their lives, owned another human being.

Tarquitius began.

'Your name?'

'Antonia Cassia.'

'Your condition?'

'I am a freedwoman. I was freed at Puteoli in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo, at the age of twenty-two, by the heir of the man who had owned me, and the manumission was registered in the town records and a copy is among the papers before this court.'

'You are the owner of a house in the fifth region, the house in which Marcus Sestius Cirrus died.'

'I am.'

'What is that house?'

Antonia looked at the judges.

'It is a house where men come,' she said. 'They come in the evening. They eat, and they drink, and they listen to music, and some of them go upstairs, and some of them do not. There are nineteen women in the house at present, of whom eleven are what the prosecution calls the business, and eight are cooks and laundresses and a physician and a doorkeeper, and one is a girl of seventeen who sings and is not for sale.' She paused. 'The men pay. The women are paid. They are paid wages, at the end of the month, in coin, and entered in a book, and they may leave when they choose and eleven of them have, and three have come back.'

'And you take a share.'

'I take a share,' said Antonia. 'It is my house. I bought it and I keep it and I pay the taxes on it, and I take a share, and I have made a considerable fortune, and I am not going to pretend in front of this court that I have not.'

'Have you ever sold a woman?'

'Twice. Once in the fourth year, to a man in Ostia at her own request and with a contract, and once in the seventh year, a woman who stole from the house, and I sold her to a baker in the fourth region because the alternative was to have her flogged and put in the street.' She looked at the judges. 'I am not going to tell this court that I am a kindly woman who has never done anything hard. I have done a great many hard things in that

house. I have turned men away and I have taken their money and I have kept the accounts honestly and I have never once sold a girl to a house worse than mine, and I have refused that four times, and one of the men I refused is sitting in the second row of this court.'

The hall stirred.

'That is a dangerous thing to say,' said Tarquitius.

'It is a true thing to say,' said Antonia, 'and I have been told by a woman of seventy-eight that I am to be dull and truthful and to say no more than is true, and I am doing my best.'

'Then tell the court how you came to this house.'

And she told them.

She told it in the flat voice she used for the accounts, and she did not hurry, and she did not once look at the gallery. She told them about the villa above the Arno, and the linen room with the green glass window, and the word *eleutheria* that she had copied onto a scrap of wood and kept in a box. She told them about the steward who had told her to ask for a paper, and about not asking. She told them about the house at Puteoli and the woman who had told her the child was dead, and about the six years and the book she had learned to keep, and about the hundred and ten thousand sesterces and the room above a laundry on the Aventine and the first thing she had bought, which was a lock.

She did not tell them about the villa's son.

When she had finished there was a silence in the hall that went on for a long time.

'You were sold,' said Tarquitius. 'At Puteoli. For two thousand four hundred sesterces.'

'I was.'

'How do you know the price?'

'Because a man came to the house with the papers when I was sixteen years old and read them out to me in the courtyard,' said Antonia, 'and I have remembered it for twenty-five years, and when I was thirty I paid a clerk four sesterces to find the record in the town books, and I have the copy.'

'Why?'

'Because I wanted to know what I had cost,' said Antonia, 'and because a woman who knows what she cost can never be told that she was given anything.'

Tarquitius was quiet for a moment. Then he said, 'Judges, I have no further questions. But there is one thing I wish to say to this court, and I will say it as the advocate for the accused and not as a witness, and the court may weigh it accordingly.'

He turned to the platform.

'Everything that has happened in this case has happened because a young man of twenty-two died in a house where he should not have been, having taken a substance he should not have been able to buy. That is a tragedy and it is not a crime, and the man who sold him the substance is in this court and has testified. The prosecution has brought this case not because the accused poisoned a boy, but because the city has decided, over twenty years, that the existence of a house like hers is a scandal, and because a praetor of Rome is a convenient man to be scandalised.'

'And I say to you that this is the oldest mistake in our law. We have a city full of men who buy and sell, and we have built an empire on the buying and selling of human beings, and the law has arranged itself, over four hundred years, so that the buying is honourable and the selling is a trade, and the woman who is bought is a scandal. She sits in this court today because she is the only person in the whole of this affair who was ever, herself, a thing for sale, and because we would rather try her than look at what that means.'

'My client is not innocent of everything. She has taken money from men for things that this court would not permit in its own household, and she has done it lawfully, in a city whose laws permit it, and she has done it better and more honestly than the men who condemn her do their own business. She is not a good woman. She is a woman who has been a slave, and who has made herself free, and who has made herself rich, and who has kept eleven other women out of the street by the only means this city left to her.'

'If you convict her, you will not be convicting a poisoner. You will be saying, in public, in the sight of this city, that a woman who was sold at sixteen and who built a house at thirty and who pays her women wages at forty is a thing that must be put down. And the whole of Rome will hear you say it, and the whole of Rome will agree with you, because the whole of Rome has been saying it for four hundred years in every transaction it has ever made.'

He sat down.

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Before she stepped down, Scaevola rose.

He was thirty-four and he had a narrow, intelligent, unhappy face, and he had spent the whole day watching the hall turn, and he knew he had lost. What he did in the next quarter of an hour was the last thing available to him, and it was not a lie, and it did more damage to him than to her.

'Domina,' he said, 'I am going to ask you four questions and I would be grateful if you would answer them as briefly as you did the advocate's.'

'Ask.'

'You have told this court that you have never poisoned anyone. Is that correct?'

'It is correct.'

'Have you ever in your life wished a man dead?'

Antonia looked at him.

'Yes,' she said.

'How many?'

'Two. The first was a man in a house at Puteoli who put out a girl's eye with a bronze lamp in my fourth year, and he died of a fever eleven months later, and I did not kill him, and I was glad.' She said it without heat. 'The second is standing at the prosecutors' table and I have wished him dead every day since the fourth of September, when a woman in his household died of a fever in five days.'

There was a noise in the hall.

'That is a very convenient answer,' said Scaevola.

'It is a true one,' said Antonia. 'I have discovered in the last four days that the two are not the same, and that this court is not used to hearing the second one spoken out loud.'

Scaevola's jaw worked.

'You have told the court about a child,' he said. 'You have told the court that you were delivered of a child at Puteoli and told that it died, and that you have spent twenty-five years believing it. Is that true?'

'It is true.'

'Have you ever — since the day you were freed, when you have had money, and house, and influence — have you ever made any attempt to find that child?'

The hall went quiet.

'No,' said Antonia.

'Why not?'

'Because I was told that she was dead and buried in a garden,' said Antonia, 'and because for twenty years I gave money every year to a wall around a piece of turned earth, and because I was a woman of thirty with a strongbox and a lock and no power at all in law, and because a midwife in a small town had told me that it was done and there was no stone and no record and I believed her.' She stopped. 'And because — this is the part that you want, advocate, and I am going to give it to you for nothing — there was a part of me that did not want to look. Because as long as she was dead I could be a woman with a sorrow, and if I looked and found that she was alive somewhere in a house like mine, I would have to be a woman who had not looked for twenty years.'

Scaevola stood very still.

'And now?' he said.

'And now I have found her,' said Antonia.

The hall came apart.

It took the magistrate four minutes, and the guard had to be called, and men in the gallery were standing on the benches, and the presiding magistrate stood up and shouted twice and then, when that did not work, sat down and waited with his hands folded until the noise had exhausted

itself, and then said, in a voice of terrible patience:

'This court is not a theatre. If there is one more demonstration I will clear the hall and sit in the empty room with the advocates and the accused, and the city may read the Acta like everybody else. The witness will not answer questions that do not relate to the charge. The court has heard enough.'

He looked at Scaevola.

'Advocate, have you anything further?'

Scaevola looked at the papers on his table for a long moment. Then he said, 'No, your honour.'

'Then we are finished for today,' said the magistrate, 'and tomorrow we vote, and I am going home, and I would like the whole of this city to consider, while it is asleep, the fact that a woman has just told the truth in a court of law and the court had to be cleared because the truth was too interesting.'

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Scaevola asked her nothing more. He stood for a moment with his tablets in his hand and looked at the platform, and then he said, 'The prosecution has no further witnesses,' and sat down beside a man who would not look at him.

The presiding magistrate looked at the court.

'The court will consider,' he said. 'Judges, we will vote in the morning. The accused will remain in the custody of her own household, on her own recognizance, and I will take a bond of one hundred thousand sesterces, and if she leaves the fifth region before the court sits I will have every one of you' — he looked at the platform — 'explain to the emperor why.'

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That night the house was quiet in a way it had not been all year.

The women had gone up to the roof because the night was warm for November, and the baker's family were asleep in the west wing, and Meno was at the gate, and Cinnamus was in the tablinum with the books, and Myrrhine was in the study with a lamp and a cup of wine she had not

touched.

Antonia went up to the room at the top of the west wing, where a girl of nineteen with soot on her hands had slept for three nights, and knocked on the door and went in.

Marcellina was awake, sitting up in bed with her arms around her knees.

'I have been thinking,' she said, 'about something my grandmother said. She said that in this family the men are magnificent in public and unanswerable in private, and the women keep the accounts and the peace and their mouths shut, and that she did it for sixty years and was never once happy.' She looked up. 'I have been in your house for three days. Nobody in this house keeps their mouth shut. The cook shouts at the atriensis. The atriensis shouts at the doorkeeper. The doorkeeper shouts at everybody and then makes the bread at the fourth hour for the baker, which he is not supposed to do, and the baker lets him, and yesterday I heard the physician tell you that you were a fool, and you said, "Yes, but I am a fool who is going to be acquitted," and he said, "Not if you keep eating nothing," and then he gave you a powder and stood over you until you took it.'

'He is sixty-one,' said Antonia. 'He has earned the right.'

'That is what I mean,' said Marcellina. 'I have been in a house for three days where a physician of sixty-one can tell the woman who owns it that she is a fool, in front of a copyist, and nobody is shocked, and the house does not fall down.' She put her chin on her knees. 'My father would not have permitted it. Not because he is cruel. Because in my father's house there is only one person who may be right at a time, and it is him, and everyone knows it, and the whole house is arranged around it, and it is the most tiring thing in the world.'

Antonia sat down on the end of the bed.

'He is not a bad man,' she said.

'I know that.'

'He is a man who was told a lie when he was thirty years old and who built a life around not looking at it,' said Antonia, 'and in the morning he

is going to stand up in that court and hear the verdict on a woman he has been told to despise, and in the afternoon the urban prefect is going to lay a document on a fire before the Senate, and by the evening the whole city is going to be talking about something else.' She looked at the girl. 'And then, in a week or a month, you are going to have to go and see him, and it will be the hardest thing you have ever done, and you will do it, and he will say something that hurts you, and you will not shout at him, because he is your father and he is fifty-three and he has lost a daughter and a marriage in the same winter, and you will say what you have to say and leave.'

'And if he will not listen?'

'Then he will not listen,' said Antonia, 'and you will have said it, and in twenty years you will not be a woman with a cupboard in her house.'

Marcellina was quiet for a moment.

'May I ask you something else?'

'Ask.'

'The woman in the gallery. The copyist with the stylus. Tertia.' She looked up. 'She was crying when you said that you had found her. And she went out at the end, before the court was cleared, and she did not come back, and nobody went after her.'

Antonia was silent.

'Is she?' said Marcellina.

'Yes.'

Marcellina nodded slowly.

'I thought so,' she said. 'She has your hands.'

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They came out into the Forum at the seventh hour of the following morning and the crowd was so thick that it took them a quarter of an hour to get from the doors to the steps.

'What will happen?' said Marcellina.

She was in the grey dress with her hair pinned and she had been in the gallery all day with a stylus, taking notes, because Antonia had told her to take notes.

‘Nobody knows,’ said Antonia.

‘You know,’ said Marcellina. ‘You have known since the first hour. I watched you. You were counting votes on your fingers under the table when Scaevola was speaking.’

Antonia looked at her.

‘Eleven to acquit,’ she said. ‘Six to convict. Five undecided, of whom three are afraid of the emperor’s opinion and two are afraid of their wives’ fathers. If the presiding magistrate does not push them, we win by four. If he pushes them, we win by one.’ She took her arm. ‘It is not the verdict that worries me. It is the morning.’

‘Why?’

‘Because in the morning, before the court sits, the urban prefect is going to lay a document before the Senate about a fire in the ninth region nine years ago,’ said Antonia, ‘and the document names the prosecutor.’

Marcellina stopped walking.

‘You did that,’ she said.

‘I did that in September,’ said Antonia, ‘and I did it because I was a woman with no power in a city with no law for her, and because I had a document in a strongbox and a man who had been cheated for six years by the man who was coming for me.’ She started walking again. ‘It will not be in this court and it will not affect this verdict. It will be in the Senate in three weeks, and there will be a prosecution, and Sestius will be ruined or he will not, and whichever it is, it will be said in the city forever that Antonia Cassia was acquitted on the day the praetor fell.’ She looked at the steps ahead. ‘That is not justice either. But it is the closest thing available, and I have been in this city for more than a decade and I have learned that the closest thing available is what a woman gets.’

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Verdict

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Before dawn, Myrrhine came into her room with a lamp and a basin and said, 'Get up. You are not going to lie there and think.'

Antonia got up.

She washed in cold water. She sat on the stool while Myrrhine pinned her hair, and the two of them were reflected in the bronze mirror, one behind the other, and Myrrhine's hands were perfectly steady and her face was the face she wore when she was frightened and had decided not to be.

'Which dress?' said Myrrhine.

'The blue.'

'The blue is unlucky. You wore it to the dedication and it rained and a man was crushed in the crowd at the gate.'

'The blue,' said Antonia, 'because it is the dress of a woman who is not asking for anything.'

Myrrhine put the pins in.

'If it goes badly,' she said, 'what happens?'

'If it goes badly I am convicted of the first charge and the penalty is exile from Italy with the loss of a third of my property, and I will not be in a cell; a woman of my rank is not put in a cell. And the second charge carries the closing of the house and the sale of the women, which would be done by the court and not by me.' Antonia looked at her hands. 'And then I would go to Massilia and you would come with me, and we would have two thirds of a fortune and no house and no name and a very quiet life, and I would spend the rest of it being a woman who was once something in Rome.'

'That is not so bad,' said Myrrhine.

'No,' said Antonia. 'That is what frightens me. It is not so bad at all. I have been lying awake for six days discovering that I could survive almost

anything, and that the only thing I could not survive is being a woman who could survive anything.' She stood up. 'Bring the tablets. And Myrrhine — if it goes badly today, there is a letter in the strongbox for you, and the strongbox is in the wall behind the second press, and the key is in the box of the four things, and I want you to open it before the magistrate's men come.'

Myrrhine's hands stopped.

'You have never told me about the box of the four things,' she said.

'No,' said Antonia. 'I am telling you now.'

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She walked to the basilica.

She could have taken a litter; Cinnamus had ordered one, and it was at the gate, and she looked at it and said, 'I will walk,' and Cinnamus said, 'Domina, it is a mile and a half,' and Antonia said, 'Then we will be late.'

They walked down the Vicus Cyprius and along the Subura and past the Argiletum and into the Forum in the grey light of a November morning, with Brennus in front and Cinnamus behind and Myrrhine at her side and eleven women of the household walking behind her in their good clothes, and the city came out to look at them.

It was not a hostile crowd. It was worse than hostile: it was curious. They stood in doorways and on steps and at the corners with their arms folded and their children in front of them and watched a woman walk down her own street to be tried, and some of them called out, and some of them said nothing, and one old woman at the corner of the Vicus Patricius said, quite loudly, to nobody in particular:

'She paid for my son's funeral.'

Antonia did not turn her head.

At the door of the basilica, the clerk of the court met her and took her through the side entrance, and in the dark passage behind the platform she stopped and put her hand against the wall.

'Domina?' said Cinnamus.

'One moment.'

She stood there with her hand on the wall for the length of about eleven heartbeats.

Then she took her hand away and went out into the hall.

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The court sat at the second hour, and the voting took until the fifth.

The procedure was this. Each of the twenty-two judges came forward in order of rank and put a tablet into the urn: a tablet marked with an A for absolution, or a C for condemnation, or, if he had not made up his mind, an N, which was not permitted by the law and which had never in the memory of the court been used, and which every man on that platform knew was the only honest answer for at least four of them.

They came forward one at a time. The hall was so quiet that the tablets could be heard going into the urn.

Antonia stood at the table with her hands folded. She did not count. She had told herself in the morning that she would not count, and she did not count for the first eleven, and then she counted the twelfth, and after that she counted every one.

She had been in the basilica for four hours. She had slept perhaps three hours in the night and had eaten because Pamphilus had stood over her. She was aware of a great many small things at once: the smell of the crowd, which was the smell of the city in November, wool and smoke and wet stone; the way the light came through the high windows and lay in bars across the marble floor; a man in the third row with a cough who had been coughing since the first hour; the fact that her left hand was cold and her right hand was not.

The fourteenth tablet went in. The fifteenth.

At the sixteenth, a man in the front rank — a consular of sixty-five, with a good name and a bad reputation — paused at the urn for a moment, turned his tablet over in his fingers, and looked at her.

Antonia looked back at him.

He put the tablet in.

At the nineteenth, Tarquitius leaned over and said, without moving his lips, 'Do not count. Whatever you are doing with your fingers, stop it.'

'I am counting.'

'Stop,' he said. 'If you are counting and you are wrong by one, you will spend the next hour of your life in a state that no woman should be in when the verdict is read, and I need you to be standing up straight when it is read, because half of them will decide how to look at you afterwards based on how you look at that moment.'

She stopped counting.

It did not help.

While the urn was carried up to the table, Antonia looked at the men who had voted.

The fourth man on the left had a brother who was still in her debt and would be for two more years, and he was looking at his hands.

The seventh on the right had been in her house nine times and had once, in the fifth year, sat in the small room by the garden for an hour and told her about his son, who was seventeen and could not read, and had wept; and he was looking at her now with an expression of pure hatred, and she understood that he had voted for absolution and that he would never forgive her for it, and that for the rest of his life he would tell a story in which she had been acquitted because she was clever and not because he had been afraid.

The old man at the end of the second row, the one who owed her nothing, was writing something on his tablet, and when he had finished he sat with it in his hand and looked at it, and Antonia thought: he has written his reason. He will keep it. In twenty years, when the whole of this is a paragraph in somebody's history, there will be an old man's tablet in a chest in a house on the Caelian with three lines on it in his own writing, and only the cockroaches will read it.

The two friends of Cirrus were in the third row, on the prosecution's side, and they had been called as witnesses on the first day and had not

helped. They looked young and ill, and one of them had been crying; not, Antonia suspected, for their friend, but because they had been in a house on the night when a boy died and had gone home and slept, and because the whole city had heard them described in the Acta as drunk, and because they were twenty-three and would be that in every room they entered for the rest of their lives.

The presiding magistrate counted the tablets himself, with two clerks, at the table in front of the platform, and it took a quarter of an hour, and then he stood up.

'Judges of this court,' he said. 'On the charge of causing the death of Marcus Sestius Cirrus by poison: thirteen for absolution, nine for condemnation. The accused is absolved.'

The hall made a sound like a wave breaking.

'On the charge of keeping a disorderly house and of corrupting the young: eleven for absolution, eleven for condemnation, and the court being equally divided, the accused is absolved by the law's presumption.'

The sound went on. Somebody in the gallery was shouting. Somebody else was crying, and it was not, Antonia thought, a woman; it was a man of about fifty in an equestrian stripe, in the fourth row, who had come to her house eleven times in six years and who was now, finally, weeping.

'Silence,' said the magistrate, without much hope. 'Silence, and hear the opinion of this court, which is not a verdict and has no force in law, and which I have been instructed to read.'

The hall quieted.

'The court observes,' he read, 'that the accused has been absolved on all charges, and that the absolution is not to be understood as an approval of the house she keeps. The court further observes that the law of this city permits such a house, that the accused has kept it with an honesty unusual in her trade, and that the evidence in this case has disclosed no crime except the sale of a noxious substance by a man who has been dealt with, and the death of a young man of good family who was, by his own act, the author of it. The court observes that the prosecution was brought in good faith by a father, and that it was conducted in a manner which this court does not

commend.' He paused. 'The court recommends that the accused close her house, not because the law requires it, but because the city has voted, in this hall, in the sight of Rome, and it is better that a woman of her ability should be occupied in some other way.'

He put the paper down.

'The court is dismissed. The accused is discharged. The bond of one hundred thousand sesterces will be returned to her household.' He looked at Antonia for the first time, directly, and he was an old man with a tired face. 'Domina. A word with you, if you please, before you go.'

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They took her into the small room behind the platform, where the magistrates robed, and the presiding magistrate sat down heavily and rubbed his face.

His name was Gnaeus Domitius Tullus and he was sixty-nine and he had been consul twenty years before, and he said, 'Sit down. There is wine; it is bad, and it is what the court provides.'

Antonia sat.

'You are going to be told a great many things in the next four days,' he said. 'You are going to be told that you have won a great victory. You are going to be told that the city is with you, and there will be a crowd in the Forum tonight, and there will be a man selling your image in clay, and in a month there will be a woman in the fourth region who will name her daughter after you, and in three years there will be a play.' He poured wine for himself and not for her. 'It is all nonsense. You have not won a victory. You have survived a case that should never have been brought, and you survived it because you are clever, and because you had the best advocate in Rome, and because the prosecutor's household killed a witness in a manner that even a Roman court could not ignore, and because eleven men on that platform have been in a house like yours and were afraid.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'Do you? Then let me tell you the part you do not know.' He put the cup down. 'The emperor has been informed of this case from the

beginning. He has read the Acta, and the charge, and he has had my report on it this morning, and he has sent me a message, which I am to deliver to you personally and not in writing.'

Antonia's hands were cold.

'What is the message?'

'That the emperor does not trouble himself with the morals of the city, which he says are a matter for the courts and the gods, and that he does not intend to make a martyr of a woman who pays her taxes and has never been convicted of anything.' The magistrate looked at her. 'And that he would be grateful if, in the spring, the house on the Esquiline were a house in which no further young men died, because he is about to begin the greatest building programme in the history of the city, and he does not intend to spend his year explaining a brothel to the Senate.'

'That is not a condition,' said Antonia.

'It is not a condition in law. It is a condition in fact.' The old man turned his cup slowly. 'You are going to close the house. I know you are; I have heard from my wife's cousin that you have been drawing up deeds for the women for a month. So I am not asking for anything. I am telling you what I know, so that you understand that the recommendation of this court was not a recommendation, and that the emperor's gratitude has a shape, and that the shape is: no more noise.'

Antonia sat in the small room with the bad wine and the smell of robes and old sweat.

'And the praetor?' she said.

'Marcus Sestius is outside this room, in the hall, and there are two men of the urban prefect's office waiting for him with a warrant in the matter of a fire in the ninth region,' said Domitius Tullus. 'I have known about that warrant since the day before yesterday. I have been sitting on that platform for six days with two pieces of paper in front of me, and I have been very careful not to let one of them fall on the other.' He stood up. 'I am sixty-nine years old and I have done a great many things in this city that I am not proud of. I am going to retire in the spring, and I am going to write a book about the law of boundaries, and no one will read it.' He went

to the door. 'Domina. For what it is worth. When you told that court what you cost, the whole hall was with you, and I was with you, and I have been in that chair for eleven years and it is the first time in my life that a witness has made me ashamed of my own household. That is all. It is not much. But I am seventy and I will not have another chance to say it to anyone.'

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They came out of the basilica at the sixth hour into a crowd that filled the whole of the Forum.

Antonia had not expected it. She had expected two hundred people and a few shouted insults. There were, she thought afterwards, perhaps eight thousand: the whole of the lower Forum and the steps and the portico of the Castors and the space in front of the Temple of Vesta, and they had been waiting since the voting began, and when she came out on the steps the noise came up like a blow.

She stood at the top of the steps with her household behind her: Cinnamus with the four boxes, Meno with his stick, Brennus, Myrrhine, Marcellina in her grey dress, nine women of the house in their good clothes, and the baker and his wife and their children, who had come because they had insisted on coming.

'What do I do?' she said.

'Nothing,' said Tarquitius at her shoulder. 'Stand still for a moment and let them look at you, and then walk down the steps and go home, and do not make a speech.'

She stood still.

The noise went on for a long time, and in it she could distinguish things: her name, chanted by a group of young men near the Arch of Tiberius; a woman's voice, high and clear, shouting something that might have been *the baker's family*; a man near the front who was shouting *whore* over and over, and being shouted down by the people around him; and a group of four men in the fourth row who were not shouting at all, but standing with their arms folded and their faces closed, watching her.

She walked down the steps.

Halfway down, a woman pushed through the crowd and put something into her hand: a small clay figure with a house on the base, and the roof coming off in her fingers. Antonia looked at it and then at the woman, who was perhaps thirty and dressed in the plain wool of a shopkeeper, and who said, 'I have one at home. I bought it on the second day. My husband said it was foolish.'

'It is foolish,' said Antonia.

'Yes,' said the woman, and then she said, 'My mother was sold twice,' and went back into the crowd.

At the bottom of the steps, at the edge of the Forum, the urban prefect's men were waiting, and they took Marcus Sestius Verus by the arm in front of three thousand people.

He did not resist. He was standing with his jurist and two of his clients, and he had been watching Antonia come down the steps, and when the men came up to him he turned and looked at them and then, over their shoulders, at her.

The crowd had gone quiet in patches.

Sestius said something to the prefect's man, quietly, and the man shook his head, and Sestius took off his own ring and gave it to his jurist, and then he walked away between the two men through the crowd, which opened for him and closed behind him and did not shout at all.

Antonia watched him go.

She had wanted this in September. She had arranged it in September, with a leather envelope and a boy from the street, and she had told herself that it was not revenge but arithmetic, and she had believed it, mostly. And now she stood at the bottom of the steps of the Basilica Julia in the middle of a crowd that had come to see her acquitted, and watched a man of fifty-eight in a good toga being taken away between two guards, and found that she felt nothing at all except a kind of enormous tiredness.

'He will be acquitted,' said Tarquitius.

'What?'

'The fire. He will be acquitted of the fire; there is no body and the contractor who signed the statement is nine years dead, and his sister's husband will not testify, and in a year he will be a man with a grudge and no office.' He was looking at the crowd. 'But he will never be praetor again, or consul, or anything at all, and every man in this city will know why, and that is worse for him than exile. You have not killed him. You have made him a man who is spoken of in the past tense.'

'Is that better?'

'It is what you did,' said Tarquitius, 'and it is done, and you will spend the rest of your life deciding whether it was worth it, and so will I.' He turned to her. 'I am going home. I have a daughter who has left a letter on my table and a mother who has not spoken to me in four days, and I have been in a basilica for six days defending a woman I have spent twenty-five years hating, and I find that I would like to sit down in a dark room.'

'You defended me,' said Antonia.

'I did.'

'Why?'

He looked at her for a long moment.

'Because you were right,' he said, 'and because I have spent my whole life being correct, and being correct is the cheapest thing in the world; it costs nothing and it earns everything and it has never once in fifty-three years required me to do anything difficult.' He pulled his toga straight. 'That is the first honest answer I have given in twenty-five years, and I am too tired to say another, and there are eleven things I have to say to you that cannot be said in the Forum. Come to the house on the Ides. Not the back door. The front gate, in the morning, with your name given to the doorkeeper.' He turned away. 'Bring the girl.'

She went up to the room at the top of the west wing before the household gathered.

The strongbox was in the wall behind the second press, and she opened it and took out the four things and put them on the table in the light of the

lamp: the ring of iron keys, too small for any door in the house; the lock of dark hair tied with a thread that had once been red; the scrap of papyrus with a name and a date in a hand that was not hers; and the small clay figure of a woman with her hands over her face.

She stood looking at them for a while.

Then she took the clay figure and put it in her sleeve, and she took the papyrus with the name and the date and the lock of hair and put them in a small box of their own, and she put the box in the chest with the piece of linen that had a cross-stitched hem and a brown stain in the corner, and she shut the chest.

The iron keys she left on the table. They had belonged to a woman in Arretium who had died in the year she was sold, and she had kept them for twenty-five years without ever knowing why, and this evening, for the first time, it seemed to her that she did know, and that the reason was not a good one, and that she was finished with it.

She went down to the garden with the keys in her hand and gave them to Cinnamus.

'What are these?'

'Keys to nothing,' said Antonia. 'Melt them down and put the bronze in the household account as a credit of eleven sesterces, and enter it in the book properly, in your own hand, with the date.'

Cinnamus looked at the keys and then at her.

'Domina,' he said, 'I have kept your books for more than a decade and I have never once entered a thing in them that I did not understand.'

'Then this will be the first,' said Antonia, 'and it will do you good. It is the only entry in that book that will ever be worth nothing at all, and every other one of them has cost somebody something.'

The house was full that night.

Not with guests. There had been no guests for a month and there would be no guests again. It was full of its own people: the eleven women who had stayed, the eight who were not the business, the baker's family,

the two men of Naso's who had come to guard the silver, Vibia Lucana, who had arrived at the ninth hour with three baskets of food and had taken over the kitchen, and Celer, who had come up from Tusculum at the news and who was standing in the peristyle looking as though he had been struck on the head.

Antonia came down at the ninth hour into the garden, where every lamp in the house had been set on the walls and on the tables, and the whole household was waiting, and she stood on the step by the fig tree with a tablet in her hand.

'I am going to read you a list,' she said.

They were quiet.

'The house closes on the Kalends of March. Not before; there is too much to do and I am not going to put nineteen people into the street in December to make a point. Between now and then, each of you will have a deed. It will be drawn by my advocate and registered in the temple of Castor and a copy will be kept by Cinnamus and a copy by you, and it will say what you are to have, and no one — not me, not a magistrate, not a creditor, not a husband — will be able to take it from you.'

She read the list.

She had worked on it for a month with Cinnamus, and it took a quarter of an hour, and she read it in the flat voice she used for the accounts, and she did not look up until she had finished.

Eucharis: the twelve thousand she had paid, returned, and the contract of the room over the garden for three years at no rent, and a letter to a household at Neapolis where a freedwoman with a harp could name her own terms.

Prima: two hundred thousand sesterces held in trust, and the house on the Aventine she had found, bought outright in her own name, with a deed that had been registered three days before, and the key, which Antonia gave her across the garden in front of everyone, and which Prima took without a word and put in her sleeve.

Chloe, who had gone and had come back in October because her sister's husband was a fool: a sum and a place in a fuller's business at Ostia.

The two cooks: a share in a cookshop near the Macellum, and the name of a man who would sell them the lease.

The laundry woman: passage to Narbo, where her brother lived, and a letter.

Meno: a cottage at Tibur belonging to Naso's cousin, and two hundred sesterces a year for life, and, because he had asked for it in September and had been told to wait, a new stick with a bronze ferrule.

Brennus: three hundred thousand sesterces, and a letter to the magistrate of Lugdunum, and the name of a man in the vigiles at Rome who would write to the governor of Gaul on his behalf, and nothing whatsoever guaranteed, because a man who has been sold away from his children nine years before cannot have them given back by a deed.

'There is a thing I should say,' said Antonia, when she had finished. 'I have been told all day that I have won. I have not won. A boy is dead, and a woman called Doris is dead, and a man I have known for eleven years was taken away in the Forum this afternoon, and I did most of it myself, and I would do most of it again, and those two sentences will be true for the rest of my life.' She looked at them. 'What I have won is this: not one of you will go out of this house in March into a place I have not chosen with you. That is all. It is not much. It is more than I had, and it is more than most women in this city will ever have, and I intend to spend the next four months making sure that not one word of it is undone.'

She put the tablet down.

'Now eat,' she said. 'Vibia has taken over the kitchen and she is a tyrant and there is a great deal of food.'

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They ate until the second hour of the night.

At the end, when the lamps were low and the children had fallen asleep on the benches and Meno was asleep sitting up with the new stick across his knees, Antonia went out to the gate to say goodbye to Vibia, and found Tertia Vipsania standing in the street with a box under her arm.

She had not been at the house since the day in court. She had not sent word. She was in her working dress with her hair pinned and her stylus behind her ear, and she had been crying, and she had stopped.

'You said the day it was over,' said Tertia.

'It is over,' said Antonia.

'I heard the verdict at the fourth hour. I was in the fourth region, in the shop, with the builder, and a man came in and told us, and the builder gave me the afternoon off, and I went and sat in my room.' Her voice was steady and her hands were not. 'And then I waited until it was dark, because I did not want to come up this hill in the daylight and have people look at me, and then I came, and I have been standing at this gate for an hour because I do not know what to say to the doorkeeper.'

'Come in,' said Antonia.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Small Room Off the Library

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They sat in the small room off the library, where a girl with a remarkable voice had slept on a stool in the spring, and where a lamp had once burned all night while a woman sat with her hands in her lap and did not write on a tablet.

There was a table, two stools, a chest, and the lamp. Antonia had had the room cleaned that afternoon and the shutters closed and a brazier brought in, and she had put the box on the table and the bill of sale beside it and the folded letter from the Palatine beside that, and then she had sat down and waited for an hour.

Tertia sat opposite her with her hands in her lap and her box of tablets on the floor by her feet, because she had brought her box, because she had come from the shop, and because she did not know what else to do with it.

'I am going to tell you all of it,' said Antonia, 'and I am going to tell it in order, and I am not going to stop in the middle to ask you whether you are all right, because you are not all right and asking would be for my comfort and not yours. If you want me to stop, say stop. If you want to leave, leave, and the door is not locked and nobody will follow you. Do you understand?'

'Yes.'

'Then I will begin with a house above the Arno in the year you were conceived,' said Antonia, 'and I will tell you the whole of it, including the parts that make me look well and the parts that do not, and at the end of it you may ask me anything and I will answer it, and I will not lie to you, not even a little, not even kindly.'

She told it.

It took an hour and a half. She told it in the flat voice she used for the accounts, because the flat voice was the only one she trusted, and she told it

in order, and she did not soften it: the linen room and the green glass window, the word *eleutheria*, the steward who told her to ask for a paper. The winter. The words *I will look after you*. The pregnancy and the eleven days in which she did not tell him. The villa in mourning and the sister from Rome and the man who came with the papers. Puteoli and Bassa and the room with the stain on the ceiling in the shape of a boot. The cry she heard and was told was the door. The turned earth at the bottom of a garden. Six years in a house with a fountain in the courtyard, and the book she learned to keep because the proprietor could not add. The hundred and ten thousand sesterces. The room above a laundry on the Aventine and the first thing she bought, which was a lock.

She told about the summer: the delator, the dealer's book, the eleven weeks. She told about Bassa dying and the paper under the tile.

When she had finished, the brazier had burned low and the lamp had been trimmed twice, and it was the second hour of the night.

Tertia had not moved.

'Show me the paper,' she said.

Antonia pushed it across the table.

Tertia picked it up and held it close to the lamp and read it four times, and Antonia watched her daughter read her own bill of sale: *a female child, age four days, of good health and no defect, for the sum of two hundred and forty sesterces; of slave condition, born of a slave woman of the household of the Tarquitii at Arretium; given the name Tertia in the household accounts, being the third such purchase of that year.*

'Two hundred and forty,' said Tertia.

'Yes.'

'That is less than the builder paid for his cart.' She put the paper down carefully, aligning it with the edge of the table. 'I have been thinking, in the shop, all afternoon,' she said, 'about what I would ask you. I made a list. I have it in my box; I wrote it on a tablet at the third hour and I have been adding to it all day. There are eleven questions on it.' She looked up. 'None of them is the question I am going to ask you now.'

'Ask it.'

'Why did you not look for me?'

Antonia sat with her hands in her lap.

'Because I was told you were dead,' she said, 'and because I believed it for twenty years, and because I have no other answer, and I know that it is not the answer you want.'

'It is the answer I expected,' said Tertia. 'I have been sitting in that shop since the sixth hour asking myself what a woman like you would say, and I made a list of the things you might say, and that was the first one.' Her voice was steady. 'And here is the thing, domina. I cannot tell whether it is true.'

'It is true.'

'You say it is true. You are a woman who has been in a court for six days and who has been acquitted, and you have spent your whole life being believed by people who did not want to believe you, and you have just told me a story in which you are the injured party in every single part of it.' She put her hands flat on the table. 'In your story, you did nothing wrong. You were fifteen and you were in love. You were sixteen and you were lied to. You were twenty-two and you bought your freedom and you were twenty-five and you built a house. Every person in your story is either a monster or a fool, and you are the only one who is neither, and I am supposed to sit here and weep and be your daughter.'

The brazier ticked.

'That is fair,' said Antonia.

'Is it?'

'It is fair and it is not the whole of it, and I am going to give you the rest now, because you have asked for the truth and not for a story, and because a woman who is told a story in which she is the injured party will spend the rest of her life being injured.' Antonia turned her cup slowly. 'I did nothing wrong when I was fifteen, and almost everything wrong afterwards. When I was twenty-two and I had money I did not go back to Arretium to look for a grave. I did not write to your father, not once, because I was told that he had ordered me sold and I was afraid. When I was twenty-six and I had a house and a strongbox, I could have paid a man

to go to Arretium and look at a grave and ask a question, and I did not, because a part of me did not want to know. When I was thirty and I was rich and I had a hundred friends in this city, I could have bought the whole of the estate at Arretium and gone through the household books, and I did not, because by then I had a position and a reputation and a house full of women who depended on me, and because looking would have cost me something.'

'What would it have cost you?'

'Everything I had built,' said Antonia. 'In this city a woman who keeps a house like mine survives by being a woman with no past. The moment I began to ask questions in Arretium, the whole of it would have come out: the villa, the son of the house, the child. It would have been in every dining room in Rome within a month, and my clients would have gone elsewhere, because a man will go to a whore but he will not go to a woman whose story he has to think about.' She looked up. 'So I did not look. For twenty years I did not look, and I told myself that it was grief, and it was not grief. It was arithmetic.'

Tertia sat very still.

'Thank you,' she said at last. 'That is the first true thing anyone has ever said to me about my own life.'

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'There is more,' said Antonia.

'Of course there is more.'

'The letter.' She pushed it across the table. 'It is from your father's mother. She is seventy-eight and blind and she lives on the Palatine, and she wrote it in the summer and gave it to me last night, and she told me that I might read it and decide whether to give it to you, and I have read it, and I am giving it to you.'

Tertia did not take it.

'My father,' she said.

'Yes.'

'You have not told me his name.'

'No,' said Antonia. 'I have told you the whole of it except his name, and I have been waiting for you to ask.'

'Why?'

'Because when I say it, everything in your life will rearrange itself, and I would like it to happen while you are looking at me and not while you are reading a letter.' Antonia put her hands on the table. 'His name is Lucius Tarquitius Priscus. He is fifty-three years old. He was consul in the year of the consulship of Nerva and Virginius Rufus. He is the curator of the public works, and in the winter he is to be a candidate for the proconsulship of Asia, and he stood up in the Basilica Julia on the sixth day of this month and defended me for two hours and eleven minutes in front of the whole of the city, and he did it knowing that it would cost him the province and probably the rest of his career, and he did it because he had discovered that the woman he was defending was the mother of his daughter.' She stopped. 'He was in that court every day. You were in the gallery every day. You have been in the same room with him for six days and neither of you knew.'

Tertia's face had gone entirely white.

'I saw him,' she said. 'I saw him — I wrote his name on my tablet, the first day, because I write down the names of everyone who speaks. Lucius Tarquitius Priscus, for the accused.' Her hands were shaking. 'I have been copying that name for nine days. It is on the charge sheet and in the Acta and at the bottom of the household register that freed me, and I have written it twenty times with my own hand and I never once —'

'No,' said Antonia. 'Nobody would. There is nothing in the world that would make you look at a name you have copied a hundred times and think: my father.'

'I have been in his household's books since I was four days old,' said Tertia. 'That is what the paper says. He owned me. He owned me for nineteen years and I never saw him, because I was at Arretium and he was in Rome, and I was a line in a book in a room I never entered.' She was very quiet. 'And when I was freed, the register said that I was freed on the instruction of Tarquitia Priscilla, and I thought: a kind old woman. I

thought: somebody in that house noticed me.'

'She noticed you on the day you arrived,' said Antonia, 'and she did nothing for thirteen years, and then she freed you and gave you four thousand sesterces and a trade and sent you to Rome, and she has been sitting in that house ever since with the knowledge of it, and she has written you a letter, and it is on that table.'

Tertia picked up the letter. She did not open it.

'What does it say?' she said.

'It says what I have just told you. It does not ask you for anything. It does not ask you to come to the house and it does not ask you to forgive her, and it does not call herself your grandmother.' Antonia looked at the folded paper. 'It is a confession, and it is the only one that anybody in that family has ever made, and she made it to me last night because she is seventy-eight and because she is afraid of dying with it. Read it or do not read it. Burn it or keep it. It is yours and nobody will ask you about it again, not her and not me.'

Tertia folded the letter and put it in the sleeve of her dress with the bill of sale.

'And the other one,' she said. 'The one who sold me.'

'She is at Tibur, and she is seventy-nine, and she is dying of a disease of the joints and in a great deal of pain. Her name is Tarquitia Aurelia and she is your father's sister. She had you sold on the day you were born and she took four thousand sesterces out of the household accounts, and she bought a house with some of it, and she has lived in it for twenty-five years, and nobody has ever asked her to explain herself.' Antonia's voice was flat. 'I am not going to tell you what to do about her. If you want to go to Tibur and stand at the foot of her bed, I will send you in my own carriage with two men. If you want her to die without ever hearing your name, that is also permitted, and it is not a sin, and I have thought about it myself for four months and I have decided that I do not want to see her face. But you are not me, and it is not my decision.'

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Tertia sat with her hands in her lap for a long time.

Then she said, 'I have eleven questions on a tablet and I am going to ask them now, and some of them are not fair, and I am going to ask them anyway.'

'Ask.'

'Was I wanted?'

'Yes.'

'By whom?'

'By me, from the moment I knew I was carrying you, and I was fifteen years old and I had no idea what a child was,' said Antonia. 'I had a plan. I worked it out in a garden at Puteoli over six weeks, and it involved a room above a shop and a lamp and a basin and the two of us, and it was a stupid plan and I have never in twenty-five years been able to think about it without wanting to put my head in my hands. But it was a plan, and it had you in it.'

'Did he want me?'

Antonia was silent for a moment.

'He wanted to do the right thing,' she said. 'Which is not the same, and it is more than most men in that position would have offered. He arranged for me to be sent to a midwife of his family's, with a trade and a sum and a manumission to be registered after the birth. He wrote to me three times. And then he was told that you and I had both died, and he believed it, and he has believed it for twenty-five years.' She stopped. 'I do not know what he would have done if he had known. Nobody will ever know. That is the thing about a lie: it does not only take away the truth. It takes away the person you would have been if you had known it.'

'Did he love you?'

'He was twenty-nine and I was fifteen,' said Antonia, 'and I loved him, and I do not know what he felt, and I am not going to invent it for him or for you. He was kind to me. He taught me to read Latin properly and he laughed when I found a hole in his argument, and he said that if I had been born a man he would have made me a jurist, and he said, "I will look after you." That is all I know. It is not enough to build a father out of, and I

would not do it if I were you.'

Tertia nodded slowly.

'When is my birthday?'

Antonia stopped.

'Nobody has ever known that,' said Tertia. 'The household at Arretium kept a day for me; the sixth day before the Kalends of October, because that is the day I was delivered to them. Sabbia kept it. When she died, nobody kept it, and for seven years I have had a day in October that is not my birthday and I have not told anyone, because when you tell somebody that you do not know your own birthday they look at you in a particular way.' She turned her cup. 'You know it.'

'I know it,' said Antonia. 'You were born on the twenty-ninth day of August, at the ninth hour of the morning, in a house on the Lucrine road at Puteoli. It was very hot. There was a bird outside the window and I remember being angry with it.' She put her hands together. 'I have kept that day for twenty-five years. I have gone to that garden every August and stood in it. This year I did not go, and she died while I was not going.'

Tertia was quiet.

'The twenty-ninth of August,' she said. 'I am a late summer child.'

'You are a late summer child.'

'It is a strange thing,' said Tertia, 'to be given a birthday in a room at the second hour of the night by a woman I have known for eleven days as my employer.' She said it without irony. 'I am going to have it recorded. In the register, when I change my name. Metrodora, freedwoman, born the twenty-ninth of August in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo.' She looked up. 'Was the bird a gull?'

'I do not know,' said Antonia. 'It was a bird, and it would not stop, and I have hated gulls for twenty-five years, which is unjust and I know it.'

'It is completely unjust,' said Tertia. 'Gulls are the most honest creatures in Puteoli; they eat what they find and they do not pretend to be anything else.' And then, quite suddenly, she laughed — one short, hard, surprised laugh, and put her hand over her mouth as though she had done something wrong, and Antonia sat in the lamplight and looked at her

daughter laughing and thought that she would remember it for the rest of her life, and that it had cost two hundred and forty sesterces and twenty-five years.

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'Do you hate him?'

'I have hated him for twenty-five years,' said Antonia. 'I hated him on a pallet in a house in Puteoli and I hated him in a basilica and I hated him every time a man in this city said his name and I had to keep my face still. And this summer I found out that the hatred was built on a letter that his sister wrote and his mother helped to compose, and I have spent four months finding out what that does to twenty-five years of hating, and the answer is: not very much. It does not give me back the years and it does not make him innocent. It just means that the man I have hated does not exist, and I have not yet decided who is standing in his place.'

'And now?'

'Now I am a woman of forty-one who is going to close her house in March,' said Antonia, 'and who has a great deal of money and no family and a trial behind her, and who has been sitting in this room for a fortnight waiting for a woman of twenty-five to come through the door and tell her what happens next.'

Tertia looked up.

'That is what I wanted to ask,' she said. 'The eleventh question. What do you want from me?'

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Antonia sat back.

'I have thought about that every day since August,' she said, 'and I am going to answer it properly, because it is the only question that matters and because I have had four months to prepare the answer and I still do not have it right.'

She turned her cup around once.

'I want you to come to dinner on the seventh day of every month. I want to know what you are reading and whether the builder pays you

properly and what you think of the new prefect. I want to be a woman of forty-one who has somebody to leave her money to. I want, when I am old and difficult, to have a person in the world who will tell me that I am being a fool, and I would like it to be you, because you are the only person I have ever met who might do it.'

'That is a great deal,' said Tertia.

'It is a great deal and it is not the answer,' said Antonia. 'The answer is that I do not want anything from you that you do not want to give, and that I am not able to say the second half of that sentence honestly, because I want it so much that I can feel it in my hands. I have been a woman who takes what she wants for twenty-five years. It is how I got the house and the money and the trial and the whole of it. And I am telling you, here, in this room, that I am not going to do it to you.' She looked at her daughter. 'So this is what I propose. You will go home tonight and you will think about it for a month, and you will not see me and I will not write to you, and if at the end of the month you want nothing to do with me, you will send me a note and I will not trouble you again. And if you want something — dinner, or money, or a name, or a woman to sit with you in a room while you decide what to do with your life — you will write and tell me what it is, and it will be yours, and there will be no conditions, and you will never have to hear the story again.'

Tertia sat with the letter in her sleeve and the bill of sale in her hand.

'A month is a long time,' she said.

'It is the shortest time I could offer you and still be honest,' said Antonia. 'Two weeks would be me hurrying you. A year would be me punishing myself, and you would be sitting in your rooms in the fourth region waiting for a woman on the Esquiline to finish being noble, and that is not fair to either of us.'

Tertia stood up.

'I am going to take the box,' she said. 'The linen. I have been thinking about it since you said it and I want to see it.'

Antonia took the chest from under the table and opened it and took out the folded cloth.

It was thin and worn and the colour of old paper, and there was a brown stain in one corner, and along the hem there was a line of small cross-stitches in dark red thread.

Tertia took it in both hands. She stood in the lamplight in the small room off the library and looked at it for a long time, and then she turned it over and found the stain with her thumb, and Antonia watched her daughter's face do something that she had no name for.

'It is very small,' said Tertia.

'You were very small.'

'I have been in this city for seven years,' said Tertia, 'and I have had a good life, and I have eleven thousand sesterces and a trade and a friend who is a midwife and a builder who is fair to me, and I have been happy in a way that most people are never happy, and I have told myself a hundred times that I did not need to know.' She folded the cloth. 'I was wrong. I have needed to know every single day of my life and I did not know it until tonight.'

She put the cloth in her box of tablets. Then she said, 'My name is not Tertia. I have been Tertia since I was four days old because I was the third child bought into a household that year. Nobody in the world has ever given me a name. I took the builder's name because that is what freedwomen do and it is not mine either.' She looked up. 'What was my mother's name? Your mother. The one who died in Baiae.'

Antonia was silent for a moment.

'Her name was Metrodora,' she said, 'and she was a Bithynian, and she was sold twice before she was twenty, and she died of a thing in the throat when I was six, and I have not said her name out loud in thirty-five years.'

Tertia nodded.

'Then that is what I will be,' she said. 'Not Cassia. Not Vipsania. Not a name out of a book. I will be Metrodora, and I will have it registered in the town records as a free woman's name, and in a hundred years there will be a woman in this city with that name on her tomb and nobody will know where it came from.'

She picked up her box, and went to the door, and turned.

'On the twenty-fourth day of December,' she said. 'The day before the Saturnalia. I will come to dinner on that day, and I will bring the woman I live with, because she is a midwife and she has been asking me questions for three days that I cannot answer, and because she will want to look at you.' She opened the door. 'And domina — I am not going to call you anything else yet. I am not being cruel. I do not have a word for you. I have been a woman with no mother for twenty-five years and I do not know what the word is, and I am not going to use one until I do.'

'That is fair,' said Antonia.

'I know it is fair,' said Tertia. 'I am trying to be fair. It is the only thing I have ever been good at.' She went out.

Antonia sat in the small room off the library for a long time after the door closed.

The brazier had gone out. The lamp was low. The chest was open and the bill of sale was gone and the letter was gone and the piece of linen was gone, and on the table there was nothing but the lamp and the cup and her own two hands.

At the fourth hour Myrrhine came in with a fresh lamp and stood in the doorway.

'Well?'

'She is going to be called Metrodora,' said Antonia, 'and she is coming to dinner on the twenty-fourth of December, and she is bringing a midwife, and she is not going to call me anything at all.'

Myrrhine came in and set the lamp down and sat on the stool opposite her.

'That is better than I expected,' she said.

'It is better than I deserved.'

'Yes,' said Myrrhine. 'It is. And in the morning you are going to get up and go to the Palatine, because he asked you to come on the Ides and bring the girl, and the girl has said she will not be called anything by anybody for a month, and you are going to have to tell him that.' She reached across and

took Antonia's hand. 'And then you are going to come home and we are going to start closing this house, and it is going to take four months and it is going to be the hardest thing you have ever done, and I am going to be here for all of it.'

Antonia looked at her.

'I am going to hold you to that,' she said.

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At the sixth hour, when the sky was beginning to grey, she went up onto the roof.

The house was quiet below her: the last of the lamps, the smell of the night's fire, the baker's boy asleep in the passage with his mouth open. She lay on the tiles in her good dress and looked at the sky, which in November is not brown but a deep, clean, cold black with actual stars in it.

She thought about a girl of fifteen in a linen room with the sun coming through green glass, who had copied a Greek word onto a scrap of wood and kept it in a box with a piece of blue glass.

She thought: in March I will be a woman of forty-two with a fortune and no house and a daughter who calls me nothing at all, and in twenty years I may be a woman of sixty-two with a daughter who calls me something, and there is no way to get from one to the other except by living every day of the twenty years.

She thought about the words *I will look after you*, which she had believed in a corridor in November when she was fifteen, and which had turned out to mean a cart at the fourth hour of the morning and a piece of bread from a kitchen woman who wept.

And then, because she was a woman who had been in business for eleven years and because her mind had a way of going back to the accounts, she thought about the men who had been standing at the corner of the street for four days.

She had noticed them on the second day. Two men, then three, then four, at the fountain and at the corner by the wineshop, in the plain tunics of men who did not wish to be noticed, and they were not the prefect's

men, because the prefect's men wore a badge, and they were not thieves, because thieves do not stand in the same place for four days.

She had told Meno. Meno had told Brennus. They had put a second bar on the garden door and taken turns at the gate.

In the morning she would have to decide what to do about it, and in the morning she was going to the Palatine to tell a man on the Ides that his daughter was going to be called Metrodora and that she would not be called anything by anybody for a month.

It would keep until the morning.

She lay on the tiles and looked at the stars until the sky began to be grey at the edge, and then she went down and slept for two hours, and dreamed of gulls.

PART FIVE

The Reckoning

CHAPTER TWENTY

Blood in the Courtyard

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The Ides of November was a cold, bright day with a wind from the north, and the house of the Tarquitii in the morning smelled of woodsmoke and the last of the roses.

Antonia went in through the front gate, in the morning, and gave her name to the doorkeeper, as she had been told to.

The doorkeeper was not the same man. He was young, and he took her name and went away and came back, and then the steward came, and the steward looked at her for a moment with an expression she could not read and said, 'He is in the garden, domina. He has been in the garden since the second hour. He does not want to be in the study.'

He was standing by the wall at the end of the peristyle with his hands behind his back, looking at a fig tree, and he turned when he heard her, and for a moment neither of them said anything at all.

'You came to the front gate,' he said.

'You told me to.'

'I did not think you would.' He gestured at the wall. 'This tree was planted by my great-grandfather. It is dying. It has been dying for eleven years and every year the gardener says it should come down and every year I say it may have one more year.' He turned. 'Where is she?'

'She is not coming.'

He stood quite still.

'She has asked for a month,' said Antonia. 'She has asked to be left alone for a month to decide what she wants, and I have promised her that she will not be written to and that I will not come to her, and I am not going to break that promise for you or for anybody. She will come to dinner at my house on the twenty-fourth of December, and she will bring the woman she lives with, and she is going to be called Metrodora, because

it was my mother's name and because she has decided that she will not have a name out of a book.'

Tarquitius put his hand out and steadied himself on the wall.

'Metrodora,' he said.

'Yes.'

'That is a slave's name.'

'It was my mother's name,' said Antonia. 'She was a Bithynian and she was sold twice before she was twenty and she died when I was six. It is a slave's name and a free woman's name and now it will be hers, and in a hundred years there will be a stone in this city with that name on it and no one will know where it came from.' She stood beside him at the wall. 'She has a list of eleven questions. She has read her own bill of sale four times. She has the cloth she was wrapped in and she has your mother's letter, and she has not read it, and she has put it in her sleeve and gone home to the fourth region to think.'

'And she knows my name.'

'She knows your name. She wrote it on a tablet on the first day of the trial, because she writes down the names of everyone who speaks.'

Tarquitius made a sound that was not quite a laugh.

'I have been in the same room with her for six days,' he said. 'I stood up in that court and I spoke for two hours and eleven minutes, and my daughter was in the gallery above my head with a stylus, writing down my name.' He turned and looked at the dying fig tree. 'What does she want?'

'At the moment, nothing from you,' said Antonia. 'She has not asked about you. She has not asked to see you. She asked me whether you had wanted her and I told her the truth, which is that you wanted to do the right thing, which is not the same as wanting a child, and that I did not know what you would have done if you had known, and that nobody would ever know.' She looked at him. 'That is more than most men in your position would be given. Do not spoil it by going to the fourth region.'

'I am not going to the fourth region,' said Tarquitius.

'Swear it.'

'I swore it in August,' he said, and turned. 'I have kept every promise I have made to you this year, and I have made four, and I am fifty-three years old and it is the only thing I have done in the whole of my life that I am not ashamed of.' He walked a few paces away and came back. 'There is a thing I have to tell you. It is not about her. It is about the Senate.'

'Tell me.'

'The province is gone. Asia. The lot was drawn in October and my name was not in the urn; the consul wrote to me to say that he had been instructed to withdraw it. The instruction came from the palace. Nothing was said about the trial and nothing was said about you, but every man in Rome knows what it means.' He said it flatly. 'The emperor does not punish a man for defending a client. He simply decides that a man who has been in a basilica for six days defending a brothel-keeper is a man who is not suitable for a province in a year when the emperor is building a forum.'

'You knew that would happen.'

'I knew it would happen in the spring, when I took the case. I did not know it would happen in this particular way, on this particular day, in a letter from a consul who has never liked me.' He looked at her. 'I am not telling you this so that you will be sorry for me. I am telling you because I am going to be a man with no province and no career and a great deal of time, and because in twenty-five years I have never once been in this position, and I find that I do not know what to do with an afternoon.'

Antonia looked at him.

'You could learn to be a father,' she said. 'You have two daughters. One is nineteen and has left your house and is living in mine. The other is twenty-five and lives above a bakery in the fourth region and has asked for a month.'

'I know,' said Tarquitius. 'That is what I have been standing in this garden thinking about since the second hour.' He put his hands behind his back. 'I am going to ask you something, and you may refuse, and if you refuse I will not ask again.'

'Ask.'

'When she comes to dinner on the twenty-fourth of December,' he said, 'will you tell her that her father asked to be at the table, and that he was told no, and that he accepted it?'

'I will tell her.'

'And will you tell her that he has written her a letter and not sent it?' He took a folded paper out of his sleeve. 'It is not a letter of explanation. I have written eleven of those and burned them; the first was in September and it was four pages and it was about me. This one is one page and it is about her. It says that she is not obliged to read it, and that if she reads it she is not obliged to answer it, and that if she answers it she may say anything at all, including that she wishes never to hear from me again, and that I will abide by it.' He held it out. 'I am not asking you to give it to her. I am asking you to have it, and to give it to her if she asks, and to burn it if she does not.'

Antonia took the letter.

'You have learned something,' she said.

'I have learned that a man of fifty-three cannot make up for twenty-five years in an afternoon,' said Tarquitius, 'and that the only thing he can do is stand in a garden and be available.' He looked at the tree. 'I am going to have it cut down in the spring. It is a great deal of trouble to keep a dying thing alive and it has been dying since my father died, and I have been keeping it out of sentiment and not out of love, and I have decided that there is a difference.'

The attack came at the second hour of the night, on the twenty-ninth day of November.

The house had been quiet for a fortnight. The men at the corner had gone after the verdict and had come back a week later, two of them, and had stood at the fountain in the way of men who are being paid by the day and are bored. Meno had counted them. Brennus had walked past them twice and had come back and said, 'They are not from the prefect's office and they are not thieves. They are hired men from the fourth region and

they are being paid too much to be standing at a fountain for a fortnight, which means somebody is waiting for something.'

'Waiting for what?'

'For us to get tired of looking at them,' said Brennus. 'A house that has been watching a corner for a fortnight stops watching it in the third week. That is when a thing happens.'

So they did not stop watching.

There were four of them. They came over the garden wall at the second hour, at the corner where the cypress was, and they came quietly, and they had a ladder and a crowbar and a jar of something that smelled of pitch, and they had not counted on a Sequani freedman of forty-four with a stick and nine years of army service and no intention of being surprised in the third week.

Antonia was in the study with Cinnamus when she heard the noise.

It was not a shout. It was a sound she had heard once before, in a street in Puteoli when she was twenty-three, and it was the sound of two bodies meeting a wall.

She was on her feet and through the door before Cinnamus had put down his stylus, and she was in the peristyle when the second sound came: a man screaming, short and high and cut off, and then the crash of something falling into the fountain.

The garden was dark and full of movement.

She saw Meno in the doorway of the kitchen court with a lamp in one hand and his stick in the other, and she saw the boy from the kitchen running with a bucket, and she saw a man on the ground by the wall with his legs moving, and she saw Brennus.

He was standing in the middle of the garden with the crowbar in his hand, and there was a man in front of him with a knife, and they were circling, and Brennus was saying something in a low steady voice that was not Latin.

Then the second man came from behind the fig tree.

Antonia saw it and could not shout in time. Brennus turned and the knife went into him under the arm and he sat down against the wall, quite

slowly, with a look of enormous surprise, and the crowbar fell out of his hand and rang on the stone.

Then everything happened at once.

Meno hit the man with the knife across the back of the head with his stick. The boy from the kitchen threw the bucket, which was full, and the water went over everyone. Prima came out of the passage by the bath with the iron bar from the garden door in both hands — she had been in the bath house, she had heard, she had taken the bar out of its brackets — and she hit the man who had come from behind the fig tree on the side of the head, once, and he went down and did not get up.

The fourth man went back over the wall.

The third man — the one who had fallen into the fountain — was on his knees in the water with his hands over his head, and Meno stood over him with the stick and did not hit him again.

'Brennus,' said Antonia.

He was sitting against the wall with his hand pressed to his side and his face grey. There was a great deal of blood, more than she had ever seen, and it was going into the gravel and into the folds of his tunic.

'Do not move him,' said Pamphilus, from the doorway, in the voice of a man who had been in the army. 'Do not move him. Get me light and cloths and the box from my room, and get that man out of the water and tie him to the gate.'

Brennus died at the fourth hour of the morning.

He was conscious for most of it. Pamphilus had put a pad on the wound and had packed it and had put his own hands on it and had said, at some point, very quietly, to Antonia, 'It is the artery under the arm. I have seen two of these. There is nothing that can be done and he knows it.'

He knew it. He had been a soldier.

They brought him into the small room by the garden and laid him on the couch — the same couch, and Antonia thought of it and could not stop thinking of it, on which a praetor's son had died in August — and the

whole household came in, one at a time, and said something to him, and he answered some of them.

Eucharis kissed his forehead. The boy from the kitchen cried and Brennus told him to stop being a fool and then said that he had done well with the bucket.

Meno sat with him for a long time and they spoke in Thracian, and Antonia, standing in the doorway, understood not one word of it, and Meno came out afterwards with his face perfectly composed and went to his gate and did not speak to anyone for two days.

At the end, when it was nearly light, Brennus said, 'Domina.'

She came and knelt by the couch.

'The letter,' he said. 'To Lugdunum. The magistrate.'

'It was sent in September,' said Antonia. 'There has been no answer. I told you that. I will not lie to you now.'

'No,' he said. 'You would not.' He was quiet for a moment. 'There is money in the box in my room. Three hundred thousand and eleven sesterces, and the eleven is for the boy from the kitchen; tell him it is for the bucket.' His hand moved on the blanket. 'And domina, there is a thing I have never told you. About the two in Lugdunum. The elder was six and the younger was three, and I have written twice a year for nine years and there has never been an answer.' He stopped. 'I have decided that no answer is an answer. I decided it in the summer, in the street, when I told you so, and I have been thinking about it ever since, and I have decided that I was wrong.'

'Brennus—'

'No,' he said. 'Listen. No answer is not an answer. No answer is nothing at all. It is a thing I made up because I could not bear to think that they had forgotten me, so I made up a rule: that silence is a kind of message, and that I could read it, and that it said they were well and had put me behind them.' His eyes were on the ceiling. 'It says nothing. It says that a man wrote two letters a year for nine years and a girl of six could not read them, and a boy of three could not read them, and their mother may be dead or may have married and may have thrown them in the fire.' He

turned his head. 'When you find them, do not tell them I decided that. Tell them I wrote.'

'I will tell them,' said Antonia. 'I will go to Lugdunum myself if I have to.'

'You will not,' said Brennus. 'You will be closing a house in March and being tried for something else in the summer.' He almost smiled. 'That is all right. I have been in this house nine years and it is the best house I have ever been in, and I have been in five, and one of them was a senator's, and I want you to know that we all say so, in the kitchen, when you are not there.'

He died at the fourth hour with his hand in hers and the sky going grey beyond the shutters.

Antonia stood in the courtyard at the fifth hour of the morning with her hands and her dress and her sleeves covered in blood, and made three decisions in the space of about four minutes.

The first was that the man Prima had killed would not be moved. He was lying where he had fallen, by the wall, with his head at an angle that was wrong, and the gravel around him was dark, and she said, 'Nobody touches him. Nobody covers him. He stays there until the prefect's men come and see him, and then he goes where they take him.'

The second was that the man they had tied to the gate would be given to the prefect's men alive, with his knife and his ladder and his jar of pitch, and that every person in the house would give a statement that day, separately, in their own words, to a clerk, and that Cinnamus would write them all out fair and no one would be coached.

The third was that she would send for the urban prefect herself, at the fifth hour of the morning, before anybody in the street had decided what had happened.

Cinnamus wrote it all down and then said, 'Domina, may I say something?'

'Say it.'

'The prefect will be here by the seventh hour. There will be a charge. A freedwoman of this house has killed a man — a free man, whatever else he was — and the law on this is not the law on a housebreaking; there will be a question of whether the force was proportionate, and there will be a question of whose house it was, and there will be a question about you.' He did not look at her hands. 'There is also a question about whether the dead man was sent by Marcus Sestius, and if he was, then the praetor's household will be in this before the ninth hour with a story of its own, and the story will be that a woman who was acquitted in November has now killed a man in her own courtyard in November.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'And Prima will be taken. Not today, perhaps; today they will take the man at the gate and the body. But in three days or five there will be a summons, and she will be charged, and a freedwoman who kills a free man in a house of that kind will not be tried by a court that is inclined to be generous, whatever happened in the basilica this month.'

'I know that too,' said Antonia, 'and that is why I am going to do the thing I am going to do, and I want you to write it down before I change my mind.'

'What thing?'

Antonia looked at the courtyard: at the body by the wall, at the ladder, at the jar of pitch, at the blood on the gravel, at the whole of the house she had built standing around her in the grey light with its doors open.

'I am going to defend her,' she said, 'in public, in the same basilica, with the same advocate, and I am going to pay for it out of my own money, and I am going to be in that court every day, sitting behind her, and every man in Rome will see me do it.'

'Domina—'

'And when it is over, whatever the verdict, I am going to give her the house on the Aventine and the two hundred thousand sesterces and a passage to anywhere in the world she wants, and I am going to tell her, in front of witnesses, that she did what I would have done and that this house is hers as much as mine.'

Cinnamus was silent.

'That is the fourth thing,' said Antonia. 'Write it down.'

The prefect's men came at the sixth hour, and the prefect himself came at the ninth, and by then the whole street was in the road.

The story was in the city by the afternoon and it was in the Acta the next morning, and it said that four men had come over the wall of the house on the Esquiline with a crowbar and a jar of pitch, and that a freedman of the household, Brennus, a Sequani, had been killed, and that one of the four had been killed by a woman of the household with an iron bar, and that a third had been taken alive and had told the prefect's clerk, before the ninth hour, the name of the man who had paid him.

It was not Marcus Sestius. It was Sestius's steward, who had been his steward for thirty years, and who was arrested at his master's house at the eleventh hour and who said, when questioned, that he had acted on his own initiative, and who would say it for the rest of his life, and who was believed by nobody at all and could not be disproved.

Marcus Sestius came to the house on the second day.

He came in the morning, alone, in a plain toga, and he stood in the atrium with his hands at his sides and said to Meno, 'I have come to pay my respects to the household of the dead man, and to say to the woman who owns this house that I did not send those men.'

Antonia came out of the study and stood in front of him.

'You did not send them,' she said.

'I did not send them.' He looked old. He had lost eleven pounds and his toga hung on him. 'I do not expect you to believe me. My steward has been with me for thirty years; he has watched my son grow up; he has been in a rage since the funeral and he has been drinking and he has said things in my own house that I should have stopped.' He swallowed. 'I did not send him. But he was my steward, and he was in my house, and he was paid with my money, and I am responsible for him in law and in everything else, and I have come here to say so in your atrium where your household can

hear it.'

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

'There is a dead man in my garden,' she said, 'who was not your son and who had never done anything to you, and he was forty-four years old and he had two children in Gaul that he had not seen in nine years, and his name was Brennus, and he was killed by a knife that was paid for with your money, and whatever you say in this atrium will not bring him back.'

'I know,' said Sestius.

'Then why are you here?'

'Because I have a daughter,' said Sestius, 'and she is twenty and she has not spoken to me since the funeral, and because in the last four months I have lost my son, my office, my name and the respect of every man I have ever known, and because there is nothing left to do but this.' He stood in the middle of her atrium. 'I am going to lay the whole of it before the urban prefect, including the fact that my steward has been drinking since August and that I knew it and did nothing, and I am going to pay for the funeral of the man Brennus and for a stone, and I am going to pay whatever the court awards to the household, and I am not asking you for anything at all.'

Antonia stood in front of him.

'He has two children in Lugdunum,' she said. 'A girl of fifteen and a boy of twelve, if they are alive. I have written twice and there has been no answer.'

Sestius looked at her.

'I have an agent in Lugdunum,' he said. 'He is a horse trader and he knows every household in the district. I will write to him today and I will send a man.'

'Why?'

'Because I have nothing left to spend my money on,' said Sestius, 'and because I would like, before I die, to have done one thing that was not about my own name.'

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They buried Brennus on the fourth day, outside the Colline gate, in the ground where the praetor's son had been buried in August, and the whole household went, and Meno carried the stick with the bronze ferrule and put it on the pyre, and the boy from the kitchen put the nine sesterces in the fold of the shroud, and Antonia stood at the edge of the ground and said nothing at all.

The household held its own mourning that night in the kitchen court, which was not a Roman funeral and had no priest and no flute player, and which was organized by the two cooks without asking anybody's permission.

They put a lamp and a cup of wine and a bowl of salt on the table where Brennus had eaten for nine years. They put his stick against the wall. The boy from the kitchen had kept the eleven sesterces and would not give them up, so they put a stone in the fold of a cloth instead, and the boy put the coins beside the stone, and the cooks said that it was not proper and let him do it.

Then they sat on the benches and told stories about him for four hours, and the stories were not respectful.

He had, it turned out, been afraid of geese. He had been afraid of geese for nine years and had never mentioned it, and the reason the household knew was that in the fourth year a goose had come into the courtyard and he had gone into the bath house and stayed there for an hour, and everyone had assumed that he was ill.

He had a way of saying *domina* that could mean yes, no, I have considered it and I decline, and it had meant all four things in a single afternoon in the seventh year.

He had never once in nine years taken a bribe at the gate, though he had been offered many, and he had told the whole household, at the Saturnalia in the sixth year, when he was drunk, that the reason was not honesty but arithmetic: a doorkeeper who takes a bribe is a doorkeeper who is owned, and he had been owned once and did not intend to be owned again.

Meno sat at the end of the bench with his stick across his knees and said nothing at all, and at the third hour he got up and went to his gate.

Antonia followed him.

He was standing in the doorway with the street beyond him and the cold coming in, and he said, without turning, 'I have been at a gate for thirty years, domina, in four houses, and I have never lost a man on my watch until now.'

'It was not your watch,' said Antonia. 'It was the garden wall, and you were at the gate, and you came when you heard.'

'I heard the first sound and I came with a lamp,' said Meno. 'If I had come with the stick and no lamp I would have been in the garden four heartbeats sooner, and four heartbeats is what it takes, and I have been standing here for an hour working it out.' He turned. 'He was twenty years younger than me and he was a soldier and he had two children and he died in the gravel, and I am sixty-eight and I have no children and I am still here, and there is no arithmetic in the world that makes that come out right.'

Antonia stood beside him in the doorway.

'What do you want to do?' she said.

'What I want,' said Meno, 'is to be at a gate in a house where nobody comes over the wall. And since there is no such house in Rome, I will stay at this one until March, and then I will go to Tibur with my cottage and my two hundred sesterces a year, and I will keep a gate there, and it will be a garden gate, and it will be very boring, and I will think about Brennus every day.' He closed the door and put the bar across it. 'That is all, domina. You may go to bed.'

Afterwards, Prima came and stood beside her.

'They will charge me in the spring,' she said.

'They will charge you in January,' said Antonia. 'I have spoken to the prefect's clerk. It will be heard in the same basilica, before a different panel, and it will be a charge of homicide, and it will be argued that you used excessive force against a man who was already on the ground.'

'Was he on the ground?'

'He was coming at you with a knife,' said Antonia, 'and there were four of them and one of them had already killed a man, and there were eleven women and a cook and a boy in this house. I do not care where he was. I care what a court can be made to see.'

Prima was quiet for a moment.

'I hit him once,' she said. 'I want you to know that. I took the bar out of the brackets and I came through the passage and I hit him once on the side of the head, and he went down and he did not get up, and I stood over him and I could have hit him again and I did not.' She looked at the ground. 'I have thought about that for four days. I did not hit him again because he was down and it would have been wrong, and I have discovered that I am a woman who does not hit a man when he is down, and I did not know that about myself, and it is the only thing I have learned from all of this that is worth anything.'

Antonia turned and looked at her.

'I am going to defend you,' she said, 'and it is going to cost me a great deal of money and the last of my reputation, and when it is over you are going to take the house on the Aventine and the money and go, and you are going to be a woman of thirty-two with a house and a deed and no past, and there will be a woman in this city who was in a brothel in the Argiletum at fifteen and killed a man in a courtyard at thirty-one and was acquitted, and she is going to be you.'

Prima looked at the pyre.

'All right,' she said.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

A House Divided

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The dinner was on the twenty-fourth of December, the day before the Saturnalia, and it was the first dinner party Antonia had given in eleven years at which nothing was for sale.

She had the small dining room done, not the great one; the one with five couches and the wall painting of the garden that was old and had been repainted twice. She had the good silver out and the ordinary wine, because the good wine would have been a statement and the ordinary wine was better anyway. She had the cook make the food that the household ate on feast days and not the food that was made for guests: a kid roasted with coriander, lentils, bread, a cheese from the country, and a honey cake.

Tertia came at the ninth hour with the woman she lived with, who was called Sabina, and who was a midwife of thirty-four with a broad face and a direct manner and a willingness to say exactly what she thought, which she demonstrated in the first quarter of an hour by looking at the mosaic in the atrium and saying, 'That is very old. You should have it lifted; there is water under this floor and in ten years the whole of it will be gone.'

'It is on the list,' said Antonia.

'What list?'

'The list of things I am going to do when I have closed the house and have nothing else to do but look after my own property,' said Antonia. 'It has eleven items on it and they are all extremely boring, and I find that I am looking forward to them more than I have looked forward to anything in years.'

They ate. It was, Antonia thought afterwards, one of the strangest evenings of her life: four women at a table — herself, Myrrhine, Tertia, Sabina — in a room that for eleven years had been the scene of a business, eating a family meal on a family feast day.

Sabina asked questions all evening and did not apologise for any of them. She asked Myrrhine how she had come to the house and what she did and whether she was paid, and Myrrhine answered all of it, and by the end of the meal the two of them were deep in a conversation about the price of linen that went on for a quarter of an hour and excluded everyone.

Tertia was quiet. She ate, and she looked at the room, and she looked at Antonia, and at the end of the honey cake she said, 'I have read the letter.'

Antonia put down her cup.

'It took me eleven days,' said Tertia. 'I carried it in my sleeve for a week and then I put it on the table in my room and looked at it for four days, and then I read it in the morning with Sabina in the room, and it is four pages long, and the first three pages are an account of what happened and the last one is about me.' She turned her cup around. 'She says that she does not ask me to come to the house, and she does not call herself my grandmother, and she says that she has written it because she is seventy-eight and does not intend to die with it. And then she says one thing that I have not been able to stop thinking about.'

'What?'

'She says that when I was four days old and she had the bill of sale read to her, she understood everything that had happened in the space of about four heartbeats, and that what she felt was not horror. It was relief. Because it was tidier.' Tertia looked up. 'She has written down the worst thing about herself. Nobody has ever done that to me before. My whole life, people have been telling me things that made them look well.'

'That is what she is,' said Antonia. 'She is a woman who has been correct for sixty years and who has discovered, at the end, that correctness is not the same as goodness, and she has written it down because she is out of time to do anything else.'

'And the other one,' said Tertia. 'At Tibur.'

'What about her?'

'I am going to go,' said Tertia. 'In January. Not to forgive her and not to shout at her. I am going to go and stand at the foot of her bed and look at her for as long as I want, and then I am going to ask her three questions,

and if she answers them I will leave, and if she does not answer them I will leave.' She pushed her plate away. 'Sabina says I should not go. She says that a dying woman in pain is the only person in the world who cannot be made to answer for anything, and that I will come away feeling as though I have been cheated.'

'You will,' said Antonia.

'I know,' said Tertia. 'I am going anyway. Because if I do not go, then in twenty years I will be a woman of forty-five who did not go, and I have had enough of my life being arranged by other people's silences.'

There was a small silence.

'Well,' said Myrrhine, 'that is the most sensible thing anyone has said at this table all evening.'

And then Tertia said, 'I have a question for you, domina, and it is not a fair one, and I am going to ask it now because it is the Saturnalia and because I have had wine.'

'Ask.'

'If I said that I wanted to be in this house,' said Tertia. 'Not as your daughter. As the woman who keeps your books, at a wage, with a room. If I said that in March, when the house closes, I wanted to be the one who closes it with you, and that I wanted to be the one who opens whatever comes next.' She met Antonia's eyes. 'What would you say?'

Antonia sat with her hands on the table.

'I would say that you should not,' she said.

'Why?'

'Because you have a place in the fourth region and eleven thousand sesterces and a name you have made for yourself, and because a woman who comes to work in the house of a woman who might be her mother will never find out whether she is any good, because everyone will be polite to her,' said Antonia. 'And because in three years, when you have decided that you hate me, you will have no way of leaving that is not also a way of leaving your mother, and I have been in that position and it is the worst position in the world.'

'That is a very careful answer,' said Tertia.

'It is a careful answer because it is the most important question anyone has asked me all year,' said Antonia. 'But there is a second half of it, and I am going to say the second half, and then you will know what kind of woman you are dealing with.' She put her cup down. 'The second half is that I would like it more than anything I can think of, and if you asked me in the spring, when I am tired and the house is empty and everything I have built is gone, I do not know whether I would be strong enough to say no to you. So the answer is: ask me now, while I am still strong, and I will say no. If you wait until March, I will say yes, and it will be the wrong yes, and you will spend the rest of your life in a house where nobody has ever been able to say no to me.'

Tertia looked at her for a long moment.

'All right,' she said. 'I will not ask in March.'

The Saturnalia itself was the last festival the house kept together, and it kept it properly.

For three days the household did what Roman households do at the Saturnalia: it pretended, with great formality, that the order of the world was reversed. The women drew lots for who would serve at table and who would sit. Meno drew the lot to sit at the head and spent the whole of the first evening in a state of profound discomfort, and then, on the second evening, discovered that he enjoyed it, and on the third became insufferable and was told so by the cook.

The baker's family came up from their new shop with eleven loaves and stayed for the day. Vibia Lucana came, and Celer, and Naso with his wife and his brothers-in-law, who had by then decided that Antonia was a very sound risk and were extremely polite to her. Marcellina presided over the household's own little ceremony of lamps and gave out the presents, and she gave Antonia a stylus with a silver case, which was the first present she had ever bought in her life with money she had earned, and she said so, and then had to leave the room.

Tertia came on the second day with Sabina and did not preside over anything and sat at the end of the table with her wine and watched the household, and at the end of the evening she said, to Antonia, in the doorway, 'They are not afraid of you.'

'No,' said Antonia.

'In my shop, the people who work for the builder are afraid of him. Not because he is cruel; because he is the one who pays. And in this house nobody is afraid of the one who pays, and one of them told you at dinner that your hair was a mess and you said thank you.' She pulled her cloak around her. 'I am not going to say that it is a good house. I have read the books and I know what it is. But it is a strange one, and I am beginning to think that strange is the best that can be said for anything in this city.'

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The trial of Prima took four days in the middle of January, in the same basilica, before a different panel of judges, and Antonia sat behind her every day.

It was not the same kind of case. There was no great speech and no crowd of eight thousand; the hall was half full and the weather was bad. The prosecution was conducted by the prefect's office, not by an injured family, and it was conducted without much enthusiasm, and the charge was homicide, and the man who had died was named Gaius Titius Saturninus and he had been a hired man with four convictions and no family and a widow in the fourth region who did not appear.

The facts were not in dispute. Meno testified to the ladder and the crowbar and the jar of pitch. Pamphilus testified to the wound that had killed Brennus. The man who had been taken alive testified, from the court's custody, to the whole of it, including the name of the man who had paid him and the sum — eleven thousand sesterces, paid in two parts, in the wineshop by the Ostian gate — and he was believed, because he was a criminal who had nothing left to gain and because he wept.

The dead man had been on the ground, and the law on that point was not simple, and the prosecutor made the most of it.

Tarquitius spoke for an hour and a half. He spoke about a house at night, and four men over a wall, and eleven women, a cook, and a boy of fifteen. He spoke about what the law permitted a householder to do in defence of a house, and about how the law had always distinguished between a killing in a courtyard and a killing in a street. He spoke about what a woman could reasonably be expected to do at the second hour of the night with an iron bar in her hands and a man with a knife in front of her, and he said that the law had been written by men who had never been in that position and that it had never once been written for the person who was.

Then he said: 'The prosecutor has asked you to consider whether the force was proportionate. I ask you to consider proportionate to what. To a man on the ground? Or to a night in which one man had already been killed in that garden, and three others were still standing?'

The court took two hours to vote.

Prima was absolved, eleven to nine, with two of the judges adding a written opinion that the case should never have been brought.

She came out of the basilica into a small crowd, not eight thousand, perhaps three hundred, and it was a different crowd from November: it was women, mostly, and not the sort of women who came to Antonia's house, but shopkeepers and the wives of artisans and a group of seven or eight who worked in the fullers' yards, and they stood at the bottom of the steps and did not cheer. They simply stood and looked at her, and one of them, an old woman with a basket on her arm, said, loudly, 'That is the one,' and they all nodded, and that was all.

Tertia went to Tibur in the third week of January, and she came back the same day, and she came to the house in the evening.

Antonia was in the study. Tertia came in with her cloak still on and sat down in the chair without being asked, which she had never done before, and said, 'I want to tell you about it and then I do not want to talk about it again.'

'Tell me.'

'The house is small and it has a garden with a wall and a fig tree. There is a nurse and a cook and a man who carries her. She is in a room at the back with the shutters open because she says the dark makes the pain worse, and she is very thin, and her hands are —' Tertia stopped. 'Her hands are the worst of it. They are turned. She cannot hold a cup and the nurse holds it for her and she hates it.'

Antonia said nothing.

'She knew who I was before I said my name,' said Tertia. 'She looked at me for a long time and she said, "You have the Tarquitius jaw and you have come to look at me." And I said, "I have come to ask you three questions." And she said, "Ask them, and then go, because I am in a great deal of pain and I cannot be looked at for long."'

'What did you ask?'

'The first was: did you know that the child was alive when you sold it? And she said yes.' Tertia's voice was steady. 'The second was: did you ever think about it afterwards? And she said, "Every day, and it has been no use to you at all, and I am not going to pretend that it has been a kind of penance, because a penance is a thing a person does for themselves."' She looked up. 'And then I asked the third one, and I had not planned it; I had planned to ask her about the four thousand sesterces, because that was on my list. But I stood at the foot of her bed and I asked her instead: "What did my mother look like?"'

Antonia's hands were cold.

'And she said, "She was small and quick and she had a way of standing in a doorway with her hands folded, and she could read, which was a nuisance, and she was in love with my brother, and I did not think about her at all. I thought about the household."' Tertia's chin was up. 'And then she said, "Do not do what I did. Whatever it is that you are going to do with your life, do the other thing." And then she told the nurse to take me out, and I went.'

'And that was all?'

'That was all,' said Tertia. 'It took a quarter of an hour. I was in that house for a quarter of an hour and I have been twenty-five years getting there.' She stood up. 'I am not going back. I am not going to her funeral and I am not going to pretend to be sorry when she dies, and I am not going to be a good and forgiving woman, and if that disappoints you then it disappoints you.'

'It does not disappoint me,' said Antonia.

'Good,' said Tertia, and went to the door, and stopped. 'She said one thing more. When I was going out. She said, "Tell my brother that I did it for the family and that I have been repaid."' She looked back. 'I am not going to tell him. I am going to tell you, and you may do what you like with it.'

The house came apart in February.

It did not come apart in a scene. Antonia had expected a scene, and there was none. It came apart in a series of ordinary mornings, in the way that houses do.

Chloe went first, to Ostia, with the deed for the fuller's business and a letter, and she cried and said she would write every month and she wrote twice.

The two cooks went to the cookshop near the Macellum, and took the boy from the kitchen with them as an apprentice, and he came back every second day for a month to see Meno and then stopped coming, which was, Antonia thought, exactly right and exactly what should have happened.

Eucharis stayed until the last week. She had found a household at Neapolis, not as a woman of the house but as a music teacher to the daughters of a shipping family, and it was, she said, either the best thing that had ever happened to her or a slow death by respectability, and she had not yet decided which. She came to Antonia's study on her last evening with the contract in her hand.

'I have read it eleven times,' she said.

'You negotiated it yourself. You wrote two of the clauses.'

'I know. I have read it nine times to see whether there was a trap in it, and there is not, and I find that I am disappointed.' Eucharis put the contract down. 'I have been in this house six years and for six years I have known exactly what I was: a woman in a house who could be sold. And now I am a free woman with a contract and a room and a wage and I am going to Neapolis to teach the daughters of a man who has never in his life had to think about what a woman costs, and I am frightened, domina. I am more frightened now than I was when I was nineteen and had nothing, because when I had nothing there was nothing to lose.'

'That is how it works,' said Antonia.

'I know it is how it works. I would like you to tell me that it is worth it.'

Antonia looked at her.

'I cannot tell you that,' she said. 'I can tell you that on the other side of the fear there is a thing that no woman in your position has ever had, which is a bad month that is your own bad month, and a good year that is your own good year. And I can tell you that in eleven years I have been frightened every single day, and that I have never once wished I had stayed in a house where somebody else owned me.' She stood up. 'And Eucharis — when you are in Neapolis and the daughters are insufferable and the family is respectable and you are bored to the edge of madness, you will write and tell me, and I will write back and tell you that I am also bored, and we will both be lying, and it will help.'

Eucharis laughed and then, unexpectedly, put her arms around her, and Antonia stood in her own study being embraced by a freedwoman of twenty-six and did not know what to do with her hands.

Marcellina went to see her father on the eleventh day of February.

She had been in the house since November. She had worked in it: she had done the accounts with Cinnamus, and learned to keep the book, and stood behind Antonia in the basilica four days in January with a stylus and a tablet. She had also, in the way of a girl of nineteen who has never had a job, been extremely annoying; she had rearranged the library twice and had

opinions about the kitchen, and she and Myrrhine had had two arguments, one of which had ended with Myrrhine saying, 'You are not the mistress here and you will not be the mistress here, and if you want to be useful you will learn to ask before you decide.'

She went on the eleventh day in a plain dress and no jewellery except a ring her grandmother had given her, in Antonia's own litter, with Brennus's replacement — a man named Faustus, who was not a replacement, and who was old and slow and bore it patiently when people called him by the wrong name.

She was gone four hours.

She came back at the ninth hour with her eyes red and her chin up and went into the small room off the library and sat down.

Antonia came in and sat on the stool opposite her and said nothing.

'He has agreed to the annulment of the betrothal,' said Marcellina. 'There is nothing to annul, as it happens, because the contracts were not signed; the boy's father had been putting it off since October because he wanted the dowry in cash and my father wanted to pay in land. So it is not a scandal and it will not be in the Acta, and Gracilis has already been seen at the house of another girl's father, and everybody in the city will have forgotten it by March.' She blew her nose. 'He was very calm. That was the worst thing. I had prepared for shouting, and he was very calm, and he said that he had been expecting it since November, and he asked me whether I had anywhere to live, and I said yes, and he said, "The house of Cassia," and I said yes, and he said, "Then I will not ask you to come home."'

'And then?'

'And then we sat in the study for an hour and did not say anything.' Marcellina's hands were in her lap. 'He asked me whether I was happy. He has never asked me that in my life. I said I did not know, which was the truth, and he said that he had never been happy either, and that he had decided at some point that happiness was not the point, and that he did not know any more whether he had been right or whether he had simply been a coward for fifty years.' She wiped her eyes. 'And then he said the thing that I have not been able to stop thinking about. He said: "I have a

daughter I have never met who is twenty-five years old and lives above a bakery in the fourth region, and I have known for four months, and I have not gone, and I am not going to go, because she has asked for a month and because I gave my word. And I find that I have spent the whole of my life keeping my word to people who did not need it and breaking it to the people who did."'

Antonia sat very still.

'He was talking about me,' she said.

'No,' said Marcellina. 'He was talking about himself. He has been talking about himself for fifty-three years and he has only just noticed.' She looked up. 'I am going to go and see my grandmother. Tomorrow, in the morning. She is seventy-nine and she is blind and she has been in that house with the whole of it for twenty-five years, and I am going to sit with her and tell her about the trial and about Tertia and about the dress I have ruined with ink, and I am not going to ask her anything at all.' She stood up. 'And then I am going to come back here and learn to keep a book properly, because Cinnamus says I am careless and he is right.'

On the last day of February, two men came from the office of the curator of the public works and asked to see the owner of the house.

They were civil. They were extremely civil. They sat in the study with a plan on the table between them and explained that the emperor's building programme had been extended, that the new baths would require an aqueduct branch on the north slope of the Esquiline, and that a corridor of land would be required for it, and that the house of Antonia Cassia stood inside the corridor.

'Required,' said Antonia.

'Bought,' said the elder of the two men. 'The treasury does not expropriate; it purchases at valuation. The valuation has been made and it is a fair one; you may inspect it at the office of the curator, and you may appeal it to the prefect, and the prefect will hear you in his own time, which at present is about eight months.'

'And what is the valuation?'

He told her. It was, she saw at once, a fair valuation of a house on the Esquiline in the ordinary way of things, and it was less than half of what the house was worth with the business in it, and rather more than she had paid for it eleven years before.

'And if I refuse?'

'Then the matter goes to the Senate,' said the man, 'and the Senate will confirm the purchase, because the emperor is building an aqueduct, and no one in Rome has ever successfully refused an aqueduct.'

Antonia looked at the plan.

'There is something I do not understand,' she said. 'You have been extremely civil, and you have come in person, and there are two of you, and you have brought a plan. That is not how the treasury behaves. The treasury sends a clerk with a notice.' She looked up. 'Who sent you?'

The two men looked at each other.

'The curator instructed us,' said the elder, 'to say that he had instructed us, and that you would ask, and that the answer is that the corridor could be moved eleven feet to the north, and there is a house in the way, and that house belongs to the guild of the sandalmakers, and the guild has a stronger claim on the treasury than a private owner, and the moving of the corridor is a matter for the curator's discretion.'

'And why would the curator use his discretion in my favour?'

'He did not say,' said the man. 'He said that you would know.'

They went away. Antonia sat in the study with the plan on the table and the lamp burning, and Myrrhine came in and looked at her.

'Well?'

'He has moved an aqueduct eleven feet,' said Antonia.

'Why?'

'Because he is a man who has spent his whole life being correct,' said Antonia, 'and he has discovered that correctness is not the same as goodness, and he has decided to try the other thing, and he has begun with the only thing he has any power over, which is an aqueduct.' She put her hand flat on the plan. 'It will not save the house. The house is finished; I

decided that in September and I have not changed my mind, and I would not keep it now if he moved the aqueduct a mile. But he has done it, and he has done it without telling me, and he has told two clerks to tell me that I would know why, and that is the first gift anyone has given me in twenty-five years that had nothing to do with money.'

Myrrhine sat down.

'You are going to have to decide what you are doing with him,' she said. 'Not this month. Not next. But there is a man on the Palatine who has moved an aqueduct for you and who has a daughter he has not met, and you are going to have to decide what he is to you, and you are going to have to decide it before you are both old.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'Do you?'

'Yes,' said Antonia. 'And I have decided one thing, and it is the only thing I have decided, and you may hold me to it. I am not going to take the bargain.'

'Which bargain?'

'The one you told me not to take in September. The one where he saves me and I close the house and I am grateful to him for the rest of my life.' She looked at the plan on the table. 'If we are ever anything to each other it will be because we have both looked at the whole of it — the villa, the linen room, the child, the letter, his sister's knife, his mother's silence — and we have decided, with our eyes open, in the light, what we are going to be.' She folded the plan. 'And that conversation has not happened. It has been postponed eleven times this year by a trial, a death, an aqueduct, a girl of nineteen and a boy with a bucket. It is going to happen, and it is going to happen in the spring, and it is going to be the last thing I do in this house.'

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Sealing of the Doors

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March came in with wind and the whole city began to move.

It was the month when leases were renewed and ships were prepared and the roads filled with people going back to their estates, and in the Golden Vine it was the month of the inventory. Cinnamus did it room by room, in the Roman way, with a clerk and a tablet, and it took eleven days, and Antonia went with him for the whole of it, because she had never in eleven years walked through her own house and looked at everything in it.

They began in the cellars, which were four rooms under the west wing, and where there was wine enough to fill a cart and a great deal of the kind of thing that accumulates in a cellar over eleven years: broken couches, a crate of lamps with no wicks, a chest of theatrical masks from the dinner in the fourth year, three hundred clay cups, and a box of the bones of a bird that had got in and died and been forgotten.

'Value?' said Antonia.

'Nothing,' said Cinnamus. 'Eleven sesterces for the cups if we sell them as a lot, and the masks are worth four hundred because they are good and a theatre will buy them, and everything else goes to the rubbish tip at the Esquiline gate.'

The dining rooms: seven couches, the citrus-wood table, the silver, the forty lamps of the zodiac room, the wall paintings which were worth nothing because they could not be moved and were going to be covered in the plaster of an aqueduct.

The bedchambers: eleven of them, and each one had been emptied by the woman who had lived in it, and each one was a different shape of emptiness. Eucharis's room still had the mark of a harp case in the dust on the shelf. Chloe's had a nail in the wall with nothing hanging from it.

The small room by the garden: the couch, the basin, the lamp, the mark on the plaster where a young man's head had rested on the nineteenth night of August.

Antonia stood in it for a while.

'Do you want it cleared?' said Cinnamus.

'It is cleared,' said Antonia. 'There is nothing in it.'

The library: eleven presses, four hundred rolls, a great many of which she had never opened. She gave the law books to Tarquitius's secretary, who came with a cart and a list and took them away with the expression of a man being handed a fortune. She gave the poetry and the histories to the household. She kept eleven rolls: Livy, the first decade, which she had read in a linen room in Arretium, and which had a mouse-bitten edge; a Greek poet, and the scrap of wood with the word *eleutheria* on it, which she had kept for twenty-five years and which was, she discovered, still in the box with the blue glass.

The peristyle: the fountain, the Neptune with his hand up against a wave that would never fall, the mosaic that Sabina said had water under it.

The garden: the fig tree, the cypress, the bench, the wall, the corner where the ladder had stood in November.

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In the second week a man came to the gate at the ninth hour and asked for the house.

He was about forty, in a good tunic, and he had the look of a man who had been drinking since the afternoon in a careful, controlled way and had come to do something he had been meaning to do for a month. Meno, who had been at the gate for nine years and could tell in three words what a man wanted, came and told Antonia.

'He says he has an appointment.'

'He does not have an appointment.'

'He says he was here in the seventh year and that you will remember him.' Meno paused. 'He says he wants to see the room.'

Antonia went to the gate.

The man was standing in the street with his hands behind his back, and he was not one of the men who had come to the house for eleven years; he was one of the ones who had come once, and had never come back, and had thought about it ever since. She remembered him. He had been in the house in the seventh year, in the winter, and he had been unable to do anything at all and had cried, and she had sat with him for an hour and had not charged him for it, and he had sent her a jar of wine at the Saturnalia for four years afterwards and then stopped.

'Domine,' she said.

'You remember me.'

'I remember everyone,' said Antonia. 'It is a professional defect.'

He looked at the street and then at the gate.

'I heard that you are closing it,' he said. 'I heard it in the baths. And I have been thinking about it for a fortnight, and I have come to ask you —' He stopped. 'I have come to ask whether I might see the room. Not for anything. I am not that man any more; I have a wife and a business and two children. I wanted to see the room and stand in it for a minute, and then I will go home.'

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

'The furniture is sold,' she said. 'The couch has gone. There is nothing in it but a mark on the plaster.'

'That is all right,' he said. 'I would not know what to do with a couch.'

She took him through the house herself. He stopped in the peristyle and looked at the fountain, and in the small room by the garden he stood for a long time with his hands at his sides and did not say anything at all.

Then he said, 'I have thought about that hour for six years. I have thought about it at night, and in the middle of the day, and once in a temple, which was the worst of it. And I have decided — I decided in the street, on the way up the hill — that what happened was not what I thought it was.'

'What did you think it was?'

'I thought I had been humiliated,' he said, 'by a woman I had paid.' He turned around. 'And on the way up the hill I understood that I had been in

a room with a stranger for an hour and that she had not laughed at me, and that I had been so frightened of being laughed at that I could not see it, and that I have spent six years being ashamed of the wrong thing.'

Antonia stood in the doorway.

'It is a very small thing,' she said, 'to sit with a man for an hour and not laugh at him.'

'It is,' he said. 'And in six years, nobody else has done it.' He looked around the room one last time. 'I am not going to come back. I am not going to be one of those men who come to the gate when they are fifty. I wanted to see it once more and now I have.' He held out his hand, which nobody did, and she took it. 'Goodbye, domina. I hope you have a good life. I hope you have a very dull one.'

'I am planning on it,' said Antonia.

On the eleventh day of the inventory she sent for the painter.

He was sixty-one and lived in a room in the fourth region and had not painted a ceiling in nine years, because his hands shook, and he came up the hill in his working clothes with his box, and he stood in the zodiac room with his cap in his hands and looked up.

'It has held,' he said.

'It has held.'

'The lapis has gone a little green at the edge of the Archer, which I told you at the time; the pigment was not what the dealer said it was.' He turned around slowly. 'I have thought about this ceiling for more than a decade. I have painted four ceilings since and none of them was any good, and I have thought about this one every day, and I have never seen it from the floor with the lamps lit because I was always on my back in the dark.'

'It is going to be plastered over in a month,' said Antonia. 'There is an aqueduct coming through the north slope and the workmen will be in this room in April and the ceiling will come down with the roof.'

The painter looked up at his own work.

'Then I would like to ask you something,' he said, 'and you may say no, and I will not be offended, and it is not about money.'

'Ask.'

'When I painted the Ram, in the fourth month, I put a small thing in the fleece. It is about the size of a fingernail and it is not in the design and nobody has ever noticed it and I have never told anyone. It is my name, in Greek, in three letters, worked into the curl of the fleece, and it cannot be seen from the floor. I did it because I was on my back in the dark for nine months and I wanted to leave a mark and I was afraid to ask.' He turned. 'I am not asking you to save it. You cannot save it; it is going to come down with the roof. I am asking you to go and look at it before it does.'

Antonia looked at him.

'Show me,' she said.

They went up on the scaffolding that the workmen had put up the week before, and she stood on a plank four feet under her own ceiling with her hand against the plaster, and he pointed, and it was there: three small letters in the curl of the Ram's fleece, worked into the pattern so that they became part of it, so that in eleven years not one of the four hundred men who had dined in that room had ever seen it.

'I am sorry I said no,' said Antonia.

'I have been angry about it for eleven years,' said the painter. 'And then in the summer I heard that you were being tried for murder and that the whole city was against you, and I found that I was not angry any more, and I could not work out why.' He put his cap on. 'I think it is because I understood, in the summer, that a woman who says no to a painter is not the same as a woman who has no reason for saying no. You had a reason. It was a bad reason. But it was a reason, and I have been in this city for sixty-one years and I have worked for eleven men who did not have one.'

The deeds were signed in the last week of the month, in the temple of Castor, in front of a magistrate's clerk and nine witnesses.

They signed them in one sitting and it took four hours. Eucharis signed her contract and her lease. The two cooks signed their share in the cookshop. The laundry woman signed her passage and a receipt for the sum. Chloe signed for the fuller's business at Ostia and could not stop crying. Prima signed for the house on the Aventine and the two hundred thousand sesterces and did it without reading it, because she had read it eleven times at home and knew it by heart.

Meno signed with a mark, because he could not write, and the clerk made a note of it, and Meno said, 'I have been in four houses in thirty years and this is the first time anyone has ever asked me to sign anything, and I find that I would rather have the cottage than the ceremony.'

Cinnamus signed last, and the deed was for eleven thousand sesterces and a shop in the Subura, and he had negotiated it himself and had driven a hard bargain with Antonia, and had told her, at the end of the negotiation, that she was a very difficult woman and that he would not have worked for anyone else.

Then Antonia signed the sale of the house.

The buyer was the treasury, and the price was the valuation, and the clerk read the schedule aloud in the flat voice of a man reading a schedule, and when it was done Antonia sat with the stylus in her hand for a moment before she signed.

'Domina?' said the clerk.

'One moment,' said Antonia.

She looked at the tablet. It said: *the house, the land, the portico, the fountain, the mosaic, the wall paintings, the cypress, and the fig tree.*

She signed it.

The last night in the house was the last night of March, and there were nine people in it.

They had sold the furniture. They had sold the silver, which had gone to a dealer on the Via Sacra for a sum that Cinnamus considered scandalous and that Antonia considered fair, because the man had to sell it

on and there was a great deal of it and everybody in Rome knew where it had come from. They had sold the couches and the lamps and the wine and the masks.

What was left in the house was a table, four stools, nine beds, the plates and cups they were using, and a chest in the hall with the household's own things in it.

Vibia Lucana came up in the afternoon with two baskets of food and stayed. Marcellina came back from her grandmother's house, where she had been sitting for a week, and did not go home again. Tertia came at the ninth hour with Sabina and a jar of wine and said, 'I am not staying the night; I have work in the morning and I am not going to be sentimental in a house I have only known for five months.'

The nine were: Antonia, Myrrhine, Marcellina, Prima, Meno, Cinnamus, Vibia, Tertia, and Faustus the new guard, who had been in the household for four months and who stood in the corner with his plate and looked as though he could not believe his luck.

They ate at the long table in the kitchen court, which was the only room with a fire, and they ate the last of the kitchen's food and drank the last of the ordinary wine, and then, because there was nothing else to do, they told stories.

Myrrhine told the story of the eleventh year, when a man had come to the house at the eleventh hour with a goat, and had insisted, at length and with a straight face, that the goat was a gift for the household and that it was worth forty thousand sesterces, and that he would take thirty thousand in cash. Prima told the story of the night the awning came down in the peristyle and eleven senators spent an hour in the rain. Cinnamus told the story of the seventh box, and how he had been wrong about it for three years and a copyist of twenty-five had been right in an afternoon, and he told it against himself, and Tertia put her hand over her face and laughed.

Meno told the story of the geese.

And at the end, when the fire was low and the wine was nearly gone, Vibia said, 'I will go first, because I have a long way home and I am too old

to walk up the Caelian at the second hour,' and she stood up and looked around the kitchen court and said, 'I have been coming to this house for a decade and I have never once been bored in it, and there is no other house in Rome of which I can say that.'

Then she said, to Antonia, 'The courtyard at Ostia. Once a month. Bring the women who have nowhere to go.' And she went.

Prima went next. She was going to the house on the Aventine in the morning; she had the key in her sleeve and had had it there for two months.

At the gate she stopped.

'I have been in this house seven years,' she said. 'I came in at twenty-four with the scars on my back and nothing else. I have been paid wages for seven years and I have two hundred thousand sesterces and a house, and when I am old I will tell people that I was in the house of Antonia Cassia and that it was the best house in Rome, and nobody will believe me.' She looked at the courtyard. 'There is a thing I have wanted to say to you since August and I have never said it, because it is not the sort of thing that is said in a house like this. When you sent Berenice away in the carriage, I told you that you had made a mistake, and I was right, and it nearly cost you everything. But I want you to know that I was standing in the passage when you did it, and I thought: that is what a woman ought to be, and there is not one woman in a thousand in this city who would have done it.' She held out her hand. 'That is all. I will see you at Vibia's courtyard, and I will bring a cake, and I will not talk about the Argiletum.'

She went out. Cinnamus went at the first hour, to the room he had taken in the Subura near the shop, and Faustus went with him as far as the corner.

At the second hour Antonia walked through the house with a lamp.

She went through the empty rooms one at a time. There was nothing in any of them. The mosaic in the atrium was grey with dust; someone had swept it and the dust had come back. The zodiac room smelled of cold plaster. In the peristyle the fountain had been turned off for a month and there was a little green in the basin.

She stood in the small room by the garden and looked at the place where the couch had been.

Then she went out and closed the door and put a wax seal on it, and did the same on the door of the library, and the door of the tablinum, and the door of the room at the top of the west wing, and the street door last of all.

She had had a seal made for the purpose, in the fourth month, from a gem-cutter in the Via Sacra, at a cost of four hundred sesterces, which she had entered in the book as a household expense. It was a small intaglio of a vine leaf with the letters A C.

She sealed the street door on the inside, which was absurd, because the door was no longer hers, and she stood in the doorway with the lamp in her hand and the wax cooling.

Behind her, Myrrhine said, 'You know that we have to go out through the garden.'

'I know.'

'And that the garden door does not lock.'

'I know,' said Antonia. 'Bring the chest. The men are coming for the rest in the morning, and there is nothing in it that anybody would steal.'

Tertia came up the hill in the morning and found the street door with a wax seal on it and the workmen's cart already at the corner.

She stood in front of it for a while. Then she walked round through the Vicus Patricius to the garden door, which was not sealed, because the garden door did not lock, and she went into the courtyard and stood among the empty rooms with her box of tablets under her arm.

Antonia found her in the peristyle, looking at the fountain.

'I came to say that I am not going to be sentimental about a house,' said Tertia, 'and then I came up the hill at the second hour and I have been standing in this courtyard for a quarter of an hour and I find that I am.' She turned. 'It is a strange thing to be sad about a building. I have no memories of this place. I was here for five months and I copied four hundred and eleven tablets and ate my dinner at that table and argued with

the atriensis about a box that did not balance.' She looked up at the ceiling of the peristyle. 'And I find that I am standing here at the fourth hour of the morning with a lump in my throat because a woman I met in October is closing a house I never lived in.'

'You lived in it,' said Antonia. 'For five months, at a table, eating your dinner. That is living in a house.'

'I know.' Tertia wiped her eyes with the back of her hand, briskly, in a way that was entirely her own. 'I am not going to ask you the question I said I would not ask in March. I want you to know that I have remembered it and that I have decided not to ask it and that I am going to be extremely smug about it for the rest of the year.'

'Good,' said Antonia.

Tertia looked around the empty courtyard one last time.

'What happens to it now?' she said. 'The stones. The fountain. The mosaic that Sabina said had water under it.'

'The mosaic is going to the hall of the sandalmakers,' said Antonia. 'The fountain will be broken up; the lead is worth something and the stone goes into the aqueduct. The paintings will be plastered over in April. The fig tree will be cut down because it is in the line of the corridor, and the cypress also. In three years there will be a wall and a channel of water and a great many people walking past it on their way to the baths, and none of them will know that there was ever a house here.'

Tertia was quiet for a moment.

'Then I am glad I copied the books,' she said. 'There are four hundred and eleven tablets in the fourth region with this house in them, in my hand, and in a hundred years somebody will open a box and find out exactly how much a woman paid a cook in the eleventh year, and that will be the only thing left of it.'

'That is a strange thing to want,' said Antonia.

'It is what I have,' said Tertia, and went out through the garden door.

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The new house was on the Aventine, three rooms and a courtyard and a yard, in a street of tanners and dyers, and it cost eleven thousand sesterces, and Antonia bought it in Myrrhine's name.

She did not tell her until the deed was in her hand.

They came up the hill at the third hour with a lamp and the chest and a basket, and the street was dark and smelled of the tannery vats, and the door of the house was blue, and there was a fig tree in the yard that was not the fig tree and a wall that was not the wall.

Myrrhine stood in the courtyard with the lamp.

'What is this?'

'It is a house,' said Antonia. 'Three rooms, a courtyard, a yard, a well that is shared with the dyer next door and a roof that needs work in the summer.' She took the deed out of her sleeve. 'It is in your name. It has been registered at the temple of Castor this afternoon. The ground rent is eleven sesterces a year and the taxes are in the schedule.'

Myrrhine did not take the deed.

'Why?'

'Because I have been thinking about what to give you for sixteen years,' said Antonia, 'and I have given you a wage and a room and a position and a share of everything I own, and none of it was a thing of your own, and I have known it the whole time.' She held out the deed. 'I have made a great many mistakes in my life and I am going to make a great many more, and one of them was in the fifth year when I decided that what was between us could be put in a box and kept in a cupboard along with everything else. I am not going to do it again. This is a house in your name, and if you want to live in it with me, that is what I want, and if you do not, it is yours anyway.'

Myrrhine looked at the deed for a long moment.

'You are a very difficult woman,' she said.

'I have been told.'

'And you have done this in the worst possible way,' said Myrrhine, 'because you have bought a house and put it in my name and handed me a deed in a courtyard at the third hour of the night, and now I cannot be

angry with you, and I have been saving up to be angry with you about something for about a year.' She took the deed. 'Sixteen years. I told you in September that you would have to ask me twice. This is not asking. This is a deed.'

'It is both,' said Antonia.

Myrrhine stood in the courtyard with the lamp in one hand and the deed in the other.

'Then I will say it once,' she said, 'and then I am going to bed, because it is the third hour and I have been moving a household for four months. Yes. There. Now put the chest down and come inside, and in the morning we will find out that the roof leaks and the well is shared with a dyer who gets up at the fourth hour, and we will be two women in a small house on the Aventine with no name over the gate, and I find that I am looking forward to it more than I have looked forward to anything since I was twenty.'

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They were in the new house for nine days.

Antonia spent them doing the things on the list. She had the mosaic lifted in a house that was no longer hers, which was absurd and which she did anyway, and gave it to the guild of the sandalmakers for their hall, and it was installed in the summer and it is there still. She wrote eleven letters. She went to the temple of Castor twice. She and Myrrhine argued about a bed and bought one, and the roof was examined by a man who said it would last the year and was wrong.

On the ninth day she went to the Palatine in the afternoon and sat with Tarquitia Priscilla for an hour while Marcellina read to her, and the old woman said, at the end of it, 'You have closed the house.'

'On the last day of March.'

'And what are you now?'

'A woman of forty-two with three rooms on the Aventine and a great deal of money and nothing to do,' said Antonia.

'Good,' said Tarquitia Priscilla. 'That is the most dangerous thing a woman can be in this city, and it has taken you twenty-five years to get there, and I hope you make a great deal of trouble.'

On the eleventh day of April, at the second hour of the night, the north slope of the Esquiline caught fire.

It began, they said afterwards, in a bakery on the Vicus Cyprius, in an oven that had been left too hot with a batch of bread in it, and the baker and his family got out, and the fire went up through the roof and into the block behind, and the wind was from the south and there had been no rain for three weeks.

Antonia was woken by Myrrhine at the third hour.

'There is a fire,' said Myrrhine. 'On the Esquiline. It is the north slope; it started at the second hour and it has taken four blocks.'

Antonia was out of bed and into her clothes in the dark.

'Get Faustus. Get the cart if there is one to be had, and if there is not, we walk.' She was at the door. 'Myrrhine. It is the house.'

'I know.'

'It is the house, and the chest went to the new house, and the four things are in the chest, and there is nothing in that house but plaster and a fountain and a mosaic that I gave away last week.' She stopped with her hand on the door. 'And the book.'

Myrrhine looked at her.

'The book is in the tablinum,' said Antonia, 'in the press behind the second door, in four boxes, and it is the whole of eleven years. It has every name in Rome in it. It has the loans and the favours and the men who came and the wives who borrowed and the magistrate's freedman and the fire in the ninth region and eleven things that would end nine men's careers, and it is in a wooden press in a room with a plaster ceiling and the roof of that block is timber.'

'Then let it burn,' said Myrrhine.

Antonia stood in the doorway.

‘If it burns,’ she said, ‘then there is nothing in the world that anybody can hold against me, and there is nothing in the world that I can hold against anybody, and every man in this city who has been afraid of me for eleven years will know by the morning that he does not have to be afraid any more.’ She took her cloak. ‘And if it does not burn, and somebody takes it out of that press before the roof comes down, then the whole of it is in the hands of whoever finds it, and there are forty men in Rome who would pay a great deal for it and one man who would pay anything.’

‘Then we go,’ said Myrrhine, ‘and we take the cart, and we take Faustus, and we get there before anybody else does.’

‘Yes,’ said Antonia.

She went out into the street, where the whole of the Aventine was awake and the sky over the Esquiline was the colour of a coal in a brazier, and the smoke was coming across the river on the wind.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Fire

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They came up the hill through the whole of the city's noise.

It took an hour and a half. The streets were full of people going the other way — families with bundles, a man carrying a door, a woman with a goat, two litters jammed against each other at the corner of the Vicus Cyprius with their bearers shouting — and twice they had to stop and go round, and once Faustus had to take the cart into a side street because a wall had come down across the road.

The sky over the north slope was orange and the smoke was going up in a column that leaned to the north-east with the wind, and it was the colour of the inside of a furnace at the bottom and grey at the top, and it had begun to blot out the stars.

They came up the Vicus Patricius at the fourth hour.

The street was a river of people and water and broken tile. The vigiles had formed two chains from the fountain of the Vicus Cyprius and one from the cistern at the corner, and they were passing buckets hand to hand and throwing the water at the fronts of buildings that were going to burn anyway, and there were men on the roofs of two houses with wet cloths beating out sparks, and there were four men with a rope pulling down the wall of a bakery that had already gone.

The bakery was gone. The whole of the corner where it had stood was a shell of black wall with the roof fallen in, and the fire was in the block behind it, and the block behind that, and the wineshop on the corner was on fire from the ground floor to the roof.

And the Golden Vine was still standing.

Antonia stood in the street and looked at it: the painted portico, the wall, the cypress, the roof, and above the roof the fig tree, and the whole of the front of the house lit orange and untouched.

'It is not burning,' she said.

'It is going to,' said a vigile, going past with a bucket. 'The block behind it has gone and the roof of your portico is timber and the wind is from the south. We are wetting the fronts of the houses on this side of the street and we have got about an hour, and then we are going to pull the porch down and let it take what it takes.'

Antonia looked at her house.

'Myrrhine,' she said. 'The chain. Take Faustus and go to the fountain and put yourself in the chain and do not go into that house.'

'Where are you going?'

'Into that house.'

'Antonia—'

'The book is in the tablinum,' said Antonia, 'and there are four boxes of it, and if the roof comes down on it, then it burns, and I will be a woman of forty-two with three rooms on the Aventine and no enemies. And if the roof comes down on it while it is out here in the street, then whoever picks it up has the whole of it, and there are forty men in Rome who would pay for it, and one of them is a man I put in front of a magistrate in November.'

Myrrhine looked at her for a moment.

'The house is not yours,' she said. 'The sale was completed at the temple of Castor in March and the money is in Naso's bank and the treasury has owned this roof for eleven days. If it burns, it burns the emperor's roof and you will not lose a sesterce.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'Then why are we going in?'

'Because the book is mine,' said Antonia, 'and because the whole of it is in a wooden press in a plaster room and I am not going to leave the private business of four hundred people to the wind.'

'Then I am coming with you,' said Myrrhine.

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The house was dark and full of the sound of the fire next door, which was not a roar but a low, enormous, irregular breathing, with cracks in it.

They went in through the garden door, which did not lock, and across the courtyard, and the peristyle was lit from above by the glow through the open roof and the shadows of the columns went across the floor like the bars of a cage. The fountain had been dry for a month. Somebody had left a bucket on the rim.

The tablinum was locked. Antonia broke the seal with her thumbnail and put the key in and the door opened, and the room smelled of dust and old wax and the press was where it had always been, behind the second door, with four boxes in it.

Faustus came in behind them with a lamp.

'Domina, the roof of the portico is alight.'

'Take that box,' said Antonia. 'Myrrhine, that one. I will take the other two. Do not run and do not go out through the peristyle; go through the passage by the bath and out through the kitchen court, and put them in the cart and put the cart in the middle of the street and stand beside it and do not let anyone near it.'

They carried them out.

The portico was burning when they came into the street: the timber of the roof had caught and the fire was running along it in a line, and the painted plaster of the front was blistering and coming away in sheets, and there was a crowd standing in the street watching it, and one of them was the woman who sold chickpeas.

Antonia put her two boxes on the cart and stood there with her hands black and her sleeves smoking.

'Is that everything?' said Myrrhine.

'That is the whole of it,' said Antonia. 'Eleven years. Four boxes.'

The roof of the portico came down at the fifth hour with a crash that shook the street, and the fire went into the front rooms, and by the sixth hour the whole front of the house was burning, and by the seventh the roof of the atrium had fallen in and the fire was in the peristyle and the fountain was giving off steam.

It was at the sixth hour, when the front of the house had gone and the fire was in the peristyle, that Antonia stopped watching her own property and began to work.

It happened without a decision. A woman came past with a child and said that there were eleven people in the insula behind the sandalmakers' street who could not get out because the passage had fallen in, and Antonia turned to Faustus and said, 'The cart. Take the cart to the fountain and fill every vessel in it and drive it up the alley; there is a way in through the yard at the back and the gate is iron and it will open with a bar.' And then she went to the vigile in charge of the chain and said, 'How many men have you got?'

'Fourteen.'

'And how many are on the roof of the bath house?'

'Six.'

'Then you have eight on the ground and you are using them to throw water at a wall that has already gone.' She pointed. 'Put four of them on that corner with hooks and pull the awning of the portico down before it falls on the chain, and put the other four on the cistern and keep the water moving, and I will find you thirty people from this street who will carry buckets if somebody tells them where to stand.'

The vigile looked at her.

'Who are you?'

'Nobody,' said Antonia. 'But I have kept a house with nineteen people in it for eleven years and I know how to make a frightened crowd do one thing at a time.'

She did it for three hours.

She stood at the corner of the Vicus Cyprius with her sleeves rolled and her hair coming down and told people where to stand: the baker's two sons, the woman who sold chickpeas, a group of eleven men from the cattle market who had come up to see the fire and stayed to work, four of Naso's clerks who arrived at the seventh hour with a cart and a chain of their own, and the copyist from the Argiletum, who turned out to have a good head for water and who spent the whole morning doing exactly what

he was told.

At the seventh hour they got the nine people out of the insula behind the sandalmakers' street, through the yard at the back, in twos and threes, and one of them was a woman of about eighty who had refused to leave her room until Antonia came in through the smoke and sat down on the bed beside her and said, 'Domina, I am a woman of forty-two and I have lost my house tonight and I am still going to walk out of this door, and I am not going to do it without you.'

The old woman came.

At the eighth hour the fire crossed the sandalmakers' street at the northern end and the vigiles pulled down the portico of the house opposite, and the men on the ropes were at it for a quarter of an hour, and Antonia stood in the street and shouted at them to stand back from the wall, and they stood back, and the wall came down into the street exactly where they had been standing and nobody was hurt.

At the ninth hour a man from the prefect's office found her and asked who was in charge of the civil arrangements on the north side of the Vicus Cyprius, and she said, 'Nobody; there is a vigile at the corner and a man from the corn office at the baths with a list of the homeless, and if you want to be useful you will take that list and find four hundred beds in the baths of Titus before nightfall,' and he wrote it down and went away and did it.

They stood in the street and watched it burn.

Somebody brought a stool. Somebody else brought wine and Antonia took it and did not drink it. The baker's wife came and stood beside her with a child on her hip and said, 'We are all out. We are all out, domina; the boy went back for the cat and came out through the window and he is all right and the cat is not, and I have been standing here for an hour telling people that.'

'Which house?' said Antonia.

'The one at the corner of the sandalmakers' street. It has gone.' The woman's face was black with smoke and she was crying without noticing it. 'Nine families. The wineshop keeper's mother is dead; she was ninety and she would not come out. And there is a man who has been going into the buildings all night, a man in a good tunic with his face black — he has been in three times and he has brought out eleven people and he is in the fourth one now and they are saying it is going to come down.'

Antonia turned.

'What man?'

'I do not know his name. He has a southern accent and a bad leg and he has been giving orders to the vigiles as though he were paying them.'

Marcus Sestius Verus came out of the fourth building at the seventh hour with a child under one arm and a woman over his shoulder, and he was three steps clear when the floor of the passage gave way behind him and the whole front of the insula came down into the street.

The crowd got him. Two vigiles got him. They laid him on the pavement and somebody put water on his face and he sat up and coughed for a long time and then said, 'There is a man in the back room on the ground floor. He is dead. I could not get to him.'

Antonia came through the crowd and stood over him.

He looked up at her. His face was black and his eyebrows were gone and his tunic was burned across the shoulder, and he was fifty-eight years old and he looked like a man who had been in a war.

'Domina,' he said.

'You have been in four buildings.'

'Five,' said Sestius. 'The first one was the bakery and there was nobody in it.' He coughed. 'I came up at the third hour. My agent has a house on this hill and I was at his table when the fire started, and we came out, and everybody was running that way and I found that I was running this way.' He looked at the burning street. 'I have spent the whole of my life in rooms with men who were afraid of me. I have never once in fifty-eight years done

anything that was any use at all. And tonight I put my shoulder against a door and it opened and there were four people behind it, and I find that I do not know what to do with the feeling.'

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

'Your face needs a physician,' she said.

'My face can wait,' said Sestius. 'There is a man in the back room of that building who is dead and there is a woman in the street who does not know that it is her husband, and I am going to go and tell her, and then I am going to sit down somewhere and not move for a week.' He got up, with difficulty, holding a vigile's arm. 'Domina. The children. In Lugdunum.'

Antonia's hands went cold.

'My agent found them,' said Sestius. 'It took him four months. The girl is fifteen and she is in service in the household of a wine merchant and the boy is twelve and he is with the same household in the stables. They are alive, and they are not free, and the girl has a mark on her arm from a burn that she says she got at seven and that her mother did not, and my agent says the household is a decent one and that the girl can read.' He wiped his mouth. 'I have the papers. The man who owns them has agreed to sell, and the price is eleven thousand sesterces for the two, and I have paid it, and they will be freed by the council's leave in the autumn and my agent will bring them to Rome in the spring, and they are not to be told that I paid for it, because I do not intend to be thanked by a girl of fifteen for a thing I did after her father was killed in my name.'

Antonia stood in the street with the house burning behind her.

'Why?' she said.

'Because I have nothing else to do,' said Sestius, 'and because I have been thinking since November about a man called Brennus who died in a courtyard with a knife in him because my steward was in a rage, and because I have discovered at fifty-eight that the only thing I have ever been any good at is going into buildings.' He looked at the fire. 'Do not thank me. Do not say anything at all. I am going to go and tell a woman that her husband is dead, and then I am going to go home and sleep for two days,

and then I am going to go and see my daughter, who has not spoken to me since August, and I am going to ask her whether she would like to come to Lugdunum with me in the spring to fetch two children who are not ours.'

He went off through the crowd, limping, with his burned shoulder, and the crowd made way for him.

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The house burned until the ninth hour of the morning.

By then the fire had crossed the street in two places and had been stopped at the third, and the vigiles had pulled down the portico of the house opposite and part of the wineshop's wall, and the whole of the north slope between the Vicus Cyprius and the sandalmakers' street was a field of black walls and standing chimneys and smoke.

Antonia's house was a shell.

The front was gone entirely. The atrium had no roof and the walls of it were standing to the height of a man and no higher. The peristyle had kept two of its columns and the mosaic was black and cracked and there was a foot of water in the fountain with something in it that had been the bucket.

The zodiac room had no ceiling.

She went in at the ninth hour and stood in the middle of it with the ash coming down around her like grey snow, and looked up, and there was nothing above her but the sky.

She found the place where the Ram had been. The plaster was there — the ceiling had come down in three big pieces and one of them had landed across the room and was lying face up like a fallen table, and the painting on it was blistered and black at the edges but the middle of it had survived, and the Ram was in the middle, and the fleece was burnt away, and the three letters that had been worked into the curl of it were gone.

Antonia stood in the ash and looked at it for a while.

'Well,' she said.

Then she went round the room, and through the arch into the peristyle, and picked up three things out of the ash.

The first was the bronze boar's head from the garden door, which had come off in the heat and was lying in the courtyard, and which was blackened and had one ear melted, and which had been on that door since before she bought the house.

The second was a piece of the mosaic from the atrium, about the size of her palm, with four white tesserae and one black one in it, which had come up whole when the floor cracked and which she found by stepping on it.

The third was a lump of plaster the size of a fist, with a curl of gold leaf on it and the corner of a fleece, and the fleece was burnt away and the gold had bubbled and gone black at one end, and under the black there was a place where the plaster was clean and pale and there was nothing written on it at all.

She put the three things in her sleeve.

Faustus came across the courtyard with a shovel.

'Domina, the men from the treasury are here. They say it is their building and they want to know what you are doing in it.'

Antonia turned around.

'Tell them I am taking three things out of a house I lived in for more than a decade,' she said, 'and that they may have everything else, and that if they want the boar's head they will have to argue with me in the street.'

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She was on the corner at the eleventh hour when a woman she did not know came up to her and said, 'You are Antonia Cassia.'

'I am.'

The woman looked at her: the black face, the burnt sleeves, the hair down, the hands.

'I have said a great many things about you in the last year,' the woman said. 'In the market. To my sister. In front of my children.' She had a basket on her arm with a loaf in it, and she was perhaps thirty-five, and she was not apologising; she was reporting. 'I said that you were a wicked woman and that the city would be better without you and that a woman with a house like that ought to be driven out. I said it in August. My

husband told me to be quiet and I did not.'

Antonia looked at her.

'And now?' she said.

'And now I have been standing at the corner for two hours and I have watched you put four hundred people in a chain and get an old woman out of a burning insula,' said the woman, 'and I do not know what to do with it, and I am not going to say that I was wrong, because I do not know yet whether I was wrong.' She held out the loaf. 'But you have not eaten since last night and I have a loaf and two children at home and I am not a fool, and I would like you to take it.'

Antonia took the loaf.

'Thank you,' she said.

'It is not a forgiveness,' said the woman.

'No,' said Antonia. 'It is bread. They are different things and I have learned this year that people confuse them constantly.'

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They put the four boxes on the ground in the street at the ninth hour, and Antonia stood over them, and Myrrhine stood beside her, and Faustus stood beside the cart, and Meno, who had come up at the sixth hour and had not said a word since, stood at the corner with his stick as though there were still a gate to keep.

A man came up to her out of the crowd: a little man, quick, with soot on his face and a bag over his shoulder, and he said, 'Domina, I am a copyist. I have a stall in the Argiletum. If those boxes are wet I can dry them and copy them; I do it for the courts.'

'They are not wet,' said Antonia.

'They are four boxes,' said the man. 'That is a lot of paper to carry about a burning street. I will give you a room to put them in and a lock and I will not ask what is in them, and I will charge you eleven sesterces a day, which is fair.'

Antonia looked at him.

'What is your name?'

'Publius Varius Felix.'

'Publius Varius Felix,' said Antonia, 'you are the first man in this city to offer me a fair price for anything in nine months without knowing who I am.' She looked down at the four boxes. 'There is no need. I am going to burn them.'

Myrrhine said, 'Antonia.'

'I have been thinking about it since the fourth hour,' said Antonia, 'and I have not been thinking about it well, because I have been carrying boxes through a fire, and a person who is carrying boxes through a fire does not think. But I have been thinking about it since the second hour of the night, when I stood in a doorway on the Aventine and decided to come and get them.' She knelt down and put her hand on the top box. 'This is eleven years of the private business of about four hundred people. It is the reason I have never been robbed and the reason no man in this city has been able to touch me since the fourth year. It is also the reason that a praetor's steward knew he could send four men over my wall and that no magistrate would believe a woman with a book like this. It is a knife in a drawer, and I have had it in the drawer for eleven years, and in that time I have taken it out twice, and one of those times a man was taken away in the Forum in front of three thousand people.'

She opened the top box.

The tablets were dry and in order, in Cinnamus's hand and Tertia's fair copy, four hundred and eleven of them, wrapped in cloth.

'It is not power,' said Antonia. 'That is what I have learned this year. A thing that can only be used once is not power; it is a debt. I have been paying the interest on it for a decade and in November it was called in.' She took the first bundle out. 'And there is another thing, and it is the true reason, and I am going to say it out loud in the street so that I cannot pretend afterwards that I did not think it. Half the men in that book are men who came to my house and were lonely in a way they had never been able to say out loud. I have their secrets because I was kind to them at the second hour of the night. And a woman who keeps a book like that is a woman who has decided, once and for all, that being kind is a transaction.'

Myrrhine looked at her.

'And if you burn it,' she said, 'and one of them comes for you in a year, or in ten years, with a charge and a witness, and you have nothing at all?'

'Then I will be a woman with three rooms on the Aventine and a great deal of money,' said Antonia, 'and I will defend myself with the truth, which is what I did in November, and which worked, and which cost me less than this book ever did.'

She carried the four boxes into the shell of her own house, into the peristyle, where the floor of the dining room had fallen into the cellar and the fire was still burning in the ruins underneath, and she opened them one at a time and put the bundles into the fire.

It took a quarter of an hour.

The wax melted first and ran, and then the wood of the tablets caught, and then the papyrus, which burned very fast and very brightly and made a great deal of smoke, and the cloth wrappings smouldered and had to be pushed in with a stick.

The whole household stood in the peristyle and watched, and nobody said anything, and Faustus came with a stick and helped.

When the last bundle was in, Antonia stood over the fire with her hands black and her face black and her eyes streaming from the smoke.

'That is the end of the house,' she said.

Meno went and stood at the gate.

There was no gate. There was a gap in the wall where the gate had been, and the doorkeeper's bench was ash, and the street outside was full of rubble and water and people going past with their bundles, and he stood in the gap with his stick across his knees the way he had stood there for nine years.

Antonia came and stood beside him.

'There is nothing to keep,' she said.

'I know,' said Meno.

'You are going to Tibur on the Kalends of May. There is a cottage with a garden gate and a wall and a fig tree and a woman next door who has already written to me twice about the roof.'

'I know,' said Meno. 'I have the letter. I cannot read it; the atriensis read it to me. She says the roof is sound and the well is good and that there is a widow at the end of the lane who keeps bees.' He looked at the street. 'Thirty years, domina. Four houses. This is the first one that burned.'

'It is a bad way to end,' said Antonia.

'It is a bad way to end and a good way to end,' said Meno, 'and I have been standing here for a quarter of an hour working out which it is.' He shifted the stick. 'A gate is a thing that keeps people out and lets people in. I have kept out eleven thousand people in nine years and I have let in perhaps four thousand, and of those four thousand, nine hundred were men who came to the house at night and eleven were men who came to the house at night and were kind to me.' He turned. 'When it burned, I found that I was not thinking about the house. I was thinking about the bench, and about the boy from the kitchen who used to sit on the step at the fourth hour with his bread, and about Brennus, who used to stand where I am standing now and say that a doorkeeper who cannot see the street is a decoration.' He put the stick down. 'So it is a good way to end. It ends with the gate open, and nobody coming over the wall, and everybody out.'

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They went down the hill at the eleventh hour through streets full of wet ash and people standing in doorways.

At the corner of the Vicus Cyprius a woman came out of a doorway and said, 'Domina. There is a room at the back of our shop, it is small but it is dry, and my husband says you may have it for as long as you need, and there is no rent.'

'Thank you,' said Antonia. 'We have somewhere to go.'

She walked down the hill with Myrrhine beside her and Meno behind her with his stick, and Faustus with the cart, and at the bottom of the hill she stopped at the corner where the Vicus Patricius meets the Subura and

turned around and looked back.

The smoke was still going up, but it had thinned, and the sun was on the roofs of the city beyond it, the whole enormous slope of Rome, temples and insulae and the tops of the aqueducts and the great shining roof of a temple on the Palatine, and the city went on, in the way it always does, indifferent and alive and extremely beautiful.

'Forty-one years,' said Antonia.

'What?'

'I was sold at Puteoli when I was sixteen,' said Antonia, 'and I came to this city at twenty-two with a hundred and ten thousand sesterces and a lock, and I have been in it for twenty years, and I have built a house and lost it twice — once in March, when I gave it away, and once last night, when it burned. And in twenty years nobody in this city has ever offered me a room with no rent until this morning.'

'That woman did not know you,' said Myrrhine.

'No,' said Antonia. 'That is the point.'

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Reckoning

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The three days between the fire and the reckoning were the strangest of her life, and she spent them being useful.

There was a great deal to do. The city had four hundred and eleven families without a roof on the north slope, and the corn office had a list and the baths of Titus had beds and the vigiles had a captain who had been up for two nights and who, on the second morning, sat down on a step in the Forum and could not get up again. Antonia went to the baths at the fourth hour with Myrrhine and Vibia Lucana, who had come over from the Caelian at dawn with a cart of blankets and had taken charge of the linen, and she stayed until the ninth hour, and what she did was not noble; it was clerical.

She sat at a table by the door with a tablet and made a list of who had come in and what they had lost: name, occupation, household, whether they had a trade, whether they had relatives in the city, whether they had papers. It was the same work she had done for eleven years, and she did it for two days, and by the second evening there were three hundred names on the list and eleven of them were people she knew.

On the second day a man came in who had been the doorkeeper of the house in the Argiletum in the year Prima was sold out of it, and he was sixty-four and had lost everything and had a cough, and he stood in front of the table and said, 'Domina, I know what you are and I do not hold with it, and I have nowhere to go.'

Antonia wrote his name down.

'There is a room in the fourth region over a bakery,' she said. 'It is small and it is dry and the woman who owns it is a midwife called Sabina and she will not be polite to you. You will go there tonight and you will tell her that I sent you and that you are to be given the room for a year, and in the

morning you will go to the workshop of a builder named Gaius Vipsanius Polla in the sandalmakers' street and ask for work as a watchman, and you will tell him that Antonia Cassia sent you, and he will not like it and he will give you the work.'

The old man looked at her.

'Why?' he said.

'Because you were at a gate for thirty years and you have a cough and you are sixty-four,' said Antonia, 'and because I have discovered this year that a person who has been at a gate for thirty years is worth more than the whole of the Senate and I did not know it until November.' She dipped her stylus. 'Next.'

On the third day the treasury's clerk came to the house on the Aventine with the papers about the burned site, and Antonia signed them in the courtyard, and the clerk said, 'Domina, there is a difficulty. The site is now a dangerous structure and the treasury does not want it, and the corridor for the aqueduct is going to be re-surveyed, and the curator has asked me to say that the survey will take place in the autumn and that nothing will be built on the north slope before the spring.'

'Why is that a difficulty?'

'It is not a difficulty for you,' said the clerk. 'It is a difficulty for me. I have to explain it in a schedule.'

Vibia Lucana, who was sitting in the courtyard with a cup of wine and her shoes off, waited until he had gone and then said, 'He has stopped the aqueduct.'

'He has delayed the survey.'

'He has stopped the aqueduct, and the whole slope is going to sit empty for a year, and in a year nobody will remember that it was going to be an aqueduct at all, and it will become a public garden with a plaque on it about the fire, and the plaque will not mention you, and I will come and look at it every year and be extremely pleased with myself.' She put her cup down. 'And you will go up the hill on the third day and stand in the ash

with him and say whatever it is you have been not saying for twenty-five years, and I will be here when you come back, and I will not ask you a single question, and then I will ask you eleven.'

'You have been talking to Myrrhine,' said Antonia.

'Myrrhine and I have been talking for four months,' said Vibia. 'We have a great deal in common. We are both women who have spent our lives being extremely competent in the service of somebody else's household, and we have both decided, at forty-five and thirty-seven, that we are going to stop.' She picked up her shoes. 'Go up the hill. Take your time. I will keep the courtyard.'

She went back on the third day, in the afternoon, alone.

The street had been cleared. The rubble was in heaps along the walls, and the vigiles had put a rope across the gap where the gate had been, and the treasury had put a notice on a post, and the whole north slope smelled of wet ash and the particular sour smell of a burned house, which is a smell she had known all her life and had never once been able to describe: charcoal and lime and something sweet underneath it.

She went in under the rope.

The house was smaller than it had been. That was the thing nobody told you about a burned building: it did not look destroyed so much as reduced, as though the fire had taken a wall away and the rooms had turned out to be the size of rooms and not the size of the life that had been lived in them.

She walked through the front rooms and the atrium and into the peristyle. Two columns were standing. The fountain's basin was full of black water and something in it, and the fig tree in the garden had burned to a black stump with four branches on it, and beyond the wall the cypress was still standing, burned on one side and green on the other.

He was standing in the middle of the peristyle with his hands behind his back.

She stopped.

'How long have you been here?' she said.

'An hour. Perhaps two.' He was in a plain tunic with no toga and no rings, and his shoes were grey with ash, and he had been standing so still that the ash had begun to settle on his shoulders. 'The treasury's clerk let me in. I told him I was the curator of the public works and that I had come to inspect a dangerous structure, which is true; the whole of this slope is a dangerous structure at the moment and I am going to spend the summer signing orders about it.'

'You did not have to come.'

'No,' said Tarquitius. 'I have been coming every day since the fire. This is the fourth time. The first time I came at the fifth hour of the morning on the day itself and the roof was still falling in, and I stood in the street and watched it, and there were four hundred people in that street and not one of them knew who I was.' He looked at the burned fig tree. 'I have wanted to say something to you for eleven days and I have not known what it was, and I have come up this hill four times in order to say it, and each time I have stood in this courtyard and said nothing at all.'

Antonia came and stood beside him.

'Say it now,' she said. 'There is nobody here and the walls are down and the roof is off, and I have discovered this year that there is no better place to say a thing than a room with no roof.'

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He was silent for a long time.

'I have made a list,' he said at last. 'In the way that I make lists. I have written it out four times and burned it four times and the fourth one was the shortest, and it had three things on it.' He took a folded paper out of his sleeve. 'I am not going to read it to you. I am going to say the three things and then I am going to give you the paper, and you may keep it or burn it, and I am not going to ask you for anything.'

'Then say them.'

'The first is that I lied to myself for twenty-five years,' said Tarquitius, 'and I did it deliberately, and it was not a mistake and it was not a weakness

and it was not the fault of my sister's letter. I was told that you and the child had died, and I believed it because believing it was convenient, and I did not ask a single question. I did not write to the household at Arretium. I did not go to Puteoli, which is four days' journey, and I was a man of thirty with a private income and no duties, and I could have gone in September and I did not go for twenty-five years.' He looked at the fountain. 'And then, when I was forty and you opened a house in Rome and every man in the city began to talk about the woman Cassia, I knew. I knew in the first month. There cannot have been a man in Rome who did not tell me the story of the woman from Puteoli who had bought the house on the Esquiline, and I heard it and I said nothing, and I did not go to see you, and I did not write, and I did not send a single message in nineteen years.'

'Why not?' said Antonia.

'Because I was a senator,' said Tarquitius, 'and because the story had me in it, and because a man who goes to that house to ask a question is a man who has answered one. And because — this is the second thing on the list, and it is worse — I was angry with you.' He turned. 'I was angry with you for nineteen years. I had built a version of it in which I had been generous and you had taken what was offered and gone, and in that version you were a woman who had done very well out of a bad business, and every year that your house got richer and your name got larger I was confirmed in it. I mentioned you in the Senate. I did it deliberately. I stood up in that chamber, year after year, and spoke about the corruption of the city's pleasures, and I did it because it was the only way I had of touching you.'

Antonia stood very still.

'That is the truest thing you have ever said to me,' she said.

'It is the truest thing I have ever said to anybody,' said Tarquitius. 'It has taken me fifty-three years and a fire.'

'And the third thing?'

He was quiet for a moment.

'The third thing is that I loved you,' he said. 'I was twenty-nine years old and I was a man who had been sent home from the frontier in disgrace

and was living in his father's house with nothing to do and no future, and there was a girl in the linen room who could read and who found a hole in my argument about the law of boundaries and laughed at me, and I have not been laughed at in that way by anybody since.' He folded the paper. 'I have never said that to anyone. I have not said it to my wife, who is dead, or to my mother, or to my daughter. I have said it in a letter every August for twenty-five years and burned it at the ninth hour in the brazier by the wall, which you knew, because your daughter told you, and which I have known that you knew since November, and which is the single most humiliating thing about me.'

Antonia looked at the burned stump of the fig tree.

'I am going to say my three things,' she said, 'and then we will be even, and I do not promise that they will be kind.'

'Say them.'

'The first is that I have hated you for twenty-five years, and I have hated you in public and in private and in a way that has been useful to me, because a woman in my position needs somebody to be against, and you were the best available. In the second year after I opened the house I turned down an offer of a partnership and a great deal of money from a man in Ostia because he was a friend of yours, and I told myself that I was being prudent, and I was not being prudent. I was being sixteen years old in a corridor with a jug in my hands.' She looked at him. 'I built a house with a wall around it and I put you outside the wall, and everything I have done since has been easier because you were outside it. That is not a small thing, and it is not a noble thing, and it is mine.'

'I know,' said Tarquitius.

'I know you do not,' said Antonia. 'You have come up this hill four times to say a thing and you have prepared a list, and the list has three items on it, and none of the three is the four thousand sesterces.' She turned. 'You asked me in November whether I took money out of your father's house and I told you no, and you looked at me as though a paper had been

turned over. And then you went home and you asked your mother, and your mother told you the truth about the accounts, and she has told me since that she told you, and that you said nothing at all and went out into the garden and stood there for an hour.' She looked at him. 'You have never mentioned it since. Not in November, not at the trial, not in the garden in December when you gave me the letter. Four thousand sesterces. Your sister took it out of the steward's account in the month I was sold, and she used part of it to buy the ground the tenements stood on, and she has lived in a house at Tibur for twenty-five years on the interest, and you have known that since November and you have not said one word to me about it.'

Tarquitius stood with his hand on the basin.

'I have not said one word to her either,' he said. 'I have written to her four times and burned all four letters. She is seventy-nine and she cannot walk and she is in a great deal of pain, and every time I begin a letter I find that I am writing to a woman who is going to die in the spring, and that there is nothing I can say to her that will do anything except make her last months worse.' He looked up. 'That is not a justification. I know exactly what it is. It is the same thing I did when I was thirty and my father died and my sister managed everything and I went back to Rome and was correct. I am a man who does nothing, and I do it with a great deal of deliberation and a great many lists.'

'Yes,' said Antonia. 'You are.'

'And the money,' he said. 'I have it. My mother gave me the whole of it out of her own purse in December, because she had it put by for twenty-five years, and it has been in my strongbox since the ides of December and I have not been able to think of a single thing to do with it. It is four thousand sesterces. It is a sum a man spends on a dinner.' He reached into the sleeve of his tunic and took out a small purse, which he put on the rim of the fountain. 'It is not restitution. There is no restitution. It is a purse on a wall in a burned courtyard, and you may take it and give it to the woman who lost her mother in the wineshop, and it will buy her a bed and a winter, and it will not be anything at all.'

Antonia looked at the purse.

'I will give it to her,' she said. 'And I will tell her where it came from, and she will not understand, and she will say thank you, and that will be the end of it.'

'Yes,' said Tarquitius.

'And you will not send your sister anything,' said Antonia. 'Not a letter and not a word and not a purse. She has been dying for more than a decade and she has had twenty-five years to say one true thing and she has not said it, and you are not going to give her absolution because you are her brother and you are tired. If she wants to say something she knows where the temple of Castor is; she can send a clerk.' She turned away. 'That is not justice either. I am aware of it. But it is what I have.'

'The second thing,' she said, 'is that I loved you and I have never once been able to say it in the past tense.' She turned and looked at him properly. 'I was fifteen. I had been a slave since I was eleven and I had never in my life been asked what I thought about anything, and you asked me what I thought about Livy, and you corrected my Latin, and you told me I would have made a jurist, and you said, "I will look after you," and I believed you.' Her voice was steady. 'I have spent twenty-five years being angry with you for what happened afterwards, and this year I have discovered that the thing I cannot forgive is not what you did. It is that I would have gone anywhere with you. If you had come to me in that garden at Puteoli when I was sixteen and said, "Get in the cart," I would have got in the cart. I would have left the child. I would have gone to the Danube with you and lived in a tent and been happy. And there is no version of my life in which I am a woman who would have said no to you, and I have never been able to look at that directly, and I am looking at it now, in a burned courtyard, at the age of forty-two.'

Tarquitius had put his hand out and was holding the edge of the fountain's basin.

'Antonia—'

'The third thing,' she said, 'is that there is nothing to forgive, and I am not going to forgive you, and I want you to understand the difference.' She turned to face him. 'If I forgive you, then we are two people who have had a quarrel and made it up, and we will be friends, and you will come to dinner, and in a year we will be an old scandal that the city has got used to, and there will be a version of it in which it all came right. And it did not come right. There is a girl of twenty-five in the fourth region who was sold for two hundred and forty sesterces and who has spent the whole of her life not knowing her own birthday, and there is a man in the ground outside the Colline gate who was killed in my garden in November, and there is a woman at Tibur who is dying in pain and who will die without ever having said a true thing to anybody. I am not going to forgive you, and I am not going to be your friend, and I am not going to be your old scandal. If we are anything at all, we will be two people who know exactly what happened and who have decided to be in the same room anyway, and that is a harder thing than forgiveness and it lasts longer.'

He stood in the ruined peristyle with the paper in his hand.

'There is a thing I have wanted to ask you for a year,' he said, 'and it is small, and it is not on the list, and I do not know why it matters.'

'Ask.'

'The first time we spoke,' said Tarquitius. 'In the corridor by the linen room, in June, in the afternoon. You came round the corner with a jug and I was standing against the wall with blood on my hands.' He looked at his own hands. 'I have thought about that afternoon for twenty-five years, and I have never been able to remember it properly. I remember the blood and the corridor and the jug. I do not remember what I said. I have a memory of saying something about your name, and I do not know whether that is true or whether I have made it up out of wanting to have asked.'

'You asked me my name,' said Antonia. 'You asked whose I was, and I said I was in the linen, under Faustus, and you said that Faustus was a good man and a thief and that it was a combination one learns to value in a

household.'

Tarquitius made a sound.

'That is exactly the sort of thing I would have said,' he said. 'Gods. I was a pompous man at thirty and I have got worse.' He rubbed his face. 'What were the blood and the jug?'

'Your father had been bled,' said Antonia. 'The physician had bled him that morning and there was a great deal of blood, and your father had said something to you that you did not repeat, and you stood in that corridor and looked at your hands as though they belonged to somebody else.' She paused. 'You said thank you. That is the thing I remember. I poured water over your hands and you said thank you, and I went away and lay in the women's room that night and thought that a man who could have anything he wanted had said thank you to a girl with a jug.'

Tarquitius was silent for a long moment.

'I do not remember saying thank you,' he said. 'I believe you. But I do not remember it, and that is the whole of it: I was thirty years old and I was kind for eleven seconds in a corridor and I did not even notice, and it was the most important thing that happened to me that year.' He looked at her. 'I have spent the whole of my life being told that I am a man of consequence, and the only thing that ever changed anybody was eleven seconds in a corridor that I do not remember.'

'That is not the only thing,' said Antonia. 'There was also the winter, and the library, and the Greek. Do not make it smaller than it was in order to make it neater.'

'No,' he said. 'All right.'

'And there is a thing I am going to say to you now that I have not said to anyone, and then we will go on to the settlement.' She looked at the burned stump of the fig tree. 'I have not been able to be a wife, and I have not been able to be respectable, and I have not been able to be a mother to a girl of twenty-five who calls me nothing at all. And I have spent this year discovering that the only thing I have ever been good at, in the end, is being a woman who keeps a house. Not the business. The house. The bread at the fourth hour and the man at the gate and the girl on the roof and the

accounts.' She looked at him. 'My whole life is going to be three rooms on the Aventine and a dinner on the seventh day of the month. And I find that I am not sorry. And I would like somebody in the world to know that I am not sorry, because everyone in this city will think that I am.'

'Then what are we?' he said.

'We are two people who are going to have dinner,' said Antonia, 'on the seventh day of every month, in a small house on the Aventine that has three rooms and a yard and a roof that will not last the year. Myrrhine will be there and she will not be polite to you. Tertia will be there when she chooses to be, and she will call me nothing at all and she will call you nothing at all, and you will not ask her to call you anything, and if you do I will have you put out of the house. You will bring the wine because you have better wine than I do. We will talk about the law of boundaries and the price of lead and the aqueduct, and we will not talk about the villa at Arretium unless one of us says the word, and if one of us says the word we will talk about it for as long as it takes.' She held out her hand. 'That is the settlement. That is all of it. It is not very much and it is more than most people get, and it is what I have, and you may take it or leave it.'

Tarquitius looked at her hand.

'You are a very hard woman,' he said.

'Yes,' said Antonia. 'I have had to be.'

'I am not complaining,' he said. 'I have spent the whole of my life in rooms where nobody was hard with me, and I have discovered this year that it is a kind of loneliness that I did not have a word for.' He took her hand. 'I will take it. The seventh day of every month. I will bring the wine, and I will not be polite to your atriens—' He stopped. 'To Myrrhine. I will not attempt to be.' He let go of her hand. 'There is one thing more, and it is not on the list, and I have to say it now or I will not say it at all. I am not going to ask you to marry me. I want to be clear that I have considered it and that I am not going to do it, and I am going to tell you why, because you will otherwise think that it is because of my name.'

'Why?'

'Because a marriage would make you respectable,' said Tarquitius, 'and I have spent this year watching what respectability does to women in this city. It would give you a place at the games and a seat in the second row and the right to be spoken to at dinner, and in exchange you would be the wife of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus for the rest of your life, and every man in Rome who came to your house in the last eleven years would say that you had done very well for yourself, and they would be right, and it would be the smallest possible version of everything you have built.' He put the paper into her hand. 'You are the only person I have ever met who is not improved by being attached to me. I am not going to ruin it.'

Antonia stood in the ash with the paper in her hand.

'That is the first thing you have said in twenty-five years that I did not expect,' she said.

'I know,' said Tarquitius. 'I have been practising it for four days. It is the only good sentence I have ever constructed without a pen.'

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They walked out through the rooms together.

In the front of the house, where the atrium had been, the treasury men had put up a trestle and were making a list of what could be salvaged, and there was nothing on the list but lead and iron. In the street the rope was down and a cart was going past with a load of burnt timber, and the woman who sold chickpeas had set up her brazier at the corner and was doing a good trade with the workmen.

At the gap where the gate had been, Tarquitius stopped and took the folded paper out of her hand and unfolded it and read it.

It said:

1. That I knew and did not ask. 2. That I was angry with her for nineteen years and used her name in the Senate to do it. 3. That I loved her, and that I have never said so to anyone, and that it is not an excuse.

At the bottom there was one line more, in smaller writing.

4. That everything I have done this year has been too late, and that I did it anyway.

He folded it and gave it back to her.

'You may burn it,' he said.

'I know,' said Antonia, and put it in her sleeve.

She walked down the hill alone, past the baths of Titus and the place where the street narrowed, and at the corner of the Vicus Cyprius she stopped and turned round and looked back at the black slope and the ruined houses and the cypress standing with one side green and one side burned.

Then she took the paper out of her sleeve and read it again, standing in the street in the middle of the afternoon with the carts going past.

She did not burn it. She had burned a great many things in her life, at the ninth hour of the evening, in a brazier, and she had discovered in the last year that a thing burned is not a thing finished; it is a thing that has been fed to the fire and will come back in the smoke.

She folded it and put it in her sleeve, and went down the hill to the three rooms on the Aventine, where Myrrhine was arguing with a man about a bed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Name

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On the third day of May, Tertia Vipsania went to the temple of Castor to have her name changed, and she took Antonia with her.

They went in the morning, on foot, up the Vicus Tuscus and into the Forum, and they went the long way round because Tertia said that she was not going to arrive at the most important morning of her life by the shortest route.

The temple of Castor was where the registers were kept, in a room behind the cella with a long counter and four clerks and a great many boxes, and the whole of it smelled of dust and ink and the beeswax they used on the tablets. There were eleven people in the queue. The queue was made up of freedmen and freedwomen and one man with a goat, and everybody in it was patient, because a queue at a registry office is the most patient thing in the world.

'What do I say?' said Tertia.

'You say: "I am a freedwoman of the household of the Tarquitii, freed by the council's leave in the seventh year before the present consulship, and I ask to be entered under the name Metrodora, which was my mother's name."'

'And then?'

'And then he will ask you why, and you will say that it is your name and that you are a free woman and that you may be called what you like. And then he will look at you as though you have asked him to give you a horse, and then he will do it, because it is the law and because the fee is eleven sesterces.'

The clerk was a thin man of fifty with ink on his fingers. He listened to Tertia, and he looked at the old register, and he looked at her, and he said, 'Metrodora is a Greek name.'

'It was my mother's name.'

'It is not a Roman name.'

'I am aware of that,' said Tertia.

'It will be entered as a Greek freedwoman's name and the tax will be the same and the entries in the margin will say —'

'The entries in the margin may say whatever the law requires them to say,' said Tertia, 'and my name will be Metrodora.'

The clerk looked at her over his tablets. Then he looked at Antonia, who was standing behind her with her hands folded, and something in his face changed, because he was a clerk in the temple of Castor and he had been in that room for twenty years and he knew exactly who she was.

He wrote it in.

It took a quarter of an hour. He made the entry in the register in his careful hand: *Metrodora, freedwoman, formerly of the household of the Tarquitii at Arretium, freed by the council's leave in the seventh year before the consulship of the emperor Caesar Nerva Traianus Augustus, entered this day at her own request under the name Metrodora, born the twenty-ninth day of August in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo, of a slave mother of the household of the Tarquitii, father unknown.*

'Father unknown,' said the clerk.

'Father unknown,' said Metrodora.

He sanded it and closed the tablet and took the fee and gave her the receipt, and said, in the voice of a man who has done his duty and would like to be done with it, 'Next.'

They came out of the temple into the Forum, and Tertia — Metrodora — stood on the steps with the receipt in her hand.

'I have a birthday,' she said. 'I have a birthday and a name and a mother, and my mother's name is written in the register of the Roman people in the temple of Castor, and in a hundred years anybody who wants to will be able to find it.' She was crying, and she was not doing anything about it. 'It cost nine sesterces.'

'Everything costs eleven sesterces in that room,' said Antonia. 'It is the only honest institution in the city.'

'Do not make a joke. I am going to cry in the Forum and I would like you to stand here and let me.'

Antonia stood there and let her.

When it was over, Metrodora wiped her face with the back of her hand and said, 'I am not going to be Metrodora Cassia. I want you to know that. I am not taking your name.'

'I did not ask you to.'

'I know. That is why I am telling you. I have thought about it for four months and I have decided that I am not going to be the daughter of Antonia Cassia in any document anywhere, because in ten years every man in this city will say that I got my school because of you, and it will not be true, and I will not be able to prove it.' She put the receipt in her sleeve. 'I am going to be Metrodora, and I am going to keep the builder's books and teach three girls their letters in the back room, and in five years I am going to have a school with my own name over the door, and it will be a school for slave girls and freed girls and the daughters of shopkeepers, and we will teach them to read and to add and to write a contract, and every one of them will be able to look at a piece of paper and know what she is signing.' She looked at Antonia. 'That is what I am going to do with my life. I am telling you before I have done any of it, which is not like me, and I am telling you because I want one person in the world to know that I decided it and that I decided it on a step in the Forum with a receipt in my hand.'

Antonia looked at her.

'You will need four hundred thousand sesterces,' she said, 'for a lease and tables and stools and styluses and the first three years of a teacher's wage. You will need an advocate to draw the deed of the school and an introduction to the guild of the sandalmakers for the lease, and you will need a woman who has kept accounts for eleven years to tell you that four hundred thousand is what it will cost and not one sesterce less.'

Metrodora was silent.

'I am not offering you money,' said Antonia.

'I know.'

'I am telling you what it costs, which is what I would tell any woman who came to my study with a plan.' She turned and looked across the Forum. 'And if you ever want it — the four hundred thousand, at no interest, with a deed in your own name and mine nowhere on it, and a clause that says I have no claim on you or on the school and that you may tell me to take it back at any time — then you will come to the house on the Aventine and ask, and I will give it to you, and I will not mention it again and I will not come to see the school unless you ask me.' She started down the steps. 'That is all. That is the whole of it. Now come and eat something; it is the third hour and you have not eaten since yesterday.'

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The empress sent for her in June.

The message came through a freedman of the palace in the morning, and it said that the Augusta wished to speak with Antonia Cassia on a matter concerning the maintenance of girls, and that a litter would be sent at the fourth hour, and that the matter was not confidential but that the Augusta would prefer it if the visit were not discussed in the city until it had been decided.

Antonia went in her dark blue dress, with the carnelian ring, and was taken through the palace by a corridor that was not the public one, and into a room with a garden on the Palatine that she had never seen and would never see again.

Pompeia Plotina was perhaps fifty. She was not beautiful and had never been, and she had a face that was entirely without malice, which was the most unnerving thing about her; a woman in Rome who has no malice is either a fool or something the city has no word for.

'Domina,' she said. 'Sit down. There is wine and there is water and I am told that you do not drink in the morning, which is sensible and which I have never managed.'

Antonia sat.

'You have been in the city this year,' said Plotina, 'in a manner which has been discussed in this house a great deal. I do not intend to discuss it. I

intend to ask you to do some work.'

'What work?'

'The emperor has decided that the state should maintain children,' said the empress. 'Not all children; there is no money for all children, and the Senate would not permit it. There will be a fund, endowed from the treasury and from the emperor's own purse, and it will pay a monthly sum to the guardians of boys and girls in the towns of Italy — four hundred towns, to begin with — and the sum will be small and the point is not charity. The point is that a child who is maintained by the state is a child who does not have to be sold, and a town that has four hundred of those children is a town that will give the emperor a great deal of money in taxes for forty years.'

'It is a very good scheme,' said Antonia.

'It is a very good scheme and it will fail,' said Plotina, 'for a reason that no one in this palace will say out loud, which is that the men who administer it will steal it. Not the great men; the clerks. A fund of that size passing through four hundred towns and eleven thousand hands will lose a third of itself in the first year to men who tell themselves that they are taking a fee for their trouble, and the emperor will be told in the fifth year that the scheme does not work and that the provinces are ungrateful, and it will be quietly ended.' She put her cup down. 'I have read your file. I have read the Acta of the trial and the report of the prefect's office on the fire, and I have had four conversations with people who know you, one of whom is my own physician, who says that you kept a fire from crossing a street by telling four hundred frightened people where to stand.'

'I was not the only one at that fire,' said Antonia.

'No,' said Plotina. 'But you were the one who did it, and I have been in this palace for fourteen years and I know the difference between a person who is in a crowd at a disaster and a person who makes the crowd into a chain.' She leaned forward. 'I am not offering you a title. There is no title for this; there is no office in the state that a woman may hold, and I am not going to invent one, because the Senate would spend a year on it and the emperor has a war to finish. I am offering you a private commission, paid

from my own purse, to travel to eleven towns in Italy in the next two years and look at the accounts of the fund and report to me in writing, and to train the clerks, and to tell me which of the men I have appointed are stealing, with evidence, so that I may have them removed without a scandal.'

Antonia sat with her hands in her lap.

'Why me?' she said. 'There are a hundred equestrians in this city who can read an account and who would be honoured by the commission.'

'Because they would be honoured by it,' said Plotina, 'and you would not.' She turned her cup. 'I have been the wife of an emperor for fourteen years, domina, and I have learned that a person who is honoured by a commission is a person who can be managed by the threat of losing it. You have lost a house and a business and a reputation and a trial this year, and you are still here, and there is nothing I can take from you that you have not already given away, and that means that I can trust you, which is a thing I cannot say about a single man in this palace.'

'That is the most frightening compliment I have ever been paid,' said Antonia.

'Yes,' said Plotina. 'Will you do it?'

Antonia looked out at the garden.

'On four conditions,' she said. 'The first is that I am paid a wage and not a favour, and that the wage is entered in a book. The second is that I choose my own clerk, and that he is a freedman of my household and not a man of yours. The third is that I report to you in writing and that my reports are kept, and that if I am removed the reports are not destroyed. The fourth —'

'Yes?'

'The fourth is that when I find a man who is stealing from a fund for orphan children,' said Antonia, 'I will not be required to be discreet about it. I will give you the evidence and a month to act, and if nothing is done in a month I will take it to the urban prefect myself, and I will not ask your permission, and I will not be sorry.'

Plotina looked at her for a long moment.

'Agreed,' she said. 'All four. And domina — the fourth condition is why I sent for you, and if you had not asked for it I would have found a way to require it.' She stood up. 'There is one thing more, and it is not a condition. The emperor is going to the east in the autumn. He will not be back in this city for two years, perhaps three, and while he is away the men in this palace will be extremely brave. I would like to know that there is one woman in Rome who is reading the accounts.'

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The first of the seventh-day dinners was on the seventh of May, and it was a disaster, and it was the best evening Antonia had spent in years.

The house on the Aventine had three rooms and a courtyard, and the courtyard held a table for six if nobody moved their elbows. Myrrhine had made the food herself because the household no longer had a cook, and it was a fish and a great deal of bread and a dish of lentils that she had made too quickly and that was, she said, a disgrace.

Tarquitius arrived at the ninth hour with four jars of wine and a face like a man going to a tribunal.

He stood in the doorway of the courtyard with the jars and said, 'Domina.'

'Do not call me domina in this house,' said Antonia. 'It is a courtyard with a fig tree in it and there are five people at that table and one of them is a freedwoman who will not be polite to you.'

'I am aware,' said Tarquitius, and came in.

Myrrhine was not polite to him. She was not rude either, which was worse; she was brisk, and she gave him a stool that wobbled, and when he complimented the lentils she said, 'They are not good, they are too quick, and you are a senator and you know it,' and he said, 'I am a senator and I have eaten in eleven provinces and they are too quick and they are not bad,' and Myrrhine looked at him for a moment and then said, 'There is salt on the shelf behind you,' and that was the end of the war.

Vibia Lucana came, and Marcellina, and Metrodora came late, at the second hour, when they had already begun, because she had been working.

She came into the courtyard in her working dress with a stylus behind her ear and stopped when she saw who was at the table.

Tarquitius put down his cup and stood up.

They looked at each other across the courtyard. Nobody said anything. Myrrhine, who could have said something, did not; she got up and went to the shelf and made a business of the salt.

'I am Metrodora,' said Metrodora.

'I know,' said Tarquitius. 'I am —'

'I know who you are.' She came into the courtyard and sat down in the empty place, which was next to him, because there was nowhere else, and put her box on the ground, and said, 'There is no wine in my cup.'

Tarquitius poured it.

He poured it very carefully, and his hand was not steady, and he did not say anything else at all for a quarter of an hour, and Metrodora ate her fish and answered Vibia's questions about the price of papyrus, and then, at the end of the fish, she turned to him and said, 'You moved an aqueduct.'

'I did.'

'Why?'

'Because it could be moved,' said Tarquitius, 'and because I am the curator of the public works and I have the discretion, and because the treasury did not care and the guild of the sandalmakers has a stronger claim than you did.'

'That is not an answer,' said Metrodora.

'No,' said Tarquitius. 'It is not. The answer is that I had spent the whole of the year being told, in every possible way, that a man in my position could not do anything at all, and I discovered in February that I could move an aqueduct eleven feet, and that it was the only thing I had done in twenty years that was worth doing, and that it was too late, and that I did it anyway.' He looked at his cup. 'The list of things that are too late is very long, and I have been adding to it all year, and I find that I am going to spend the rest of my life doing small useless things in the hope that one of them will not be useless.'

Metrodora ate a piece of bread.

'That is an answer,' she said.

Marcellina went to Lugdunum in June.

She went with her father, who had hired a carriage and a physician and a woman to look after the children on the road, and she went with a box of her own clothes and a purse of her own money and a letter from Antonia to a shipping agent at Massilia, and she was away for eleven weeks.

She came back in September with two children: a girl of fifteen called Verana and a boy of twelve called Brennus, who had been called something else and who had asked, on the second day of the journey, whether he might be called Brennus, because that was the name of the man who had been killed in his father's place.

Antonia met them at the gate of the house on the Aventine, and the boy stood in front of her with his cap in his hands and said, 'Domina, I am to thank you for the four sesterces.'

'What eleven sesterces?'

'The fifteen sesterces in the fold of the shroud,' said the boy. 'The man from the prefect's office told us. He said that a boy in a kitchen in Rome had put eleven sesterces in with my father, and that it was all the money he had, and that he had been saving it, and that he had put it in the shroud and would not take it out.' He held out his hand, and there were nine sesterces in it, and they were the same eleven sesterces. 'I have carried them from Lugdunum. I would like to give them back to him, and I am told that he is in a house in the fourth region now, and that he is a watchman.'

Antonia looked at the coins in his hand.

'His name is Gaius,' she said. 'He is at the workshop of Gaius Vipsanius Polla in the sandalmakers' street, and he is a watchman, and he is sixty-four, and he will cry when he sees you, and then he will pretend that he has something in his eye.' She put her hand on the boy's shoulder. 'You may keep the four sesterces. He would want you to keep them. But you will go and see him tomorrow, and you will tell him that you came all the way

from Lugdunum, and you will let him give you dinner, and he will give you the worst dinner you have ever eaten and you will eat all of it.'

In August, the stone was put up over Brennus, outside the Colline gate, and Antonia went to see it with Sestius.

He had paid for it and he had arranged it and he had written the inscription himself, and he had not told her what it said, and they stood in the ground outside the gate in the heat with the cypresses and the small square plots and the sound of the road beyond the wall.

It was a good stone: a plain stele of Luna marble, three feet high, with a moulding at the top and the letters cut deep and filled with red.

It said:

TO THE MEMORY OF BRENNUS, A SEQUANI, FREEDMAN WHO WAS NINE YEARS IN THE HOUSE OF ANTONIA CASSIA AND WAS KILLED IN HER COURTYARD DEFENDING IT AGED FORTY-FOUR YEARS HIS SON BRENNUS AND HIS DAUGHTER VERANA WHO WERE FOUND, HAVE SET THIS UP AND HIS FRIEND MENO, WHO KEPT THE GATE WITH HIM, HAS PAID FOR THE LETTERS.

Antonia read it twice.

'He will not be able to read it,' she said.

'No,' said Sestius. 'But he will come and stand in front of it, and somebody will read it to him, and in a hundred years there will be a stone in this ground with a Sequani's name on it and two children's names under it, and that is more than most people in this city get.' He looked at the stone. 'My daughter wrote the fourth line. She would not let me have it my way; I had written "his master's house" and she said that he was a freedman and that it was not his master's house, it was his house, and that the stone would say so.'

'She is right,' said Antonia.

'She is always right,' said Sestius. 'It is the most irritating thing about her.' He put his hands behind his back. 'I am selling the house on the

Esquiline. Not because I am ruined; I am ruined, but that is not why. I am selling it because my daughter has said that she will not live in it, and because I have discovered that I do not want to live in a house that my wife will not leave and my son will not come back to.' He looked at the stone. 'I am going to Tusculum. There is a small property there, eleven acres and a bad house, and I am going to grow olives badly and be extremely dull, and once a month I am going to come to Rome and have dinner with my daughter, and once a year I am going to come to this stone and stand in front of it.' He turned. 'Domina. I am not going to ask you to forgive me and I am not going to say that I have learned anything. I am going to say one thing, and then I will go and be dull.

'Say it.'

'When I brought that charge,' said Sestius, 'I believed every word of it. I want you to know that. I was not a liar and I was not a man manufacturing evidence; I was a father who had lost his son and who had been told a story by a physician and a steward who both had reasons of their own. And I have thought about that for a year, and what I have concluded is this: it is possible to be entirely sincere and entirely wrong, and to do a great deal of harm, and to be believed by the whole city while you are doing it. I did not know that at fifty-eight. I know it now. And I find that it is the only useful thing I have ever learned.'

He went away through the cypresses toward the road, limping slightly, in a plain toga, and one of the workmen touched his cap to him as he passed, and Antonia stood by the stone for a while after he had gone.

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In October, the emperor offered Tarquitius the proconsulship of Asia.

It came through the consul, in the ordinary way, in a letter of four lines, and it said that the emperor had reconsidered the matter of the previous year and that the province would be available in the spring and that he would be glad to know whether the curator of the public works could be spared.

He came to the house on the Aventine with the letter in his sleeve and sat in the courtyard and did not say anything for a while.

'You are going to take it,' said Antonia.

'I do not know.'

'You are going to take it,' she said again, 'and I am going to tell you why, and then we will not discuss it again. You are fifty-four years old and you have one province left in you and you have spent the whole of this year being told that you are finished. If you do not go, you will be a man in a garden in Rome with a great deal of time and no work, and you will become the sort of man who reads the Acta in the morning and complains about the aqueducts, and in five years you will be unbearable and I will not be able to have you at my table.' She poured the wine. 'Go to Asia. Govern it well; you are very good at the law and you have a horror of being thought corrupt, which is better than virtue. Come back in two years. Write to me once a month, and do not write about your feelings, because you write about your feelings like a man drafting a will. Write about the province and the price of grain and the men who are stealing.'

'And Metrodora?' said Tarquitius.

'Metrodora will be here,' said Antonia, 'and she will have her school, and she will write to you if she chooses, and you will not ask her to.' She looked at him. 'You have two daughters, Lucius. One of them is nineteen and has just come back from Gaul with two children who are not hers, and she has discovered that she is good at something, and it is not keeping accounts. The other is twenty-five and has a name in a register and a plan and four hundred thousand sesterces that she has not yet asked me for. Neither of them needs you to stay in Rome. Both of them will be here in two years. Go and be a proconsul and come back with a reputation and a great deal of money and something to say at dinner.'

Tarquitius looked at the letter.

'Two years,' he said.

'Two years,' said Antonia, 'and a letter once a month, and the seventh day of the month when you are in Rome, and no promises. We are neither of us in the business of promises; we are in the business of showing up.'

She held out her cup. 'Now drink your wine and tell me about the price of lead, because I have been asked to look at the accounts of a fund in eleven towns and I have discovered that I do not know the first thing about lead.'

That night she went up onto the roof.

The house on the Aventine had a flat roof over the back room with a low parapet, and it was not the roof of the Golden Vine and it would never be, and from it you could see the river and the roof of the temple of Portunus and, on a clear night, the top of the Palatine.

Myrrhine came up with a lamp and a cup and sat down beside her.

'Well,' she said.

'Well.'

'He is going to Asia.'

'In the spring.'

'And you are going to be a woman of forty-three in a courtyard with a fig tree, reading the accounts of orphan funds in eleven towns, with a daughter who calls you nothing at all and a girl of nineteen who has adopted two children and a dinner on the seventh day of every month.'

'Yes,' said Antonia.

Myrrhine was quiet for a while.

'When I was nineteen,' she said, 'in the house at Puteoli, I used to lie on the roof at night and look at the sky and think: there is a woman somewhere in the world who has a house and a courtyard and a fig tree and nobody's name over the gate, and if I could be her for one day I would die happy.'

Antonia turned her head.

'And now?'

'Now I am her,' said Myrrhine, 'and I have been her for twenty-two years, and it turns out that being her is mostly reading the accounts and arguing with a dyer about a well and telling a woman of forty-three that she cannot have four jars of wine in the house because there is nowhere to put them.' She lay back on the tiles. 'I would not change a day of it. I want that

in the record. Whatever happens, whatever the city says, whatever is written on the plaque in the public garden where the house used to be — I would not change a day of it.'

Antonia lay back beside her and looked at the sky.

It was the fourth day of October and the night was clear and cold, and above the river and the temple and the top of the Palatine the whole of the sky was full of stars, and the Ram was somewhere up there and the Bull and the Twins, and there was nobody on the roof to point them out.

'Myrrhine,' she said.

'Mm.'

'There is going to be a plaque.'

'Of course there is going to be a plaque. The city puts a plaque on everything. It will say that the site was cleared after a fire in the consulship of two men nobody remembers, and in a hundred years there will be a garden with a wall round it and children will play in it and nobody will know.'

'And do you think,' said Antonia, 'that in a hundred years, someone will stand in that garden and say that there was a woman here, and that she was a slave, and that she built a house, and that she was tried for murder in the Basilica Julia in November and was acquitted, and that when the house burned she stood in the street and put four hundred people into a chain?'

Myrrhine thought about it.

'No,' she said. 'But you will know. I will know. Metrodora will know, and she has it in a register in the temple of Castor in her own hand, and Marcellina will tell the two children, and the boy will tell his children that his father was killed in a courtyard and that a woman put eleven sesterces in his shroud.' She reached over and took Antonia's hand. 'That is the whole of it. That is the only immortality there is, and it is not very much, and it is ours.'

They lay on the roof until the second hour of the night, and then they went down into the house, and Antonia put out the lamp.

EPILOGUE

The Garden

— ◆ —

Rome, six years later.

In the summer of the year when the emperor Hadrian came back from the east with the news that the provinces beyond the Euphrates were to be given up, the north slope of the Esquiline was a garden.

It had taken four years and a great deal of argument. The aqueduct had been abandoned in the autumn after the fire and the site had sat empty for a year with a rope around it, and then the treasury had sold the land to the city for a sum that was entered in the accounts as a nominal price because nobody could think what else to do with it, and the city had built a wall and laid a path and put in eleven fig trees and a fountain at the corner which did not work properly and was never repaired.

In the middle of the garden, on a low stone base, there was a bronze tablet.

It said that the site had been cleared after a fire in the consulship of two men whose names nobody remembered, that eleven houses and four workshops had been destroyed and forty-one people had died, and that the ground was given to the people of Rome for a garden in the fourth year after the fire, in the consulship of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus and Publius Calpurnius, by the favour of the emperor Caesar Nerva Traianus Augustus and of the senate and people.

There was no other inscription. There was no mention of a woman, or of a house, or of anything that had happened on that slope before the fire.

The children played in it.

———

Antonia was forty-eight years old and she had a house on the Aventine with four rooms and a courtyard and a fig tree, and she was, by the reckoning of the prefect's office, a person of some consequence in the city.

She had spent six years travelling to eleven towns in Italy, twice, with a clerk and a strongbox and a letter from the Augusta, and she had looked at the accounts of the imperial fund for the maintenance of children, and she had found that in four of the towns the money was being stolen by the clerk of the local council, and in one town by two men who had been appointed by the provincial governor, and in one town by nobody at all, which had astonished her and which she had reported in writing with a certain amount of pleasure.

Four men had been removed. One man had been prosecuted and had gone into exile at Massilia, and had written to her from Massilia, of all things, to complain about the climate. The fund had lost eleven per cent in the first two years and four per cent in the third, and in the fourth year it had lost nothing at all, and the empress had sent her a letter of four lines in her own hand, and Antonia had kept the letter in the chest with the other things.

She was not respectable. That had not changed and she had stopped expecting it to. She was not invited to the dinners of the senatorial families, and when she went to the baths the women of the old houses were civil to her in a way that was worse than rudeness, and the aedile in the fifth year had asked her opinion on the price of bread and had then, in the Senate, forgotten to mention that he had asked.

But four men had been removed from their posts, and eleven towns had kept their money, and there were four hundred children in Italy who were being fed at the state's expense and whose names were in a book that Antonia Cassia had caused to be kept honestly.

She had decided, in the second year, that this was what she had instead of a name.

Metrodora's school was in a building in the sandalmakers' street with a yard and two rooms and a door painted green.

She had taken the four hundred thousand sesterces in the December after the fire, in the courtyard on the Aventine, with a deed that Antonia's

own advocate had drawn and that said, in the fourth clause, that the lender had no claim upon the borrower, the school, its property or its income, and that the sum was to be repaid at no interest when and if the borrower chose, and that if she never chose, it was a gift.

Metrodora had read the deed four times. Then she had said, 'There is no clause about you coming to the school.'

'There is not.'

'Then I will put one in,' said Metrodora, 'in my own hand, under the fourth clause, and it will say that the lender may come on the seventh day of any month and shall not be asked to teach anything.'

In the sixth year there were eleven girls in the school in the mornings — the daughters of shopkeepers, two slaves whose owner had agreed to it because a girl who could add was worth more, and three freed girls from the fourth region — and four in the afternoons who were older and who came to learn to write a contract.

Metrodora was thirty-one. She had married in the third year, a surveyor named Gaius who was quiet and who thought that she was the most interesting person he had ever met, and who had asked Antonia, at the wedding, whether it was true that she had once put four hundred people into a chain at a fire, and had been extremely disappointed to be told that it had only been about a hundred and fifty.

She called Antonia nothing at all. She had never found the word. In six years she had called her *domina* perhaps eleven times, and each time it had been in a moment of stress or hurry, and once, in the fourth year, when Antonia was ill for a fortnight and would not admit it, she had called her *mater* in the doorway of the sickroom and then had gone very red and had said, 'There is no bread in the house,' and had gone out to buy some.

That was the whole of it. It was enough.

Marcellina had married in the fifth year, and she had married a man of no family at all.

He was a physician of thirty-four named Hermias, who had been trained at Alexandria and who had a practice among the equestrians and no money and a great many opinions, and who had met her at Antonia's table on a seventh day and had argued with her about the treatment of a burn for an hour and a half, and who had afterwards walked her home and told her that she was entirely wrong and that he would prove it.

She had said, at the wedding, that she had spent nineteen years in a house where nobody argued, and that she had discovered at twenty that she could not be happy in a room where everybody agreed with her.

They lived in a house on the Caelian with a courtyard and a great many children — their own two, and Verana, who was twenty-one and had married a potter and lived four streets away and came on Sundays, and Brennus, who was eighteen and was apprenticed to a shipping agent at Ostia and who came home when he needed money.

Verana and Brennus had never been formally adopted. There had been a great deal of legal discussion about it in the first year, and in the end Tarquitius had written a letter from Asia explaining that the adoption of free children required the consent of the council and a good deal of paper and that, in his opinion as a jurist, the whole of it was unnecessary, because Marcellina had already done the only thing that mattered, which was to go to Lugdunum and fetch them.

Tarquitia Priscilla had died in the spring of the fifth year, at eightyfour, in her own bed, and had left Marcellina the house on the Palatine and the masks and the whole of the estate except a sum of eleven thousand sesterces, which she had left to a freedwoman named Metrodora, formerly of the household at Arretium, with a note that said only: *for the school*.

She had never met her granddaughter. She had never asked to. Metrodora had taken the money and had put it into the lease of the green door, and she had not gone to the funeral, and she had not said anything about it at all, and Antonia had not asked her to.

Tarquitia Aurelia had died at Tibur in the summer of the fourth year, alone, of the disease of the joints and a fever. There had been eleven people

at the funeral, of whom nine were servants. Nobody from the family had gone.

The others were scattered and were not lost.

Meno had gone to Tibur in the May after the fire and had kept a garden gate for five years and had written eleven letters, of which four had been about the widow with the bees and seven had been about the roof. He had died in the winter of the fifth year, in his own bed, at seventy-three, and Antonia had paid for the stone and had gone out to Tibur for the funeral, and the widow with the bees had come, and had cried, and had said that he had been a difficult man and that she had been very fond of him.

Cinnamus had the shop in the Subura and had made a success of it, and had taken on two clerks and a boy, and had come to the seventh-day dinners for six years and had never once failed to bring the accounts. He had taught Marcellina to keep a book properly and had told her, on the day she married, that she was now competent and that she should never trust a man who told her otherwise.

Prima had the house on the Aventine with the two rooms and the yard, four streets from Antonia's, and had let the second room to a family of dyers and had bought a share in a fuller's business with the money, and by the sixth year she had four women working for her and a lease in her own name and a reputation in that quarter for being extremely hard and entirely fair. She came to dinner on the seventh day and she and Myrrhine argued about the price of wool. She never spoke about the Argiletum and nobody asked her to.

Eucharis had taught music in Neapolis for six years and had written nine letters, of which nine had been complaining about the family and two had been about a man. In the fifth year she had married him, and he was a ship's captain of forty with a house at Puteoli and a bad temper and a good laugh, and she had brought him to Rome in the sixth year and had stood in the courtyard on the Aventine and said, 'This is my husband, and he

knows everything, and if anybody is polite to me about it I will leave.'

Vibia Lucana had her courtyard at Ostia and her shipping office and her roses, and she had kept the promise she made in the portico of the Basilica Julia on the first day of the trial: once a month, on the eleventh day, there was a dinner in the courtyard at Ostia for the women who had nowhere to go, and there were eleven of them in the first year and thirty in the sixth, and Antonia went when she was in Italy and sent money when she was not.

The baker's family had rebuilt their shop on the north slope in the second year and had a good trade from the garden, and the baker's wife had named her fourth daughter Antonia, which Antonia had not known about until the child was two years old and had been brought to the house on the Aventine to be looked at.

In the autumn of the sixth year a letter came from the east.

It came in a packet of eleven, with the seal of a legion and a name on the outside in a hand she knew, and it had been six weeks on the road, and it was from Antioch.

She opened it in the courtyard on the Aventine, in the afternoon, with Myrrhine sitting opposite her, and she read it twice before she said anything.

'He is dead,' she said.

Myrrhine put down her cup.

'In the summer,' said Antonia. 'The eighth day before the Kalends of August. A fever, in Antioch, four days. He had been with the emperor's staff since the spring; he was fifty-nine years old and he had gone east because the emperor asked for jurists and because he had spent two years in Asia and knew the province.' She turned the letter over. 'It is from his secretary. The secretary is sixty-one and has a club foot and has been with him for thirty years, and he wrote this himself in the inn at Antioch while the body was being prepared, and he says that he died in the afternoon and that he was in a great deal of discomfort for the last day and that he was

clear in his mind until the end.'

'Antonia—'

'He says that there are four boxes of papers and a strongbox and that they will come by the military post in the spring, and that the strongbox is not to be opened except by the person named in his will, and that the person named in his will is me.' She folded the letter. 'He has left me something. In the strongbox. And there is a letter with it that I am to read first.'

Myrrhine looked at her.

'He was in your life for twenty-five years and then for six,' she said, 'and he has left you a strongbox and a letter, and you are going to have to decide whether to open them.'

'I know,' said Antonia.

'When?'

'In the spring,' said Antonia, 'when they come. Not before.' She put the letter in her sleeve. 'There is nothing in a strongbox in Antioch that will not keep until the spring.'

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It came in April, in four boxes and a strongbox, on a wagon with a military escort, and the escort was a young man of twenty-four who had been told to deliver it into the hands of Antonia Cassia and who was extremely correct about it.

The strongbox was iron, with two locks and a lid that had been sealed with the boar's head and the two letters. She broke the seal in the courtyard, with Myrrhine and Metrodora and Marcellina present, because she had asked them to be present, and because she had discovered in the last six years that she did not want to open anything alone.

Inside there was a bundle of papers tied with a thread, and a smaller box, and a letter.

She read the letter aloud.

Antonia. You are reading this in the spring, and I have been dead since the summer, and I find that I am not able to write this as I would wish,

because I have written it nine times and burned ten of them and this one is not elegant.

There are two things in this box. The first is a bundle of letters: thirty-one of them, one for each August since the year we met, which I wrote and did not send and did not burn. I have kept them because I discovered, at some point in my forties, that a man who burns a letter is a man who is arranging his own feelings for his own comfort, and that keeping them was more honest and considerably more painful. You may read them or burn them. They are not good. They are the letters of a man who was correct for thirty years and who was afraid.

The second thing is my will, in a copy made by my own hand, and the original is with the Vestals and will be opened in Rome in the autumn.

I have left the estate to my two daughters in equal shares. Marcellina is named in the will in the ordinary way. The second share is left to Metrodora, freedwoman, formerly of the household at Arretium, whom I have described in the will as my daughter by a slave woman of that household, born at Puteoli in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo.

I have thought about this for six years. I have thought about whether it is a gift or a violence, and I have concluded that it is neither, because it is not for her. It is for the record. There will be a document in the temple of Vesta, and in a hundred years, when the whole of this is nothing, there will be a girl in this city who is told that she cannot be anything because of her mother's condition, and there will be a copyist who finds the will of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus in a box and reads that he acknowledged a daughter by a slave woman in the year of his consulship. That is all it will do. It will not give her anything she does not have. But it will be in the record, and she will be in the record, and it will not be possible afterwards for anyone to say that she was not.

I have not asked her permission, and that is the only thing in this letter that I am ashamed of. I have spent my life doing things to people for their own good and calling it care. I am doing it once more, and I am doing it because I am fifty-nine and going to the east and I do not expect to come back,

and because a man who is dying may leave a record, and a woman who is living must decide what to do with it.

You will decide. That is the last thing I have to ask you, and I have no right to ask it, and I am asking it because in six years you have never once done what I expected and I have come to rely on it.

L. Tarquitius Priscus.

They read it in the courtyard in the spring.

Metrodora sat with her hands in her lap and did not move for a long time.

Then she said, 'He has put me in the will of a Roman senator as his daughter.'

'Yes,' said Antonia.

'Without asking me.'

'Yes.'

'And in the autumn the will will be opened in Rome, and there will be eleven men in the Forum who will read it out in the Acta, and by the winter every man in this city will know that Metrodora who keeps a school in the sandalmakers' street is the natural daughter of the consul Lucius Tarquitius Priscus and a slave.' She was very pale. 'And every girl in my school will be told by some woman in the market that her teacher is a senator's bastard, and there will be a version in which I am a fortune-hunter and a version in which I am a tragedy, and I will not be able to say a word in my own defence, because the whole of it is true.'

'Yes,' said Antonia.

'And you have known about this since April and you have not told me.'

'I have known since the letter came, which was eleven days ago,' said Antonia. 'I have not told you because I wanted you to hear it with the paper in front of you, in this courtyard, with witnesses, and not in the street.' She put the will on the table. 'There is a thing I can do. I am named in the will as the person to whom the strongbox was entrusted, and the will

is not yet opened; the original is with the Vestals and it will be opened in the autumn. I have an advocate and I know the prefect of the archives, and I can have the clause about you struck out before it is read, on the grounds that it names a person who has not consented, and it would be irregular and it would take two months and eleven favours, and it could be done.'

Metrodora looked at her.

'And if it is struck out,' she said, 'what happens?'

'You are not in the will. You are not in the record. You are a freedwoman of the household of the Tarquitii who keeps a school, and nobody in Rome will ever have a reason to look at you twice, and in a hundred years the copyist will find the will of Lucius Tarquitius Priscus and it will say nothing at all about a daughter, and nobody will know.'

Metrodora sat in the courtyard for a long moment.

'No,' she said.

'Think about it.'

'I have thought about it. I have had nine days to think about it while you were deciding how to tell me.' She put her hands flat on the table. 'I have spent six years building a school and a name and a life out of nothing, and I have done it without a father and without a mother and without a name that anyone gave me, and I am not going to give it up to protect the sensibilities of a city that has never done one thing for me.' She looked up. 'Read it. Let them read it. Let the whole of Rome read it and let them say what they like. I have a school and a husband and a name in the register of the temple of Castor and eleven girls in the morning, and every one of them is going to learn to read, and in twenty years there will be a woman in this city who is somebody's clerk because Metrodora taught her, and the fact that my father was a senator will be a thing that people say about me at dinner, and it will not be the first thing or the second thing or the tenth.' She pushed the will back across the table. 'And I am not going to take the money.'

'It is a great deal of money,' said Antonia.

'I know what it is. I have read the schedule; it is four hundred and eleven thousand sesterces and a house at Arretium that I have never seen.'

Metrodora stood up. 'I am going to take the house at Arretium and I am going to sell it, and I am going to put the money into the school, and the school will be in my name and not his, and there will be no plaque and no inscription and no thanks.' She picked up her box. 'And I am not going to read the thirty-one letters. You may read them or burn them. I have had one father for six years and he was a man who wrote me a letter every August and burned it, and I do not need thirty-one more.'

She went out.

Myrrhine, who had not said a word for a quarter of an hour, said, 'That is a remarkable woman.'

'She is,' said Antonia.

'She is exactly like you.'

'I know,' said Antonia. 'It is the most frightening thing that has ever happened to me.'

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She read the letters in the summer, all thirty-one of them, in the garden on the Esquiline, sitting on a bench in front of the fountain that did not work.

They were not good. He had been right about that. They were the letters of a man who had been taught to write like a magistrate, and each of them began with the date and the year and an account of the weather, and then, in the middle of the second paragraph, the thing that had been in him for a year would come out in one sentence and he would retreat into the weather again.

The first was from the year she was sold. It said, in the middle of a paragraph about the harvest in Etruria: *I have been told a thing that I do not believe and I have decided to believe it because the alternative is to go to Puteoli and find out.*

The eleventh, from the year she opened the house on the Esquiline, said: *I am told that you have bought a house on the Esquiline and that you are doing very well, and I have ridden past the end of your street four times this year and have not turned into it, which I record here because there is no*

one else to whom I would record it.

The twenty-third, from the year of the fire, said nothing about the fire at all for two paragraphs and then: *There was a fire on the Esquiline in April and nine houses were destroyed and I have spent the summer signing orders about it and I have discovered that a man can be of use at fifty-seven and that it is not the same as being admired.*

The last was written in July, in Antioch, three weeks before he died, and it was four lines long.

The heat here is very great and the flies are worse than in Dacia. I have been reading the rescripts of the province and there are eleven that I cannot in conscience sign, and I have written to the emperor about them, and he will do what he does, which is usually the right thing and always a year too late.

I find that I have nothing to add. I have written thirty-one of these and each of them was supposed to say the same thing and none of them has said it. I am fifty-nine years old and I have been correct for the whole of it, and I find, at the end, that I would rather have been in a courtyard on the Aventine with a woman who does not forgive me and a daughter who calls me nothing at all, eating a fish that was cooked too quickly.

I hope you are well. L.T.P.

Antonia sat in the garden with the letter in her hands.

Then she folded it with the others and tied the thread and put the bundle in her sleeve, and got up and walked to the middle of the garden, where the bronze tablet was, and stood in front of it for a while.

Two children were playing on the path: a boy of about seven and a girl of about five, and they had a hoop and a stick and they were arguing about whose turn it was. Beyond them the eleven fig trees stood in a line along the wall, and at the corner the fountain that did not work had a little green water in the bottom of it, and beyond the wall the whole of Rome went on in the sun.

The girl won the argument. She took the stick and hit the hoop and it went off down the path, wobbling, and the boy ran after it, shouting.

'Domina.'

She turned. Myrrhine was coming across the garden with a basket on her arm.

'It is the seventh day,' said Myrrhine. 'There is a fish, and I have made it too quickly, and Vibia is coming up from Ostia, and Marcellina has sent word that she will be late because of the children.' She stopped beside her. 'Are you all right?'

'Yes,' said Antonia.

'You have been standing in front of that tablet for a quarter of an hour.'

'I know,' said Antonia. 'It does not say anything about me. In a hundred years there will be a garden with a fountain that does not work and a plaque about a fire, and there will be nobody in this city who knows that I was ever here, and I find that I do not mind at all.' She took the basket. 'What is in it?'

'Bread, and the fish, and the lentils, and a jar of the wine that the proconsul sent from Asia before he died, and I have been saving it for a year and I have decided that tonight is the night.'

They walked out of the garden together, through the gate in the wall, into the street.

'Myrrhine,' said Antonia.

'Mm.'

'There is a thing I have never said to you, and I am going to say it badly, and then we will go home and eat the fish.'

'Say it.'

'For twenty-two years,' said Antonia, 'I have been a woman who was building something, and I have never once been able to say what it was for. Not the house. Not the money. Not the women in it or the book or the trial or the fund or the school. I have said to a great many people that it was for safety, and it was not for safety, and I knew it was not for safety at the time.' She stopped in the street. 'It was for this. A courtyard, and a fish cooked too quickly, and a woman coming up from Ostia, and a girl who calls me nothing at all, and seven people at a table on the seventh day of the month, and a garden where the house used to be, with children playing in

it who have never heard of me.'

Myrrhine looked at her.

'Yes,' she said. 'I know. I have known for about ten years.'

'Why did you not say?'

'Because you were not ready to hear it,' said Myrrhine, 'and because I have discovered that there are two kinds of silence, and one of them is a thing that has to be borne and the other is a thing that is waiting for the right day.' She shifted the basket on her arm. 'This is the right day. Now come home; the fish will be cold, and I am not going to cook another one.'

In Rome, power is inherited, and fortunes are made, and some wounds never heal.

But a house is not the walls of it, and a name is not the register that holds it, and on the seventh day of the month, in a courtyard on the Aventine, there is a table with seven places at it, and a lamp, and a woman who was sold for two thousand four hundred sesterces in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Corbulo, and who was, in the end, worth considerably more.